

The Referendum

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Chapter 1

The phone rang at six-fifteen in the morning and Mamadou Diallo already knew who it was.

He was standing at the bathroom mirror. Shaving cream on his jaw, the cheap kind, in a blue tube, the same brand his father had used in the little house in Kanema. This was his one vanity of consistency: he could have used anything, any brand shipped from Paris or Dubai, the residence staff would have procured it without being asked. Diallo used the blue tube because his father had used it. The sharp, medicinal, and faintly antiseptic smell reminded him of his father preparing his face for the world. Some mornings, Diallo needed this reminder that his father had done this in a two-room house in the northern province, and now he did it in a bathroom in the presidential residence. Despite the difference in setting, the act was the same.

The razor was a safety razor. The blade was new. He changed it every Sunday, a small ceremony he performed alone, unscrewing the head, removing the old blade, unwrapping the new one from its wax paper sleeve. The blade was Japanese. This fact bothered him slightly, a president of an African country shaving with a Japanese blade, but the blades were the sharpest he had found and vanity was vanity.

Steam from the shower still clung to the mirror. He wiped a clear circle with his forearm and began the first stroke, chin to jaw, pulling the skin taut with his left hand the way his father had taught him when he was fifteen. Through the window behind him, the bathroom caught the first gray light. The residence sat on the hill above the Plateau, and the bathroom, the private one attached to the bedroom, not the guest bathroom downstairs with the Italian marble that the previous president had installed, had a window that looked east, over the rooftops of the Médina toward the ocean. He could see, on a clear morning, the cranes of the port. The minarets. The half-finished towers that had been half-finished for two years because the construction companies had run out of money or patience or both. And beyond them, the ocean, flat and silver and indifferent to the city that sat at its edge and the country that sat behind the city and the continent that sat behind the country.

He looked at the ocean every morning. He had never swum in it. Twenty years in a coastal city and he had never once entered the water. The fear was old, older than the presidency, older than the marriage, older than the PhD. He was seven. A beach north of Saint-Louis. A current that pulled him under for twelve seconds. His mother's hands hauling him out by the wrist, the sand scraping his ribs, the water in his lungs. He had not gone back. He watched the ocean from windows and balconies and the back seats of cars. He watched it from the cemetery where Mariama was buried. Every morning, respectful and wary, never closer.

He set the razor down on the edge of the sink and walked to the bedroom, his wet feet leaving prints on the tile that faded with each step.

"Papa."

"Ibrahima."

His son called every Sunday from Paris. Always this early. Seven-fifteen in Paris, six-fifteen in Port Sélani, the hour between first coffee and second coffee when Ibrahima was at his sharpest and his father was at his most exposed. The timing was not accidental. Diallo suspected his son had figured out, sometime in the last year, that early-morning arguments were harder to win and easier to regret, and had adjusted his schedule accordingly. "I read the full terms of the deal, Papa. Not the summary. The actual text. The Special Economic Zone provisions."

"Good morning to you too."

"Chinese labor law inside the corridor. Chinese commercial courts. Article 7, section 3: 'security within the corridor shall be provided by a contracted entity designated by the project operator.' That means a private army, Papa. Chinese private security on Kessaran soil."

Diallo walked back to the bathroom. He put the phone on speaker and set it on the shelf above the sink, between Mariama's perfume bottle, which he had not moved in three years and would not move, and his toothbrush, which he had replaced four times in the same period. The perfume was Chanel No. 5. She had bought it in Paris, on the trip before the diagnosis, at a shop on the Champs-Élysées where the saleswoman had assumed she was a tourist's wife and not a school principal from a country the saleswoman could not have found on a map.

He picked up the razor and resumed shaving. He had learned, in four years of these Sunday calls, that his hands needed something to do while his son talked.

"I negotiated those provisions," Diallo said. "I sat in a room with Zhonglu's legal team for nine days. I know what every clause says." "Then you know what they mean."

“I know what they cost, Ibrahima. Do you?”

In the mirror, he watched himself work the blade along the curve of his jaw. Fifty-eight years old. Gray at the temples. It had arrived the year Mariama got sick and spread like weather, unstoppable, unremarkable. Lines around the eyes that deepened when he was tired, which was always. His father’s face. His father had been a mathematics teacher for forty years, in the same classroom in Kanema. The room had a chalkboard, twenty wooden desks, and a window that overlooked a yard where goats would wander in during lessons because the fence had never been properly repaired. His father had died at sixty-one with the satisfied exhaustion of a man who had done one thing well.

Diallo envied him. Diallo was doing thirty things badly and one thing, this deal, this referendum, that he wasn’t sure about at all. “The cost is sovereignty,” Ibrahima said. “You’re giving away sovereign territory for ninety-nine years.”

“I’m restructuring eight point two billion dollars of debt that is bleeding this country to death.”

“At what price?”

“At the price of a phone call from my son in Paris who has never had to choose between paying the debt and keeping the hospitals open.”

He heard the intake of breath on the line. He had gone too far. He always went too far with Ibrahima, always swung through the space where correction lived and into the space where damage was done. It was the razor, he told himself. The steady, careful work of the blade freeing his hands and leaving his tongue unguarded. But it wasn’t the razor. It was simpler than that. Diallo had bought his son’s distance with his own proximity to ruin. Neither of them said so. Saying so would mean admitting that Ibrahima’s opinions about Kessara were formed by safety, not by study.

“That’s not fair, Papa.”

“No. It isn’t. I’m sorry.”

A pause. Five thousand kilometers of undersea cable carrying nothing.

“You never explain it to me,” Ibrahima said. His voice had dropped, not softer but lower, the register of a son who has decided to stop arguing and start asking. “You just tell me I don’t understand.”

Diallo rinsed the razor under the tap. The water was warm. The residence had a solar heating system on the roof, installed by the Germans in a development partnership three governments ago. It worked well. Like most things the Europeans built in Africa, it worked well for the people who lived in the house where it was installed and not at all for anyone else. “Because the explanation takes longer than a

phone call. Come home. Sit in the cabinet meeting. Read the debt reports. Talk to Asante about the bond payment. Four hundred and eighty million dollars, due in sixty days. Sixty days, Ibrahima. After that, this country defaults. Do you know what default means for a country like ours?"

"I know what it means."

"You know what the textbooks say. You don't know what it looks like in a hospital pharmacy when the credit line is cut and the insulin doesn't arrive. You don't know what it sounds like when a teacher calls the ministry to ask why her salary is three months late and the ministry doesn't answer because the phones have been disconnected because the phone company hasn't been paid either." He wiped his face with a towel. The shaving cream was gone. Underneath it was a face he recognized and a face he didn't. The private face of a man who had just said more to his son about his job than he had said in four years, and the public face that would appear on television screens and newspaper front pages and campaign posters and would say, with presidential calm, that the referendum was a democratic exercise and the people should vote their conscience.

"The referendum is in six days," he said, quieter now. "Come home and vote."

"I have a seminar."

A seminar. Twenty-eight million people were about to decide the future of their country and his son had a seminar.

"Your mother would have voted," Diallo said.

He regretted it immediately. Mariama was the line they did not cross.

She would have voted. This was true. Mariama Diallo, née Camara, had voted in every election since 1990, the year she turned eighteen, the year the military government allowed multiparty elections for the first time, the year she stood in a line that wrapped around the secondary school in the Médina and waited four hours in the sun because she had been born in a country that did not let women vote and she intended to vote so hard that the ballot box remembered her.

She had told him this story on their second date. They were both at the university. He was teaching economics, she was completing a diploma in secondary education. They sat at a café in the Plateau district and she drank a Fanta and he drank a coffee and she told him about the line and the sun and the four hours and the moment she put her ballot in the box.

"I cried," she said. "Not because I was happy. Because my mother died without ever voting. She lived in this country for sixty-two years and never once held a pen in a voting booth. I cried because she should have been there and she wasn't, and I was,

and the distance between those two facts was measured in her life.” He had fallen in love with her during that sentence. Not gradually, not over weeks or months, but in the space of that sentence, the precision of it, her refusal of self-pity, how she honored her mother by measuring rather than mourning. He had known, sitting in that café with his cooling coffee, that this woman understood something about Kessara that he had been trying to articulate in academic papers for five years and failing, and that she had said it in one sentence over a Fanta.

They married eighteen months later. They lived in the apartment near the university for twenty years. She ran a secondary school in the Médina. Six hundred students, most of them girls, in a building with a leaking roof and not enough textbooks. She fixed the roof herself, with money she raised from a parents’ committee. The textbooks she never solved.

“You can fix a roof with money,” she said. “You can’t fix a curriculum with money. Curricula need teachers who care, and teachers who care need to be paid, and being paid requires a government that values education, and valuing education requires a country that values its own future, and there we are, back at the beginning.”

She spoke like that, in spirals that circled a point and landed on it from above, the way a hawk lands on a mouse, with precision and inevitability. Diallo, who spoke in straight lines, in economic models and policy frameworks, who built his arguments like bridges from premise to conclusion, had never met anyone who could demolish a bridge with a spiral.

He missed her spirals. He missed them more than he missed her cooking or her laugh or the sound of her breathing at night, though he missed those too. He missed her mind, how it found the connection between a leaking roof and a national curriculum and a government’s priorities and the future of a country, all in one sentence, all landing on the same point: there we are, back at the beginning.

The silence after “your mother would have voted” lasted long enough for both of them to hear it.

Ibrahima did not strike back. He said, “I’ll try to come,” and they both knew he wouldn’t, and the phone call ended the way their calls always ended: with the sound of a connection closing and the longer, heavier sound of a silence that had nothing to do with the phone.

Diallo dressed. Dark trousers, a white shirt, no tie. He walked downstairs through a house that was not his house. The paintings on the walls were government property, a mix of Kessaran contemporary art and colonial-era landscapes, hung by someone with a budget and no taste. The furniture was government property. The carpets were

government property. The air itself felt institutional, the sterility of a building that was cleaned by people who did not live in it and used by a person who did not own it. The books in the study he had brought himself. Fourteen boxes from the apartment near the university. Mariama had labeled each box in her handwriting, small, slanted to the right, as if every word she wrote was leaning into a wind only she could feel. ECONOMICS: FRANCOPHONE. ECONOMICS: ANGLOPHONE. HISTORY: GENERAL.

HISTORY: KESSARA. NOVELS: MARIAMA'S. He had not opened that last box. It sat in the corner of the study behind his desk, taped shut, her handwriting on the flap.

The kitchen was large and empty. He made his own coffee, instant, stirred with a spoon he kept in the same drawer, because the kitchen staff arranged things in ways he could never find and the spoon was his anchor point, the one object in the residence that stayed where he put it.

He drank the coffee standing at the window. Port Sélani in the early morning. The light was gray-blue, the heat not yet arrived. The residence sat above the Plateau, and from the kitchen he could see south, over the colonial rooftops, over the Médina with its compound walls and its minarets, to the port where the cranes stood against the sky like metal birds frozen mid-flight. The generator hummed beneath the floor. City power had failed at two. The backup kicked in without a pause. Eight seconds of battery while the diesel caught. Ordinary Kessarans lived inside that gap for hours. He lived inside it for eight seconds.

He had run for president on Clean Hands. He had promised to fix the power grid.

Four years later, the only reliable electricity in the country ran through his bedroom.

He rinsed his cup. He put it on the drying rack, the habit of a man from a two-room house, the habit that no amount of residence staff could train out of him because the habit was older than the residence, older than the staff, and it would outlast both. Captain Ndoeye was at the front door. Forty, quiet, built like a man selected for his dimensions. Twelve years in presidential security, three presidents. He had the patience of someone who understood that his job was to keep the body alive regardless of what the mind was doing.

"The cemetery?" Ndoeye said.

"The cemetery." "I'll follow in the second car."

"You always follow in the second car."

"And you always drive yourself, Mr. President. And I always disagree."

“And yet here we are.”

Ndoye almost smiled. Their Sunday ritual. A negotiation that both men knew the terms of.

The president drove himself to Mariama’s grave. The security detail followed. This arrangement had survived four years because Ndoye was smart enough to know that a president who could not grieve in private would eventually break in public.

He drove through the Plateau. The colonial facades, shuttered windows, wrought-iron balconies, courtyard gardens going to seed. The French had built this quarter to remind themselves of Bordeaux, and the architecture still carried that longing, the proportions of a Mediterranean town transplanted to a West African coast, the buildings slowly surrendering to a climate they were never designed for. Paint peeling. Iron rusting.

Bougainvillea growing through the cracks because bougainvillea does not care about architectural intent. He turned south into the Médina. The streets narrowed.

Compound walls in fading pastels: blue, pink, a green that had once been the color of new leaves and was now the color of old ones. A woman swept the pavement in front of a bakery. The smell of bread, the first baguettes of the morning, the smell that was both French inheritance and Kessaran daily life, because colonialism leaves behind many things and bread is one of them. Two boys in school uniforms walked along the road, Sunday-clean, the uniforms the best clothes they owned.

The call to prayer began. First from the Grand Mosque, a single voice, rising from the minaret, cutting through the dawn, clean and deliberate, opening a space. Then a smaller mosque two blocks south. Then another. Until the city was wrapped in overlapping voices and the air itself seemed to hum with them. Diallo was not a praying man. Raised Muslim, his faith had settled into a quiet respect for the forms. But the sound reached something in him that economics did not: the recognition that twenty-eight million people shared a gesture five times a day, and the sharing meant something he could feel but not name.

He drove past the Grand Mosque. The compound was filling. He thought about Thierno Bâ inside, leading the prayer. The Grand Marabout had not spoken about the referendum. Four million followers waiting for guidance that was not coming, and both campaigns circling the old man like aircraft waiting for a runway that might not open. The cemetery sat on a hillside above the Médina, facing the ocean. The graves covered the slope in no order. Stone markers beside painted wood, concrete slabs beside mounds of bare earth. Rich and poor side by side. The city arranged its living by income. The dead it arranged by arrival.

He parked at the gate and walked up the path. Packed dirt, worn smooth by years of feet.

Bougainvillea along the low wall, pink and orange, the only bright color in a landscape of gray and brown and the dull red of laterite soil. A groundskeeper raked leaves near the entrance. He looked up when the president passed, recognized him, and went back to raking.

Mariama's grave was in the third row from the top, near a jacaranda tree that had not been there when she was buried but had grown since. The headstone was white marble. Her name. The dates. Nothing else.

"If you need words on a stone to remember me, then you have already forgotten."

He sat on the ground beside the slab. The earth was cool. The sun was breaking the horizon, spilling gold across the ocean below. From here he could see the port. The cranes, the ships, the fishing boats already out. Seven ships at anchor. He knew from the shipping reports that most were Chinese-flagged, waiting to load ore.

"The referendum is this week," he said.

He told her things he could not tell his cabinet. He told her the deal was the best he could get and it was not good enough. He told her about Asante's bond math and the sixty days and the default that would follow. He told her about Ibrahima's op-ed that he expected any day. The elegant arguments, the Fanon quotes, the view from Sciences Po.

"He writes about sovereignty the way his professors write about it," Diallo said. "As a principle. He doesn't know what it costs to exercise it. He doesn't know that sovereignty without money is a flag on an empty pole."

He picked at the grass beside the headstone. A nervous gesture. A small thing.

"But he's not entirely wrong, Mariama. That's what I can't say to him. The deal is a concession. It is a concession that I have spent four years trying to avoid and have failed to avoid because the alternatives are worse. There are no good options. There is the deal and there is the default, and the deal costs us the corridor and the default costs us everything."

The sun was fully up now. The gold on the water turning white. "You would have seen the angle I'm missing. You always did." He touched the marble. Warm. The night she was diagnosed, the hospital had one oncologist. Dr. Traoré, fifty-something, tired, eleven years as the country's only cancer specialist because every other oncologist trained in Kessara had left.

He faced them across his desk. Behind him, a window looking onto a parking lot where an ambulance rested on two flat tires. The office smelled of disinfectant and the

mustiness of a building that was cleaned regularly but maintained never.

“It’s ovarian. Stage three. Possibly four. I can’t tell from the imaging we have. The CT scanner hasn’t worked since September.” The CT scanner. A machine that had been donated by the Japanese government in 2011 and had functioned well for six years until a circuit board failed. The replacement part cost twelve hundred dollars. The hospital had submitted a requisition. The requisition had traveled from the hospital administrator to the regional health directorate to the Ministry of Health to the Ministry of Finance, where it sat in a queue behind four thousand other requisitions, ranked by a priority algorithm that did not include

“the president’s wife might have cancer” because the president’s wife did not yet know she had cancer and the requisition had been filed in September and the diagnosis came in November.

Twelve hundred dollars. A circuit board. A life.

“We’d need an MRI,” Dr. Traoré said. “The nearest is in Dakar. Or Paris.”

Paris. Val-de-Grâce. The French military hospital where African leaders and their families were treated when their own countries could not treat them. A service provided as a courtesy. A reminder. Both.

Diallo made the call that night. The French ambassador’s aide: “Of course, Professor Diallo.

We’re here to help.”

The helicopter came the next morning. Mariama on the stretcher. She looked at him and said: “Promise me you will fix this.” He thought she meant: promise me you will fix my cancer, promise me I will live. Later he understood she meant: promise me you will fix the CT scanner. Promise me the next woman won’t have to get on a helicopter. Promise me the hospital will work. She died four months later in Paris. He won the election six weeks after. He had not fixed the CT scanner. It was still broken. The requisition was still in the queue.

That was the thing he could not say in speeches. The deal was not about economics. It was about a twelve-hundred-dollar circuit board that sat in a procurement queue while his wife died in a French hospital. It was about what a country owed its people and what it could afford to give them, the terrible arithmetic of a man who had calculated it between a helicopter and a headstone. He stood up. Brushed the dirt from his trousers.

“I’m not selling the country. I’m trying to buy it back.” He walked to the car. Ndoye straightened against the second vehicle.

“Home?” Ndoye asked.

“The office.”

“It’s Sunday, Mr. President.”

“The debt doesn’t take Sundays off, Captain.”

They drove back. Market stalls opening. The smell of corn grilling on charcoal. Church bells joining the muezzin, Christians and Muslims waking to separate rituals in the same neighborhoods, the sound overlapping the way it had for a hundred years. The radio came on. Music and talk. The news: the referendum, the polling, the opposition rally.

Then: “In international news, the price of cobalt fell three percent on the London exchange.

Lithium prices remain steady.”

Then another item, brief: “Security analysts report continued activity by private military contractors in the northeast border region. Sources indicate ongoing recruitment of young men from drought-affected communities.”

He turned off the radio. He drove to the office.

Six days.

Chapter 2

Ousmane Traoré woke the way he always did, before the light, before the heat, before anyone had anything to say about the world. His body did not need an alarm. Forty years of farming the same soil had joined them at the root. The man and the ground beneath him, each one knowing when the other was ready.

When the darkness thinned, something in his bones said go, and he went.

He lay still for a moment. The bed was a wooden frame, built by his father from timber cut in the forest that used to stand north of the village. The forest was gone now, retreated with the rain, kilometer by kilometer, year by year, until the trees were a memory and the wood they'd left behind was the only proof they had existed. The mattress was cotton stuffed with kapok, made by Aïssatou thirty years ago, restuffed twice since. The kapok came from the tree behind the compound, a tall, pale tree with buttress roots that dropped its white fiber every January. Aïssatou used to collect it in a basin, picking out the seeds, stuffing it into the cotton casing with her hands. The mattress smelled faintly of her, a presence, the trace of a person who had slept on the same surface for twenty years. He did not know if the smell was real or remembered. He did not investigate.

The room was small. Mud-brick walls, the bricks made from the same soil he farmed, mixed with water and straw and set in wooden molds and dried in the sun. His grandfather had made the first bricks for this compound. His father had added the second building. Ousmane had added the third when he married. The walls were thick, two hands wide, and they held the cool of the night the way a clay pot holds water: slowly releasing it through the morning, keeping the room bearable until the sun overwhelmed the mass and the heat won.

A corrugated iron roof. A single window with a wooden shutter. His clothes on a nail behind the door. His sandals at the foot of the bed, aligned, toes toward the door.

He dressed in the dark. Cotton trousers faded to the color of the earth they were washed in, the shade that laterite soil produces when it gets into fabric and refuses to leave. A shirt that had been blue once. Sandals repaired so many times he could not tell which leather was the original and which was the repair.

Under the shirt, against his chest, the leather pouch on a cord. He had worn it for twenty years. Inside: a Quranic verse on folded paper, written by the village marabout in ink made from charcoal and gum arabic, the old way, the way the traveling scholars had written when they crossed the Sahara carrying the faith on their backs. Three seeds of a plant his mother had named for him at his birth. She had planted it in the compound yard and it had grown tall and broad until the drought of 2003 killed it. The seeds she had saved in a tin. He found the tin after her death and put three seeds in the pouch. The rest he kept in the tin, in the grain store, in case.

And a pinch of soil from the field where his grandfather was buried. He had added it himself, kneeling at the base of the baobab the week after Aïssatou died, pressing his thumb into the earth, rubbing the grains between his fingers, feeling the texture, the weight, the faint grit of laterite and the smoother particles of decomposed organic matter, and placing it inside the leather and pulling the cord tight.

He pushed open the compound door. The hinges were hand-forged iron. The door was carved wood, heavy, dark, cut from a tree that no longer grew in the region.

The air hit his face. He read it.

Dry. Too dry. The dryness had a texture. It pulled at the moisture on his lips, at the inside of his nostrils, at the thin skin around his eyes. The air should have carried weight at this time of year. Not rain, not yet, but the promise of rain, a humidity that built in the south and pushed north like a slow tide, announcing itself days before the first clouds appeared.

His father had called it the breath of the rains. You could feel it on your face like a warm cloth pressed gently against the skin. This morning there was no breath. The air was thin and parched. The dust rose from his footstep and hung without settling, suspended in nothing, going nowhere.

Three weeks late. Last year, two weeks. The year before, one. He walked east. The millet.

The path from the compound to the eastern fields was three hundred meters of packed dirt, worn smooth by forty years of his footsteps and his father's before him and his grandfather's before that. The path did not follow a straight line. It curved around a termite mound that had been there longer than the compound, past a neem tree his mother had planted when she was pregnant with his older brother, through a gap in a low stone wall that his grandfather had built to keep the goats out of the millet and that now served no purpose because the goats were gone, sold in the drought of 2003, the same drought that killed his mother's tree, but the wall remained because removing a wall is a decision and leaving it is not.

Twenty hectares of pearl millet. The stalks were up, knee height, planted in rows that followed the gentle slope of the field, each row spaced the width of a man's stride. He walked between the rows and ran his hand across the tops. The stalks brushed his palm, dry, papery, the sound of them like a whisper in a language he almost understood. He crouched. He pinched a stalk between his thumb and forefinger, just above the first node. It snapped cleanly. Too dry. A healthy stalk at this stage should bend before it breaks, the moisture inside giving it flexibility, the fiber resisting the pressure, the plant saying not yet, I'm still growing. This stalk said nothing. It broke the way dry wood breaks.

He dug his fingers into the soil beside the root. Down past the surface, past the first centimeter, which was damp from the morning dew, the one reliable moisture the field received, into the layer beneath. Dry. Crumbling. He brought up a handful and held it in his palm and looked at it.

The soil was lighter than it should have been. He had been watching this for years. The slow paling of the earth, a little lighter each season, a little less of the dark that meant richness. His grandfather's soil had been almost black. Everything that fell on it, stalks after harvest, dung from the cattle, leaves, dead insects, rotted back into the ground and the ground grew darker and richer with each season. His father's soil had been dark brown.

Good soil. Productive soil. Soil that grew millet to a man's shoulder and groundnuts that filled a basket by the armful. Ousmane's soil was the color of groundnut shells.

He crumbled it between his fingers and let it fall. The grains scattered in the slight breeze and did not settle. Too light. Too dry. Too far from what it had been.

He stood and looked across the field. The millet stretched to the tree line. Row after row, pale green against brown. Short. The stalks barely reached his waist. His grandfather's millet had grown past a man's chest. The height told the story of the soil, and the soil told the story of the rain, and the rain told the story of something larger that Ousmane could not name but could feel in his hands when he turned the earth each planting season. Something was leaving. Slowly, steadily, without announcement. You did not notice it going. You noticed it gone.

He walked back to the compound for water and stopped at the door.

His phone was on the shelf beside the bed. A basic handset, no screen to speak of, the kind sold at the market for four thousand francs. He picked it up and scrolled to Ibrahim's number.

His eldest son. Twenty-six. Gone three years.

The phone rang. Once. Twice. Three times. The sound of a connection reaching across distance toward a device that might or might not still belong to the person it was registered to. Four. Five. Six. Seven. Eight. Nine. The recorded message. French. The subscriber was unavailable.

He tried again. Same.

Five days now. The longest silence. Usually Ibrahim called on Thursdays. Short calls, guarded, the voice of a man who was speaking from a place he could not name about work he could not describe. The calls lasted three or four minutes. They covered the essentials: health (fine), money (sending it), the farm (managing), Awa (studying), Sékou (working).

What they did not cover was everything else: where Ibrahim slept, what he ate, who he worked for, what the work was, and why the money he sent, seven hundred, eight hundred dollars at a time, was more than any mine in the region paid.

Ousmane did not ask. The money paid for Awa's university. It paid for the diesel. It paid for the medicine when Amadou's wife was sick. The money did good work. Ousmane did not want to know what work had earned it.

He put the phone on the shelf. He filled his water bottle from the clay pot in the kitchen house. He walked back toward the fields. The groundnuts were better.

He walked the southern plots. Ten hectares, the plants low and bushy, dark green, healthy.

Groundnuts were patient. They pulled their water from deeper in the soil than the millet could reach, and they gave back more than they took. Nitrogen fixation. The marabout in the village had once asked him to explain it and Ousmane had said: "The groundnut eats air and turns it into food for the soil." The marabout had nodded. "Like prayer," he said. "You give breath to God and He gives strength to the earth." Ousmane had not corrected him because the analogy was better than the science.

The rotation was his father's teaching and his father's father's before that. Millet one year, groundnuts the next. You planted millet to eat. You planted groundnuts to heal the earth.

Then millet again. The cycle was older than any calendar, older than the village, older than the language the village spoke, older than the religion the village practiced. It was the first agreement between people and ground: I will feed you if you feed me. I will take what I need if you give back what I take.

His father had not explained this. His father had shown him. You plant this, then you plant that. The field tells you when it is ready. You listen.

The western field. The baobab. He reached it at six-thirty. The light was still low, the sun above the horizon but not yet harsh, the shadows long, the air carrying the last of the night's cool. The tree stood at the center of the field. Everything grew around it. Everything pointed toward it. The field without the tree was a field without a center, and a field without a center was just ground. His grandfather had planted it the year the French flag came down. 1962. He had walked three days from his father's village in the north, carrying the seedling in a clay pot wrapped in wet cloth. The cloth was the same indigo-dyed cotton that the women in his village wove on horizontal looms, fabric so deeply blue it was almost black, the dye made from the leaves of a plant that grew along the river. The pot was clay, fired in a pit kiln, shaped by the old man's wife, who made pots for the village and whom Ousmane had never met but whose work he held every day in the clay water vessels in the compound.

His grandfather put the seedling in the ground on the morning of independence. The village watched. Someone asked why he was planting a tree when there was palm wine to drink and a flag to raise.

"This tree will be here when all the flags are gone," he said. Sixty-three years. The trunk was wider than Ousmane's arms could reach. He had measured once, wrapping his arms around it as far as they would go. His fingers did not meet. The circumference was somewhere beyond the span of a man's embrace, which seemed right.

Some things are larger than what a single person can hold. The bark was smooth in places, rough in others, a history written in bark. Where it was smooth, the gray-brown surface was warm to the touch even in the early morning, holding yesterday's heat. Where it was rough, the bark had cracked into patterns. Deep fissures running vertically, smaller ones branching off, the wood beneath visible as a lighter shade, like bone beneath skin. He could read the tree's history in these cracks. The storm of 2011 that tore a branch off and left a hollow where bats now lived. The drought of 2003 that stressed the tree enough to split the bark on the south-facing side. The year, he did not remember which, when termites had tried to colonize the base and failed, leaving a scar of dried mud tunnels that crumbled to dust when touched.

Birds. Weaverbirds in the upper branches, their hanging nests made from strips of grass woven into tight spheres, each one built without a knot coming loose, each one holding through the wind season. A pair of grey hornbills that returned each dry season and left each wet season, keeping their own calendar. Hoopoes with their orange crests, pecking the bark for insects. The sound of all of them together, each one calling in its own pitch, filling the tree from the inside out.

Ants. A colony had built a highway from the roots to the first fork. A line of red bodies carrying fragments of leaf, moving with a purpose and coordination that struck Ousmane, every time he watched them, as evidence of something organized beyond what eyes could see.

His father was buried at the base. The grave was unmarked, just a slight rise in the ground, covered in grass that Ousmane trimmed with a machete once a month. Invisible unless you knew. He knew. He had dug the grave himself, alone, in the heat of the dry season, because his father had asked to be buried under the tree and a son does what his father asks.

Thirty meters east, at the edge of the millet field, Aïssatou's grave. A flat piece of laterite, the red-brown stone of the escarpment, dense and heavy. He had cut it himself with a hammer and chisel, working for two days, shaping it roughly, then smoothing the surface with a rasp until it was flat enough to lie flush against the ground. He had carried it on his back, two kilometers, from the escarpment to the field. The weight of it, twenty or twenty-five kilograms, had bent him nearly double, and he had arrived at the grave site with the stone on his back and his knees trembling and Sékou watching from the compound doorway, wanting to help, told to stay.

No name on the stone. No dates. Just the stone. The right color, in the right place.

He put his hand on the trunk. Warm. He closed his eyes. He made his offering. A handful of millet grain from his pocket. He carried it for this purpose, a small amount, enough. A cup of water from the bottle, poured slowly at the roots, darkening the earth in a circle that would dry before noon.

He spoke to the tree. Not aloud. Not in any language that could be written. He told it about the rains. About the millet being short. About the groundnuts being good. About Sékou, nineteen, quiet, the one who stayed. About Awa, twenty-two, fierce, the one who went to the city and came back angry about things Ousmane could not fix. About Ibrahim. The phone ringing into nothing, five days now, the money that came from a place without a name.

The village imam would have called it something else. Ousmane did not call it anything. It was the practice of attention, the acknowledgment that the tree was more than wood, the soil was more than dirt, the dead were not gone but still here, in the soil and the wood, and they needed tending. The marabout would have understood. Dramane, the diviner, would have nodded without being asked, because Dramane lived inside this understanding without separation, without the need to name it.

Sékou appeared at seven.

He came from the compound carrying two bowls. Millet porridge, thick, cooked with groundnut paste, the same breakfast his mother had made every morning of her life. When Aïssatou died, the cooking had passed to Sékou without discussion. He had watched his mother make the porridge a thousand times and his body knew the motions, the ratio of millet flour to water, the speed of the stirring, the moment when the paste was ready (a slight change in resistance, the spoon pulling differently, the texture shifting from liquid to something that held its shape on the back of the hand). He cooked it the way she had. He did not say this was why.

They ate under the tree. The porridge was hot. The morning was warm. A lizard watched them from a rock, doing push-ups in the sun, the territorial display of a small animal defending a large claim. Sékou ate carefully. He did everything carefully. Walked, worked, spoke. He had finished secondary school the year before and chosen not to go to university, not because he couldn't but because someone had to stay. Awa was at the university. Ibrahim was wherever Ibrahim was.

Sékou stayed. He said it was because the farm needed him. Ousmane suspected it was something else, that Sékou understood, at nineteen, a thing that his siblings had not yet grasped: that leaving was easy and staying was the harder thing, and that the harder thing was sometimes the right thing, and that the land did not care about your reasons for being there as long as you showed up. They worked together after breakfast. The eastern field. Side by side, one row apart, pulling weeds. The work had a rhythm: bend, pull, shake the soil from the roots, set the weed in the pile, move forward. Bend, pull, shake, set, move. The rhythm was old. It was the rhythm of Ousmane's body and his father's body and his grandfather's body, the same motions repeated across generations, the same muscles sore at the end of the day, the same dirt under the fingernails that no washing could entirely remove because the dirt was not on the skin but in it.

They did not talk. There was nothing to discuss that the work did not already say. The sun moved. The shadows shortened. The pile of weeds grew. The millet, freed from competition, stood a little straighter in the rows they had cleared, or Ousmane imagined it did. Sometimes the work itself was a conversation between the farmer and the crop, and the crop's response was visible only to someone who had been listening for forty years.

At nine-thirty, Sékou said: "Have you heard from Ibrahim?" Ousmane pulled a weed. He shook the soil. He set it in the pile. "Not this week."

"The money transfer didn't come. I checked at the kiosk." "I know." Sékou pulled the next weed in his row. The silence between them belonged to two people thinking

about the same absent person and deciding, separately, not to say what they were thinking.

“He’s busy,” Ousmane said.

Sékou looked at him. The look of a son who knows his father is choosing words like a man choosing steps across a flooded river, carefully, testing each one before putting his full weight on it. They went back to the weeds.

The government car arrived at ten.

Different people this time. A Director Coulibaly, older, heavier, in a suit that belonged in an office with air conditioning. And Cissé again, with the new leather folder.

Ousmane met them under the baobab. He offered water.

“Twenty-two million CFA francs,” Coulibaly said. “Relocation plot. Forty hectares. Transition payment. Agricultural extension for three years.”

Ousmane took the papers. He looked at the number. He looked at Cissé, who was looking at the ground.

“The resettlement zone. I asked about it last time. Red clay. Deep water table.”

“Our agronomists,”

“Have any of your agronomists farmed red clay?”

He dismantled the offer the way he weeded, methodically, one root at a time. The diesel pumps. The drainage. The cassava-not-millet problem. Coulibaly adjusted. Cissé made notes. Then Ousmane stopped dismantling and said the thing that could not be answered with adjustments.

“My wife is buried in that field.”

He pointed. The laterite stone, thirty meters east. Visible in the short millet, a flat red-brown shape on the ground, the color of the escarpment, the weight of a man’s back bent nearly double for two kilometers.

“My father is at the base of this tree. My grandfather planted this tree the morning the French left. My mother is behind the compound. My brother who died of malaria is beside my mother.” “There is a provision for respectful relocation,”

“You are offering me twenty-two million francs to leave my dead.”

Coulibaly looked at his shoes.

“The offer is open for thirty days.”

“My family has been here for longer than thirty days.”

They left. Sékou came from the field.

“They raised the price,” Sékou said.

“Yes.”

“Is there a number?”

Ousmane looked at the tree. At the stone. At the millet that was shorter this year.

“Your mother asked me once what I would do if the farm failed. I told her I would stay. She laughed. She said, ‘You would sit on dead land and wait for the world to agree with you.’ She was right.” He paused.

“But this is different. The land has not failed. The land is being taken. There is a difference between a drought and a theft.” That evening, the diviner came.

Ousmane heard him before he saw him. A shift in the air around the compound, a presence arriving. Dramane did not announce himself. He appeared when conditions required him. Seventy years old. Maybe older. Barefoot, his feet reading the ground with a precision that had nothing to do with sight. He walked to the baobab without asking because the tree was not Ousmane’s to gate-keep.

He sat on the ground between two roots, his legs folded beneath him. He opened a cloth bag and laid its contents on the earth: seventeen cowrie shells, a piece of kola nut, and a handful of sand from the sacred grove.

The shells were old. Polished by decades of handling, the natural ridges worn smooth, the color shifted from white to the warm ivory of bone. Each shell had a flat side and a rounded side. The flat sides had been filed open, a small slit, just wide enough to see into the hollow interior. Ousmane did not know when the shells had been opened or by whom. He did not ask. Some things were older than questions.

Dramane arranged them in a pattern on the ground. The kola nut at the center. The sand in a circle around it. The shells placed one by one at positions around the circle, some flat-side up, some rounded-side up, the arrangement deliberate, each shell placed with a pause and a murmured word.

He cast them. He took the seventeen shells in both hands, held them for a moment, his lips moving, his eyes closed, and released them. They fell on the hard-packed earth with a sound like dry rain. They scattered into a pattern that meant nothing to Ousmane and everything to Dramane.

The diviner studied the pattern. He leaned forward. He touched one shell with his forefinger and moved it slightly, a correction, or a confirmation. Ousmane could not tell. The fire that Ousmane had lit against the evening chill threw moving shadows across the shells, and the shadows made the pattern shift and breathe.

“The grove is inside their fence,” Dramane said.

“I know.”

“The spirits do not understand fences.”

He gathered the shells. He placed them back in the bag one at a time, in an order that was not the order they had fallen. He stood. His knees did not crack. His back did not protest.

He moved like a man half his age, his body still answering to him without argument.

“The land will be here after the machines,” he said. “It was here before the maps. The tree may go. The graves may go. But the land does not go. The land does not leave.”

He walked into the darkness. Ousmane watched him go. His bare feet on the path, his cloth bag against his hip, his back straight as he moved toward the grove where he had work to do that had nothing to do with referendums.

Ousmane walked back to the compound. The kerosene lamp was still burning on the bench. He sat down and tried Ibrahim’s phone. One ring. Then nothing. Not the recorded message. Not voicemail. A dead line. The phone was off, or broken, or taken. He sat on the bench in the compound. The kerosene lamp threw its circle of yellow. The radio was on, low, the evening news. Sékou was in the kitchen house, washing the dinner bowls. The sound of water and the scraping of a spoon against a pot. The compound going about its evening. He held the phone. He thought about calling Awa. He did not call.

He turned off the radio. He turned off the lamp. He lay on the bed in the dark and placed his hand on his chest, over the leather pouch. The verse. The seeds. The soil.

The night sounds. Insects. A distant dog. The iron roof ticking as it cooled, the metal shrinking in the dark, settling, adjusting to the temperature the way it did every night.

Everything here lived with what it was given.

He did not sleep for a long time.

Chapter 3

The heat hit Fatou Mensah like a debt she had forgotten she owed. She stepped off the plane at Port Sélani International Airport and the air closed around her.

All at once. Her lungs pulled hard on the first breath and got something thicker than air, humidity and dust and the tang of jet fuel mixing with dry laterite earth and, beneath that, something organic, something green and rotting and alive. Her glasses fogged. She took them off and the world smeared into shapes and heat. The sweat started before she reached the terminal door, immediate, total, her body remembering a temperature it had not felt in twenty-two years. Everything switched on. Pores opened. Her cotton shirt, chosen in Toronto that morning, ironed, professional, darkened at the collar and under the arms in the time it took to walk thirty meters.

Twenty-two years. She had been twelve the last time this air wrapped around her. Toronto had reset her entirely. Her body had learned to expect cold, to conserve heat, to treat humidity as a summer anomaly. Canadian air was thin and clean and manageable. Kessaran air was thick enough to lean against, warm enough to taste, heavy enough that breathing required intention. She could feel Toronto being stripped off her, layer by layer, the Canadian winter lifting off her skin like something that had never quite belonged.

She put her glasses back on. Wiped them on her shirt. They fogged again. She gave up and carried them.

The terminal was new. Glass and steel. Clean floors reflecting the fluorescent lights. Air conditioning that worked, the transition from the tarmac to the arrivals hall was a temperature drop of fifteen degrees, and her sweat turned cold on her skin. She read the plaque by the entrance: BUILT WITH THE GENEROUS SUPPORT OF THE PEOPLE'S REPUBLIC OF CHINA, in French, Arabic, and Mandarin. Three languages, one message: this building was a gift, and gifts between nations are never free.

She had seen identical terminals in Nairobi and Addis Ababa. The same generous proportions. The same polished surfaces. The same feeling of a building designed for a busier future, gates sized for crowds that hadn't arrived, departure boards listing

twelve flights where Toronto Pearson listed twelve hundred. Built by a country that understood exactly how to make another country feel both grateful and small.

She collected her bag from a carousel that worked on the second attempt. She cleared immigration. The officer, a heavyset woman in a blue uniform, gold earrings, reading glasses on a chain around her neck, looked at her Canadian passport, then at her face, then back at the passport. The look lingered on the surname. “Mensah. That’s Kessarar.”

“My father was Kessarar.”

“Was?”

“He passed away. Five years ago. In Canada.”

The woman looked at her again. Something moved in her expression, not sympathy, which would have been professional, but recognition, which was personal. The look that Kessarars gave each other in airports and embassies and grocery stores in foreign cities, the look that said: I know why you left. I know what it cost. I am still here.

“Welcome home,” she said, and stamped the passport.

Home. The word followed Fatou through customs and into the arrivals hall, where it was immediately drowned by noise. Voices in French, Dioula, Malinké, Soninké, and three languages she couldn’t identify, layered, overlapping, every conversation conducted in at least two languages and usually three. Car horns from the pickup lane outside, each horn a distinct personality, the irritated staccato of a taxi, the long plaintive note of a minibus, the brief polite tap of a private car. Music from a phone speaker somewhere, turned up to full volume, a guitar riff over a drum pattern she half-recognized. A grandmother in a gold-embroidered boubou stood near the exit, weeping into the shoulder of a young man who must have been away long enough for his return to mean something words couldn’t carry. The young man’s arms were around her and his eyes were closed and his suitcase sat forgotten beside him, and Fatou looked at them and then looked away because the scene was not hers to watch and she knew this and she watched anyway, the way journalists watch, with the part of the brain that files things for later.

Her fixer was at the edge of the crowd. Moussa, twenty-three, wearing a pressed white shirt with the collar starched so sharply it could have cut paper. He held a sign made from the back of a cardboard box, MENSAH FATOU, GPS, written in blue marker in handwriting that leaned to the right, the kind of handwriting that suggested hurry and care in equal measure.

“Ms. Mensah. Welcome.”

“Fatou. Please.”

“Fatou.” He smiled, open, immediate, the kind of smile that in a different economy would have been selling something on television. In this economy, it was selling competence and reliability to a foreign journalist who needed both and could afford to pay for neither at the rate they deserved. “I have a taxi. The hotel is forty minutes if the traffic is reasonable.”

“Is the traffic usually reasonable?”

“The traffic is never reasonable. But I am an optimist. In this country, that is a professional qualification.”

The taxi Moussa had waiting was a yellow Peugeot 504, dented, sun-faded, the dashboard cracked in three places. Half the taxis in West Africa were Peugeot 504s. They outlasted everything. The driver honked the horn like a musical instrument, producing long notes and short notes and trills that communicated, to other drivers, information that Fatou could not decode but that clearly meant something, because the traffic responded. Cars moved. Gaps opened. The horn was a language.

Moussa sat in the front and began narrating. He did it naturally, not the rehearsed patter of a tour guide but the instinctive commentary of a person who loved his city the way you love a difficult relative, with honesty and exasperation and a refusal to pretend things were other than they were.

“The construction on the left. That’s the new Ministry of Finance. Three years behind schedule. The contractor ran out of money. The government ran out of patience. They brought in a Turkish company to finish it. The Turkish company brought in a Chinese subcontractor. Nobody is sure who is building it anymore, but it will have twelve floors and a view of the ocean, which is nice if you are a minister and not nice if you are a fisherman whose beach was taken for the foundation.”

Fatou reached for her notebook. Then she stopped. She put it down. She needed to listen with her body first, the way her professor at Columbia had taught her: “Before you write, feel the ground. Feel the temperature. Feel the rhythm. The notebook comes after.”

She felt the ground. Through the taxi floor, through the worn seat, through the horn-language and the heat and the smell. The smell had changed since the airport, thickened, layered with charcoal smoke and the sharp green scent of crushed mint and the indefinable sweetness of ripe fruit and the diesel exhaust that sat beneath everything like a bass note.

Her phone rang. The screen said MAMA.

“Did you land safely?”

“Yes, Mama. Just got in the taxi.”

“Good. Good.” A pause. Her mother’s pauses were never empty. They were loaded, and you could tell by the length how much was being held back. This was a long pause. “Fatou, when you’re in the city, stay away from the Plateau district. The old part.” Fatou looked at Moussa’s back. He was talking to the driver about the traffic in rapid Dioula.

He was not listening to her call.

“Why?”

“There’s nothing there for you.”

“Mama, that’s not...”

“I have to go. Your aunt is calling. Be safe.”

The line went dead. Not a normal ending, not a click, not a return to the home screen. A closing. Fatou heard it in the flatness of her mother’s last sentence, *be safe*, two words her mother said every time they spoke, but this time delivered without warmth, delivered to end a conversation she should not have started. Her mother had never told her to avoid anywhere. Her mother had barely spoken about Kessara in twenty-two years. The country existed in their Toronto apartment as a collection of cooking smells and a radio station her father listened to on his phone and a set of customs (remove shoes at the door, greet elders with both hands, always offer water before business) that persisted without explanation. Kessara was the country her mother came from and did not discuss. The silence had thickened year by year until breaking it would require more force than anyone had.

Stay away from the Plateau district.

She put the phone down. The taxi crawled along the Corniche, the coastal road that curved from the airport toward the city center, the ocean on the right, the city rising on the left.

She had covered elections in Kenya, protests in Sudan, the aftermath of a coup two countries north. She knew how to read an African capital, the construction cranes that meant foreign money arriving, the checkpoints that meant the state was nervous, the campaign posters that meant someone was spending more than they could account for. She could write the dispatch in her sleep: “Country X faces a pivotal moment as voters prepare to decide the future of...”

But this was different. This was the country she came from. The country whose name she carried in her surname and whose food she craved on winter nights in Toronto: *thieboudienne*, the Senegalese-Kessaran fish-and-rice dish that her father made on Sundays, the smell filling the apartment, the rice stained red with tomato and

palm oil, the fish whole, the vegetables arranged around it in a pattern her father said was traditional and her mother said was just the way his mother did it. The country whose music she listened to without understanding the words because her father had spoken Dioula at home until she was twelve and then stopped, as if the language were a faucet he had turned off the day they left. Through the taxi window, the city scrolled past.

Construction cranes. She counted twelve before the road curved. New towers going up on every block, glass and steel, the architecture of money that had arrived from elsewhere.

Banks, hotels, a telecommunications tower with a Zhonglu logo. A half-built shopping complex with a banner in French and Mandarin: KESSARA GATEWAY: BUILDING TOMORROW TOGETHER.

Election posters on every surface: walls, lampposts, the sides of buses, the backs of truck cabs. President Diallo's face on the left: VOTE YES FOR KESSARA'S FUTURE. He looked tired in the photograph. His campaign team had chosen an image that projected steadiness, but what it actually projected was exhaustion, the exhaustion of a man who had been carrying something heavy for four years and had learned to stand upright under it but could not hide the weight from a camera. Aminata Kourouma's face on the right: SOVEREIGNTY IS NOT FOR SALE. She looked certain. Her photograph was better. Someone had lit it properly, angled her chin up, caught the intelligence in her eyes. Certainty photographs well. Military checkpoints at the major intersections. Gendarmes in camouflage behind sandbag positions. Their rifles were old. She recognized the model, French-made, a generation behind anything a modern military would deploy. Their eyes were young and sharp and attentive, men who had been told something might happen but not what.

And through everything, from every direction, the radio. Not one radio. Every radio. The sound leaked from shops and taxis and open windows and the phone speakers of men sitting on plastic chairs outside small businesses, and it combined into a single, pulsing, argumentative river of sound. The music came first. She recognized the structure now. Mbalax. The Senegalese-born rhythm that Kessara had adopted and remixed and claimed. Built on the sabar drum, the sharp, talking drum that could sound like laughter or argument depending on who was playing it, and the electric guitar, a clean tone with a chorus pedal, the melody climbing and falling in patterns that were not Western and not quite anything else, a sound that had been invented by fusion and had become, over decades, its own tradition. Between the guitar and the drum, a bass line that walked rather than ran, holding everything

together underneath.

Between the songs, the voices. Call-in shows. The country's conversation, live, unedited, conducted in French and Dioula simultaneously, the hosts switching between languages mid-sentence the way bilingual people do, not translating but thinking in two languages at once, each one carrying meanings the other couldn't. A woman's voice, in Dioula, Moussa translating in fragments: "The Chinese are not here to help us. They are here for what is under our feet. When they've taken it, they will leave. The French did this. The Americans do this. The difference is only the flag."

A man's voice, in French, immediately, the host barely managing the transition: "Then what do you propose? We owe eight billion dollars. We have two doctors for every six hundred patients. Our children leave for Europe and don't come back. At least the Chinese are offering to build something. What are you building? Speeches?"

The two voices were both angry and both right and both incomplete, and the fact that they followed each other without resolution, one fury answering another fury, neither canceling the other out, was the sound of a country that knew exactly what was wrong and could not agree on what was worse.

Moussa glanced at the radio and then at Fatou in the mirror. "Everyone has an opinion this week."

"What's yours?"

Moussa was quiet for a moment. The taxi passed through an intersection where a gendarme was directing traffic by hand, his white gloves cutting precise shapes in the air, his authority derived entirely from the fact that he was standing in the middle of the road and the cars had decided to obey him.

"My grandmother says the land is not ours to give," Moussa said. "She is from the Bassam region. Her family has farmed the same land for, I don't know how many generations. She says the land belongs to the dead and the unborn and we are just the ones walking on it now."

He shifted gears.

"My cousin says the land isn't feeding us anymore, so what's the difference. He went to university. He has a degree in agronomy. He works at a phone shop in the Médina because there are no jobs in agronomy."

He checked the mirror.

"My mother says she just wants the hospital to have medicine. Her brother, my uncle, is diabetic. He needs insulin. The clinic doesn't have it. He takes a bus to Port Sélani once a month and stands in line for four hours at the government hospital and sometimes they have it and sometimes they don't. She doesn't care about the Chinese.

She doesn't care about sovereignty. She cares about insulin."

He paused. "Everybody is right. That is the problem."

Fatou took out her notebook, physical, spiral-bound, Columbia Journalism School stamped on the cover, a relic of a professor who had insisted: "Phones die. Notebooks survive." She wrote down Moussa's words. All of them. Exactly as he said them.

The taxi passed through the edge of the Plateau district. Moussa pointed through the windshield.

"That building on the corner. That was the old Ministry of Mines. They moved to the new government complex a few years ago."

A colonial-era building. Two stories. Stone facade, the kind of stone the French quarried from the escarpment and shipped to the coast for their administrative buildings, heavy, gray, meant to project permanence. Shuttered windows, the wooden shutters warped by decades of humidity, some hanging at angles. A metal gate, padlocked, the padlock and the chain both rusted the same shade of brown, as if the rust were trying to join them permanently. Weeds grew from the gutter line. A crack ran from the second-floor window to the roofline, the building's own slow commentary on neglect.

Fatou looked at it and something tightened in her chest. Not recognition. She had been twelve when she left, and twelve-year-olds do not memorize government buildings. But something in her body answered the building before her mind could.

Something else. Deeper than memory. A pull, the kind of pull you feel when you walk past a house where something important happened to someone you love, you don't know the story, you can't see the evidence, but the building holds it and some part of you knows.

Stay away from the Plateau district.

She turned to ask Moussa about it, when was it closed, why, was there a story, but the call to prayer started. First from one mosque, then another, then a dozen at once. Voices layered on voices, each muezzin in his own register, the combined sound filling the car and the street and the spaces between buildings in a sound older than music and older than speech. Five times a day this happened. Five times a day the city paused its argument and remembered there was something older than the question on the ballot.

The moment passed. She let it go. But she didn't forget the building. And she didn't forget the pull.

In the front seat, Moussa watched her in the mirror. He said nothing.

The hotel was on the Corniche. Four stories. A rooftop bar. A room on the third floor with a window that looked out over the port. She stood at the window. Below her, the industrial geometry of a working port, container cranes, their long arms extended over the holds of ships, loading pallets of dark material.

Cargo ships at anchor, their hulls sitting low in the water under the weight of what they carried. She counted seven. The flags were visible, red, five yellow stars. Chinese. All of them.

Between the cargo ships, wooden fishing boats painted in colors that did not exist in the industrial palette, orange and turquoise and a yellow that was more feeling than color. The boats were heading out, their motors coughing blue smoke, their bows cutting the flat water of the harbor. The industrial and the traditional, occupying the same water, operating on different logics, neither acknowledging the other.

She picked up her phone. Warm in her hand. She turned it over, looking at the smooth glass, the thin metal frame. Somewhere inside, in the circuits, in the capacitors, in the battery that kept the screen alive, was a mineral called coltan. She knew this the way she knew most things about the global supply chain: professionally, factually, at a distance that allowed comprehension without guilt. Coltan came from countries like Kessara. It was pulled from the ground in sacks and shipped to processing plants in China and assembled into components and sold back to the world as part of a device that cost a thousand dollars. The mineral left Africa at eighty dollars a ton. It returned as the phone in her pocket at a markup that could fund a school district. The same weight, transformed. The same earth, repriced.

She held the phone and looked at the ships. Seven vessels, all outbound, all carrying raw material east. The port was the hinge, the point where Africa's ground became Asia's product. She was standing at the hinge, holding a device made from what passed through it.

She thought about her father. Amadou Mensah. A civil servant. A quiet man with a quiet job in a quiet office in a part of the government she had never fully understood.

What she remembered most was his hands. Sunday mornings in the Toronto apartment, the smell of tomato and palm oil reaching her bedroom before she was awake, pulling her down the hallway to the kitchen where her father stood at the stove with his sleeves rolled up, arranging the fish on the rice. He laid the vegetables around the plate in a careful pattern, carrots here, cabbage there, the cassava in a ring, and when Fatou asked why, he said it was traditional. Her mother, passing through with a coffee, said it was just the way his mother did it. He moved over the food with a care that did not match the rest of him, a man who filed documents for a living, who spoke

softly, who took up little space.

But at the stove on Sundays he was precise and unhurried and certain, and the kitchen smelled like a country Fatou was slowly forgetting, and her father's face, in the steam, looked like the face of a man who was briefly home. He came home one evening and told them they were leaving. "Opportunity," he said. Her mother packed a single suitcase. Only soft things: clothes, a blanket, a stuffed animal Fatou had slept with since she was four. No picture frames. No hard edges. Nothing that would break. The packing took an hour. An entire life, sorted into what would survive a journey and what would not.

Fatou had been twelve. She had stood in the hallway of their apartment in the Plateau district, the apartment she could no longer picture clearly, the details gone except for the hallway, which was narrow and dark and had a tile floor that was cold under bare feet, and she had asked her mother: "Will we come back?"

"Of course," her mother said.

Twenty-two years later, here she was. And "of course" had become the family's oldest prayer, the kind of thing you say at an airport because the truth is too heavy to carry through the departure gate, the kind of promise that is not a lie because the person saying it believes it in the moment, the way a drowning person believes in the hand they're reaching for.

She opened her notebook. Pages of Moussa's words, her own shorthand, fragments from the corridor villages. She turned to a fresh page and wrote: Six days. One question. Twenty-eight million answers.

She looked at it. Tight. Professional. A wire-service sentence, the kind of thing you file when you haven't yet understood what you're looking at and you need to send something before the deadline. Below it, she wrote: The question is not whether to take the deal. The question is whether there was ever a choice.

She closed the notebook. She put her glasses back on. They had stopped fogging in the air conditioning. She looked at her reflection in the window, superimposed on the port and the ships and the ocean beyond. A thirty-four-year-old woman with a Canadian passport and a Kessaran surname and a notebook full of professional reflexes and, beneath them, a question she had carried since she was twelve years old and had never found the right moment to open.

Stay away from the Plateau district.

She picked up the phone again. She scrolled to the photograph she had taken from the taxi.

The old Ministry of Mines. Shuttered. Chained. Weeds in the gutter. A crack running from the window to the roof.

Her mother's building. Her father's building. The building where something happened that made them leave.

She didn't know this yet. She wouldn't know it for five more days, until a woman named Madame Konaté told her the story in a kitchen with a cracked tile floor and chickens in the courtyard. But the pull was there, in her chest, behind her ribs, in the place where inherited knowledge lives before the mind catches up.

She was a journalist. She was also a daughter coming home to something she didn't understand yet.

Everything else was the cover story.

Chapter 4

Aminata Kourouma had a rule: never enter a room angry. She broke it every morning. She was just careful about it.

The campaign office was on the second floor of a building that also housed a tailor, a mobile phone shop, and an accountant who was either very busy or very loud, his voice came through the floor at all hours, rising and falling in heated Dioula as he debated figures with unseen clients. The stairwell smelled of starch from the tailor's pressing iron and the warm-plastic scent of new phone cases. The floor of the hallway was concrete, unfinished, the kind of surface that municipal buildings in Port Sélani had because the budget for flooring was always redirected to something more urgent, and eventually people stopped noticing.

Her office was at the end of the hall. A room that had been a storage closet in a previous life. You could see the marks on the wall where shelving had been removed. It was small enough that the desk took up half the floor space. A window looked onto the street below, where the morning's first vendors were setting up stalls and a woman was frying beignets in a vat of oil, the smell rising through the window, hot oil, dough, and sugar, mixing with the dust and the exhaust and becoming part of the air Aminata breathed every working day.

On the walls: a framed copy of the Kessaran constitution, a map of the Bassam Corridor marked with colored pins she had placed herself, and a photograph of Sékou Bassam. The independence leader, the man who had stood in the Place de la République in 1962 and said "We are free." Three syllables that had carried a nation for sixty-three years and were now, depending on whom you asked, either the foundation of the No campaign or the most ironic sentence in Kessaran history.

On her desk: legal files, polling data, a laptop she kept closed until the first meeting ended because screens consumed the attention she needed for faces. A cold cup of coffee from yesterday that she had not removed because removing it required walking to the kitchen and the kitchen was past the meeting space and walking past it meant being seen and being seen meant being talked to and she was not ready to be talked to. Not yet.

She closed her office door. She turned the key. The lock was heavy, an old French mechanism, brass, the kind installed when the building was new and doors were expected to do the job of keeping things separate. The sound of the bolt sliding into the frame was solid, definitive, the sound of a woman buying herself sixty seconds of privacy in a life that had almost none. She sat at her desk. She opened the bottom drawer.

The drawer was deep. It held three things: a box of tissues she never used in public, a sealed envelope containing a handwritten letter she had composed to the families of political detainees during her first year at The Hague and never sent, and a photograph in a wooden frame.

She took out the photograph.

Moussa. Her brother. Twenty-two years old in the picture. The photograph had been taken at the university, you could see a corner of the lecture hall behind him, the edge of a chalkboard, the fluorescent light giving his skin a slightly blue cast that flattened the features and made everyone in photographs from that era look like they were standing underwater.

But Moussa looked like himself. He always did. The camera could not diminish him. He had a face that committed to its expressions. When he was serious, as he was here, the seriousness went all the way through, from the set of his jaw to the stillness of his eyes. He did not pose for cameras. He arrived in front of them with whatever he was already carrying and let the lens deal with it.

He was wearing the blue shirt. She had bought it for him, a birthday gift, his twenty-second, purchased at a market stall in the Médina with money she had saved from her first internship at the legal aid clinic. The shirt was good cotton, a deep blue that held its color through washes, with a collar that sat properly without being starched. Moussa had liked it.

He wore it twice a week. He was wearing it the evening he left for the meeting, and this fact, the shirt she had given him, chosen for him, carried home in a plastic bag from the market, was the detail that destroyed her every time, because it placed her hands on the last thing he wore, and her hands had not touched him since. November 1997. The military government. Moussa was a student activist, not the loud kind, not the kind who led chants and climbed onto platforms. The quiet kind. The kind who organized logistics: meeting rooms, printed materials, transport for speakers from other campuses. He was the person who made sure the chairs were arranged and the water was on the table and the photocopies were collated. He was meticulous. He was, in his organizing, almost bureaucratic, a trait Aminata now recognized as the family

inheritance, the Kourouma precision, the same instinct that had sent her to law school and then to Oxford and then to The Hague, the instinct that said: if you are going to challenge a system, you must first understand exactly how it works.

He went to a meeting one evening. He told their mother he would be home for dinner. He said this in the hallway of the apartment, their parents' apartment, second floor, the building with the blue shutters on Rue Faidherbe that had been renamed after independence but that everyone still called by its French name because names, like currencies, outlast the regimes that issue them. Their mother was cooking. The smell of groundnut soup, rich, thick, the peanut steam filling the hallway. Moussa put on his shoes at the door. He did not tie them tightly. He expected to be taking them off again in two hours.

He was not home for dinner. He was not home the next day. He was not home the next week.

Twenty-eight years. No body. No trial. No phone call in the night. No officer arriving at the door with a form to sign. No grave to visit. No stone to place a hand on. Just absence. A chair at the table that was never removed because removing it was an admission and the family was not ready to admit.

Three democratic governments had each promised to investigate. Each had appointed a commission. Each commission had conducted interviews, gathered documents, published a preliminary report, and then, gradually, without announcement, gone quiet. The files were closed. Not officially. Officials did not close files officially because official closure implied official knowledge and official knowledge implied official responsibility. The files were simply no longer active. They sat in drawers in government offices, growing old, waiting for someone to care enough to open them.

Her daughter, Hawa, was twelve. She had Aminata's eyes, dark, wide-set, and direct, but when she frowned, it was Moussa's face that surfaced. The same line between the brows, the same downward pull at the corners of the mouth. Aminata saw it every morning across the breakfast table and said nothing, because saying something would mean explaining Moussa, and explaining Moussa would mean explaining the chair that was never removed, and the shirt in the bottom drawer, and the reason her mother had spent twenty-eight years building a legal career on the foundation of one unanswered question. Hawa did not know she had an uncle. Aminata had been meaning to tell her for years and had not yet found the morning or the words.

She put the photograph back in the drawer. She closed the drawer. She placed both palms flat on the desk and pressed down, a grounding gesture, a physical reset. She breathed in through her nose and out through her mouth. She unlocked the door. She walked into the meeting.

Everything she had built, the law degree, the Oxford fellowship, the years at The Hague, the party, the campaign, this office above a tailor's shop, was a structure erected on top of a hole in the ground where her brother should have been. She knew this. The knowledge was the foundation. Remove it and everything above it collapsed. The conference room was the largest of the three offices: a table that seated eight, walls covered in campaign materials and district maps, a whiteboard where someone had written SIX DAYS in red marker and circled it twice. Eight chairs. Seven occupied.

Her inner circle. Diop, Camara, and Sow, the lawyers, all three trained at the University of Port Sélan, all three veterans of the legal aid years. They worked for conviction and a salary that required conviction, because nobody who cared about money would have taken it.

Binta and Rachid, the organizers. Binta was from the Médina and knew every neighborhood leader, every market association chair, every imam who would listen. Rachid was from the north and knew the rural networks, the village chiefs, the farmers' cooperatives, the women's credit unions that operated beneath the formal economy like roots beneath pavement. Oumar, the media director, fast, bilingual, capable of writing a press release in French and translating it into Dioula and Malinké in the time it took to drink a coffee.

And Derek.

Derek Coleman was forty-one, American, and he worked for the Alderton Foundation. He sat at the far end of the table with a tablet propped in front of him showing polling numbers that refreshed from a server in Virginia. He wore a pressed shirt, open at the collar, and he had the confidence of a man who had been sent by people with money to help people without money and had not yet examined the assumptions embedded in that arrangement.

The Foundation paid for democracy programs across Africa: voter education, press freedom, civil society capacity building. Good things. Necessary things. Two point three million dollars a year to the DFA, routed through grants with names that could have been generated by an algorithm: Civic Engagement Initiative, Governance Capacity Building, Democratic Participation Fund. The paperwork was spotless.

Derek's job was simple: make sure the campaign's message reached Washington and London and Brussels. Make sure CNN picked it up. Make sure the donors saw results they recognized. This morning, he was excited.

"Six-point swing overnight," he said. He tapped the tablet. "The leaked terms are devastating. SEZ provisions, Chinese courts, Chinese security forces, people are furious. This is the moment. We hammer it. Every press conference, every radio hit.

Sovereignty, sovereignty, sovereignty."

Aminata watched him. She watched the way she had learned to watch at The Hague, not the words but the assumptions behind them, the architecture of the argument, the floor plan of the building someone was trying to sell her. "The sovereignty message works in Port Sélani," she said. "It works at the university. It works on radio call-in shows. It does not work in the Bassam villages." "Why not?"

"Because a farmer in the corridor doesn't wake up thinking about jurisdiction. He wakes up thinking about whether the road to the market will be paved before the rains destroy what's left of it. Tell him the Chinese deal gives him Chinese courts and he'll ask: does it give me a road? Tell him it compromises sovereignty and he'll ask: does sovereignty fix the water pump?"

Binta nodded. Rachid was already nodding. They had run these conversations in the districts. They knew.

"Then we localize it," Derek said. "Same message, different frame. 'The Chinese road comes with Chinese rules. Do you want Chinese police in your village?'"

"That's not what the deal says."

"It's what the deal implies."

"I'm a lawyer, Derek. Implications don't hold up. And the farmers know the difference between a claim and a contract. They've been sold things before."

He smiled. He always smiled when she pushed back, the smile of a man who believed that disagreement was a phase in the process rather than a conclusion. She had worked with Americans long enough to recognize the pattern: listen, acknowledge, wait, restate. The assumption was that persistence equaled persuasion. In Kessara, persistence equaled rudeness, but Derek had not been here long enough to know that.

She ended the meeting early. "Back at two. Bring district-level data, not national polling. I need to know what the corridor villages are hearing, not what Port Sélani is tweeting."

Everyone left except Khadija.

Khadija Touré. Forty-seven. Chief of staff. Northern province. She had survived two coups, a famine, and a marriage to a man who had joined the military government and then, when the government fell, discovered that his wife's quiet record-keeping during those years had been more deliberate than he imagined. She divorced him. She kept the records. She joined Aminata's legal aid organization in 2009 and had not left.

Khadija closed the door without being asked. This was their rhythm. The meeting ended, everyone left, the door closed, and the real conversation began.

"The Foundation wire came through yesterday," Khadija said. She did not sit down. She delivered information standing, the way soldiers deliver reports. "Three hundred and forty thousand dollars. Earmarked for 'media engagement.'"

"Who authorized it?"

"The memo came from their DC office. You weren't copied." Aminata looked at her. Khadija looked back. They had known each other for sixteen years.

The look was a complete conversation: This is a problem. I know it's a problem. I'm telling you because you need to know.

What you do with it is yours.

Three hundred and forty thousand dollars. For purposes she hadn't approved. From people who hadn't told her.

She had known what the Foundation's money was from the beginning. She had taken it with her eyes open because the alternative was not having a campaign. You could not run a national operation on conviction alone. You needed offices and staff and radio time and vehicles and printing and the thousand small expenses that turned an idea into an organization. You needed money. In Kessara, money without conditions was money that did not exist.

But three hundred and forty thousand she hadn't asked for, arriving in her campaign like a guest who walks into your house while you're out and rearranges the furniture, that was different. That was a hand on a lever she hadn't known was connected to her machine.

"Find out what they're spending it on," Aminata said. "Quietly. Don't use the Foundation's communication channels. And don't tell Derek."

"Aminata." Khadija paused. This was rare. Khadija did not pause. "Be careful with this. If you pull the thread and the sweater comes apart, you're standing in public with no clothes." "I know."

"Do you?"

They looked at each other. Two women in their forties, running a campaign in a country that took everything from women who tried to lead and then asked why they

were angry. What held them together was not friendship exactly. It was the more durable thing that forms when two people have seen each other fail and chosen to continue.

“Find out what they’re spending it on,” Aminata said again. “I need to know what I’m wearing before I decide whether to take it off.”

Ambassador Hartley called at noon. James Hartley, United States Ambassador to the Republic of Kessara. Career diplomat. Thirty years. Georgetown accent laid over fluent French like wallpaper over old plaster, covering the surface, not changing the structure.

“Just checking in. How’s the campaign feeling?”

“Like a campaign, Mr. Ambassador.”

“Good, good. We’re watching with interest. You know our position. The United States supports Kessara’s sovereign right to make its own decisions.”

She could recite it. She could also translate it.

“I appreciate the call.”

“One more thing, Aminata. Concern in Washington about the security situation. The northeast. Reports of private military contractors recruiting young men from the border regions. If there’s anything we can do to support electoral security.”

“We have it under control.”

“Of course. Of course.”

He hung up. She put the phone on the desk. Hartley was not a bad man. He probably believed every word he said. A liar you can fight, you find the lie, you expose it, you move on. A man who honestly believes he is helping while the system he represents extracts, that you just have to outlast.

She had fourteen minutes before the next meeting. She spent them at the window, looking at the street below. The beignet woman was doing brisk business, a queue of six, school children in uniforms, the oil popping and the dough browning and the sugar dusted on with a spoon. The accountant’s voice came through the floor: “Five hundred thousand! Not four!

Five!” A motorcycle passed too fast. A child laughed.

The ordinary life of a city that continued regardless of what happened in campaign offices.

She thought about Moussa. The blue shirt. The meeting he went to, the chairs he would have arranged, the photocopies he would have made. Her brother, the quiet organizer, who understood that revolutions are not made by the people on the stage but by the people who set up the chairs. He would have been fifty this year. He might

have been a lawyer. He might have been a teacher. He might have been a father who tied his daughter's shoes in the morning and cooked groundnut soup on Sundays the way their mother had. He might have been anything. That was the weight of a disappearance, not the single thing you lost but the infinite things you would never know.

She turned from the window. She went to the next meeting. She made decisions. She gave instructions. She performed the leadership that seven people needed from her, and the performance was not false. The decisions were sound, the strategy was real, her mind was where the campaign needed it to be.

But beneath the performance, beneath the legal arguments and the polling data and the message discipline, the bottom drawer was always open. The blue shirt was always there.

And the question that had driven her from a legal aid clinic to Oxford to The Hague to this office above a tailor's shop was always the same: What happened to my brother, and when will someone answer for it?

The referendum was not the answer. The referendum was the closest she had come to building something large enough to make the question impossible to ignore.

Chapter 5

Chen Liwei loved the quiet of engineering. Not silence. Silence was the absence of information, and absence was something an engineer distrusted. Quiet was different. Quiet was the state of a system in equilibrium, every load accounted for, every force balanced, every number pointing at the same conclusion. The soil bore weight or it didn't. The gradient was steep or manageable. A beam held or it failed. In eighteen years of building things in countries where the language changed and the politics shifted and the rules were rewritten between breakfast and lunch, the clean certainty of structural calculation was the one constant. The numbers did not care who was president. The concrete did not know which flag flew over the ministry.

She sat in the Zhonglu Development Corporation's project office, a converted warehouse near the Port Sélani docks, and reviewed the soil surveys for the Bassam rail corridor.

The warehouse had been a fish processing plant in a previous life. The conversion had been functional, not thorough. The concrete floor still had the drainage channels, shallow grooves cut in a herringbone pattern, angling toward floor drains that had been capped but not removed. On humid mornings, when the port air pushed in through the loading bay doors, a faint salt tang rose from the concrete as if the building were sweating out its former self. The walls were corrugated metal on the ocean side, cinder block on the street side. The metal walls expanded in the heat. She could hear them ticking in the afternoon, the same sound as a cooling roof, but in reverse, the building growing slightly larger as the temperature climbed, then contracting at night. An engineer noticed these things. An engineer could not help noticing, because buildings were not static. They expanded and contracted and responded to their environment, and the difference between a building that stood and a building that fell was the difference between an engineer who noticed and one who didn't.

Her desk was a sheet of plywood on two sawhorses. Her laptop sat on it, a laptop, matte black, three years old, the screen slightly dimmer than when it was new but still functional. Beside the laptop: the soil survey binders, the topographic maps, a

calculator she used even though the laptop had one because the physical act of pressing buttons helped her think, and a thermos of green tea she had brought from her room because the office kitchen stocked only instant coffee and instant coffee was, in her professional opinion, an insult to the concept of beverages.

The data was promising. Laterite base across the coastal plain, a reddish-brown soil formed by the weathering of iron-rich rock, dense, well-drained, with a bearing capacity of 180 to 220 kilopascals per square meter. Good ground. The kind of ground you could build on without spending half the budget on foundation reinforcement. She had worked with worse. The black cotton soil in western Kenya that swelled when wet and cracked when dry, turning a road into a roller coaster in two rainy seasons. Laterite was a gift.

The gradient from the coast to the plateau averaged four percent over the first hundred kilometers. Four percent was gentle, a rise of four meters for every hundred meters of horizontal distance. A train could handle four percent without additional traction. The gradient steepened near the escarpment, six percent through the ridge, which required either switchbacks (expensive, slow, maintenance-intensive) or tunnels.

She had run the tunnel calculations three times. The ridge at kilometer 287 presented a clean cross-section: metamorphic rock, primarily gneiss, with predictable foliation patterns.

Two tunnels required, one of 800 meters through the main ridge, one of 600 meters through a secondary spur. Total bore: 1.4 kilometers. The gneiss was hard but consistent, the kind of rock that tunnel boring machines were designed for, no sudden voids, no unexpected aquifers, no pockets of loose material that could collapse during excavation.

She had modeled the stress distribution, the ventilation requirements, the drainage gradient within the bore, the emergency egress spacing. The numbers held.

She made notes in the margins of the survey report. Her handwriting was a hybrid, Mandarin characters for the technical terms she had learned at Tsinghua University, English for the field terminology she had picked up across four African countries, French for the geological classifications that Kessaran surveys used because the country's geological survey had been established by the French and still used French nomenclature. Three languages in the same margin, in handwriting so small and precise that a colleague had once told her it looked like circuit diagrams. She had taken this as a compliment.

She had become an engineer because of her mother's hands. This was not a story she told people. It was not a dramatic origin, no flash of inspiration, no mentor's speech, no moment of destiny.

Her mother, Zhou Meifang, was seventy-four and lived alone in a Shenzhen apartment that Liwei paid for and visited twice a year. Her mother had been a factory worker for thirty years, textiles first, then electronics assembly, then back to textiles when the electronics plant moved to Vietnam. She had worked on production lines that required her hands to repeat the same motion, feeding fabric through a machine, soldering connections on a circuit board, stitching seams, thousands of times a day, six days a week. By the time Liwei was fourteen, her mother's hands ached every evening. She would come home and soak them in a basin of warm water at the kitchen table, flexing her fingers slowly, and the sound she made, not a groan, not a complaint, just a quiet exhalation, the sound of a body adjusting to the pain it carried, was the sound that shaped Liwei's life.

She decided at fourteen that she would build things. Not the things her mother made, garments, circuits, products that were consumed and discarded, but the structures inside which people worked. If the factory were designed differently, if the workstation were at the right height, if the motion were optimized, if the engineering of the space accounted for the engineering of the body, then the hands would hurt less. That was the theory. It was the theory of a fourteen-year-old watching her mother soak her fingers, and it was naive, and it was also the reason Liwei had spent eighteen years building highways, dams, bridges, and rail lines across a continent that her mother had never visited and could not find on a map.

The bridge in Kenya. She carried it the way she carried her mother's memory, close to the chest, invisible, the thing she reached for when the calculations felt abstract and the project felt like numbers on a screen. A pedestrian bridge over the Nyando River, outside Kisumu. Twelve meters long. Simple steel truss, concrete abutments. The village on the east bank had been cut off from the school and the clinic on the west bank during the rainy season. The river flooded, the ford became impassable, and for four months of the year the children did not go to school and the sick did not reach the doctor. Six people had drowned in the crossing in the previous five years.

Liwei's team built the bridge in three weeks. On the day it opened, a girl, seven years old, wearing a school uniform, carrying a bag that was too big for her, walked across it holding Liwei's hand, small, dry, warm, gripping her fingers as if unsure they would stay. The bridge was real. The girl was alive because of it. No politics, no trade

deal, no diplomatic calculation could take that away. This was the certainty that Liwei carried, the certainty that building things mattered, that a twelve-meter span of steel over a river in

Kenya was proof that engineering served human life, and that the complications and compromises and corruptions that surrounded every project she had ever worked on did not erase the bridge. Or so she had always believed.

Her phone buzzed. Mei's face on the screen. Calling from Shenzhen. Four in the afternoon there. Ten in the morning here. "Mama."

"Mei-Mei." The screen filled with a face that changed every time they spoke. Fourteen now. New haircut, short on one side, swept across on the other, copied from a Korean pop star whose name Liwei did not know. Behind Mei, the apartment, and each time they called, Liwei scanned the background the way she scanned a construction site, looking for what had changed since the last inspection. The bookshelf had been rearranged. New manga volumes on the top shelf. A poster on the wall that hadn't been there last month, a band, Korean, five young men in elaborate outfits. The apartment was modern, clean, well-lit, white walls, bamboo flooring, the mid-range Shenzhen aesthetic of a tech-sector salary. Things Liwei had not chosen. Furniture she had not sat in. A home she funded and did not live in.

The divorce had been three years ago. Jianming had said it was the travel. The months apart. The birthdays missed, Mei's eleventh, twelfth, thirteenth. The school concerts. The parent-teacher meetings. The ordinary infrastructure of a family that requires presence the way a bridge requires abutments, and you cannot build abutments from six thousand kilometers away.

He said it calmly. Rationally. The way an engineer would describe a structural failure, no blame, no recrimination, just load exceeding capacity. The structure could not hold. It was not a question of fault. It was a question of physics.

She had not argued because he was right.

"Bàba says I can get a puppy if you say yes."

"We'll talk about it when I'm home."

"When are you coming home?"

The question she could not answer honestly. Eighteen months of preliminary work. Five months in. Her contract said twelve more. A referendum that might cancel everything or might change nothing.

"Soon."

"You always say soon."

"And I always mean it."

“Meaning it and doing it are different things, Mama.”

Liwei looked at her daughter’s face on the screen. The directness. Jianming’s jaw, her own eyes. A girl who was learning, at fourteen, that promises only matter when they arrive.

“You’re right,” Liwei said. “They are different things.” Mei held up her math homework. Geometry, angle bisectors and perpendicular lines. Liwei solved it in her head in three seconds. The angles were basic. But she walked Mei through it step by step. Identify the known values, state the theorem, build toward the answer the way you build a bridge, one support at a time, because helping with homework was the one act of mothering she could perform from this distance. It wasn’t enough. Nothing transmitted through a screen was enough. But a girl who understood angle bisectors today would understand load distribution tomorrow, and the line between those two things was the line Liwei had walked her entire career.

They hung up. The warehouse was quiet. The port sounds came through the metal walls, cranes, diesel engines, the hollow clang of containers being stacked. Outside, the heat was pressing against the roof, and the metal was beginning its afternoon expansion, tick, tick, tick, the building growing.

She went back to the soil surveys. For two more hours, she worked. The gradients held. The tunnels were feasible. The drainage models confirmed what the topographic data predicted.

The world, contained inside the calculations, was coherent. Ambassador Zhou Xinran arrived at eleven-thirty. Without appointment.

She stood in the doorway of Liwei’s office, if you could call a plywood desk in a converted fish warehouse an office, and did not sit down. Zhou was sixty. Career diplomat. Fluent in French, conversational in Dioula, functionally fluent in the body language of five African countries. She had run Chinese diplomatic and commercial operations across the continent for fifteen years and had reached the stage of her career where surprise was no longer available to her and disappointment had been replaced by management.

She wore a dark suit. Her hair was cut short and precise. She looked at the soil surveys on Liwei’s desk the way someone reads a balance sheet, not for the data but for the leverage.

“The referendum campaign is creating visibility problems,” Zhou said. “Protests near the project site. International media arriving daily. You are not to speak to journalists under any circumstances.”

“I understand.”

“You are to continue preliminary engineering work as if the referendum were not happening.

The timeline does not change.”

“The timeline depends on the referendum result.”

Zhou looked at her. The look of someone who has just heard an employee state a fact that is true and irrelevant simultaneously. “The timeline does not change.”

Liwei nodded. She had learned, eighteen years, four countries, when to push and when to record the instruction and move on. “One more thing.” Zhou was already turning to leave. “The facilitation arrangements for the corridor communities, those are handled by my office. You don’t need to involve yourself.” “What facilitation arrangements?”

“Exactly,” Zhou said, and left.

The door closed. The warehouse was the same warehouse. The surveys were the same surveys. The gradients were the same gradients.

But something had shifted. A door she hadn’t known existed had been opened a crack and shut in her face. “Facilitation arrangements” was a phrase with weight, the kind of phrase that appears in audit reports and corruption investigations and the footnotes of deals that are later described as “problematic.” She had heard phrases like it before. In Kenya, in Ethiopia, in Angola. They were the sounds a project made when part of its budget was going somewhere the engineering drawings didn’t show.

She turned back to her laptop. She opened the full deal text, the document that had been circulating since the leak yesterday. She found Article 7, Section 3.

Security within the corridor shall be provided by a contracted entity designated by the project operator, subject to coordination with the Kessaran National Gendarmerie.

She read it as an engineer. Security fencing: what gauge of wire, what height, what spacing of posts. Access points: vehicle and pedestrian, controlled or uncontrolled, barrier type.

Perimeter clearances: how many meters between the fence and the nearest structure.

Guard stations: placement, line of sight, communication infrastructure.

These things affected her work. They were part of the site layout. They mattered.

She did not read the clause the way a twenty-six-year-old farmer’s son six hundred kilometers away would read it, as the legal framework that had put a rifle in his hands, that had paid him eight hundred dollars a month to do things he would not tell his father about, and that would not let him leave.

She closed the document. She went back to the soil surveys. The laterite was still promising. The gradient was still four percent. The tunnels were still 1.4 kilometers of clean gneiss.

The numbers held. They always held. That was the gift of engineering, the certainty. The numbers did not lie. The numbers did not facilitate. The numbers were what they were. But something had shifted underfoot. The floor still held. The surveys were the same. But she knew now that there was a crack in the foundation, and knowing changed where she put her weight.

Chapter 6

Awa Traoré read the message three times in the second-floor bathroom of the university library before she deleted it. The bathroom was small. Two stalls, one sink, a mirror with a crack running diagonally from corner to corner that made your reflection look like it had been cut in half and reassembled slightly wrong. The air conditioning had broken in February, a compressor failure, the maintenance office said, parts on order, the parts never arriving because the maintenance budget had been spent on something else, nobody knew what, and by March the heat had settled into the room like a tenant who refused to leave. The window was frosted glass, sealed shut. The light was fluorescent, the greenish-white of institutional bulbs that made everyone's skin look slightly ill.

She stood at the sink. The phone in her hand. The screen bright in the ugly light.

We know where you live.

Sent at 3:47 that morning. No profile picture. No post history. No previous messages. An account created for the sole purpose of sending five words to a twenty-two-year-old student who ran a social media account that fourteen thousand people followed. She read it a first time and her stomach tightened, not fear exactly, but the tightening that comes just before fear. She read it a second time and her mind engaged, who, why, how did they find the account, was it traceable, was it a bot, was it a troll, was it someone who knew her. She read it a third time and her thumb moved to the delete button and she pressed it and the message disappeared and the screen showed the inbox as it had been before, supportive, angry, curious, rude, the usual traffic of a political account in a country where politics was personal and the personal was dangerous.

She flushed the toilet she had not used. She washed her hands she did not need to wash.

The water was warm. It was always warm, the pipes ran through the outer wall and the sun heated them, so the cold tap produced warm water and the hot tap produced nothing because the boiler had been disconnected years ago. She dried them on her jeans because the paper towel dispenser was empty and had been empty since she

started at the university three years ago. She looked at herself in the cracked mirror. Her mother's cheekbones. Her father's jaw. Eyes that her friends called too serious, which was probably fair. She was twenty-two years old and she had just received a threat and she was about to stand in front of forty-three people and tell them what to do this week and none of them would know about the five words because the five words were hers and she would carry them alone.

She was not afraid.

She kept telling herself this.

The student union building was a three-story concrete block on the north end of campus, built in the 1980s with Soviet development money, the architecture of a generation when the Cold War expressed itself through university buildings and hydroelectric dams. The concrete was stained with water damage. The stairwell smelled of cooking oil from the cafeteria on the ground floor, where a woman named Madame Sow had been frying plantains and serving rice-and-sauce for seventeen years and whose food was the only thing about the university that worked exactly as it should every single day.

The meeting room was on the third floor. No air conditioning. The windows were open and the city came in with the heat, traffic on the boulevard, a motorcycle accelerating too fast, the call to prayer from the mosque three blocks south, and beneath everything, cycling every fifteen seconds, the chant of a man selling phone credit from a stall at the campus gate: "Orange! Orange! Crédit Orange!"

Forty-three people. She had counted them as they entered, a habit from her organizing work, the instinct to know exactly how many people were present and where the exits were. Most of the faces she knew. Law students, political science, a handful of engineering students who could read the technical specifications of the deal better than either campaign's policy team. Aïssata Bâ, who ran the women's caucus and had the organizational patience of someone twice her age. Mamadou Diakité, who managed the social media accounts for the Mouvement de la Jeunesse Souveraine, the MJS, Awa's student movement, and could turn a leaked provision into a viral graphic in twenty minutes. Ibrahima Sow, a different Ibrahima, not her brother, the name was common, who handled logistics, the buses, the printing, the small machinery of protest. Three faces she did not know. Back row, far right. Two men, one woman. The men wore clean shirts and the careful blankness of people who had decided to observe rather than participate. The woman had a notebook but was not writing in it. They had arrived together, sat together, and spoken to no one.

After the message this morning, every stranger was a question. Awa did not use notes. Notes were for people who hadn't decided what they believed. She stood at the front, no podium, no microphone, just her body and her voice and the heat from the open windows, and she ran through the week.

"Monday. Teach-in at the Faculty of Law. We explain the SEZ provisions in language everyone can understand."

She paused. She looked at the room. This was the part that mattered, not the schedule but the substance.

"Let me show you how to explain it. Don't use legal language. Don't use the word 'jurisdiction.' Don't use the word 'sovereignty.' Those words are for people who already agree with us. We need the people who don't."

She picked up a marker and drew a rectangle on the whiteboard. Inside it, she wrote CORRIDOR.

"This is the Bassam Corridor. Four hundred kilometers. Under the deal, this becomes a Special Economic Zone. You know what that means legally. Here's what it means for your cousin who works in the processing plant."

She drew a stick figure inside the rectangle.

"Your cousin, let's call him Moussa, everyone is called Moussa," a laugh from the crowd, "Moussa works at the mineral processing facility. Good job. Eight hundred thousand francs a month. Better than the market. Better than farming. He's happy."

She drew an X on the stick figure's arm.

"Moussa's hand gets caught in a machine. His fingers are broken. He can't work. He wants compensation. He wants a doctor. He wants someone to say: the machine was not maintained properly and the company is responsible."

She tapped the rectangle.

"Outside this rectangle, Moussa goes to a Kessaran court. A Kessaran judge. Kessaran labor law. The case takes a year, maybe two, because our courts are slow, but eventually someone listens. Inside this rectangle, inside the SEZ, Moussa goes to an arbitration panel. Three members. Two appointed by Zhonglu. One appointed by the Kessaran government. The hearing is in French and Mandarin. The labor standards are Chinese.

Moussa does not speak Chinese. Moussa has never read the Chinese labor code. Moussa's broken fingers are assessed under a legal system that was not designed for him, in a language he does not speak, by a panel where the company that broke his fingers has a two-to-one majority."

They were listening.

“That is what the SEZ means. Not sovereignty. Not jurisdiction. Moussa’s fingers.”

She capped the marker.

“When you go to the villages this week, don’t talk about the constitution. Talk about Moussa. Everyone knows a Moussa.” “Tuesday: the rally at Place de la République. Aminata Kourouma’s people have the stage.

We don’t need the stage. We need to be visible. Banners. Chants. Film everything, phones up, cameras rolling. If the gendarmerie moves, we document. We don’t run. We record.”

“Wednesday and Thursday: Bassam Corridor. Three buses.” She looked at Ibrahima Sow.

“The buses are confirmed?”

“Confirmed. A church in the Médina is lending us two. The third is Rachid’s cousin’s, he’s charging us fuel cost only.” “Good. We go to the villages and we listen. I mean it, we listen more than we speak. These are people whose land is on the line. Their families have been farming that soil since before this university had a foundation stone. They don’t need students from Port Sélani lecturing them about sovereignty. They need to know that someone in this country gives a damn about what happens to their millet.”

“Friday is for whatever Friday brings.”

“Saturday: we vote. Every one of us. And we make sure everyone we’ve talked to this week votes. Not a suggestion. Not optional. Voting is the one thing they cannot take unless we hand it over.” Questions came. She answered them the way she answered everything, fast, direct, with the sharpness that her father would have called unnecessary and her mother, if her mother were alive, would have called inherited.

Her mother. Aïssatou. Awa was fourteen when she died. Old enough to remember. Young enough that the memories had the quality of photographs rather than film, frozen moments, no movement, no sound. Her mother’s hands shelling groundnuts in the compound yard. Her mother’s voice calling her in from the field at dusk. Her mother’s body in the bed in the last weeks, smaller each day, the illness taking her the way drought takes a field, not all at once but slowly, a little less each morning, until the bed held more absence than body.

She did not think about her mother often. She thought about her father, who was alive and stubborn and standing in a field refusing to sell, and she thought about Ibrahim, who was gone and silent, and she thought about Sékou, who was nineteen and quiet and present and holding the farm together because someone had to. A boy

spending his youth on soil that was not his problem, missing the years he should have spent learning or leaving or finding out who he was holding a hoe. The responsibility had chosen him. He had not complained. And the silence cost him something too. Her mother she carried differently, not as a thought but as a posture. The straightness of her spine when she stood in front of people. The refusal to cry in public. The way she controlled her voice when she was angry, pitching it lower instead of higher, which was something her mother had done and which Awa had inherited the way you inherit the color of your eyes, without choosing, without noticing, until someone points it out.

After the meeting, she stood by the door and shook hands. She thanked people by name, because names mattered. When you asked someone to stand in a crowd where tear gas was possible, the least you owed them was knowing what to call them.

The three strangers left without introducing themselves. They moved together down the stairwell. The woman's notebook was still blank. Awa watched them go and memorized what she could. The taller man's watch (gold, too expensive for a student), the shorter man's shoes (leather, polished, city shoes on a campus where everyone wore sandals or sneakers), the woman's bag (black, new, the kind you buy at the shops near the government quarter). She filed it. She could not act on it. But she could remember it. She called her father from the courtyard. A concrete bench under a flamboyant tree, the only shade on this side of the campus, its red-orange flowers scattered on the ground like someone had dropped a bowl of embers.

"Papa."

"Awa."

His voice on the phone was the same as in person, low, steady, unhurried. He spoke the way he farmed: one thing at a time, each word placed like a seed. Her entire life, she had never heard him raise his voice. Not when the rains failed. Not when the compensation men came. Not when Ibrahim left. Her father's anger was not loud. It was geological, slow, deep, expressed through pressure rather than explosion, the kind of anger that moved the ground instead of the air.

She had inherited his stubbornness but not his patience. She remembered a morning. She must have been eight or nine, when a truck from the road construction project had parked at the edge of their land and a man in a hard hat had walked onto the field without asking.

Her father had been weeding. He stood up. He walked to the man. He did not shout. He did not gesture. He stood in front of the man and said, in a voice so quiet the man had to lean forward to hear: "You are on my land." The man said something about the road survey, about authorization, about the regional development plan. Her

father repeated: “You are on my land.” He said it the same way both times, same volume, same speed, same absolute certainty. The man left. The truck left. The road was eventually built two hundred meters further south.

Awa had watched this from the compound doorway. She was eight. She learned two things: that her father could stop a truck with his voice, and that the truck might come back. Her father’s method, stand, speak quietly, wait for the world to agree with you, worked when the world was a man in a hard hat. She was not sure it would work when the world was a twelve-billion-dollar infrastructure deal backed by two governments and a railway that was already drawn on a map.

“The government men came?” she asked.

“They came.”

“What did they offer?”

“Fourteen million.”

“That’s an insult.”

“It’s a number, Awa. Numbers are not insults. Numbers are just numbers. The insult is thinking the land has one.”

She pulled at a thread on her jeans. She loved him. She also wanted to grab his shoulders and shake him until the stubbornness rattled loose and something more tactical fell out. He would not sell. She knew this the way she knew the sun would rise. It was a fact about the universe, not a decision. But facts about the universe do not protect you from a government that has decided your field is a railway corridor.

“Papa, journalists are coming to the corridor this week. International press. Television. If you let them visit the farm, the baobab, the field, the grave.”

“I am not a photograph, Awa.”

“You are a farmer whose land is being taken. People need to see that.”

“People see what they want to see. A camera will find the tree. It will not find the family buried beneath it.”

She didn’t push. She knew the difference between his silences. This one meant he had already decided.

“Papa, have you heard from Ibrahim?”

A pause. Longer than it should have been. Her mother used to pause like this, the same shape, the same held breath, when she was keeping something from the children. Awa heard her mother in her father’s silence and the hearing made her chest tight.

“Not this week.”

“The money transfer didn’t come. It usually comes on the fifteenth.”

“He’s busy.” “Papa.”

“He’s busy, Awa.”

She heard it, the flatness in his voice, the careful levelness of a man placing words on a surface and making sure they don’t tilt. Her father never lied. But he could build a silence so precisely that the truth fit inside it without being visible.

Ibrahim had been gone three years. He sent money, seven hundred, eight hundred dollars.

More than the mines paid. She had done the math. She had looked up mining wages in the region. She had searched online for what kind of work paid eight hundred dollars a month in countries where the average income was sixty. The answers she found made her stomach tighten the same way the DM had this morning, that same tightening.

She did not ask her father directly. She had decided, sometime in the last year, that the question would break something between them that she was not prepared to break. So she circled it, checking the transfers, noting the silences, building a case she hoped she would never have to open.

“Tell him I said hello,” she said. “When he calls.”

“I will.”

“Be safe, Papa.”

“The land is safe, Awa. The land does not leave.”

“I meant you.”

“I know what you meant.”

She hung up and checked the MJS account. Four hundred new followers since yesterday.

Fourteen thousand total. The posts about the leaked SEZ provisions were being shared across the region, Senegal, Mali, Guinea, Côte d’Ivoire. Students in Dakar had reposted with the tag: Kessara today, all of us tomorrow. Students in Bamako had organized a solidarity teach-in for Thursday. The movement was spreading the way movements spread, not by design but by recognition, each country’s students seeing their own future in Kessara’s present.

She scrolled through the messages. The usual spread, encouragement, anger, curiosity, insults, the occasional marriage proposal from men who confused political visibility with romantic availability. She did not look at the deleted folder. The five words were gone from the screen. They were not gone from her head. They hummed, low, constant, like a current running behind everything she did, audible only when the room was quiet. She walked across the campus toward the library. The courtyard was busy, students between classes, a professor carrying a stack of folders held together

with a rubber band, two young men playing cards on the steps of the science building, a woman selling bags of roasted cashews from a basin on her head. The ordinary traffic of a university where the lecture halls had no air conditioning and the library had no budget for new books and the professors earned less than the security guards at the Chinese construction site across the highway, and yet the students kept coming, kept studying, kept believing that the degree they were working toward would matter in a country that had not yet decided what it valued.

The library was on the east side of campus. Three stories. Concrete. The reading room on the second floor was where she studied, wooden desks scarred by decades of pen marks and carved initials and the occasional political slogan etched into the surface by students who had graduated into the world and left their opinions behind like fossils.

She found her desk, the one by the window, third row from the back, where the light was good in the afternoon and you could see the flamboyant tree in the courtyard and the street beyond it and, if you looked up from your books at the right moment, the sun hitting the minarets in a way that made them glow like candles. She opened her textbook. Constitutional law. The exam was Wednesday.

Chapter 7: Fundamental Rights and the Limits of State Authority. The right to property. The right to due process. The right to equal protection under the law. The provisions that the SEZ agreement was arguably violating, the same provisions she had just spent thirty minutes explaining to forty-three people through the story of a stick figure named Moussa whose fingers were broken in a factory.

She almost laughed. She was studying the constitution she was trying to defend. Preparing for an exam on the rights the deal would suspend. The textbook and the campaign were the same argument, made in different rooms, at different volumes, to different audiences.

She read. She took notes. She highlighted passages with a yellow marker that was running out of ink and that she would not replace because markers cost money and money was for bus fuel and printing and the hundred small costs of trying to change a country's mind in six days.

Outside, the campus lived its ordinary life. Inside, the constitutional law textbook laid out the rules of a system that had been designed to protect people like Ousmane Traoré from having their land taken without due process, and people like Youssouf Coulibaly from being shot at a rally. The phone credit seller's chant drifted up from the gate. "Orange! Orange! Crédit Orange!" Every fifteen seconds. The heartbeat of the campus.

She was twenty-two years old. She had received a death threat this morning and deleted it.

She had organized a week of political action in a country where political action got people killed. She had argued with her father about stubbornness and cameras and sovereignty.

She had noticed three strangers in a meeting and memorized their shoes. She had the constitution open on her desk and the referendum in her blood and a brother who might be a mercenary and a mother who was dead and a father who would not move and a country that could not decide and five words in the back of her skull that would not stop humming.

She was not afraid.

She kept telling herself this. And the telling, she was beginning to understand, was the bravest thing she did all day, not the meeting, not the speeches, not the organizing, but the simple, daily act of hearing the fear and choosing to call it something else.

Chapter 7

Grand Marabout Thierno Bâ rose for the fajr prayer the way he had risen for it every morning for fifty-four years. Before dawn. Before the city woke up and started wanting things from him. The title, Grand Marabout, meant supreme spiritual leader, head of a Sufi brotherhood that four million Kessarans followed. The fajr was the first prayer of the day, offered when the sky was still dark. He had never missed it.

The room where he slept was behind the mosque, a small chamber, whitewashed walls, a narrow bed, a prayer rug on the floor that had been woven by his mother when he was a boy, carrying in its fibers the smell of prayer, wool and dust and the faint warmth of a body that had knelt on it ten thousand times. The rug was threadbare in the center, where his forehead touched the ground five times a day. The worn spot was the exact shape of his brow. The rug knew his face.

He rose in the dark. He did not turn on a light. His body knew this space, the three steps from bed to door, the hook on the wall where his robes hung, the threshold that was slightly higher than the floor on either side, worn smooth by fifty years of bare feet. The washing room was adjacent. Stone floor. A drain. The clay jar.

The jar was large, the height of a man's knee, brown, with a wide mouth and a chip on the rim that had been there since before his father died. It had come from the north, carried by donkey when his grandparents moved to Port Sélani two generations ago. His grandmother had made it. She was a potter, patient, unhurried, her hands working the clay with a care that did not distinguish between the sacred and the practical because in her understanding there was no distinction. The jar held water better than anything manufactured. The clay was porous enough to sweat in the heat, keeping the water cool through evaporation. The water inside tasted faintly of earth. Thierno Bâ had been drinking this taste for fifty years and would not have described it as a taste. It was simply what water was.

His grandson Amadou, seventeen, quiet, devout in the uncomplicated way of a boy who has not yet been to university, filled the jar each evening from the mosque's well. The well was forty meters deep. The water was clean.

Thierno Bâ began the wudu. The washing before prayer. The sequence was fixed, fourteen centuries fixed, carried across the Sahara by the scholars and traders who had brought Islam to this coast a thousand years ago.

He said the bismillah. In the name of God, the Most Merciful, the Most Compassionate. He said it the way he had said it every morning since he was six years old, sitting beside his father in this same room, learning the words before he understood them, understanding them before he believed them, believing them before he could explain why, and finally arriving, decades later, at a faith that did not need explanation because it was not an argument. It was a practice.

He washed his hands. Three times each. The water from the jar was cool. The night air had brought the temperature down, and the clay had done its work, and the water that touched his palms was the temperature of the earth at dawn. He felt each finger separately. The webbing between them. The wrists.

He rinsed his mouth. Three times. The water tasted of clay and depth. He swirled it and spat into the drain, the sound quiet against the stone, a small, private sound, the sound of a body preparing itself for an encounter with something larger than a body. He washed his face. Three times. From the hairline to the chin, from ear to ear. The water ran down his cheeks and into his beard, white now, close-trimmed, the beard of a man who maintained himself the way he maintained his faith: daily, without vanity, as a matter of discipline.

He washed his arms. Right first, then left. Three times each. From fingertips to elbows. The water ran off his skin and onto the stone floor and into the drain and back, eventually, to the earth. He wiped his head. Once. Wet hands passing over his scalp, then over his ears, then the back of his neck. A gesture of completion. He washed his feet. Right first, then left. Three times each. Between the toes. The soles.

The ankles. His feet were the feet of a man who had walked the corridors of this mosque for decades, calloused, strong, the toenails thick and clean. He had walked to Mecca twice on these feet. He had walked the streets of Port Sélani a thousand times. He had walked the paths of his family's village in the north and the roads between villages and the corridors of universities where he had debated scholars who had studied Islam in Cairo and Medina and Riyadh and who had arrived with certainties that his kind of Islam, the Sufi kind, the mystical tradition that valued inner experience over rigid doctrine, the patient kind, the kind that accommodated the older things, did not share.

The wudu took four minutes. It had taken four minutes every morning for fifty-four years. He did not rush it. He did not extend it. The four minutes were a container, and

the container held exactly what it needed to hold.

He dressed. White robes, simple, cotton. A white prayer cap. No jewelry. No watch. No phone. The phone stayed in his study. Prayer did not compete with screens. The Grand Mosque of Port Sélani filled the center of the Médina. Everything in the district arranged itself around it, the streets, the market, the houses. The mosque was the reason the neighborhood existed. The neighborhood knew this. The mosque did not need to.

The building was stone and concrete. Built in the 1960s by the first independent government, men who had fought the French with words and marches and went to prison and came out and built a nation and built a mosque because a nation without a place to pray was a house without a floor. The mosque had been expanded in 1978 and again in 2003.

The main prayer hall held four thousand. The courtyard held fifteen thousand more during Fridays and festivals, the faithful spilling into the surrounding streets where shopkeepers rolled out mats and joined from their doorsteps.

This morning, Sunday, fajr, the congregation was smaller. Thierno Bâ walked from his chamber through the side door and into the prayer hall. The hall was dim. The light came from the high windows on the eastern wall, where the first gray suggestion of dawn was pressing against the glass. The floor was covered in mats, green, the green of Islam, worn soft by years of knees and foreheads and the friction of bodies rising and falling in unison. Two hundred people. Maybe two hundred and fifty. The devoted, old men whose sleep had grown thin and who came to fajr because the prayer was the most honest part of their day. The young men who worked the night shift at the port and stopped at the mosque on their way home, still wearing the smell of diesel and salt. Women in the screened section to the left, their presence quiet and constant, the foundation the building rested on and the last thing anyone acknowledged.

Thierno Bâ took his place at the front. He faced the qibla, the direction of Mecca, marked by a niche in the wall, an arch carved in stone. He raised his hands. He spoke.

His voice was not loud. It had never been loud. His father's voice had carried through the mosque like a bell. Thierno Bâ's voice was lower, closer to the ground. It did not demand silence. It made silence unnecessary. When he spoke, the noise simply stopped, the way noise stops when something more important enters.

The words were fourteen centuries old. He spoke them in Arabic, the Arabic of the Quran, which was not the Arabic of conversation or commerce but the Arabic of revelation, a language that had been carried across the Sahara by scholars who memorized the entire text and recited it from memory in mosques built of mud and

thatch in villages that no map had recorded and no empire had claimed. The prayer had survived everything, colonization, slavery, drought, independence, military rule, democracy, corruption, and the modern indignity of being reduced to a “cultural practice” by development agencies that could not measure what they could not see.

He prayed. The congregation prayed with him. Rising, bowing, kneeling, pressing foreheads to the ground. Two hundred bodies moving in the same rhythm. The sound of the collective, the rustle of robes, the soft impact of knees on mats, the murmured responses, was a sound that existed nowhere else. It was the sound of agreement made physical. The sound of a room full of people who had decided, for four minutes, to do the same thing at the same time in the same direction.

The sun came through the high windows and the glass turned gold.

After the prayer, his day began.

The study was behind the mosque, his father’s before him, his grandfather’s before that. It was the most important space in Port Sélani, more important than the president’s office or the cabinet chamber or the courtroom. Four million people’s spiritual guidance originated here, not in edicts or declarations but in conversations, one at a time, across a desk, over tea.

Three walls of bookshelves. The shelves held Arabic texts in leather bindings, commentaries on the Quran, collections of hadith, the recorded sayings of the Prophet, works of Sufi philosophy. French academic works on theology and comparative religion. And the manuscripts, handwritten Quranic texts, some of them two hundred years old, copied by scholars whose names survived only in the inscriptions at the end of each page. The ink was iron gall, dark brown, almost black, made from oak galls and ferrous sulfate. The paper was handmade. The calligraphy was the calligraphy of men who believed that the act of writing the word of God was itself an act of worship, and whose penmanship reflected this belief, each letter formed with a care that modern printing could replicate but not replace.

A desk. A chair. On the desk: a pen, a notepad, a stack of correspondence, and a glass for attaya.

The tea. Attaya was not a beverage. It was a ritual. His assistant Boubacar, fifty-three, thin, patient as a river, brewed it on a small charcoal burner beside the desk. The process was fixed. Green tea leaves in a small metal pot. Boiling water. Sugar. The brewing took fifteen minutes, during which Boubacar poured the tea back and forth between the pot and a small glass, raising the stream higher with each pour, aerating the liquid, building a foam that was the sign of proper preparation. Boubacar poured like an artist. The higher the stream, the better the foam, and Boubacar could

pour from a height of thirty centimeters without spilling a drop, the golden-brown liquid arcing through the air in a thin, steady line. Three rounds. The first was strong and bitter, the taste of attention, as Thierno Bâ's father had called it. The second was lighter, sweeter, the sugar added in greater measure, the taste of understanding. The third was sweet and mild, the taste of acceptance. The three rounds were a conversation in liquid form: first you listen hard, then you begin to understand, then you accept what you have heard.

Boubacar set the first glass on the desk. Thierno Bâ drank. The tea was hot and bitter and it reached something in his chest that food did not reach.

The visitors began at seven.

A woman. Forty, maybe. Wearing a wrap dress, printed cotton, the pattern a bright geometric in orange and green. She carried a child on her back, a boy, three years old, quiet, his eyes too large for his face. The boy was sick. The woman did not say what kind of sick. She said: "He does not eat. He does not sleep. He cries at night and I cannot comfort him."

Thierno Bâ looked at the child. Not a medical look. He was not a doctor. A different kind of look. The kind that sees what the body is carrying that is not physical.

"How long?"

"Two weeks. Since the full moon."

"Has he been to the clinic?"

"The clinic has no medicine. The clinic has not had medicine since February."

He took a piece of paper, heavy, cream-colored, the kind he used only for this purpose.

He wrote a verse from the Quran on it, in the iron-gall ink, in the old calligraphy. The verse was about protection. About the shelter that God provides. He wrote it slowly, each letter formed with the care of a man who believed the ink itself carried weight. "Dissolve this in water. Give it to the boy to drink. Morning and evening. For seven days."

The woman took the paper. She held it the way you hold something that might save your child, with both hands, against her chest.

He did not know if the prayer would heal the boy's body. He knew it would heal the fear. And sometimes fear was the sickness, and sometimes the sickness was the fear, and the difference was smaller than medicine assumed.

A businessman. Fifties. Pressed suit. He had been cheated in a land deal. A cousin had sold him a plot that turned out to have a disputed title, and now a third party was claiming ownership and the courts were slow and the lawyers were expensive and the

businessman wanted the Grand Marabout to arbitrate. “Bring the other party,” Thierno Bâ said. “Next week.”

“But Grand Marabout, I have the documents. I can show you.” “I cannot judge a wall by looking at one side.”

The businessman opened his mouth. Closed it. Opened it again. He was accustomed to environments where documents settled disputes. He was sitting across from a man who believed that documents were the surface of a dispute, and beneath the surface was a relationship, and the relationship was where the truth lived. “Next week,” Thierno Bâ said. “Both of you. And bring your documents and your cousin and your patience.”

A farmer from outside the city. Older. Weathered. He wanted to know if the rains would come.

Thierno Bâ looked at him. The farmer’s hands were cracked and dark with soil, the hands of a man who had been having a conversation with the ground for longer than he had been having conversations with people.

“Pray for the rain,” Thierno Bâ said. “Prepare for the rain. And plant your millet regardless.

God rewards the man who works whether the rain comes or not.”

The farmer nodded. He had heard this before. He came every year. The answer was always the same. He came for the asking, not the answer, for the act of bringing his question to a man whose role was to receive it.

Between visitors, Thierno Bâ stood at the window.

The street outside the mosque was filling with the morning, vendors setting up stalls, children in school uniforms, women with basins on their heads. The ordinary commerce of a city that ran on faith and hustle in roughly equal measure.

A young man passed. Eighteen, maybe nineteen. Carrying a bag, a duffel, green, military surplus. He was walking toward the bus station with the stride of someone who has made a decision and is moving before the decision can be questioned. Head forward. Shoulders set.

Not looking back.

Thierno Bâ had seen this walk before. A hundred times in the last two years. Young men with bags, heading for the buses that went north. To the border. To the camps and the companies and the contracts that promised eight hundred dollars a month and brotherhood and purpose, all the things a young man needs and that a country with forty percent youth unemployment and a drought-ravaged north could not provide. He watched the young man disappear around the corner. He would not

see him again. He would see his mother, though. In a week, or a month, or three months. She would come to this study. She would sit in the chair across the desk. She would ask Thierno Bâ to pray for her son's safety.

He would pray. He always prayed. He could not do more than pray, and the inability was something he shared with the farmer, both of them knowing what they could give and what they could not.

Four families this month. Four mothers. Their sons went north. The mothers wanted prayers.

The mothers wanted their sons to come home. The prayers he could give. The sons he could not return.

He returned to his desk. Boubacar brought the first glass of tea. On the desk, beside the correspondence and the notepad, a document.

It had arrived two days ago in a plain envelope, no return address. Boubacar had found it slipped under the study door at the fajr prayer and had brought it in without opening it, because Boubacar understood that sealed envelopes left at the Grand Marabout's door were not accidents.

A geological survey of the Bassam Corridor. Printed on heavy paper, thick, cream-colored, the kind used for official documents and professional reports. The mineral deposits were marked in red: coltan, lithium, cobalt. The proposed rail line in blue. The industrial zone perimeter in green.

Someone had taken a pencil and circled a small area east of the main corridor. The circle was drawn carefully, not hurried but deliberate, the graphite dark against the cream paper, the line smooth and steady. Inside the circle: the sacred grove. A cluster of ancient trees, represented on the survey as a topographic anomaly, a dense cluster of biomass that disrupted the elevation model.

A topographic anomaly. That was what the grove was on this paper. A disruption in the data.

A problem for the drainage calculations. Not a place where a man named Dramane tended the relationship between the living and the land. Not a place where offerings were made and spirits addressed and ceremonies conducted that connected this generation to every generation before it. A topographic anomaly. Beside the circle, a handwritten note in French: Inside the industrial zone perimeter.

Thierno Bâ had looked at this document every morning for two days. He had not tried to find out who sent it. The information was the information. Someone, inside Zhonglu, inside the government, inside one of the embassies, had decided the Grand Marabout should know.

The decision to tell him was itself a kind of prayer, a person reaching toward authority they trusted, placing dangerous knowledge before a man whose power was not political but spiritual, hoping that spiritual power could do what political power would not.

He left it on his desk. Open. The penciled circle visible to anyone who sat across from him.

At nine-fifteen, a car pulled into the mosque courtyard. Black sedan. Government plates.

Thierno Bâ watched from the window.

Ismaël Diop, the president's private secretary. Fifty-two years old. Slim. A man whose suit fit him the same way his words did, precisely, formally, with nothing showing that had not been approved. He stepped out of the car and straightened his tie before walking toward the study door.

Thierno Bâ noted the gesture. A man adjusting his tie before entering a mosque. The tie was his armor. The mosque was a space where armor was not required and not welcome. Diop was choosing the tie over the mosque, and the choice told Thierno Bâ everything about the conversation that would follow.

"Grand Marabout. Thank you for seeing me."

"I have not agreed to see you, Ismaël. You are here. That is different."

Diop sat in the chair across the desk. He crossed his legs. Uncrossed them. Crossed them again. His eyes moved across the desk, the pen, the notepad, the tea glass, the survey.

His gaze passed over the survey without pausing. He did not know what it was. To him it was paper on a desk. Paper on desks was the landscape of his professional life. He did not read the penciled circle or the handwritten note or the red and blue and green markings. He saw a document and saw nothing.

Thierno Bâ saw him not see it. This, too, was information. "The president sends his respects. He asks for your guidance regarding the coming vote."

"My guidance is not something the president can request. It is something God provides. The president is welcome to pray for it, as I do."

Diop adjusted. He was a professional adjuster. His career depended on translating what powerful people meant into what other powerful people could accept.

"The president values the brotherhood's perspective on matters of national importance."

"The brotherhood values the nation's perspective on matters of divine importance. These are not the same conversation." Thierno Bâ drank his tea. First round. Bitter.

Diop waited. Waiting was the correct response.

The study enforced it, the quiet of the study, the weight of the manuscripts on the shelves, the faint sound of Boubacar's charcoal burner. This study had hosted conversations between marabouts and presidents for three generations. The walls knew the pace. Thierno Bâ set down his glass. He placed his hand on the survey, lightly, but his fingers rested on the edge of the penciled circle. The grove. Inside the zone.

"Ismaël. Does the president know what lies in the eastern section of the corridor? Not what lies beneath it. What lies on it." Diop blinked. The question was not in his briefing. "The eastern section includes several rural communities that will be part of the resettlement."

"I am not asking about the communities. I am asking about the grove."

"The grove?"

"The sacred grove. East of the main alignment. The place where the custodian of the old traditions tends the relationship between the living and the land. Does the president know it is inside the industrial zone?"

Diop's face went still. He did not know the answer and was deciding whether to admit it or fill the silence with something that sounded like one.

"I'm sure the technical teams have accounted for all significant."

"It is not a technical matter, Ismaël. It is a grove. People pray there. Not the way we pray, not facing Mecca, not reciting the Quran. But they pray. And the grove is inside your fence." The study was very quiet. Boubacar's charcoal burner hissed softly. Outside, the city's noise pressed against the window without entering.

"You may tell the president that I have not spoken on the referendum because I have not yet heard what God wishes me to say. When I hear it, I will say it. Not before."

"The president understands. He merely..."

"Ismaël." The name was enough. Diop stopped. The name, spoken in Thierno Bâ's low voice, carried the authority of five decades and four million followers and a tradition that was older than the presidency and would outlast it.

"This is not a political question. A man is asking whether he may sell something that God placed in his keeping. That is a theological question. It deserves a theological answer. And theological answers do not run on election schedules." Diop nodded. He stood. He thanked the Grand Marabout. His eyes passed over the survey one more time as he turned, and this time they paused. A half-second. The penciled circle. The handwritten note. He did not read the French. He did not need to. The circle itself was

a language he understood: someone had marked something for attention, and the Grand Marabout had placed it where visitors could see it, and the placement was no accident.

He straightened his tie, the gesture automatic, the armor restored, and left.

The quiet after the door closed was the quiet of a place that has held a confrontation and absorbed it.

Thierno Bâ looked at the survey. The grove. He had not been there in years. He did not tend it. Dramane tended it, and Dramane's tradition was not his, and the relationship between Sufi Islam and the indigenous practices that predated it was not hierarchy but adjacency.

They lived side by side, the way the mosque lived beside the market and the minaret lived beside the baobab. His eldest son Abdoulaye, seven years in Medina, a Saudi-educated certainty that Islam was pure and singular, would say the grove was not Islam. "The grove is not Islam, Father."

Thierno Bâ would answer the way he always answered: "The grove was here before Islam. It will be here after Islam. What I believe about it does not change what it is."

Four million people followed his guidance. When he spoke, families adjusted. Businesses moved. Politicians recalculated. His silence on the referendum was a kind of weather, felt by everyone, controlled by no one. Both campaigns wanted his voice. Both assumed it was for sale, because in their world everything was for sale and the only question was price.

His silence was not for sale. It was not strategy. It was discipline, the discipline of a man who had spent fifty-four years learning the difference between speaking because you have something to say and speaking because someone wants you to. The first was prayer. The second was politics. He served one employer. He finished his tea. First round done. Boubacar was preparing the second, pouring the liquid back and forth, the golden stream arcing through the air. The foam was building. The taste would shift from bitter to sweet. Understanding replacing attention. Through the window, the city was fully awake. The vendors. The taxis. The radio voices, already arguing, already dividing the world into Yes and No as if the world could be divided that simply. Inside the study, the survey lay on the desk with its penciled circle, and the manuscripts lined the walls with their iron-gall calligraphy, and the tea moved from bitter toward sweet, and Thierno Bâ waited. There was time. There was always time, if you were willing to be still inside it. The men who drew the maps and the men who signed the deals and the men who marched in the streets, they all believed that

time was running out. They were wrong. Time did not run. Time stood still. It was the people who ran, and their running made them believe the ground was moving.

He would speak when God told him to speak. Not before. Not after.

He drank the second round. Understanding.

The third would come later.

* * *

<div align="center">

DAY 2: MONDAY

“The Terms”

</div>

“The slave trade was not ended by moral enlightenment. It was ended when it became unprofitable.”, Thomas Sankara, President of Burkina Faso, 1987

* * *

Chapter 8

Jean-Baptiste Ouédraogo called at five-forty in the morning because Jean-Baptiste Ouédraogo did not believe in sleep as a right. Fatou answered on the third ring. She had been awake already, jet lag, heat, the restlessness of a body sleeping in a country it remembered and a mind sleeping in one it didn't. The hotel room was dark. The air conditioning unit rattled against the wall. "I have the full text," he said. "Every page. The provisions they didn't release."

"How?"

"A friend in the Ministry of Justice with a conscience and a photocopier. Get dressed."

Le Réveil occupied three rooms above a tailor's shop in the Médina. The stairwell was narrow and smelled of starch and the warm plastic of phone accessories from the shop next door. The office door was unlocked. It was always unlocked because the lock had been broken during a police search in 2019 and nobody had replaced it, either because there was no budget or because Jean-Baptiste considered a broken lock a form of editorial commentary.

The office was two desks, four chairs, a shelf of yellowed back issues stacked by month, and a ceiling fan that moved air from one side to another without lowering the temperature of either. The walls were covered in front pages, fifteen years of Le Réveil headlines, pinned up with thumbtacks, the paper turning gold at the edges. One wall was all political coverage. Another was investigative work, land deals, mining contracts, the series on police brutality that had earned Jean-Baptiste the scar.

The scar ran across his left cheekbone, a clean line, almost surgical, the kind of mark a blade would leave if the blade were a police baton swung at close range by a man who was not aiming but not trying to miss. 2016. A protest outside the Ministry of Justice. Jean-Baptiste had been covering it. The gendarme had not asked for his press credentials. The baton had not asked for his opinion. The scar healed in six weeks. The story he filed from the hospital bed ran in three international outlets and was cited in a Human Rights Watch report and changed nothing about the gendarmerie's conduct and Jean-Baptiste kept going because keeping going was the

only tool he had that the baton could not break.

He was forty-four. Thin, the body of a man who ate when he remembered to and forgot when he was working. He wore glasses that he pushed up his nose every few minutes with his index finger, a metronome of concentration.

He handed Fatou a stack of photocopied pages. Ninety-three pages. The paper was warm from the machine and slightly damp. The photocopier was old and ran hot and the humidity condensed on the output tray. The pages smelled of toner and the faint organic tang of paper that had been stored in a government filing cabinet for months, absorbing the atmosphere of bureaucracy.

“Read,” he said. “All of it. I’ll make coffee.”

The coffee was instant, a brand she didn’t recognize, the kind sold in small foil packets at market stalls, one packet per cup. Jean-Baptiste made it strong enough to qualify as an engineering material. He set the cup on the edge of the desk where Fatou was already sitting, already reading, already gone.

She read the way she had been trained at Columbia and sharpened at the wire service, not for the story but for the structure beneath the story. Every deal had an architecture. The public version was the facade, the project scope, the investment timeline, the promises. Behind the facade was the frame: the clauses that determined who actually controlled what, who paid whom, and who could walk away.

The first sixty pages were facade. Project scope: railway, deep-water port, mineral processing facilities, new city for two hundred thousand people. Investment: \$12.4 billion over fifteen years. Job creation: fifty thousand direct, two hundred thousand indirect. She had read these figures on the plane. They were the numbers the government wanted the voters to see, large, round, dressed up in infographics.

She skimmed them. She was looking for the structure.

She found it on page sixty-one.

Article 7: Special Economic Zone Provisions. She read it once, quickly. Then she went back and read it diagnostically, slowly, word by word, looking for what was hiding inside the language. The Bassam Corridor, once established, would operate under a separate legal framework.

She underlined “separate.” Chinese commercial law would govern business disputes within the corridor. She underlined “Chinese commercial law.” Labor regulations would follow Chinese standards. She underlined “Chinese standards.”

She had covered a Chinese-built railway in Kenya two years ago. She had spoken to the workers.

Workers' complaints within the corridor would be heard by an arbitration panel. Panel composition: two members appointed by Zhonglu, one by the Kessaran Ministry of Labor.

She circled the numbers. Two to one. The company that employed you also judged your complaint. She wrote in the margin: fox/henhouse.

Article 7, Section 3: Security. "Security within the corridor shall be provided by a contracted entity designated by the project operator, subject to coordination with the Kessaran National Gendarmerie."

She read "contracted entity" twice. Private security. Armed. Inside Kessaran territory.

Answerable to Zhonglu. "Coordination" with the Kessaran police was a word doing the work of a wall. It looked solid but you could walk through it.

The power cut out. The ceiling fan died. The room went dark except for the gray morning light through the window.

Jean-Baptiste's voice from the other desk: "Generator will kick in. Give it a minute."

It took three minutes. The generator was on the roof and it was old and it started the way old generators start, with a cough, a wheeze, a negotiation between the starter motor and the fuel line that sounded like two elderly men arguing about whose turn it was. The lights came back. The fan resumed its useless rotation. Fatou's pages had stuck together with sweat where her forearm had rested on them. She peeled them apart carefully, the toner smearing slightly at the edges.

She kept reading.

Article 12: Land Use and Resettlement. Communities within the corridor would be "relocated to designated resettlement zones" with compensation "determined by an independent valuation committee." Committee composition: two Kessaran members, three Zhonglu appointees.

Three to two. She stared at the numbers. An "independent" committee where the buyer held the majority. The word "independent" in this clause was performing the same function as the word "coordination" in the security clause, creating the appearance of balance while engineering its absence.

She wrote in the margin: Who decided "independent" means 3-2 against you? Article 19: Revenue Sharing. This was where she slowed down. Revenue sharing was the structure that determined whether the deal was a partnership or a purchase. The numbers would tell her which.

For the first fifty years, Zhonglu would retain eighty-five percent of mineral processing revenue. Kessara: fifteen percent. After year fifty, Kessaran equity would rise to forty percent. After year seventy-five, to fifty-one percent, a bare majority, the thinnest possible margin of ownership.

She did the math on the back of page seventy-six. Fifty years at fifteen percent. Then twenty-five years at forty percent. Then the final quarter of the ninety-nine-year lease at fifty-one percent. The total value transfer over the life of the deal depended on production volumes and commodity prices, neither of which she could predict, but the structure was clear: Kessara was not entering a partnership. Kessara was lending its ground to a foreign corporation for half a century and receiving, in return, the right to own a majority of the output of its own minerals starting in 2100.

2100. She would be dead. The farmers whose land the corridor would absorb would be dead. Their children would be dead. Their grandchildren would be middle-aged.

The first generation of Kessarans to hold majority ownership of Kessaran minerals would be people who were not yet born. She wrote in the margin: This is not a deal. This is a layaway plan. Kessara is paying in time.

She put the pages down. She looked at Jean-Baptiste, who was editing copy at the other desk, red pen in hand, the scar catching the fluorescent light.

“Has anyone else seen this?”

“You’re the first journalist. I wanted someone who would read all of it before writing a word.”

“Why me? You don’t know me.”

He looked up from his editing. His glasses reflected the light. “I know your father’s name.”

The sentence hung between them. He did not explain it. He went back to his copy. Fatou looked at the stack of pages, ninety-three pages, warm, smudged, carrying in their bureaucratic language the blueprint for the largest land deal in Kessaran history, and she looked at the man across the desk who had said her father’s name as if it were a credential, and she understood that something connected the two: the pages and the name.

She did not yet know what.

“What are you going to do with it?” Jean-Baptiste asked without looking up.

“Read it again. Then call everyone who will answer.” She spent four hours in that chair. The power cut out twice more. The generator coughed back to life each time. She drank three cups of Jean-Baptiste’s coffee, each one worse than the last, the

instant granules dissolving reluctantly in water that was not quite hot enough because the electric kettle shared a circuit with the ceiling fan and running both at once tripped the breaker.

She called the Ministry of Information. A receptionist answered, put her on hold, came back, put her on hold again, came back a third time and said the minister was unavailable. “When will he be available?” “He is unavailable.” The word “unavailable” carried, in its careful blankness, the entire communications strategy of a government that had just been caught with its provisions exposed. She called Zhonglu’s public relations office. A woman answered in French with a Mandarin accent and read from a prepared statement: “The Kessara Gateway Partnership is a mutually beneficial framework for sustainable development, reflecting the shared commitment of the People’s Republic of China and the Republic of Kessara to inclusive growth and south-south cooperation.” Fatou asked a follow-up question. The woman read the statement again, word for word, with the same inflections, as if the statement were a recording and the woman were the machine that played it.

She called Aminata Kourouma’s office. A staff member, young, tense, the background noise suggesting a room in controlled chaos, said the opposition leader would be available for an interview tomorrow. “Tomorrow is fine,” Fatou said. “Tell her I’ve read the full text. All ninety-three pages.”

A pause on the line. Then: “I’ll make sure she knows.”

She called her own bureau. Her editor in London, a man named Callum who had run the Africa desk for eleven years and had the combination of genuine interest and institutional ignorance that characterized the best and worst of international journalism. “What have you got?”

“The full deal text. The unpublished provisions. SEZ terms that are worse than the government disclosed. Chinese courts inside the corridor. Private security. A resettlement committee where Zhonglu holds a three-to-two majority.”

“Both sides?”

“Callum.”

“I know. But I need both sides. Get the Chinese response on record, even if it’s a non-response. Get the government’s position. File by six.” By noon she had a draft. She wrote it at Jean-Baptiste’s desk. He had left for a meeting with a source, using his computer because her laptop battery was dead and the outlet near her desk didn’t work. His desktop was old. The keyboard had a French layout. The space bar stuck on the left side. She wrote in English and thought in three languages and the dispatch that emerged was tight, factual, and furious in the only way good journalism allows, every

sentence a controlled detonation, the anger carried inside the precision.

She read it once. She deleted the first two paragraphs. They were explaining context, providing the background that a reader would need to understand the significance. This was a wire-service instinct: front-load the context, assume the reader knows nothing. But the reader who was going to read this story at six AM London time did not need Fatou to explain what a Special Economic Zone was. The reader needed the numbers. The provisions. The three-to-two majority. The math.

She tightened the rest. She cut every adjective that was doing emotional work. She let the provisions speak for themselves. She filed at one-fourteen PM.

Her editor called back in twenty minutes. "This is strong. We're leading with it for the evening cycle. Can you get anything from the Chinese ambassador by four?"

"The Chinese ambassador does not take calls from wire services."

"Try."

She tried. He didn't.

She walked back to the hotel in the late afternoon. The city was different today. The leak had changed it overnight. Yesterday, Port Sélani had been arguing, the call-in shows, the debates, the ordinary friction of a country with an opinion about everything. Today the arguing had hardened. The radio voices were sharper. Tighter. The leak had given the arguments teeth.

In the Médina, she passed a printer's shop where a young man was running off copies of the provisions, translated into Dioula, stapled, stacked on a folding table outside the door.

Fifty francs each. The stack was diminishing fast. People buying the document that would determine the future of their country for the cost of a bag of groundnuts.

She stopped. She bought a copy. The paper was warm. The ink was fresh. The young man who sold it to her was maybe twenty, university age, wearing a T-shirt with a logo she didn't recognize. He had a stack of five hundred copies and he was selling them without commentary, without political affiliation, without editorial position. He was selling information. The market was the market, and information was a commodity, and the demand today was for ninety-three pages of bureaucratic French that most of the buyers would need translated by a neighbor or a nephew or a radio host who would read it aloud at the evening broadcast.

This was how democracy worked in a country where the internet reached thirty-eight percent of the population and the literacy rate was sixty-two percent and the most powerful communications technology was a man with a radio and a voice that people trusted. The document would travel from this table to a kitchen to a radio

studio to a compound yard where an old man and his neighbor would sit under a baobab tree and read it together, and by evening the provisions would be inside the country's nervous system, and the country would react.

Her route back to the hotel did not need to pass through the Plateau. The hotel was north.

The Plateau was east. The direct route was along the Corniche, fifteen minutes, sea breeze, the easy path.

She turned east.

The Plateau at dusk was different from the Plateau at midday. The colonial buildings that had looked merely neglected in the taxi yesterday looked abandoned now. The failing light filling the shuttered windows with shadow, the facades losing their detail, the architecture retreating into silhouette. The streets were emptier. The government workers who populated the quarter during the day had gone home. The shops that served them, the stationery stores, the photocopier shops, the cafés where civil servants drank coffee between meetings, had pulled down their shutters.

The old Ministry of Mines was at the corner of Rue de la République and a side street whose sign had fallen off. She stopped across the street. She had been here yesterday, in the taxi, when Moussa pointed it out and something tightened in her chest. Her chest tightened again. Stronger now. She stood on the pavement and looked at the building.

Two stories. Stone facade, the heavy gray stone the French had quarried from the escarpment, stone meant to project permanence, to say: we built this, we are here, we intend to stay. The shutters were closed. Some hung at angles where the hinges had failed. The metal gate was padlocked, the chain and the padlock rusted the same shade of brown.

Weeds grew from the gutter line. The crack she had noticed yesterday, from the second-floor window to the roofline, was more visible now, a dark line against the gray stone, the building slowly splitting along a fault that the builders had not anticipated because the builders had assumed permanence and permanence was the one thing the building had not achieved. A streetlight caught the padlock. The rust glowed briefly, an orange flare on the chain, then gone as the light cycled.

Stay away from the Plateau district.

Her mother's voice. Flat. Careful. The voice of a woman sealing something shut. Fatou had heard that voice exactly once before, the night her father told them they were leaving. Her mother's voice, in the hallway, saying "of course" to a twelve-year-old who asked if they were coming back. The same flatness. The same

care. The voice of a woman who has decided what she will and will not say and has welded the door shut between them.

She took out her phone. She photographed the building. The padlock. The weeds. The crack. She did not know why she was doing this. She knew only the pull, the tightening in her chest, the feeling of standing in front of a locked building that held something that belonged to her.

She scrolled to her mother's number. Her thumb hovered. She put the phone away. She walked on. The streetlight cycled again behind her, catching the padlock, orange and gone.

Chapter 9

The president learned about the leak from his minister of information, who learned about it from his wife, who heard it on the radio while making breakfast.

This was how news traveled in Kessara. Not through the encrypted channels and secure briefings and classified folders that governments built to control the flow of information.

Through kitchens. Through women who turned on the radio while heating water for coffee and heard a host reading, in a voice that was not trying to hide its anger, the provisions of a deal that the government had spent nine months negotiating in closed rooms with lawyers who billed by the hour.

The minister of information called Diallo at six-fifty-two. Diallo was in the residence kitchen, drinking the instant coffee he made himself each morning, the habit the residence staff had never been able to break. The minister's voice was tight, the voice of a man who had just realized that control was the only tool he had left. "Mr. President. The full negotiation text is on three radio stations. Two news websites. It's being shared on WhatsApp groups faster than we can monitor."

"Which provisions?"

"All of them. Article 7, the SEZ terms. Article 12, the resettlement clauses. Article 19, the revenue sharing. Someone gave them everything."

Diallo set his coffee down. The cup made a small sound on the marble counter, the Italian marble, the counter he had considered ripping out, the surface that cost more than three village wells. The sound was precise and ordinary and it was the last ordinary sound of his morning.

"Who?"

"We don't know. The document is genuine. It's the full negotiation text, not a summary."

Someone with access to the Justice Ministry files. There are fourteen people with that clearance."

"Get me a list."

He hung up. He stood in the kitchen. Through the window, Port Sélani was waking, the gray-blue light, the first traffic, the call to prayer beginning from the Grand Mosque. The same city he had looked at yesterday morning while shaving. The same cranes. The same minarets. But the air had changed. Yesterday the city had been arguing about a referendum. Today it was arguing about the terms, and the terms were worse than what the government had disclosed, and the people now had the document to prove it. He had negotiated those terms. Nine days in a room with Zhonglu's legal team. He knew what every clause said. He also knew what every clause concealed, the gulf between the language and the reality, the space where "coordination" meant notification and "independent" meant three-to-two against you. He had fought for better terms and these were what he got, and the truth was that better was not good enough, and the other truth was that better than this did not exist because he had looked for it for four years and it was not there.

He finished his coffee. He rinsed the cup. He put it on the drying rack. He went to the office.

By seven-thirty, the leaked provisions were on every radio station in the country. The SEZ clauses were being read aloud in four languages by hosts whose editorial restraint had evaporated overnight. A host on Radio Kessara Libre, the station Diallo listened to when he wanted to know what people actually thought, as opposed to what his polling told him they thought, was reading Article 7 with the deliberate emphasis of a man who wanted every word to land separately.

"Chinese commercial law will govern. Not Kessaran law.

Chinese law. Inside Kessara. On your soil. My soil."

Diallo turned off the radio. Not because the host was wrong, the host was, technically, correct, but because correct was not the same as complete, and the gap was what he governed.

His communications director arrived at eight. A young man named Seydou who had studied digital media in Montreal and returned to Kessara with a degree and the helplessness of a person who understood how information moved in the twenty-first century and worked for a government that communicated in the twentieth.

"How bad?" Diallo asked.

"The hashtag is trending across the region. Not just Kessara, Senegal, Mali, Guinea, Côte d'Ivoire. Student organizations in four countries have shared the provisions. The Dioula version is the most shared. I can't translate the hashtag, Mr. President, but my staff tells me it means 'Kessara today, all of us tomorrow.'" "And our response?"

“We don’t have one yet. The minister of information wants to emphasize that the leaked version is a draft and not the final agreement.” “Is it a draft?”

Seydou paused. The pause was the answer.

“It’s the negotiation text, Mr. President. It’s the agreement we initialed. The final version has cosmetic changes, formatting, numbering, some definitions moved to an annex. The substance is identical.”

“Then we will not call it a draft. The people of this country are not stupid, Seydou. They know what they’re reading. If we call it a draft, they will know we’re lying, and they will stop listening to everything else we say.”

The cabinet met at nine. Fourteen ministers around a long table in a chamber Diallo kept cold. The air conditioning set low enough to make people uncomfortable, because uncomfortable people spoke less and listened more.

Today the cold did not work. Everyone spoke.

The minister of agriculture went first. Hamidou Keïta, a quiet man from the northern province, the kind of minister who prepared for meetings by visiting the people his policies affected, which was a practice so unusual in the Kessaran government that his colleagues had initially mistaken it for a political strategy rather than a conscience.

“Mr. President.” He stood. He was the only minister who stood when he addressed the cabinet, a habit from the village councils where standing meant you had something important enough to cost you the comfort of your chair. “I need you to hear what is happening in the north.”

The cabinet adjusted. When Keïta stood, people listened. Not because he was loud, he never was, but because the standing itself was a signal that he had been outside the capital and had brought the outside back with him.

“The rains failed. Two consecutive seasons. The CILSS data, the Sahel’s regional drought monitoring body, confirms what the farmers already know. The rainfall deficit in the northern provinces is thirty-four percent below the ten-year average. The planting season has effectively been abandoned in three districts.” He paused. He was not pausing for effect. He was pausing because the next number was heavy and he wanted to carry it carefully.

“Forty thousand people have moved south in the last six months. Forty thousand. These are farmers who have farmed the same land their entire lives, and the land has stopped producing. They are coming to the cities. The displacement camps outside Port Sélani are at three hundred percent capacity. We have confirmed cholera in Camp Bassam. The health system cannot absorb the load.” Silence. The air conditioning

hummed.

“And now you are asking these people, people who have lost their farms to a drought that the climate scientists say will only get worse, to vote on whether to hand more land to foreigners.”

“I am asking them to vote on whether to build an economy that does not depend on rain,”

Diallo said.

“They will hear it differently, Mr. President. They will hear: the government that could not save my farm now wants me to approve a deal that takes someone else’s farm.”

Diallo looked at Keïta. The minister’s face was the face of a man who had been to the camps. Who had seen the tents and the queues and the children sitting too still, their eyes too large for their faces. Who had stood in the cholera ward and counted the beds and done the math that nobody here wanted to do.

The minister of defense raised the security question. General Kaboré, large, careful, a man who had spent thirty years in a military that was simultaneously the most respected and the most dangerous institution in the country. “The private security clause in Article 7 has concerned my staff. A private entity providing armed security inside Kessaran territory, outside the chain of command of the Kessaran armed forces. My generals do not enjoy being told that a Chinese corporation will operate an armed force inside our borders ‘subject to coordination,’ which every officer in this room understands to mean ‘without asking permission.’”

“The clause was negotiated to prevent Zhonglu from requesting Kessaran military protection,” Diallo said. “Which would have placed our soldiers under de facto corporate command.”

“With respect, Mr. President, the clause achieves the same result from the opposite direction. Instead of our soldiers serving the corporation, the corporation hires its own soldiers. The difference is cosmetic.”

The minister of justice raised the constitutional questions. The minister of health raised the hospital numbers, the same numbers Keïta had raised, confirmed with data that was worse.

Then Asante spoke.

Kofi Asante did not stand. He did not need to. He placed a single sheet of paper on the table and the paper did the standing for him.

“Fifty-six days,” he said. “The Eurobond payment. Four hundred and eighty million dollars.”

The number landed like a diagnosis. “If we miss it, we default. If we default, our credit rating drops to junk. If our rating drops to junk, no one lends to us at any rate. The restructuring is part of the deal. If the deal fails, the restructuring fails. If the restructuring fails, the payment comes due in fifty-six days. There is no alternative financing available. I have exhausted every option.” “And the restructuring terms?” the minister of justice asked. “China forgives two point eight billion. The remaining five point four rolls into project financing at one point two percent over forty years. The bond payment is covered. We breathe.”

Silence.

“So the question,” Keïta said slowly, the agriculture minister, the man who had been to the camps and counted the beds, “is not whether we want this deal. The question is whether we can afford to say no.”

Nobody answered. Nobody needed to.

The cabinet adjourned. Diallo walked back to his office. A folder marked CONFIDENTIAL was on his desk, the daily intelligence summary. He opened it standing up.

The Granite Group. Two hundred Kessaran nationals estimated serving with private military operations across the border. Recruitment accelerating in the drought communities, the same communities Keïta had described emptying into the cities. The same young men, flowing in two directions. South to the displacement camps. North to the mercenary camps.

Both directions away from the farms that could no longer hold them. The drought produced refugees. The refugees produced recruits. The recruits produced revenue for a Russian corporation that profited from the instability that the drought had created. Diallo read the number. Two hundred. He thought about Keïta’s number, forty thousand displaced. Two hundred recruited. A ratio. For every two hundred farmers who lost their land to the climate, one picked up a gun for the Russians. Desperation with a ledger. He closed the folder.

He thought about Mariama. The helicopter. The CT scanner that cost twelve hundred dollars and sat in a procurement queue. The minister of health had just told the cabinet that the government side of the hospital in Port Sélani had two doctors for six hundred beds. Two.

The orthopedic surgeon had left for Dubai. The X-ray machine had been broken since March.

The deal was not about minerals or sovereignty or the CFA franc. The deal was about a hospital with two doctors and a camp with forty thousand displaced people

and a school where the textbooks were older than the students reading them. The deal was about hospitals with two doctors and schools without textbooks and a government that spent thirty-four percent of its revenue servicing debt it could not repay.

He could hear Aminata's voice, not literally, but in his mind, the version of her that lived in the opposition speeches and the radio call-in shows and the hashtags that Seydou couldn't translate. Sovereignty is not for sale. And she was right. Sovereignty was not for sale. But a hospital with two doctors was for sale, and a school without textbooks was for sale, and a displacement camp at three hundred percent capacity was for sale, and Diallo was the man standing at the cash register trying to figure out which currency was accepted.

At eight that evening, he gave a televised address.

He sat behind his desk. Dark suit. The flag behind him, green, gold, red. The camera two meters away, operated by a technician from the national broadcaster who had been doing this job for twelve years and who adjusted the lighting without being asked because he knew the president's face, which angles showed composure, which showed exhaustion, where the gray at the temples caught the light.

He spoke for eleven minutes. French first, then the key points in Dioula. He asked the nation for patience. He asked them to read the full agreement, not just the leaked portions. He asked them to trust the democratic process.

He did not mention Article 7 by name. He did not mention the private security clause or the arbitration panels or the three-to-two valuation committee. He spoke about investment, jobs, infrastructure, the future. The words were true in the way that selected truths are true, accurate in content, dishonest in omission. He watched the broadcast afterward on a screen in his office. The lights were off. The building was quiet. Just him and the screen and the image of a man who looked calm, who looked presidential, who looked like he was managing a situation rather than being managed by it.

He turned off the screen.

The building hummed. The generator. The security detail's footsteps on the floor below. The air conditioning that kept this one building at a constant temperature while the city outside cycled through power cuts and candlelight and the darkness of a capital that could not keep its own lights on. Beneath the generator, if he listened, and he was listening now, because the building was quiet and his performance was over and the performer had gone, he could hear the ocean. The Atlantic, two kilometers south, pressing against the shore. The sound reached the residence on still nights, through the walls, through the glass, a low steady pulse that the building could muffle

but not stop. He heard it. He always heard it. The water that had almost taken him at seven. The water that carried the ships. The water that separated his son from the country his son refused to come home to.

He had looked like a man who knew what he was doing. That was the job, looking like you knew, especially when the alternative was letting twenty-eight million people see that their president was making the best decision available to him and the best decision available was not good enough.

He sat in the dark and listened to the ocean and did not move. His phone showed a text from Ibrahima, sent from Paris twenty minutes ago. One line: I watched the address. You looked tired, Papa.

He did not reply.

Chapter 10

The radio reached Ousmane's farm the way it reached every farm in the Bassam region, through a small battery-powered set that his neighbor Amadou kept on a shelf beside his front door, tuned permanently to the community station that broadcast in Dioula from a transmission tower twelve kilometers south.

Ousmane heard it first as a change in the sound of the morning. He was in the eastern field, crouching between the millet rows, pulling weeds. The radio was usually a murmur at this distance, music, the morning greetings, a host whose voice had been part of the mornings for as long as Ousmane could remember. But this morning the voice was different. Tighter.

Faster. The host was angry about something and trying not to show it.

Ousmane stood up. He wiped his hands on his trousers. He walked to the edge of his field where the sound was clearer and he listened.

He could not hear the words, too far, the speaker too small, but he could hear the tone.

Something had happened. The man on the radio knew what it was and was trying to tell people before they heard it from someone else.

He walked back to the compound. He would hear the details soon enough. In the Bassam villages, news traveled the way rain traveled. It started somewhere else and arrived on its own schedule, and when it arrived it was already inside everything.

Amadou came at nine.

He was walking faster than Amadou usually walked, which was itself a piece of information.

Amadou was seventy, three years older than Ousmane, and he moved through the world at the pace of a man who had concluded, decades ago, that hurrying was a form of disrespect to the ground beneath his feet. He farmed the adjacent property, thirty hectares, millet and groundnuts, the same rotation, the same soil. They had been neighbors for forty years.

Their fathers had been neighbors before them. The path between their compounds was worn so smooth by generations of visiting feet that grass no longer attempted to

grow on it. Amadou was carrying a stack of papers. Held together with a rubber band. The papers were warm, fresh from a machine somewhere, and Ousmane could see that the ink was dark and slightly uneven, the print quality of a photocopier running at speed. “Have you heard?”

“I heard the radio. The voice was different this morning.” “This is more than the radio.” He held up the papers. “A university student in the market town translated the leaked deal into Dioula. They’re photocopying it at the market. Fifty francs.”

Fifty francs. The same price as a bag of groundnuts at the market.

They walked to the baobab.

This was where important things happened on Ousmane’s farm, not inside the compound, which was private, and not in the fields, which were work, but under the tree. Disputes were heard here. Decisions were made here. His father had received the independence-day officials here, seated on the ground, offering water, the new flag flying from a branch.

Ousmane brought water from the clay pot. Two cups. He set them on the ground between the roots. Amadou sat. Ousmane sat. Two old men, two pairs of worn sandals, two cups of water. The shade of the baobab was wide enough to hold them both and leave room.

Amadou could read French and Dioula. Ousmane could read Dioula and enough French to follow a government form, the kind of French that told you where to write your name and where to press your thumbprint. The deal’s language was not that kind of French. It was French that did not want to be understood. The words went in circles. One sentence sent you to another sentence, and that one sent you to a third, and by the time you reached the meaning you had forgotten where you started. Ousmane had seen this kind of language before, on tax documents, on land registration papers. It was the language of people who wanted to say yes and no at the same time.

But the Dioula translation was different. Whoever had done it, the university student, working fast, working in the market town with a dictionary and a sense of urgency, had stripped the nesting and the clauses and the cross-references and replaced them with flat, direct sentences. The Dioula version did not say “the contracting parties shall establish a Special Economic Zone within which the regulatory framework governing commercial disputes, labor relations, and security provision shall be determined by the project operator in consultation with the relevant national authorities.” The Dioula version said: “Inside the corridor, Chinese law will apply. Not Kessaran law. Chinese law.”

Amadou read aloud. His voice was steady. He had been doing this for decades, reading government papers to neighbors who needed the French explained. Birth certificates, tax notices, letters from the district office. Amadou read them all, turning the official words into words people could use.

Ousmane listened. He sat against the trunk of the baobab with his legs extended and his hands on his thighs. He watched Amadou's face as Amadou read. There were places where Amadou slowed down and his forehead tightened, those were the parts that mattered.

There were places where Amadou read smoothly and fast, those were the parts that meant nothing.

Amadou reached Article 7. The SEZ provisions. Chinese courts. Chinese labor law. Private security.

Ousmane held up his hand. "Read that again."

Amadou read it again.

"So inside this corridor," Ousmane said, "Kessaran law does not apply."

"That is what it says."

"And the corridor runs through my field."

"Yes."

"So my field would no longer be under Kessaran law."

"That is what it says."

They looked at each other. They had been through this before, different law, different name, same people telling them what the ground underneath them was worth. Now it was the Chinese. And this time, they were being asked to agree.

Amadou continued reading. The resettlement provisions. The compensation structure. The revenue sharing, eighty-five percent to Zhonglu for the first fifty years. Ousmane did not need the Dioula translation for the numbers. Numbers were the same in every language. Eighty-five was eighty-five. Fifty years was fifty years. The arithmetic of the deal did not require a university student's translation. It required only the ability to count, and Ousmane could count.

"Fifty years," he said. "I will be dead. My grandchildren will be grown before Kessara owns forty percent of its own ground." "That is what it says."

Amadou turned to the last page. A map. Printed in black and white, blurred from the photocopier, but clear enough. The Bassam Corridor was marked in a thick dark line from the coast to the plateau. Towns were labeled. Rivers were labeled. And the rail line, a thinner line running through the center of the corridor, was drawn from southwest to northeast, straight as a ruler, the way only machines and men who have

never walked a piece of ground draw lines. Ousmane took the stack from Amadou. He held the map in both hands. The paper was warm. The ink was fresh. He could feel the slight roughness of the toner against his thumbs.

He traced the rail line with his finger. Past the coast. Past the first range of hills. Past the market town where he sold his groundnuts every other Wednesday. Past the junction where the road split north to the villages and south to the river. Into his western field.

His finger moved slowly. The line crossed the field from southwest to northeast. He followed it. Past the point where the fallow strip met the millet. Past the southern edge of the baobab's canopy shadow. Through the center of the field.

He placed his finger on the point where the line passed over a spot he knew better than any spot on earth.

Aïssatou's grave. The laterite stone. The red-brown stone he had cut from the escarpment with a hammer and chisel and carried on his back for two kilometers. The stone that marked where his wife lay, thirty meters east of the tree where his father lay, on the land that his grandfather had planted the morning the country was born. The rail centerline ran directly over it. Not near it. Not beside it. Over it.

He folded the map. He folded it carefully, along the existing creases, matching the edges precisely, the way his wife used to fold the laundry, with care, as if the thing being folded deserved the attention. He put it in his shirt pocket, next to the leather pouch. "What will you do?" Amadou asked.

Ousmane looked at the tree. At the field. At the sky, clear and dry and empty of rain for the twenty-second day.

"I will wait," he said. "The tree waits. The land waits. I can wait." Amadou nodded. He did not ask what Ousmane was waiting for. He had known this man for forty years. Ousmane waited the way the tree waited, not for anything, just because moving was not something he did. He was here. That was the answer.

He gathered his papers. He walked back across the path between their compounds. That evening, Ousmane tried Ibrahim.

The mobile phone. The basic handset on the shelf. He scrolled to the number and pressed the green button. The phone rang. The sound traveled, from the handset to the cell tower the Chinese had built on the ridge four kilometers south, from the tower to a satellite, from the satellite to wherever Ibrahim's phone was, if it was anywhere, if it was still in his son's pocket, if his son was still able to answer.

Nine rings. The recorded message. French. The subscriber was unavailable.

He tried again at eight. Same.

He tried at nine. Sitting on the bench in the compound. The kerosene lamp throwing its circle of yellow on the packed-earth floor. Sékou in the kitchen house, washing the dinner bowls. The sound of water against metal. The scraping of a wooden spoon against the inside of the millet pot, loosening the crust that formed at the bottom where the porridge stuck, a sound Aïssatou had made every evening of their married life, and that Sékou made now in exactly the same rhythm, because the pot was the same pot and the spoon was the same spoon and the motion was a motion learned by watching.

Nine rings. Nothing.

Five days. The longest silence. The mobile money transfer had not arrived either. Sékou had checked at the kiosk in the market town, walking the six kilometers there and back because the kiosk did not have a phone line and you had to go in person. Nothing on the fifteenth. Nothing since. The money that had arrived every month for three years, seven hundred, eight hundred dollars, from a place without a name, earned by work without a description, had stopped.

Ousmane held the phone. He thought about calling Awa. He did not call. If Awa had heard from Ibrahim, she would have said so. And if she hadn't, the question would force him to say what he already knew, what the money meant, what the work was, what

Ibrahim had become in the place without a name. He had been holding this alone for three years, and the knowing grew worse each month when the transfer arrived.

He turned off the radio. He turned off the lamp.

He lay on the bed in the dark. The same bed, the same night sounds, the same iron roof cooling overhead. But tonight the folded map was in his shirt pocket, pressing against his chest beside the leather pouch. The pouch held the verse and the seeds and a pinch of soil from this ground. The map held a straight line that ran through his wife's grave.

Both about the same field. One to keep it. One to take it. He lay still and listened to the compound settle around him and did not sleep.

Chapter 11

Liwei spent the morning building a lie. Not a large one. Not the kind that gets you fired or arrested or named in an investigation. The kind that lives inside a PowerPoint presentation, a number that is true on its own but false in context. The kind of lie that corporations build entire departments around and that engineers, if they are honest with themselves, recognize as the place where their discipline meets the discipline of money and the discipline of money wins.

The instruction had come from the regional director's office at seven AM. A message on the internal system: Prepare updated employment projections for Thursday briefing. Use current multipliers. Emphasize local capacity development.

She read the instruction twice. "Use current multipliers" was straightforward. She had calculated the employment multipliers six months ago, using standard methodology for industrial zone development. "Emphasize local capacity development" was not straightforward. It was a direction that told her what conclusion the presentation should reach before the data had been consulted. She opened her laptop. The laptop, three years old, the screen slightly dimmer. She opened the modeling software. She opened the spreadsheet where the employment multipliers lived, a grid of numbers, each one the product of a calculation she had performed herself, each one defensible, each one correct.

Slide 1: Project Overview. The Kessara Gateway Partnership. \$12.4 billion. Railway, port, processing facilities, new city. She built the slide from the template, Zhonglu branding, the company logo in the corner, the navy-and-gold color scheme that the communications department had decided looked like money. Slide 3: Employment Projections. This was where the lie lived. She had run the model twice. The first run used the standard assumptions: full local hiring across all employment categories, construction, operations, management, maintenance, support services. Under these assumptions, the project would generate fifty thousand direct jobs and approximately two hundred thousand indirect jobs over the fifteen-year construction and ramp-up period. These numbers were real. She had calculated them herself. They were defensible. They would hold up to scrutiny from anyone who examined the

methodology.

The second run used different assumptions. She had done this one on her own, at night, in the dormitory room, not because anyone had asked but because the engineer in her could not leave a calculation half-finished. This run used the actual employment patterns from comparable Chinese projects in Africa, the ones she had worked on, the ones she had seen with her own eyes. In Ethiopia, ninety percent of the construction workforce had been Ethiopian. This was good. The Ethiopian government had demanded local hiring and enforced it through contract penalties. In Angola, seventy-four percent of the workforce was Angolan. Also reasonable.

In Kenya, the proportion varied by project phase, high local hiring during earthworks and basic construction, dropping to twenty percent for technical installation and specialized systems. The Kessara SEZ provisions did not specify local hiring requirements. Article 7 placed labor regulation under Chinese standards. Chinese construction companies brought their own workers, men from Sichuan and Fujian and Henan, recruited through labor agencies that operated in the industrial cities, transported to Africa in groups, housed in dormitories inside compound fences.

Under realistic assumptions, the assumptions that reflected what she had seen in four countries over eighteen years, the project would generate approximately twelve thousand jobs for Kessaran nationals during the construction phase. Not fifty thousand. Twelve thousand. The remaining thirty-eight thousand would be filled by Chinese workers on Chinese contracts at Chinese wage rates. She had two numbers. Fifty thousand and twelve thousand. One was the assumption. The other was the experience.

She built slide 3 using the first number. Fifty thousand. She formatted it in the navy-and-gold color scheme. She added a bar chart showing the projected growth in employment by year. The chart rose in a clean upward curve. Briefings liked upward curves. The regional director liked upward curves. Nobody in the chain between her desk and the final presentation would question an upward curve.

She did not build a slide using the second number.

Slide 7: Local Capacity Development. This was the slide the instruction had told her to emphasize. She pulled the data from Article 19, the technology transfer clause. Zhonglu was required to train and certify Kessaran engineers by year fifteen. She built a timeline showing the training milestones: year 3, initial technical certifications; year 7, operational management transfer; year 15, full Kessaran technical capacity.

The timeline was real. The milestones were contractual. Whether they would be met was a different question, one that the slide did not ask and the briefing would not

raise, because asking whether contractual commitments would be kept was the kind of question that made everyone uncomfortable and that nobody with a contract to protect wanted to answer.

Slide 12: Community Engagement. Resettlement support.

Agricultural transition programs.

“Respectful relocation of cultural and heritage sites.” She typed this last phrase from the deal text and looked at it on the screen. “Respectful relocation.” The sacred grove. The cemeteries. The market that had operated for three hundred years. Respectful relocation.

She thought about the grove, the clay pot at the base of the tree, the swept ground, the water in the cup catching the light. She had been there two days ago. Mamadou had told her not to enter. “The spirits live here.”

Respectful relocation of cultural and heritage sites.

She typed one more line on slide 12. A footnote. Small font, gray text, the kind of line that appears at the bottom of a slide and is read by no one: Employment projections assume full utilization of local labor markets. Actual outcomes may vary based on project operator hiring practices and SEZ labor provisions.

She looked at the footnote. It was the truth. It was also invisible. Gray text on a white background, ten-point font, at the bottom of a slide that would be displayed for forty-five seconds during a briefing where the regional director would be talking over it. She selected the footnote. She changed the font color from gray to white. The text disappeared. It was still there, in the file, in the data, recoverable by anyone who looked.

But on the screen, on the projector, in the briefing, it was gone. She saved the file. She closed the laptop.

She had not lied. She had not fabricated a number. She had used a defensible methodology and presented a defensible result. She had also hidden the sentence that would have made the result honest, and hiding it was the lie, the kind engineers learn to live with because the alternative is a career-ending conversation with a regional director who does not want to hear that his fifty thousand is actually twelve thousand.

She walked to the port after lunch.

She needed to move. The warehouse felt smaller today. The drains in the floor were more visible. The salt tang was stronger. The humidity pushing it up from the concrete, the old fish plant asserting itself through the conversion.

The port was fifteen minutes on foot from the office. Through the commercial gate, her Zhonglu badge opened it, and along the quay to the container terminal. The sun

was high and the concrete radiated heat from below while the air pressed down from above. She walked between the two, her shadow short and dark at her feet. Seven ships at anchor. All Chinese-flagged. She stopped at the edge of the quay and watched the loading.

The cranes worked in a rhythm, the long arms swinging out over the holds, the cables taut, the pallets rising from the dock. Each pallet carried approximately two metric tons of ore. The ore was dark, black-brown, dense, still carrying the look of the ground it had come from. Coltan. Cobalt. Copper. Raw material pulled from the Bassam Plateau, trucked two hundred kilometers to the port on roads that were paved for the first eighty-seven kilometers and laterite for the rest, loaded onto ships that would carry it to Guangzhou and Shenzhen.

She watched a pallet rise from the dock. Two tons. She did the math, the math she had done before, the math that lived in her head like a splinter.

The ore left Kessara at approximately eighty dollars per metric ton. FOB, free on board, the price at the ship's rail, the price that included extraction and transport but not processing. By the time the same material reached a processing facility in China and was refined into battery-grade cobalt sulfate, the value was approximately thirty-five thousand dollars per ton. The multiplication factor was four hundred and thirty-seven. Four hundred and thirty-seven. The same weight of material, transformed by processing, by the application of heat and chemistry and engineering, by the work of machines and the workers who operated them, became worth four hundred and thirty-seven times more.

The deal promised to close that gap. Processing facilities inside Kessara. Refining capacity.

Value-added manufacturing. Fifty thousand jobs. Slide 3. Or twelve thousand jobs. The number she had not put on a slide. She watched another pallet rise. Two tons. Eighty dollars. By the time it came back, as a battery, a capacitor, a component inside a phone or a car or a laptop, it would be worth thirty-five thousand. That ratio was why twelve billion dollars was on the table. Nobody spends twelve billion to help. You spend twelve billion when the return is four hundred and thirty-seven to one.

Seven ships. All outbound. The port was a hinge, the point where the ground became product and the product became profit and the profit went east. She was standing at the hinge, building presentations that predicted fifty thousand jobs for a country that would be lucky to see twelve thousand, hiding the honest sentence in white font on a white background, and watching pallets of raw material leave for processing plants that should have been here but weren't because the deal that would

build them had not yet been approved by the people whose ground the material came from. The sun hit the water. She drank from her bottle. The water was warm. She walked back to the office. She opened the presentation. She looked at slide 3. Fifty thousand. She looked at slide 12. Respectful relocation of cultural and heritage sites. She looked at the white text hiding at the bottom, invisible, recoverable, the most honest thing in the file.

She did not change anything. She saved the file and closed it and went back to the soil surveys, where the numbers said what they meant and did not need a color scheme to say it.

Chapter 12

The leaked provisions landed on Aminata's desk at six in the morning, carried by Binta, who had downloaded them from a WhatsApp group that one of the student organizations was running before the sun came up.

Aminata took the printed pages. She did not read them immediately. She set them on her desk, beside the cold coffee from yesterday, and looked at them. Ninety-three pages. The full negotiation text. She would read every word before she said a single one. The pages were warm from the printer.

Around her, the campaign office was accelerating. Through the door, she could hear the machinery responding to the leak at speed. Oumar on two phones simultaneously, drafting a press statement in French on his laptop while dictating a social media post in Dioula to an intern. Binta was calling the market association networks, the women's groups, the credit unions, the informal distribution channels that could move a message from Port Sélani to the corridor villages in four hours using nothing more than phone calls, bus drivers, and the ancient, unbreakable infrastructure of women who talked to other women. Rachid was working the rural networks, the district chiefs, the farmers' cooperatives, the village radio stations that could be reached only by phone because their internet connections did not exist.

Derek was in the conference room on a call to Washington, his voice carrying through the thin wall. "...radioactive. The SEZ provisions are exactly what we predicted. We need to move the media placement up to..."

Aminata closed her office door.

She had the document. The question was not what it said. She would know that in an hour.

The question was what to do with it, and "what to do with it" was not the same as "react to it." Reacting was for campaigns. Processing was for lawyers. She was both, and the lawyer needed to read before the campaigner spoke.

She read for ninety minutes. Alone. Door locked. The tailor's sewing machine humming through the floor below.

She read the way she had been trained, at Oxford, in a tutorial room with a window overlooking the Bodleian, where a professor named Henderson had taught her to read contracts like a forensic accountant reads a ledger. “A contract is not an agreement,” Henderson said. “A contract is a distribution of risk. Every clause transfers risk from one party to another. Your job is to find out who ends up holding the most.”

Article 7 was a gift. The SEZ provisions, Chinese courts, Chinese labor law, private security, were the provisions that won campaigns. She could hear the press statement writing itself. She could feel the polling move. Binta was already distributing translations. Oumar was already drafting. The machine was already running. She read past Article 7. The gift was on the table. She was looking for what was under the table.

Article 12: resettlement. The three-to-two valuation committee. She marked it. Another gift, a committee where the buyer held the majority and called it “independent.” She circled the composition and moved on.

She reached page seventy-eight.

Article 19, Section 4. Revenue sharing. Long-term equity transition. She had been expecting the standard arrangement, declining foreign ownership, gradual Kessaran equity increase, the usual staircase that looked like progress on paper and functioned like a delay in practice. The standard arrangement was what she had prepared her campaign to attack.

What she found was not standard.

Buried in the subsection, between a paragraph about accounting methodology and a paragraph about dispute resolution, three sentences: The project operator shall establish, fund, and administer a comprehensive technology transfer program for the purpose of training and certifying Kessaran nationals in the operation, maintenance, and management of all mineral processing facilities within the corridor. Certification standards shall meet or exceed international benchmarks as defined in Annex K. Full operational transfer to certified Kessaran personnel shall be completed no later than Year 15 of the project term.

Shall. Not “may.” Not “where feasible.” Not “subject to mutual agreement” or “in consultation with” or any of the elastic phrases that contracts use when they want to promise without committing. Shall. The word that means a binding legal obligation with a penalty clause.

She read the three sentences again. She read Annex K, a technical appendix specifying the certification levels, the training timeline, the funding requirements. The annex was detailed. Professionally drafted. Someone at Zhonglu, an engineer, a

program manager, someone who understood that a promise without a specification was not a promise, had built a genuine training framework into the deal.

It was not enough. Fifty years before Kessara owned forty percent of its own minerals was too long. Eighty-five percent to Zhonglu for the first half century was an extraction rate that would have made the French colonial administration blush.

But the technology transfer clause was real. And it was more than she had expected. And it was more than any previous deal, French, American, British, or otherwise, had ever offered. The French had extracted for a hundred years and transferred nothing. The Americans had extracted through proxies and called it “development assistance.” The British had left behind a railway gauge and a legal system and called it civilization. Nobody, nobody, had put “shall establish, fund, and administer” into a binding clause with specifications and a deadline.

It was the skeleton of a fair deal buried inside an unfair one. She had spent enough years reading contracts to know what this one should have looked like, local processing within the corridor, not raw export. Training programs that transferred control, not just skills. Revenue terms a farmer could survive long enough to benefit from. Arbitration under Kessaran courts, not a private tribunal appointed by the investor. The technology transfer clause proved that someone at Zhonglu understood what a real partnership required. The rest of the deal proved they had decided not to offer one.

She closed the document. She opened the press statement Oumar had drafted during the hour she’d been reading. It was good, clean, sharp, leading with Article 12, hammering the sovereignty argument. It mentioned Article 7 twice. It mentioned Article 19 once, focusing on the eighty-five percent revenue share. It did not mention the technology transfer clause.

Aminata read the statement. She could add three sentences. She could say: “While the revenue terms are unacceptable, the agreement includes a technology transfer requirement that, if enforced, would represent the first binding commitment to industrial capacity development in Kessaran history.” Three sentences. True. Important. The kind of nuance that a legal mind recognized and a campaign mind suppressed.

She did not add the three sentences. She approved the statement as written. She sent it to Oumar for distribution.

The bottom drawer was six inches from her right knee. She did not open it. Moussa’s photograph was inside. The blue shirt. The face that held nothing back. She did not need to look at it this morning. Moussa was in every decision she made. He

had been in every decision since he disappeared. He was in this one now, the choice not to mention the technology transfer clause, the omission she was about to commit in the name of the campaign she had built because the system that took her brother had never stopped.

The technology transfer clause was true. She chose not to say it. The choice was the first lie of omission in a campaign built on the premise that the government was hiding the truth.

She crossed the line quietly. And the crossing made no sound. At four in the afternoon, Khadija came into her office and closed the door.

Khadija did not close the door gently. She closed it the way a woman closes a door when she has information that needs one closed.

Before Khadija could speak, Aminata said: "Have you read the full text?"

"Page seventy-eight." Khadija had read it. Of course she had read it. "The technology transfer clause."

"It's real."

"I know it's real. That's not why I'm here." Khadija's face shifted from the clause to whatever she was carrying. "The three hundred and forty thousand," she said. "I traced it."

She stood. She always delivered findings standing, on her feet, facing the person who needed the information, with no furniture between them.

"Sixty thousand to a media monitoring firm in Johannesburg. South African company, legitimate, they track broadcast and print coverage across the continent. Standard service.

Nothing unusual."

Aminata nodded.

"Eighty thousand to a PR company in Nairobi.

Kenyan-registered, but the actual work is done out of London. They specialize in what they call 'international advocacy', placing stories, coordinating talking points across time zones, making sure a narrative in Dakar matches a narrative in Washington. Professional. Expensive. Also standard for a Foundation this size."

"And the rest?"

"Two hundred thousand to a consulting group registered in Delaware." Khadija paused. The pause was calibrated, long enough to signal significance, short enough to maintain pace.

"The consulting group has no website. No public employees. No listed office. The Delaware registration uses a registered agent, a law firm in Wilmington that

specializes in entity formation.” “A shell.”

“The registered agent is the same firm that handles entity formation for a company called Meridian Strategic Partners. Meridian does contract work for the United States Department of State. Specifically, for the Bureau of African Affairs.” The sewing machine downstairs stopped. The quiet it left behind was louder than the stitching had been.

“So the American government is running operations through money that was sent to my campaign.”

“I can’t prove that. The shell could be a cutout for anyone, the Foundation, a donor, a third party we haven’t identified. The link to Meridian is the registered agent, not the ownership. It could be coincidence.”

They looked at each other. Khadija’s face said what it always said: I am giving you the information. What you do with it is yours. “Is it coincidence?” Aminata asked.

“In sixteen years of working with you, I have never seen a coincidence that used the same registered agent as a State Department contractor.”

Aminata turned to the window. The beignet vendor was packing up. The accountant downstairs had gone silent. The street was emptying into the evening, people heading home, the day’s arguments cooling into the night’s reflections.

Her campaign was fighting for Kessaran sovereignty. Her campaign was funded by an American foundation whose board included mining executives and whose money traveled through Delaware shells that shared infrastructure with the State Department. The No campaign was not about sovereignty. It was about access, who got the minerals, through which door, under whose flag.

She had known this. Known it the way you know the terms of a contract you signed without reading the fine print. You know the obligation is there, you just haven’t looked at the number. She had taken the money because without the money there was no campaign, and without a campaign Moussa disappeared twice, once in 1997 and again in the silence that followed.

But knowing and seeing were different experiences. Knowing was theoretical. Seeing was Khadija standing in her office with a Delaware registration and a registered agent and a line that ran from the Foundation’s bank account to a shell company to the Bureau of African Affairs to the minerals under the Bassam Plateau. “Keep looking,” Aminata said. “Don’t use the Foundation’s channels. Don’t tell Derek.”

“Aminata.” Khadija did not use her name often. When she did, it carried the weight of sixteen years. “Two discoveries in one day. The technology transfer clause and the

shell company.

Both of them change what you're doing. You need to decide which one matters more."

"They both matter."

"They do. But you can't act on both. If you go public with the shell company, you lose the Foundation's money and the campaign collapses. If you go public with the technology transfer clause, you lose the sovereignty argument and the campaign softens. You have two truths and you can only afford to tell one of them." Aminata looked at her. The steadiness. The precision. The woman who had survived two coups and a famine and a marriage to a man who had been on the wrong side of history and who had kept the records that proved it.

"Find out what the two hundred thousand is buying," Aminata said. "That's the truth that matters first. What the Americans are doing with my campaign's money, that I need to know before I decide anything else." Khadija nodded. She opened the door. She left.

Aminata stood at the window. The street was dark now. The power had gone. Somewhere in the Médina, a generator coughed to life and the lights in a shop window flickered on, a small island of electricity in the general dark.

She had two truths and she could only afford to tell one of them. Khadija was right. The technology transfer clause complicated her argument. The shell company threatened her operation. Both were real. Both changed what she was doing. And the campaign she had built, the legal challenge, the constitutional argument, the case for sovereignty, was holding, but the evidence had shifted, and today she had learned how far.

Chapter 13

Colonel Viktor Sokolov woke at five AM in the Hôtel Atlantique and exercised on the floor of his room.

Push-ups first. Four sets of twenty-five. His palms flat on the carpet. The carpet was thin, hotel-grade, the kind that existed in every hotel in every African country he had worked in, which was seven, and which he could not distinguish from each other by carpet because the carpets were the same. His body rose and fell. His breathing was regulated, inhale on the descent, exhale on the push. The rhythm had not changed in twenty-three years. The body had, forty-eight now, the shoulders heavier, the joints slower to warm, the left knee producing a small click on every third repetition that had not been there five years ago and that he logged like equipment degradation, noting it, scheduling the replacement. Sit-ups. Three sets of thirty. Hands behind his head. The ceiling above him was white, featureless, marked only by the smoke detector and the air conditioning vent. He counted without thinking. Counting was automatic. Everything about the routine was automatic. He had designed it that way, a sequence that required no decisions, no adaptation, no engagement of the mind. The mind was saved for later. The body was maintained first, the way you service an engine before you drive it.

Stretching. The routine from GRU training, hip flexors, hamstrings, shoulders, the thoracic rotation that his instructor in Moscow had called “the survivor’s twist” because it kept the spine mobile enough to function in confined spaces. Vehicles. Holding cells. The crawl spaces beneath buildings where listening devices were installed. Sokolov had not installed a listening device in eleven years. He had moved from intelligence to private military contracting, from serving a state to serving a market, and the transition had required less adjustment than he expected because the work was the same. Observe. Assess. Position.

Act. The employer changed. The verbs did not.

He stretched on the floor and looked through the window. His room was on the seventh floor. The window faced south, over the rooftops of the Médina. In the gray light before dawn, the buildings were silhouettes, flat roofs, satellite dishes, the

occasional tree growing from a courtyard. Three blocks away, a large structure rose above the roofline.

Stone walls. A green-tiled roof. A minaret.

The call to prayer started while he held the thoracic twist. His torso rotated, his right hand on the floor, his left arm reaching toward the ceiling. The sound came through the window glass, muted but present. A single voice from the minaret, then other voices from other mosques, layering over each other.

People were arriving. He watched them from the floor, small figures in white and bright colors, moving through the streets toward the mosque in streams that merged and thickened as they approached the entrance. He counted. Professional habit. Three hundred.

Maybe more. A crowd that size, assembling voluntarily, at five-thirty in the morning, in response to a voice from a loudspeaker.

He assessed the crowd, density, movement patterns, entry and exit points, the ratio of young men to the total. Approximately fifteen percent were young men. The rest were older men and women. A low-threat profile. The building had four exits visible from this angle. The surrounding streets were narrow, good for crowd control, bad for rapid dispersal.

Whatever the man inside that building was selling, the distribution network was excellent.

He stood. He showered. The water was hot. The Hôtel Atlantique was the only hotel in Port Sélani with reliable hot water, which was why he stayed here despite the price, because reliable systems were rare in this country and Sokolov paid for reliability wherever he found it.

He dressed. Dark trousers. A shirt he did not need to think about because he owned six identical shirts and they were packed in his bag in the order he would wear them, so dressing in the morning required no selection, no decision, no expenditure of the cognitive budget he reserved for things that mattered.

He sat at the desk. He opened his laptop. He took out the folding knife.

Carbon steel. Worn wooden handle, the grain darkened by years of contact with his palm.

The blade was no longer than his thumb, small enough to be unremarkable, sharp enough to be useful, the kind of blade that security personnel did not confiscate because it did not look like a weapon. It was not a weapon. It was a tool. He used it to open packages, to cut cord, to strip wire, and, every morning, while the laptop booted, to clean his fingernails.

One finger at a time. Left hand first. The blade edge moving beneath each nail in small, precise strokes. He removed nothing visible. The act was not about cleanliness. It was about maintenance, the daily verification that each component was in working order, that the hands were steady, that the blade was sharp, that the man holding it was the same man who had held it yesterday and would hold it tomorrow. Continuity. Functionality. Readiness.

The laptop opened to the personnel database. He did not check email. He did not read news. He read his own data first, the way a pilot reads instruments before looking out the window.

He turned on the radio. The local station. He spoke French but not Dioula, and this morning the broadcast was in Dioula, the host reading something, the voice tight, the rhythm faster than yesterday. Sokolov did not need the words. He needed the temperature.

He had been reading temperatures for twenty-three years, in Chechnya, in Syria, in Libya, in Mali, in the Central African Republic, in Mozambique, in this country. The temperature was the aggregate emotional state of a population as expressed through its media, its markets, its streets. You measured it the way you measured weather, not by understanding every cloud but by reading the pressure. High pressure meant stability. Low pressure meant storm. The transition between them was where work was found.

Yesterday the pressure had been moderate. The referendum was coming. The campaigns were active. The streets were argumentative but orderly.

This morning the pressure had dropped. The host's voice was different. The callers, he could hear them breaking in, their voices cutting across each other, were angry. The leak had changed the temperature overnight.

Good.

Low pressure meant instability. Instability meant uncertainty. Uncertainty meant fear. And fear was the commodity that Sokolov's industry traded in, not directly, not crudely, but through the mechanism of supply and demand. When governments were afraid, they purchased security. When they purchased security, they purchased it from companies like the Granite Group. The price was set by the level of fear. The level of fear was set by the level of instability. The level of instability was something that could be observed, predicted, and, in certain circumstances, influenced. He turned off the radio. He had the temperature.

Two phone calls.

The first to Captain Amadou Touré, Kessaran National Gendarmerie. Sokolov had been paying Touré for eight months. The payment was modest, four hundred dollars a

month, made in cash, delivered by a local intermediary, recorded in Sokolov's books as

"consulting, security assessment." Touré was not a corrupt man in any interesting sense. He was a mid-ranking officer with three children and a government salary that did not cover all three school fees. Sokolov covered the gap. The transaction was clean, documented, and mutually beneficial.

"The referendum," Sokolov said. "Security at the polling stations."

"The capital, yes. We have the personnel. The north, probably. The military is supplementing in the border districts. The corridor," A pause. The pause of a man doing a calculation he did not want to perform. "It depends."

"On what?"

"On whether anyone wants it to go wrong."

Sokolov noted the phrasing. Whether anyone wants it to go wrong. Touré was not asking about accident or incompetence. He was asking about intent. The question implied that he understood, as every mid-ranking security officer in every African country Sokolov had worked in understood, that the line between a security failure and a security operation was a question of authorization, not capability.

"Thank you, Captain."

The second call to his operations base. Six hundred kilometers northeast, across the border, in a country whose name did not appear in Sokolov's reporting because the camp could have been anywhere and the anywhere was the point. The Granite Group operated across borders without paperwork, without announcement, going where the conditions demanded.

His operations manager answered. A South African named van der Merwe who had served in the South African National Defence Force and transitioned to private work with the efficiency of a man who had discovered that the private sector paid better and asked fewer questions.

"Recruitment pace," Sokolov said.

"Twelve confirmed this month. Forty projected by end of next."

"Double it. Widen the net to the drought communities south of the border."

"Those are Kessarans nationals. We've been pulling from Bassam for three years."

"I know what they are. The referendum makes them easier to find and harder to keep. Recruit now, before the result changes the border traffic."

A pause. Van der Merwe processing the instruction. He would not question it. Questioning instructions was not part of his function, but he would note it, because recruiting from a country where a referendum was underway had operational

implications that an experienced manager would want to have documented. “Understood.”

Sokolov hung up and opened the personnel database. He entered the search term: TRAORÉ, IBRAHIM.

The file loaded. Age 26. Nationality: Kessaran. Region of origin: Bassam. Recruited three years prior through the standard channel, a labor agent in the border town who identified candidates from the farming communities, vetted them for physical fitness and compliance, and transported them to the training camp. Ibrahim Traoré had been a standard recruit, adequate performance, adequate discipline, the adequate functionality of a young man who had joined because eight hundred dollars a month was more than his father’s farm produced in a year.

The most recent entries were flagged.

Two weeks ago, unit commander’s note: Subject has requested discharge. Request denied per standard operating procedure. Subject cited “family obligations” as reason for request. Note: no family contact information on file. Subject has been communicating via personal satellite phone during restricted hours. Phone confiscated and returned per company policy (first offense). One week ago: Subject’s satellite phone confiscated a second time. Phone returned with formal warning. Subject’s unit performance has declined, two missed patrol check-ins, one equipment infraction. Recommend enhanced monitoring.

Sokolov read the entries. He folded the knife. He put it in his pocket. He typed a single line into the notes field: Monitor. Do not engage unless he runs.

He spent the afternoon on operational planning, logistics, supply chain reviews, three more calls to contacts in the capital. The work was administrative and he performed it with the same mechanical attention he gave the morning push-ups. At seven, he closed the last file. He did not think about Ibrahim Traoré after closing it. The file was noted. The system would track the rest. He ordered room service. Grilled fish, rice, a beer. The fish arrived on a white plate with a wedge of lime. He ate at the desk because the desk had the laptop and the laptop had the database and the database was the closest thing to company he required. He ate methodically. The fish was good, port city, fresh catch, properly grilled. The rice was adequate. The beer was cold. He consumed these things mechanically, assessing quality, noting efficiency, deriving the necessary energy.

Below his window, Port Sélani was waking into its new temperature. The leak had made the city louder. He could hear it through the glass, the radio voices sharper, the traffic horns more insistent. A city that had read the terms and conditions of its own

future and found the fine print worse than the advertisement. He opened a map on his laptop. Kessara. He marked three locations.

Port Sélani, the capital. The center of political gravity. Where the result would be announced. Where the reaction would begin. The Bassam Corridor, the deal's physical footprint. Where the construction would happen or not happen. Where the land was. Where the communities were.

The northeast border region, his operating area. Where the camps were. Where the recruits came from. Where the drought had broken the farming economy and created a labor pool for an industry that processed young men the way the port processed ore: extracting them from the ground where they grew, transporting them elsewhere, and converting them into something more useful to someone far away.

Three points on a map. A triangle. The referendum would produce a result on Saturday. The result would produce a reaction. The reaction would produce a demand for security. The demand would produce a contract. The contract would produce revenue. The sequence was predictable. The variables were the margin (how close the vote) and the reaction (how violent the losing side). The closer the margin and the more violent the reaction, the higher the price. Sokolov did not hope for violence. Hope was not a professional tool. He prepared for violence the way an umbrella manufacturer prepares for rain, without moral investment, with full commercial attention.

He finished his beer. He washed his hands. He closed the laptop. He set the alarm for five AM, the same time, the same alarm, the same sequence tomorrow.

He slept well. Eight hours. As he did every night, in every country, in every room with a thin carpet and a window facing south.

Some people have difficulty sleeping when they know what is coming. Sokolov was not one of those people. Difficulty implied incomplete preparation, and Sokolov was never incompletely prepared.

The knife sat on the nightstand beside his phone. The blade was closed. The handle was smooth from years of use. It would be in his hand again tomorrow.

* * *

<div align="center">

DAY 3: TUESDAY

"The Ground"

</div>

*“Maps are never innocent. They are always an argument.” — Chimamanda
Ngozi Adichie*

* * *

Chapter 14

Chen Liwei walked the alignment for the first time on a Tuesday morning, and the ground disagreed with the drawings.

This was normal. The ground always disagreed with the drawings. In eighteen years of building things across four countries, she had never once encountered terrain that matched the topographic survey with the precision that the survey implied. Surveys were abstractions. They measured elevations at fixed intervals, interpolated the spaces between, and produced a surface that was mathematically correct and physically approximate. The ground did not care about interpolation. The ground had its own topography, the gully that the survey missed because the measurement point was twenty meters to the left, the rock outcrop that the elevation model smoothed into a gentle rise, the termite mound that registered as noise in the data and was, in reality, a structure three meters tall and harder than the surrounding soil. She had told Mamadou to drop her at the kilometer-zero marker and drive ahead to kilometer sixteen to wait. He had looked concerned, a Chinese woman walking alone through the Kessaran countryside, but she outranked his concern, and he knew the hierarchy well enough to express disagreement through silence rather than argument.

“I need to see the alignment on foot,” she said. “Alone. The car changes what I see.”

This was true. From a car, terrain was a sequence of images passing a window. On foot, terrain was a conversation. The ground spoke through the soles of your boots, through the resistance of the soil, through the angle of the slope and the way your knees adjusted and what your body told you about bearing capacity and drainage and stability. An engineer who had never walked an alignment was an engineer who had never listened to the ground, and Liwei had been listening since her first project, a highway outside Addis Ababa, where she had walked thirty-two kilometers in three days and arrived at the design review meeting with blistered feet and a list of sixteen corrections to the survey data that saved the project four months of rework.

She walked.

The survey flags began at the kilometer-zero marker, a concrete post at the edge of the coastal plain. Orange flags on wire stakes, planted every fifty meters, running in a line toward the plateau. The flags were the alignment's advance party, the first physical evidence of the deal on the ground. Before the machines, before the fences, before the workers and the concrete and the rail, these small orange markers were the deal made visible. Each one said: this ground has been claimed. Each one was planted by a survey crew that had walked this line with instruments and notebooks and had recorded what they saw in numbers that would be transmitted to an office where Liwei would convert them into engineering drawings that would be transmitted to a construction team that would convert them into a railway.

The chain of abstraction ran in one direction: from ground to number to drawing to structure. Liwei was walking it in reverse. The coastal plain was flat for the first six kilometers. Laterite soil, the red-brown surface she had been studying in the survey binders. On foot, the soil told her things the binders could not. She crouched and pressed her palm against the ground. Warm. The surface layer was dry, cracked in places, the fine hexagonal cracking pattern of clay-rich soil losing moisture. But two centimeters down, when she pushed her fingers into the earth, the soil was denser. Cooler. The bearing capacity she had calculated from the survey data, 180 to 220 kilopascals, felt right. The ground pushed back against her fingers with the firm resistance of soil that would hold weight.

She took a sample. A small boring kit in her backpack, a hand auger, sample bags, labels.

She drove the auger into the ground, twisted, pulled. The core came up clean, a cylinder of red-brown earth, layered, the top two centimeters lighter than the rest. She bagged it, labeled it (KM 3.2, DEPTH 30CM, SURFACE DRY), and moved on.

Between the survey flags, the land was what the engineering drawings could not show: inhabited. Millet fields in various states, some green, some fallow, some abandoned. The green ones had been recently weeded; she could see the cleared rows, the small piles of pulled grass drying at the field edges. Someone had been here this morning, doing the same work they had done yesterday and would do tomorrow. The survey recorded these fields as "agricultural, subsistence" and assigned them a land-use code that would appear in the environmental impact assessment as a category to be mitigated.

She passed a well at kilometer five. A concrete ring, knee-height, with a pulley and a rope and a yellow jerrycan tied to the end. A woman was drawing water, pulling the rope hand over hand, the jerrycan rising from the darkness, water sloshing over the

rim. The woman looked at Liwei. Liwei looked at the woman. The woman had hands that were strong and cracked, dark from decades of water and soil and sunlight. Liwei thought of her mother's hands. Factory work, different kind of cracking, different kind of labor, different continent. But the wear was the same.

The well drew from the aquifer. She knew this from the hydrological survey. The aquifer sat beneath the proposed rail bed at this section, a lens of groundwater trapped between the laterite surface layer and the metamorphic bedrock below. Her team had flagged it in the drainage assessment. "Hydrological consideration", the phrase she had written, the phrase that meant the groundwater might interfere with the rail bed drainage and required mitigation.

The woman pulled the jerrycan to the surface and set it on the ground. She poured water into a basin. The water was clear. "Hydrological consideration." Two words. In the drainage assessment, the aquifer was a variable to be managed. At the well, the aquifer was the reason two hundred people had clean water. The drainage assessment did not mention the two hundred people. It mentioned the aquifer's depth, its yield, its seasonal variation, and its potential impact on sub-grade stability. The people who drank from it were not a hydrological consideration.

They were a resettlement consideration, and resettlement was a different section of the report, prepared by a different team, and the two sections did not cross-reference each other because the report's structure kept hydrology and humanity in separate chapters. Liwei walked on. She did not introduce herself. She did not explain what she was doing. The woman watched her go.

The grove was at kilometer twelve.

She felt it before she saw it. A temperature change. The air cooled by two or three degrees as she approached, the way air cools near water or dense shade. Then the canopy appeared above the scrub, tall trees, their crowns merging into a continuous roof of dark green, blocking the sun, creating a pocket of shadow and humidity that was distinct from the surrounding landscape the way an island is distinct from the sea around it.

She stopped at the edge. The survey flags ran along both sides of the grove. The alignment did not pass through it. Someone, at some stage of the route design, had adjusted the center line to avoid the dense vegetation. She did not know who had made the adjustment or why. The engineering reason would have been drainage, the root systems of old trees disrupted sub-grade stability and created preferential water channels that could undermine a rail bed. The other reason, the reason that did not appear in engineering reports, was that the grove looked like a place you did not enter

without permission.

The trees were old. She could not identify the species. West African botany was not her training, but she could read their age the way she read any structure: by the evidence of time. The trunks were wide, the bark deeply fissured, the root systems visible above the surface, spreading across the ground in patterns that spoke of decades of slow, patient growth. The undergrowth was cleared, swept, she realized, not naturally sparse. Someone maintained this space.

At the base of the nearest tree, she saw the offerings. A clay pot, small, containing water.

Beside it, a kola nut, split in half. Beside that, a handful of grain, millet, she thought, the same pale grain she had been walking past in the fields. The offerings were fresh. Someone had been here this morning.

She did not enter. She stood at the edge and looked. The air inside the grove was different, not just cooler but denser, like the air inside a cathedral.

The same molecules, differently arranged. She was an engineer. She did not believe in spirits. But she believed in atmospheres, the measurable reality that certain spaces produce certain responses in the human nervous system, responses that had nothing to do with belief and everything to do with the accumulated effect of age, shade, silence, and the knowledge that the space had been tended for longer than she had been alive.

She marked her notebook: KM 12. GROVE. SIGNIFICANT VEGETATION. CULTURAL INDICATORS PRESENT. ALIGNMENT DIVERTS, VERIFY DESIGN INTENT.

She walked on.

At kilometer fourteen, the field opened and she saw the baobab. Alone in the landscape. A young baobab, but already substantial, a trunk a full meter across and still thickening, bark smooth and gray, branches already spreading wide. The survey flags ran along both sides of the field. The center line, on the drawings she carried in her bag, passed through the trunk's position.

She walked to it. She stood in the shade. The shade was wide, fifteen meters across, a circle of cool ground in the middle of the hot, bright field. The relief was immediate. She put her hand on the bark. Rough under her palm. Warm from the sun on the south-facing side, cooler where the trunk curved into shadow. She could feel the texture, ridges and grooves, the scar tissue of old wounds. The tree had been standing here since before independence.

She sat at the base. She drank water. She ate groundnuts she had bought at the last village, from a woman who was sitting under a smaller tree, selling them in small plastic bags, who had looked at Liwei with curiosity but not hostility and who had, when Liwei held out the coins, taken them with one hand and pressed the bag of groundnuts into Liwei's other hand with a firmness that was not commercial but personal.

The groundnuts were roasted, salted, warm from the afternoon. She ate them one by one. The field stretched around her, millet, short, pale green. The soil between the rows was dry and cracked. She could see a compound in the distance, a cluster of buildings behind a low wall, a corrugated roof catching the sun. Someone's home. Someone's life. Inside the corridor.

A boy appeared at the edge of the millet. Tall, quiet, watching her from across the field. He stood at the boundary between the cultivated rows and the fallow ground, and he watched her the way the woman at the well had watched her, not with fear or anger but with the attention of someone who had never seen a stranger come here without a reason.

She raised her hand. He did not wave back. He did not leave. He stood and watched.

Her phone rang. The screen said ZHOU, D. She answered.

"Ms. Chen. The alignment walk, status."

"Seventeen corrections to the survey data so far. Two drainage flags at the coastal plain transition. There's an aquifer concern at kilometer five, the well at the fifth community draws from the sub-grade lens. The drainage assessment will need to cross-reference with."

"The corridor is passable?"

"Mostly. There's a grove at kilometer twelve that."

"The grove is in the routing log. The alignment diverts around it."

She looked at the tree. "There's a second tree. Kilometer fourteen. A baobab. On the center line."

A pause. Brief. Not thinking, calculating.

"That's on the earthworks schedule, Ms. Chen."

"I'm standing next to it."

"And?"

She touched the bark again. The ridges. The old scar tissue. "It's significant. One-meter trunk diameter. The root system extends well past the." "A tree is a removal item." His voice was patient. The patience of a man explaining something

that did not require explanation. “Cost: negligible. Half a day.”

She said nothing.

“Is there an engineering concern? Load, drainage, sub-grade?” “No.” “Then finish the walk. Report when you’re back in the city.”

He hung up.

Liwei sat for a moment in the shade. The boy had not moved. The corrugated roof flashed in the distance. The survey flags ran south, orange on wire stakes, every fifty meters, patient and indifferent.

She opened her notebook. She turned past the survey corrections, past the drainage flags, past the aquifer note, to a clean page.

She wrote: KM 14. BAOBAB. APPROX. 60-70 YRS. CENTER LINE CONFLICT. NOT CLASSIFIED AS SIGNIFICANT IN EARTHWORKS SCHEDULE.

She looked at what she had written. Then she wrote: COMMUNITY USE, TO BE DETERMINED.

She closed the notebook.

She packed up. She brushed the groundnut shells from her trousers. She took out her drawings and looked at the center line. It passed directly through the trunk’s position. She looked at the drawing. She looked at the tree. She put the drawings away. She walked back toward the survey flags.

The boy was still watching. Behind him, past the compound, the corrugated roof flashed in the sun. Past the roof, the sky, flat, clear, the blue of a country that was running out of rain.

She walked on past the baobab. The survey flags continued north. In her notebook she had written seventeen corrections to the survey data, two drainage concerns, one aquifer note, one grove notation, and two lines, not technical, not categorized, not fitting any section of the environmental impact report, about the tree. She reached the car at four. Mamadou was waiting at kilometer sixteen, leaning against the hood, eating mangoes from a bag. “How was the walk?”

“The ground disagrees with the drawings.”

“The ground usually does.”

She got in. They drove back to Port Sélani in silence. The road was laterite for the first hundred kilometers. The car rattled. The dust rose. The survey flags disappeared behind them, one by one, swallowed by distance and the red dust of a country that stuck to everything and did not let go.

Chapter 15

Fatou arrived at Aminata Kourouma's campaign office at nine in the morning and waited forty minutes on a plastic chair in the hallway while the sounds of organized chaos leaked through the wall. She used the forty minutes. She always used waiting time. It was a resource, not a waste, and a journalist who couldn't work while sitting on a plastic chair in a hallway hadn't been trained properly. She reviewed her notes from the leaked text. She drafted three questions that she knew Aminata would deflect and two that she might answer. She listened to the sounds through the wall, rapid Dioula, a phone ringing, someone saying "the corridor numbers, the corridor numbers", and she assembled, from the fragments, a picture of a campaign that was running hot and knew it. Aminata opened her office door personally. This was a signal. A campaign leader who opened her own door was either understaffed or making a point about accessibility. In Aminata's case, Fatou suspected both.

"Ms. Mensah. Come in."

The office was small. Clean. A framed constitution on the wall, a map bristling with pins, a window that looked onto a street where a woman was frying beignets. The desk had the organized density of a mind that processed a great deal and stored it in categories. No clutter. Nothing decorative. A cold cup of coffee that had clearly been there since yesterday.

Aminata sat behind the desk. Fatou sat in the chair across from it and placed her recorder between them. The recorder was a ritual. It marked the transition from person to subject, conversation to interview. Both women understood the shift.

"Tell me about the provisions," Fatou said. "Not the talking points. Your actual legal analysis."

Aminata looked at her. Assessing. The look of a woman who had been interviewed by a hundred journalists and could sort them in three seconds, those who wanted a quote, those who wanted a story, those who wanted the truth, and the rare ones who understood that what you printed was only half the story, and which half mattered. "The SEZ provisions create a parallel legal jurisdiction inside Kessaran territory," Aminata said. "Not adjacent. Not complementary. Parallel. Two legal systems

operating on the same ground. That has been tried before. The French did it during the colonial period. The mandate system. It did not end well.” “The government says the provisions are standard for international investment zones.”

“The government is correct. They are standard. That is the problem. The standard is designed to protect the investor, not the host country. The standard was written in boardrooms in Shanghai and London and New York by lawyers whose clients are corporations, not citizens.”

Fatou wrote. Not everything. She had the recorder for that. She wrote the sentences that carried weight, the ones she would build paragraphs around. She wrote the standard was written in boardrooms and underlined it.

“The technology transfer clause,” Fatou said. “Article 19, Section 4. ‘Shall establish, fund, and administer.’ Binding. With a deadline.” Something moved in Aminata’s face. A micro-expression, surprise, quickly controlled. The surprise of a woman who had found the clause herself and had assumed she was one of the only people who had read the full ninety-three pages carefully enough to locate it.

“You read the full text.”

“All of it.”

“The technology transfer clause is better than any previous arrangement this country has seen,” Aminata said. “That is not the same as good enough.”

She said it cleanly. Fatou noted the precision. Aminata was acknowledging the clause without endorsing it, criticizing the deal without denying this one provision. Legal training. Oxford training. The ability to hold two truths in the same sentence without dropping either one.

The interview ran twenty minutes. When Fatou left, she had seven usable quotes, one headline, and a question she had not asked: Who is paying for your campaign, and what do they want? She would ask it later. She didn’t have enough yet.

She drove to the Bassam Corridor that afternoon.

Moussa drove. The borrowed Peugeot. Four hours on the highway, then two on laterite. The transition from paved road to red dirt was a physical event. The car shuddered as the tires left asphalt and bit into the loose surface, and the dust began immediately, rising behind them in a plume that she could see in the side mirror, a red-brown cloud that marked their passage through the landscape the way a boat’s wake marks its passage through water.

The highway out of Port Sélani was lined with evidence of the deal’s promise and the country’s need. Construction sites, the new ministry buildings, the telecommunications tower, the Chinese-built projects that were either half-finished or

recently completed, their concrete still clean, their paint still bright, standing in the landscape like guests who had arrived overdressed. Between them, the existing infrastructure, the cracked roads, the leaning power poles, the school buildings with their chipped paint and their bars on the windows.

The corridor began where the highway ended. There was no sign. No boundary marker. Just a change. The paved road stopped and the laterite began and the landscape opened from the compressed urban-suburban sprawl of the highway corridor into something wider, quieter, older. Millet fields. Fallow ground. The occasional compound, a cluster of mud-brick buildings behind a low wall, a corrugated roof, a tree. "Stop here," Fatou said.

They stopped at the first village inside the corridor. The village was called Kounda, population two thousand. She learned this from the chief, who received her at the entrance to his compound with the formality and patience of a man who had been receiving visitors his entire life and had learned that the quality of a visitor was measured not by their credentials but by their capacity to listen. She listened for four hours.

The chief spoke first. White boubou, the long flowing robe worn by men of standing, and a voice that did not need volume to carry authority. He told her what the corridor was: not an economic zone or a project footprint or a line on a map, but a place where people lived. Fourteen villages. Seven thousand farming households. Markets that had operated on the same days of the week for longer than anyone could remember.

Schools, clinics, mosques, churches, wells. An economy that ran on groundnuts and millet and the credit that women extended to each other through savings circles that were older than the banking system and more reliable.

"We are not against progress," he said. "We would like a road. We would like a clinic with medicine. We would like a school with books written after 1994. But nobody is offering us those things. They are offering a railway that goes past us and a resettlement zone we did not choose."

She wrote it down.

She spoke to women at the well. Three of them, filling jerrycans in the morning heat. They spoke in Dioula and Moussa translated. The conversation was not about sovereignty or the CFA franc or the special economic zone. It was about water. The well was deep, forty meters. The water was clean. The resettlement zone, one woman said, had no well. "They say they will drill one. They have been saying this for two years."

“Has anyone from the government come to ask what you need?” Fatou asked. The women looked at each other. The look was its own answer, the shared recognition of a question so far from their experience that it required consultation before it could be processed.

“The government sends people to tell us things,” one woman said. “Not to ask.”

She spoke to a school teacher. Young, twenty-four, maybe. She taught four grades in one room. Forty-seven students. She had not been paid since January. The chalkboard was cracked. The textbooks were from 2006. She taught mathematics using a method she had invented herself because the curriculum assumed resources she did not have, calculators, workbooks, a second teacher for the upper grades.

“If the deal brings a new school,” Fatou asked, “would that change how you feel about it?”

The teacher looked at her with the patience of a woman who had answered this question before. “A new school is a building. A building without teachers is a warehouse. I have been teaching forty-seven children alone for three years. No one has asked whether I need help.

They ask whether I need a building.”

Fatou wrote it down. All of it. The names, the ages, the details that mattered, the 2006 textbooks, the forty-seven students, the unpaid salary since January. These were not statistics. They were the faces the statistics were made from, and her job was to carry the faces from this village to a screen in London where someone at a desk would read them and feel, for thirty seconds, what the deal meant at ground level.

She walked through the village. Past the compounds, past the school, past the market square where Wednesday’s trading had left its evidence, a scattering of groundnut shells, the marks of stall posts in the packed earth, the smell of dried fish and cooking oil still in the air from the morning. At the edge of the village, the corridor’s future was visible. Orange survey flags on wire stakes, running in a straight line through the fields toward the escarpment. Bright, artificial, temporary-looking but permanent in intent. Each one a small claim planted in the ground. In the distance, past the last row of millet, she could see a single tree standing alone in a field, and beneath it, a figure. Too far to make out clearly, but the shape was wrong for this landscape: someone sitting under the tree with what looked like a notebook, someone whose posture did not belong to the farming communities she had been listening to all afternoon. She noted it and moved on. The flags were the story. The figure was someone else’s.

Beyond the flags, the fields. Millet, short and pale. A baobab tree in the distance, she could see its shape against the sky, wide and singular. She raised her phone and framed it: the trunk dark against pale sky, the canopy spreading, the survey flags in the foreground like a picket line. She took the shot. She did not know whose tree it was. She did not know that the man who tended it had sat beneath it two days ago and traced a rail line through his wife's grave. A woman who sold groundnuts at the junction market said, without prompting, "You should talk to Ousmane Traoré. His baobab is on the center line."

For now, the tree was a photograph on her phone.

She got back in the car. They drove on. More villages. More stories. The same words repeated with different faces: we are not against progress, but nobody asked us what we need.

On the drive back, the sun set. The laterite turned from red to purple. The dust behind the car was gold in the low light. Moussa drove in silence for a while. Then: "You're building something."

"What?"

"A story. You're collecting pieces. I can see it, the way you write certain things down and not others. You're building a structure." She looked at him. In the mirror, his eyes were on the road. He was not performing observation. He was simply observant, the quality that made him invaluable as a fixer and that she had recognized the moment he had watched her stare at the Ministry of Mines and said nothing.

"What kind of structure do you think it is?" she asked. "I think you came here to write about a referendum. I think you are writing about something older."

She did not answer. The car rattled over the laterite. The dust settled behind them. The survey flags were gone, swallowed by distance and the falling dark.

He was right. She was writing about something older. She didn't yet know how old, or how close it was to her own name. She didn't yet know how the building she had photographed in the Plateau district, padlocked, cracked, weeds in the gutter, was connected to the flags in the field and the faces in the village and the country she had left at twelve and was now, at thirty-four, beginning to understand.

But the structure was building. Piece by piece. Face by face. The corridor was not an abstraction anymore. It was a chief in a white boubou. A teacher with forty-seven students.

Women at a well with no replacement. A baobab tree on a center line. A story older than the deal and older than the referendum and older than the argument about who got the minerals.

The story was about who got to stay.

Chapter 16

The African Union observers arrived on the morning flight from Addis Ababa, and Diallo met them at the airport because the meeting was a performance and performances require a stage. He had been preparing since six. Not the briefing. The briefing was prepared by the electoral commission staff and was, in its factual content, impeccable. He had been preparing himself. The shave. The suit, dark blue, the one the French ambassador had complimented at the last state dinner, a suit that projected competence without projecting wealth, which was a calculation as precise as anything Asante ran on a spreadsheet. The coffee, instant, standing at the kitchen window, looking at the cranes and running the morning's arithmetic: what does this meeting cost me, what does it buy me, what is the exchange rate between democratic credibility and the sixty minutes I will spend performing it. He drove to the airport himself. Captain Ndoeye in the second car. The airport road was smooth. The Chinese had paved it two years ago as a goodwill project, and the irony of driving to meet African Union election observers on a Chinese-built road to discuss a Chinese-funded deal was not lost on him. Irony was never lost on Diallo. He noticed it, noted it, and moved on.

Five observers. He assessed them before they cleared the arrivals gate.

Dr. Adama Ndiaye, leading the delegation. Senegalese. Sixty-one. Constitutional lawyer. He knew her reputation, fourteen countries, no scandals, the credibility of a woman who had monitored elections in places where monitoring required not just observation but courage.

She carried, in the weariness of her handshake, the accumulated evidence of every democratic exercise she had witnessed that was not entirely democratic and not entirely an exercise.

Behind her: a Ghanaian political scientist whose work Diallo had read (sharp, fair, inconveniently thorough); a Kenyan former judge who had overseen election dispute tribunals; and two younger staff members, a man and a woman, both carrying tablets, both wearing the neutral expressions of people trained to record everything and react to nothing.

Diallo shook each hand. He read each grip. Ndiaye's was firm and brief, the handshake of a woman who had shaken ten thousand hands and had learned that the information traveled in the first second and everything after was courtesy. The Ghanaian's was warmer, academic, collegial, the grip of a man who believed that elections were problems to be studied rather than ceremonies to be staged. The Kenyan judge held his hand a moment too long, already weighing, already comparing this arrival to the seventeen other arrivals he had experienced in seventeen other countries where the president came to the airport because showing up was the message. "Mr. President. Thank you for receiving us."

"You are welcome in Kessara, Dr. Ndiaye. Always." He held the car door for her himself. An old habit. His mother had taught him: when an elder visits, you do not send someone to open the door. "The constitution brings you here. But you are welcome beyond the constitution."

Ndiaye looked at him. A flicker, not warmth exactly, but recognition. The recognition of a woman from the same region, the same generation, who understood that courtesy and strategy could occupy the same sentence without either one being false. He drove with them to the electoral commission headquarters. The route had been chosen by his chief of staff, through the Plateau, past the new government buildings, along the Corniche where the ocean was visible and the cranes were visible and the construction suggested a country that was building things.

The route did not pass through the Médina, where the power had been off for six hours and the streets were dark. It did not pass the displacement camp on the northern edge, where forty-three thousand people lived in structures that would not survive the next rain. And it did not, could not, pass through the Bassam Corridor, two hundred kilometers to the east, where the route would have shown them something no briefing could contain: the farms, the compounds, the graves marked with flat laterite stones, the baobab trees that stood in the fields like witnesses at a trial where nobody had been called to testify.

Diallo knew what was in the corridor. The resettlement reports were on his desk. He had read them, the numbers, the village names, the compensation calculations, the clinical phrase "respectful relocation of human remains" that appeared in Section 12 and that he had not been able to read without hearing Mariama's voice: fix this. He knew there were families who had buried their dead in fields the railway would bisect. He knew there was a grove. His intelligence folder had mentioned it, an aside, a footnote, that religious communities considered sacred. He knew these things the way a general knows the terrain behind the map: as facts that did not change the strategy

but that sat beneath it, bearing weight. Dr. Ndiaye looked out the window. She had done this before, the guided tour, the curated route, the city presented from its best angle. She knew the angle was chosen. She would find the other angles herself, over the next three days, because that was her job, and her job required her to see what the president did not show her. Diallo watched her watch the city. She was reading the route the way he had read the handshakes, noting what was absent. Every country has two tours, the one it gives visitors and the one its people live in. The distance is measured in generators and hospital beds and the number of hours the power stays on.

At the commission headquarters, the briefing room was cold. Air conditioning set low.

Uncomfortable people were attentive people. Printed folders at each seat. Water glasses, filled. The choreography of democratic procedure.

Diallo presented the briefing. Voter registration: 97.4 percent. Polling stations: 3,200. Ballot security: paper, sequential numbering, tamper-evident seals. International standard.

Everything by the book.

He presented it well. He had always presented well, the economist's clarity, the professor's patience, the instinct for the answer that was true and the answer that was complete and the tension between them. The most dangerous lies are made entirely of facts.

He watched the observers as he spoke. The Ghanaian was taking notes, not transcribing but annotating, writing in the margins, cross-referencing. Building his own model from Diallo's numbers. Diallo recognized the methodology. He had read the man's paper on electoral legitimacy in post-conflict states. Rigorous. Skeptical. The work of a mind that stress-tested everything it was given. Across the table, they were performing the same operation on each other: two men trained to interrogate what they were given, each checking whether the other's figures held.

The Kenyan judge was not writing. He was watching Diallo's hands. The micro-gestures.

Diallo adjusted, hands flat on the table, open, the posture of a man with nothing behind his back. The judge noted the adjustment. The adjustment was itself a data point.

Dr. Ndiaye asked her question: "The displacement camps. Will displaced persons have access to polling?"

His chief of staff shifted. Diallo noted the shift, a subordinate's body giving testimony his face was trained to withhold. "We have arranged temporary registration

at all displacement sites. Additional staff have been deployed.”

“And the Bassam Corridor communities, the ones under resettlement orders. Where will they vote?”

“Where they are now. Nobody has moved yet.”

“Yet.” The word stayed in the room after she moved on. She wrote something in her notebook. The judge looked at Diallo. Diallo looked at the judge. “Yet” was not a question. It was a measurement, the life span of a promise, spoken as grammar.

Diallo’s answer was accurate. The prediction was about a future his answer had not addressed. The farmers, the families, the dead beneath their stones, the briefing did not reach them. The observers could not reach them from this cold room in the capital. The deal would reach them. That was the problem.

After the briefing, Diallo returned to the residence. His phone showed two texts. Asante: Bond payment confirmation deadline moved forward. 52 days now.

Ibrahima, from Paris: I’m writing something, Papa. You won’t like it but I hope you’ll read it.

He put the phone down. He stood at the window. The cranes. The ocean. From this angle, a country building its future. From another angle, the camps, the dark neighborhoods, the hospital with two doctors, the corridor where a farmer was standing in a field today being asked to leave his wife’s grave, a country mortgaging it. The observers were checking whether the vote was free. Nobody was checking whether the question was fair.

He opened his laptop. He began drafting remarks for tomorrow. The remarks contained nothing that was untrue. Nothing that was complete. This was governance, the management of that tension. He had been managing it for four years. The space was getting wider. The management was getting harder. And somewhere in the corridor, two hundred kilometers from this desk, a man whose name Diallo did not know was holding a piece of paper with a railway line drawn through his family’s history, and the signature that had put the line there was Diallo’s, and the line would not move because the engineering did not accommodate grief.

Chapter 17

The No campaign's man arrived at Ousmane's farm at two in the afternoon in a car that did not belong on a laterite road. Ousmane and Sékou were in the eastern field. They had been there since dawn, weeding the fifth and sixth rows, side by side, one row apart, the rhythm between them as familiar as breathing. Bend, pull, shake the soil from the roots, set the weed in the pile, move forward.

The sun was directly overhead and the shadows had disappeared and the sweat ran down Ousmane's back in a line that followed his spine the way rainwater follows a groove in the earth. He heard the engine before he saw it. Wrong sound for this road. Too high, too smooth, the voice of a machine that lived on pavement and was suffering on dirt. He straightened.

He shielded his eyes. A sedan, dark blue, pitching over the ruts like a boat in short waves.

The suspension hit bottom twice. The back end swung wide on the third rut and threw a wing of red dust across the millet. Sékou looked up from his row. They watched the car together. You could learn everything about a visitor from how they arrived. A government car came steady. The driver knew the road, the weight of the state behind the tires. A neighbor came on foot, at the pace of the path, because the path set the pace. A merchant came in a truck, fast, because merchants rented time.

This car came the way a goat walks on wet rock, uncertain, overcorrecting, every step a negotiation with a surface it did not trust.

"City," Sékou said.

"City," Ousmane agreed.

His name was Bakary. Young, twenty-eight, maybe less. He wore a shirt that had been ironed that morning and was now dark with sweat at the collar and the small of his back. His shoes were leather. The leather was already turning red. Everything turned red here. The soil took what it wanted from whatever touched it. Ousmane offered water. You offered water before anything else. Even to a man whose shoes were wrong.

They went to the baobab. Bakary looked up at the tree, following the trunk until the neck strained and the eyes lost themselves in the canopy. The tree did this to people. It made them small, and the smallness was honest, because the tree had been growing for sixty-three years and the people looking at it had not. “Mr. Traoré. I work with the DFA. The opposition party. We would like to tell your story.”

“Tell it to whom?”

“To the country. To the people in Port Sélani who have never been to the corridor. Your family, your land, this tree, people need to see what the deal will take.”

“You want to bring a camera.”

“A small crew. Two people. A journalist and...”

“A camera.”

Bakary stopped. The old man had said the same word twice. Not because he had forgotten the first time. Because he wanted to hear what the word sounded like when it came back to him.

“Yes. A camera.”

Ousmane drank his water. He looked at Bakary’s hands. Clean. Trimmed nails. No calluses, no scars, no soil in the creases. There was nothing wrong with them. They had simply never held a hoe or pulled a weed or dug a grave. Same country by name. Different country by labor.

The government wanted his land. The opposition wanted his face. Both of them needed something from him. Neither of them had asked what he needed from them.

“Come,” Ousmane said. “Let me show you.”

He walked into the field. Past the tree, past the offering place at the roots where the morning’s millet grain was still visible in the dirt. Bakary followed. His shoes caught in the stubble. The polished leather gathered the red dust of six generations with every step. They reached the stone. Flat. Red-brown. The color of the escarpment it came from.

“My wife,” Ousmane said.

The wind moved through the millet. The stalks whispered in the rows around them. Bakary looked at the stone and did not speak. “She was sick for six months. The clinic had nothing for her. The hospital had no room. She died in the compound, on a bed she made with her own hands, and I put her here. In the field where she worked every day of her life.” He pointed east, toward the escarpment. “I cut this stone with a hammer. I carried it on my back. Two kilometers.”

He looked at Bakary.

“The railway goes through this stone. Not beside it. Through it.” “Mr. Traoré, I...”

“You want to bring a camera here. You want to show people this stone and this tree and this old man, and the people who watch will feel something for three minutes and then they will eat their dinner. My wife will still be under this stone. The railway will still be on the map. And you will have your picture.”

He was not raising his voice. He never raised his voice. His father had never raised his voice.

Volume was for men who did not trust what they were saying. Ousmane trusted what he said.

“I am not a photograph. My wife is not a photograph. This tree is not something you hang on a wall.”

Bakary stood in the field. The wind pulled at his shirt. Dust gathered at his ankles. He had the face of a man who had come to do a job and had just learned that the job required something from him that the job description did not mention.

“I understand,” he said.

“You are a good young man. But you do not understand this. You cannot. You have not buried anyone in a field.” He said it without cruelty. The way you tell a young tree that the rain is late. “You cannot photograph what it feels like to bury your wife. No camera catches the weight of the stone on your back, or the years you spent together before the stone was needed. A photograph is a moment. This is a life.”

They walked back. Ousmane offered more water. They drank in silence, the silence of two men who had reached the end of what words could do and were waiting for the silence to finish what the words had started.

“In the next village,” Ousmane said, as Bakary stood, “there is a teacher. The chief’s son. He will talk to your camera. He has words for it. I do not.”

“Thank you, Mr. Traoré.”

The car lurched away over the ruts. The dust hung in the air for a long time after the sound was gone, settling slowly into the still afternoon.

Evening came to the compound in layers. The light changed first, the white of the afternoon softening to gold and then to the color of old honey. The shadows returned, stretching from the compound wall across the yard in long dark lines. The heat loosened its grip. The air moved. Sékou cooked. Rice and groundnut sauce. He worked at the fire behind the kitchen house, three stones, a pot, the charcoal that Ousmane made himself each dry season from the pruned branches of the neem. The smell of groundnut paste heating in palm oil came across the compound and settled into Ousmane’s chest, not as hunger exactly, but as the smell of the day ending, the work finished, the fire lit, a meal coming, and someone to eat it with.

They ate in the compound by the kerosene lamp. The flame was small and yellow and it threw shadows that moved when the breeze came through the doorway. The compound walls, mud brick, his grandfather's bricks, repaired each dry season with the same soil they were made from, caught the light and held it the way clay holds heat: gently, slowly, giving it back through the night. The radio was on. Low. Voices still arguing about the leaked provisions. A woman caller, her voice sharp, frightened, the voice of someone who had read the document and understood what it said about her land. A man caller, calmer, defending the deal, saying the word "jobs" the way a man says the word "rain" in a drought: with hope that has not yet given up but is beginning to.

Ousmane listened with one ear. The other ear belonged to the compound. The sounds of home: Sékou washing the pot, the scrape of the wooden spoon against the bottom where the porridge had stuck. The fire settling. A gecko on the wall, its tongue snapping at a moth near the lamp. The iron roof cooling, tick, tick, the metal giving back the day's heat in small metallic confessions. The dog, old and half-blind, sleeping by the compound door, sighed in his sleep, the sigh of an animal dreaming about something only animals know.

Twenty-two million CFA francs. That was the number they had put on the compound. On this fire. On the spoon on the pot. On the roof and the walls and the grave in the field.

Ousmane had never held twenty-two million CFA francs. He knew what this fire looked like.

The man who set that number had never eaten at this fire. He had not planted this soil. He did not know what he was pricing. At nine-forty, the phone rang.

The sound broke the compound the way a stone breaks a still pool, a sharp digital chirp that did not belong in this room, in this light, among these walls. Ibrahim had sent the phone six months ago, wrapped in newspaper, with a note in his handwriting. The handwriting was smaller than Ousmane remembered. Tighter. The writing of a man who had learned to fit himself into small spaces. He picked up the phone.

"Papa."

Ibrahim's voice. Changed. Thinner than the last call, the sound of a voice that had been rationed, used carefully, spent only when necessary. Behind it, sounds Ousmane could not place, wind, or engines, or the hiss of a connection carried across distances that wires could not reach.

"Ibrahim. Where are you?"

"Near the border. Northeast."

“Are you safe?”

A pause. Too long for yes. Too short for a lie.

“Safe enough, Papa.”

“Five days. No call. No money at the kiosk.”

“They took the phone. The company takes the phones when...” Static swallowed his voice.

Three seconds of nothing. Then he was back, pushed through the gap: “Papa. I need to come home.”

“Then come home.”

The simplest sentence in any language. A father saying: the door is open. The compound is here. The bed is here. Come.

“It is not that simple. They do not let people leave.”

The words came through the phone and into the compound and into Ousmane’s body the way cold water enters the ground in the first rain after a drought, all at once, everywhere.

They do not let people leave.

His son was not in a mine. His son was not doing contract work across the border. His son had been taken. Not by soldiers, by wages. By a bus ticket and a promise and a gate that only opened one way. Men came to the drought villages with work offers and clean hands, and the sons went because the farms could not feed them. And the wages became the fence. And the fence became the only country the sons had.

Ibrahim had gone for the money. Ousmane had let him go. Ousmane’s left hand began to shake, not the one holding the phone but the other, hanging at his side. The tremor started in his fingers, the same fingers that had held Aïssatou’s hand through six months of dying without shaking once. The same fingers that had cut the stone and carried it and placed it in the earth. They had never betrayed him. They were shaking now, and the shaking moved up his wrist, and he watched it, knowing what it meant, unable to stop it.

“Ibrahim. What do you need from me?”

“Do not call the mobile. They watch it. If they see calls from Kessara, they will know.”

“Know what?”

“That I am leaving.”

“How?”

“I have a way. It is not safe. But staying is not safe either.” Static again. The satellite passing overhead. Somewhere above the compound and the baobab and the

laterite stone, a machine was carrying his son's voice across the sky, and the sky was taking it away.

"Papa. If I do not call again, tell Awa I am sorry."

"Sorry for what, Ibrahim?"

Quiet. Not static, a different kind of quiet. The quiet of a man standing at the edge of what he can say.

"For what I have been doing. For what I have become."

"You are my son. You have not become anything else."

"Papa..."

The line cut. Not a fade. A severing. One breath his son was there. The next breath, the phone held only the sound of its own silence.

Sékou was in the doorway. He had heard his father say Ibrahim's name. He had heard the sound a man's voice makes when it is carrying more than a voice should carry.

"Papa?"

"Go to bed."

"Is he..."

"Go to bed, Sékou."

Sékou went. He left the kitchen house door open.

Ousmane was alone. The kerosene lamp was out. The fire was ash. The compound was dark except for the stars, which were the same stars his grandfather had used to navigate and his father had used to plant and he had used to teach his children on nights when the sky was close enough to touch.

His son was a soldier for people he had never met, doing work he would not name, in a place he could not leave. His son wanted to come home. His son might not make it.

Each one heavy. Each one his to carry. He could not put them down. He could not hand them to Sékou or Awa or the tree or the stone. They were his the way the field was his, not because he had chosen them but because they were on his ground and his ground did not let go.

The stars turned. The roof ticked. The dog sighed. And Ousmane held a silent phone against his chest and waited for a morning that would come whether he was ready or not.

Chapter 18

Fifteen thousand people filled the Place de la République and Aminata Kourouma stood at the edge of the stage and waited for them to finish becoming a crowd.

This was a thing she had learned, not at Oxford, not at The Hague, but here, in Kessara, in rooms and squares and market grounds where people gathered and needed to be spoken to. A crowd is not fifteen thousand individuals. A crowd is a single organism that assembles itself from its parts over the course of minutes, like water finding its level. You could not speak to it until it had finished assembling. If you started too early, you were speaking to a collection of people. If you waited, if you stood at the edge of the stage with your hands at your sides and your face still and your body saying I am not in a hurry, and neither are you, the collection became a body, and the body had one pair of ears, and those ears were ready.

She waited. The evening was warm. The Place de la République was the largest open square in Port Sélani, a colonial parade ground, originally, built by the French for military reviews, the kind of space that colonialism left behind everywhere: large, flat, designed for the display of power. Independence had renamed it. Renaming it had not changed the dimensions. The square was still built for the display of power. Tonight the power on display was hers. The stage was a flatbed truck with a plywood platform. Two speakers on stands. A microphone that Ibrahima Sow, the logistics organizer, had tested three times that afternoon because the last rally's microphone had died mid-sentence and the image of Aminata Kourouma standing on a stage moving her mouth without sound had appeared on four opposition websites before Oumar could take it down.

The speakers were playing music. Mbalax. The sabar drums cutting through the evening heat, the electric guitar weaving above them. The sound was enormous, not loud exactly, but large, filling the square the way the crowd filled the square, occupying every corner.

People moved to it. Bodies in the crowd shifted and swayed, the rhythm entering them through the ground, through the soles of their shoes, through the physics of bass frequencies that the body receives before the ears do.

She could see individuals. This was the discipline, to see individuals inside the organism, to remember that the crowd was made of people who had come here on buses and on foot and in shared taxis, each one carrying a reason. A woman in the front row holding a child against her hip, the child asleep despite the noise, the talent of children for sleeping through history. A young man in a red cap filming with his phone held above his head, the screen showing the stage from the crowd's perspective, the image already traveling to accounts she would never see. An old man near the back, standing still while the crowd moved around him, watching with the attention of someone who had been to every rally since independence and was comparing this one to all the others. Khadija stood at the side of the stage. Arms crossed. Watching the crowd the way a lawyer watches a witness during cross-examination, looking for the hesitation, the overreach, the moment when what was claimed exceeded what could be proved. They made eye contact. One second. Khadija's face was neutral. Her neutrality was its own communication. It meant: the crowd is solid, the logistics are holding, the three things I know that you know that nobody else knows are still between us. The Foundation money.

The Delaware shell. Page 78.

Aminata stepped to the microphone.

"I am not going to tell you what to think."

Fifteen thousand people. The murmur dropping to silence the way a wave drops to glass when the wind stops.

"You have read the deal. Many of you have read it in Dioula, translated by students who worked through the night because they believed you had the right to understand the document your government wants you to sign. You have read the provisions. You know what is inside them."

She paused. The pause was not performance. The pause was Aminata listening to the crowd, reading its temperature, its attention, the quality of its silence. A hostile crowd is loud. A bored crowd is restless. An engaged crowd is still. This crowd was still. "I want to talk about money. Not the deal's money, twelve billion dollars, a number so large it stops meaning anything. I want to talk about the money in your pocket."

She held up a coin. A hundred-franc piece. CFA.

"This coin. You earned it. You worked for it. You carried it home. It is yours." She turned it in her fingers. The stage light caught the metal. "But this coin is not controlled by you. It is not controlled by the president. It is not controlled by the central bank of Kessara. This coin is controlled by the Banque de France. By the

French Treasury. By a room in Paris where men who have never been to this square decide what your money is worth.”

The crowd was listening. Not the polite listening of a lecture. The leaning listening of people hearing something they already knew described in words they had not yet heard.

“The CFA franc is tied to the euro. Fixed. That means when Europe’s economy changes, your money changes with it, but you did not make the change and you cannot undo it. When the euro is strong, your exports are expensive and nobody buys your groundnuts.

When the euro is weak, your imports are cheap, but the euro is never weak enough to help you and always strong enough to hurt you. This is not an accident. This is a system. The system was built in 1945, by France, in Paris, the year the war ended, and it has not been rebuilt since, because the people who built it are the same people who benefit from it, and they are not in this square tonight.” She lowered the coin.

“Now. The Chinese are offering a different system. They are offering twelve billion dollars.

Roads. A railway. A port. Processing facilities. Jobs.” She paused. “And in exchange, they want the land beneath your feet for ninety-nine years. They want Chinese courts inside your borders. They want to decide who works and who doesn’t, who is paid and who isn’t, who has rights and who has ‘provisions.’”

A murmur in the crowd. The word “provisions” landed. It was the word of the week, the word the radio hosts used, the word the Dioula translations used, the word that had traveled from a leaked document through a photocopier through a market stall into every kitchen and compound and taxi in the country.

“So the question is not: do we want roads? Of course we want roads. The question is not: do we want jobs? Of course we want jobs. The question is: who is offering them, and what do they want in return, and will our children thank us or curse us for the answer we give on Saturday?”

She looked at the crowd. The woman with the sleeping child. The old man at the back. The young man with the phone.

“Five countries are fighting over this land. The French held it for a hundred years. The Americans want the minerals. The Russians want the instability. The Chinese want the corridor. And we, we get to vote. That is the consolation prize. Five countries fighting over one country, and the one country gets a ballot.” She spoke for twenty-two minutes. She did not use notes. The speech was in her body, built over weeks of rallies and radio appearances and conversations in campaign offices and

villages and market stalls, refined each time, the arguments growing more precise with every challenge, every heckler, every question she had not anticipated and had then anticipated and had built the answer into the next version.

Henderson's voice ran beneath every sentence like a bass line. A contract is a distribution of risk. Every clause transfers risk from one party to another. She heard his Oxford voice while she spoke in her Kessaran voice, and the translation between them, the conversion of risk distribution theory into the language of a woman holding up a hundred-franc coin in a public square, was the skill that made her dangerous. She could hold the economics in one hand and the human cost in the other and show the crowd and the argument without dropping either one.

She reached the point in the speech where page 78 would fit. The technology transfer clause. Article 19, Section 4. "Shall establish, fund, and administer."

The binding commitment with a deadline. The one provision in the deal that was better than anything the French or the Americans or the British had ever offered. She could say it here. She could say: "Even their own deal contains a training clause that none of our former colonial partners ever provided, and ask yourself why we should trust a better promise from a new partner when we could not enforce a worse promise from the old ones." It would be honest. It would be nuanced. It would cost her six points in the polls.

She skipped it. She moved to the resettlement provisions, the three-to-two valuation committee, the Article 12 provision that her own lawyers had flagged that morning. The crowd responded. The omission of page 78 passed through the speech the way a missing stair passes beneath a careful foot. Only the one who knows it's gone notices the skip.

Khadija knew. From the side of the stage, her face did not change. But her arms uncrossed.

A small adjustment. The body language of a woman who had just watched her friend step over a line and was noting where the line was for future reference.

After the rally, the car. A borrowed SUV. The mining company again, the company that asked only that its name not appear. Aminata sat in the back seat. The residual hum of fifteen thousand people was still in her ears, the phantom sound that follows a crowd when it has gone.

The streets were dark, power out in this district for the second hour, but not empty. People were walking home from the rally in clusters, their voices carrying through the warm air, still arguing, still processing what they had heard. The SUV's headlights caught faces in mid-sentence. A radio played her speech from a shop doorway, the

sound tinny and recognizable.

Aminata's hands were in her lap. Steady now. They had not been steady before the speech, the tremor in the left hand, the one she hid by gripping the edge of the stage, the one that Khadija had never mentioned because Khadija understood that some things a leader carries alone and the carrying is part of the job. She had spoken to fifteen thousand people. She had told them what the deal contained and what it would cost and why they should vote No. She had meant every word. Every word had also been chosen for its effect on the polls. She had meant what she said. She had also known what she was leaving out. The technology transfer clause, unmentioned, accurate, omitted. She thought about Moussa. Not the photograph. She did not need the photograph tonight.

She needed the absence. Moussa would have been at the rally. Not on the stage, on the ground. Setting up the speakers. Testing the microphone three times. Counting the water bottles backstage. Collating the leaflets. He was the logistics. She was the voice. She had become the voice because he could no longer be the logistics, and the reversal was not irony. It was evidence. Her entire public life had Moussa inside it. The campaign, the speeches, the fifteen thousand people in the square tonight. All of it grown from the fact of his disappearance. The fact was solid. The disappearance was a hole in the ground that never filled.

The car passed through the Médina. Dark streets. A generator running somewhere, the sound of private electricity, a single household's refusal to accept the dark. A dog barked.

Another answered. The city's night conversation, dogs and generators and the distant thump of music from a bar that had its own power.

"The speech was good," Khadija said from the front seat. "It was incomplete."

"Speeches are always incomplete. That is what makes them speeches and not depositions."

Aminata almost smiled. Almost.

"You skipped the clause."

"I skipped the clause."

"Are you going to tell me why?"

"Because I am running a campaign, Khadija. Not a seminar." "Henderson would be disappointed."

"Henderson is in Oxford. I am in Port Sélani. The separation of those two places is not measured in kilometers."

They drove in silence. The SUV's headlights found the road. The road led home, to an apartment where Hawa was sleeping, in a city that had just heard Aminata Kourouma speak for twenty-two minutes about sovereignty and money and the price of a hundred-franc coin. The city would vote on Saturday. The woman who had spoken to it was sitting in the back of a borrowed car in the dark, knowing that the best speech she had ever given was missing one paragraph. The missing paragraph was the truest thing she knew.

Chapter 19

Thierno Bâ prayed the maghrib, the sunset prayer, at the end of the day, and the sky turned the color of a wound closing.

Orange at the horizon. Purple above. The thin line of gold where the sun had been, narrowing, the light retreating from the city in degrees, leaving behind an air that was merely less hot. The muezzin's voice rose from the minaret. His voice. His minaret. His mosque. But the prayer did not belong to him. It had been spoken before he was born and would be spoken after he died. He was only the voice it was using tonight.

He prayed in the small room behind the mosque. Alone. The congregation had gone. The maghrib crowd was always smaller than the fajr or the jummah, the Friday congregation, the sunset prayer being the one most people performed at home, between the work of the day and the meal of the evening. But Thierno Bâ prayed it here, in the room where his father had prayed it and his grandfather before that, because he had prayed in this room for fifty years and the habit had become part of the prayer itself. He finished. He sat. The study held the quiet the way the clay jar held water, completely, without leaking.

Abdoulaye came at seven.

Thierno Bâ heard his son's car before he saw it, a newer car than most, bought with money earned in Saudi Arabia, the engine quieter than the vehicles that normally entered the mosque courtyard. Abdoulaye drove carefully. He dressed carefully. He spoke carefully.

Seven years in Medina had given him a precision that was different from his father's precision. Thierno Bâ's was earned through practice, worn smooth like a river stone.

Abdoulaye's was built through study, each position fitted to the next with the certainty of a man who had learned the plan before he had lived inside it.

He entered the study. He kissed his father's hand. He sat in the chair across the desk, the same chair where Diop had sat two days ago, where the sick woman had sat, where the businessman with the disputed land had sat. The chair received everyone the same way.

The chair did not rank its visitors.

Abdoulaye was thirty-eight. Tall. His beard was fuller than his father's, trimmed in the Saudi style. His robes were white but a different white. The cotton was finer, the cut slightly different, the collar higher. The details were small. They were not small. A man who had studied Islam in Medina for seven years and returned to West Africa wearing Medina's cotton was a man who had brought a different Islam home with him, and the cotton was the first thing people saw.

"The rally," Abdoulaye said. "Fifteen thousand."

"So I heard."

"She spoke about the CFA franc. About the French. About the corridor." He paused. "She spoke well."

"You were there?"

"Rachid told me. His cousin was in the crowd."

Thierno Bâ poured tea. Not attaya. The evening tea was simpler, a green tea steeped in a pot, served without ceremony. The attaya was for mornings, for visitors, for conversations that required the three rounds. The evening tea was for family. One round. Hot. Sweet. The taste of the day ending.

"She is a skilled woman," Thierno Bâ said. "She believes what she is saying. That is rare in politics."

"She is also funded by Americans whose interests are not Kessaran."

"How do you know this?"

"People talk, Father. The Foundation. The money. It is not a secret."

"Nothing is a secret in Kessara. That does not make everything true."

Abdoulaye drank his tea. The silence between them was the silence of a father and son who loved each other across a distance that neither of them had chosen. The distance was theological. It was also generational. Abdoulaye had gone to Medina at thirty-one and returned at thirty-eight with a certainty that his father, who had spent fifty-four years arriving at uncertainty, could not share. The certainty was not wrong. The texts Abdoulaye had studied were the same texts Thierno Bâ had studied. The Arabic was the same Arabic. The prayers were the same prayers. But the Islam Abdoulaye had brought home was cleaner, harder, more defined, an Islam of clear boundaries, of what was permitted and what was forbidden, of a world divided into the correct and the incorrect. Thierno Bâ's Islam was older, softer, more porous, an Islam that had arrived in West Africa a thousand years ago and had learned, over centuries, to live beside the things that were here before it. The Sufi way. The way of accommodation. The way that said: God is vast enough to contain what we do not

understand.

The two Islams lived in the same mosque. They prayed the same prayers. They disagreed about everything else, and the disagreement was conducted in the language of tea and silence and the careful management of a love that neither man would jeopardize by pushing the argument to its conclusion.

Through the window, the city carried the residue of the rally. The Place de la République had emptied an hour ago, but fifteen thousand people do not disperse quietly. They carry the energy home with them, through the streets, into the taxis and the buses and the market stalls where the vendors were still open and the arguments were still fresh.

Thierno Bâ could hear it, not the rally itself but its echo. And the echo was different from yesterday's city. He knew the sounds of

Port Sélani the way a mother knows the sounds of her household, not by listening for them but by living inside them, so that any change registered in the body before the mind gave it a name. The evening traffic was louder tonight. The car horns were more insistent, not the lazy communication of drivers navigating familiar routes but the sharp, impatient honking of people who were agitated and did not know where to put the agitation. Voices raised at a street corner two blocks south, the pitch of argument rather than conversation. A radio in a shop playing a clip of Aminata's speech, her voice tinny through the small speaker, the cadence unmistakable: the rhythm of a woman who had held fifteen thousand people in her hand.

The city was different tonight. He could feel it through the walls of his study the way he could feel a change in the season through the walls of the mosque, not the temperature but something heavier. The people were unsettled tonight. The leak had given them information. The rally had given them language for the information. And the combination of knowing and having words for what you know was a dangerous thing, because it meant the silence was over and what followed silence was never quiet.

The political noise of the city, entering the spiritual quiet of the study through glass and stone, uninvited, undeniable. His people, restless. His city, turning in its sleep.

Abdoulaye tilted his head toward the sound. "The rally has made the city loud tonight."

"It has. And tomorrow the city will be quiet again, and the people will still need water and medicine and a school for their children. The rally does not change that. The vote does not change that. Only the work changes that, and the work is slower than a speech."

“Abdoulaye. What do you know about the grove?”

His son looked up. The grove was a subject they had circled many times and entered rarely.

“The grove east of the corridor. The one Dramane tends.”

“I know which grove, Father.”

“Tell me what you know.”

“It is a pre-Islamic site. The practices conducted there are not sanctioned by the Quran or the hadith. The offerings are addressed to spirits whose existence has no basis in Islamic theology. The grove is not our concern.”

Thierno Bâ drank his tea.

“And yet,” he said, “the people who pray there are our people. They attend this mosque.

They follow this brotherhood. They ask me for guidance on the same day they ask Dramane for protection. They do not see a contradiction. Do you?”

“They are confused, Father. Confusion is not a contradiction. It is a condition that requires correction.”

“Correction.” Thierno Bâ set his glass on the desk. Beside the geological survey. The penciled circle. Inside the industrial zone perimeter. “And if the grove is destroyed, if the machines come and clear the trees and pour concrete over the ground where Dramane has been placing offerings since before you were born, will that be correction?”

Abdoulaye was quiet. This was not the question he had expected.

“The grove is inside the project zone,” Thierno Bâ said. “The deal your president is asking us to approve includes the destruction of a site where Kessarans have prayed, not in our way, but in their way, for longer than this mosque has stood. What does your Islam say about that?”

“My Islam says there is one God and the grove is not His house.” “And my Islam says there is one God and He lives everywhere, including in places we did not build for Him.”

The silence held. Outside, the city was loud. The post-rally energy still in the streets, the radio voices still debating, the sound of a country that had been argued into exhaustion and was not yet ready to sleep. Inside the study, the manuscripts on the shelves held their silence. The survey on the desk held its circle. And two men who served the same God from different rooms in the same house looked at each other across a desk that had held conversations like this for three generations and would hold them for three more. “I am not asking you to agree with me,” Thierno Bâ said. “I

am asking you to see what is being destroyed. Not because it is Islam. Because it is old. Because it is ours. Because a country that allows the oldest things to be paved over has lost something that is harder to rebuild than a road.”

He touched the survey. The penciled circle. The grove.

“A country that remembers only what is profitable will eventually forget what is sacred. And a country that forgets what is sacred has nothing left to sell, because it has already sold the thing that made it worth buying.”

Abdoulaye left at nine. He kissed his father’s hand again at the door. The gesture was the same, the bowing, the pressing of the lips to the knuckles, the physical grammar of respect that survived every theological disagreement because the grammar was older than the theology.

Thierno Bâ watched him cross the courtyard. His son’s back. His son’s stride, purposeful, certain, the walk of a man who knew where he was going. When Thierno Bâ died, and he was seventy-two, and the body knew it even when the schedule did not, Abdoulaye would lead the brotherhood. Four million people. The mosque. The manuscripts. The study. The chair where the sick came and the cheated came and the mothers came. All of it would pass to a man who believed the grove was not God’s house, and the passing would reshape how a nation prayed. The change would happen so slowly that most people would not notice until the morning they looked up and the Islam they had inherited, the soft, porous, accommodating Islam of the Sufi way, was not the Islam being taught from this desk. He did not blame his son for this. A father cannot blame a son for being what the world made him. Medina had made Abdoulaye certain. Kessara had made Thierno Bâ patient. The two qualities would not survive in the same body, and the body that would inherit the institution had chosen certainty.

Thierno Bâ was alone in his study. The survey on his desk. The manuscripts on his walls.

The tea glass empty. The study holding its quiet.

He thought about the rally. Fifteen thousand people, listening to a woman talk about money and sovereignty and the price of independence. He thought about the president, who had spent the morning performing democracy for international observers. He thought about the farmer in the corridor. He did not know Ousmane’s name, but he knew the type, the way a shepherd knows his flock: not each sheep by name but each sheep by position, by movement, by how it stands when it is afraid. There were farmers in the corridor who were afraid. Their fear reached him through the mothers who came to his study and the reports that arrived under his door and the prayers that were spoken in the mosque each morning by people who did not name

what they were praying for because the naming would make it real.

He thought about the young men. The ones who left. The ones whose mothers came. On Monday, a woman named Djeneba Diallo, no relation to the president, the name was common, had come to his study. She was fifty. She wore a green wrap. Her hands were clasped in her lap so tightly that the knuckles were pale. Her son Mamadou had left for the border seven months ago. He was nineteen. He had told her he was going to the mines. He sent money, five hundred dollars, then three hundred, then nothing for two months, then two hundred with no message. The money came through a transfer service she did not recognize. She had asked Thierno Bâ to pray for Mamadou's safety. She had also asked, and this was the thing that stayed with him, the thing that pressed against the floor of his chest, whether it was a sin to use the money her son sent if she did not know how he earned it.

He had not answered her. He had prayed with her. He had written a verse on paper and given it to her. He had not answered the question because the answer required a certainty he did not have, and the weight that distinguished him from his son was precisely this: Abdoulaye would have answered. Abdoulaye would have said the money was haram, forbidden, or the money was halal, permitted, and the ruling would have been clean and the woman would have left with a verdict. Thierno Bâ left her with a prayer and an open question, because an open question was more honest than a closed answer, and honesty was the only currency he trusted. The bus station. The green duffel bags. The walk that did not look back. He had watched them from his window. He could not stop them. He could pray for them. He could receive their mothers. He could hold, in the vast patience of his faith, their leaving, the way the earth holds the weight of rain: absorbing it, carrying it downward, storing it in places no one sees until someone digs a well.

The city was quieting. The generators were shutting down one by one, each silence a small surrender, a household accepting the dark. The mosque compound was empty. The minaret was a dark shape against a darker sky. The stars were appearing.

He had not spoken about the referendum. Four million people waited. Both campaigns waited. The president waited. The opposition waited. The journalists waited. They all wanted his voice, because his voice carried weight that no poll could measure and no campaign could manufacture, and the weight was not his. It was the weight of a tradition that had been carried by men like him for a thousand years, passed from hand to hand like a flame that each generation received and each generation was responsible for not letting go out.

He would not speak until God spoke to him. Not stubbornness. Not strategy. The simple recognition that the loudest space in the country was the wrong place to hear the quietest voice in the universe, and the quietest voice was the only one worth waiting for. Four days. The vote was in four days. The campaigns would grow louder. The streets would grow tenser. The arguments would sharpen until they drew blood, and they would, he could feel it coming the way a farmer feels the change in the air before a storm. Something was building. He could feel it in the mothers who came to his study, in the young men with duffel bags at the bus station, in the money that arrived from across the border without messages attached. Someone was recruiting Kessara's sons, and the recruiting was getting faster, and the referendum was making it easier. He washed his glass. He placed it upside down on the tray. He stood at the window. The city was dark. The stars were bright. God was patient. God had always been patient. The men who ran and argued and campaigned and calculated and feared. They believed time was running out. They were wrong. Time did not belong to them. Time belonged to the One who made it, and He had made enough of it for everything that needed to happen, and not one minute less.

Thierno Bâ turned from the window. He went to his room. He lay on his narrow bed.

The third round of tea, the round of acceptance, would come when it came. He was not in a hurry. The tea knew when it was ready. The man who drank it had only to be present when it was poured.

* * *

<div align="center">

DAY 4: WEDNESDAY

"The Corridor"

</div>

"We do not inherit the earth from our ancestors. We borrow it from our children." — Attributed to Chief Seattle, Duwamish, c. 1854

* * *

Chapter 20

Ousmane was in the eastern field before the light came, and the soil told him what the radio could not.

He knelt at the end of the third row. The millet was knee-high, short for this time of year, shorter than last year, shorter than the year before that. He pressed his hand flat against the earth between the stalks. The surface was dry. Not the dry of early morning, when the dew has not yet arrived, the dry of soil that the dew can no longer reach, because the moisture beneath has retreated below the depth where morning air can pull it up. He pushed his fingers in. Down past the first centimeter, past the second. At three centimeters the soil should have been damp. It was not. At five centimeters, his fingers found the faintest coolness, not moisture but the memory of moisture, the ghost of what had been there a week ago and would not return without rain.

He pulled his hand out and held the soil in his palm. He crumbled it between his thumb and forefinger. The grains scattered in the slight breeze and did not settle. Too light. The organic matter that gave soil its weight, the decomposed leaves, the manure he worked in each season, the slow patient accumulation of life returning to the ground, was thinning. He could feel it. Not with instruments, not with the language of the agricultural extension officers who came from the capital once a year and took samples and sent them to a laboratory and returned six months later with a report that told him what his hands had known since planting day. He could feel it the way you feel the difference between a full sack and a half-empty one, by weight. The soil was lighter than it should be.

He stood. His knees complained. They had been complaining for five years, the protest of joints that had spent forty years bending and rising, bending and rising, a hundred times a day, the body paying the price of its own use. He did not think about the knees. The knees were the knees. They would work until they stopped, and when they stopped he would find a different way to get to the ground. He walked the rows. This was the morning's work, not the weeding, which would come later, but the reading. The millet had things to say and you could hear them only by walking. This

stalk was strong, the green deep, the leaves spread, the root holding well. This one was weak, the green fading to yellow at the tips, the stalk leaning, the root losing its argument with the soil. This one was dead. He pulled it out and held it. Dry. Light. The color of old paper. He tossed it on the ground. The field would take it back. Everything returned to the field eventually.

Sékou appeared at the edge of the rows, carrying two bowls. Porridge. The morning routine, the porridge, the tree, the water, the work. The routine was older than either of them and would, if the field survived, outlast them both. Sékou set the bowls on the ground at the base of the baobab and went back to the compound for water. He did not need to be told.

The routine told him. They ate in the shade. The porridge was thick, the groundnut paste stirred in properly, the consistency right. The spoon stood upright for a moment before slowly falling. Aïssatou's test. If the spoon stands, the porridge is ready. If it falls immediately, more flour. If it never falls, too thick, start again. Sékou had learned this without being taught. He had watched his mother cook for fourteen years and the knowledge had entered his hands the way water enters soil, by contact, by time, by the slow patience of a surface that does not resist.

The morning was warm. The birds were in the tree, weaverbirds, building. Their nests hung from the outer branches like small woven rooms, each one a sphere of grass strips, the entrance at the bottom, the work precise and unpredictable.

Ousmane watched one bird working, a male, orange-headed, pulling a strip of grass through a loop he had made, tightening it, pulling another strip, weaving. The bird did not consult drawings. The bird did not file permits. The bird built because building was what the bird did, and the building was perfect because the bird and the building were the same thing. If a man with a clipboard came to the tree and told the bird that the branch it was building on had been designated for removal under Article 12, Section 4, of a Special Economic Zone agreement, the bird would not understand the sentence. The bird would continue building.

The man with the clipboard would call this a problem. The bird would not call it anything. It would build.

The government car came at ten. A different car this time. Newer. The tires were wider, not the city tires of Bakary's sedan but the heavier tires of a vehicle that expected bad roads. Someone had learned from someone else's mistake. The car came down the laterite road without pitching, without lurching, without the metallic complaint that had announced every previous visitor. It arrived with weight, with preparation, with the quiet confidence of a machine that has been doing this for a long

time and does not intend to stop. Two people. Cissé, the woman from the Ministry of Land Affairs, the one with the leather folder, the one who had come the first time with the fourteen-million-franc offer. She was back. Her folder was new. And a man Ousmane had not seen before, older, heavier, wearing a suit that must have been punishing in the heat. His name was Director Coulibaly.

He announced the title like a fact about the world, as a fact about the world that the world was expected to accommodate. Ousmane met them under the baobab. Water first. The custom held. Coulibaly drank without thanking. Cissé drank and said thank you. Ousmane noted both.

“Mr. Traoré. I’m with the Corridor Resettlement Program.” Coulibaly did not sit. He stood in the shade of the tree and looked at the field the way a buyer looks at property, measuring, calculating, already seeing what would replace it. His eyes moved across the millet, the fallow ground, the compound behind the low wall, and arrived at the baobab with the expression of a man who sees a large object in the wrong place. “We have a revised offer.” Cissé opened the folder. New papers. The same map Ousmane had seen, the map Amadou had read to him under this tree, the map with the line through Aïssatou’s stone, but with different numbers in the box. “Twenty-two million CFA francs. A priority relocation plot, forty hectares in the Bassam Resettlement Zone, cleared, fenced, and ready for planting. A transition payment of two million for relocation costs. And agricultural extension support for the first three years.” Twenty-two million. Eight million more than the first offer. The number had gone up because Ousmane had said no. In the government’s thinking, every no was an opening. You added money until the no became yes. Their calculations did not account for a no that was not an opening but a closed door.

“The resettlement zone,” Ousmane said. “I asked about it when Cissé came the first time.” Cissé looked at the ground. She remembered.

“Red clay soil,” Ousmane said. “Deep water table. Twenty meters, maybe more. You cannot reach it with a well they had dug. You need a diesel pump. Diesel costs money. The money comes from where?”

“The agricultural extension program.”

“The program runs for three years. Then what? The pump runs on diesel. Diesel runs on money. Money runs out. Then I am standing in a field of red clay with a broken pump and no well and forty hectares of land that will grow cassava if I am lucky and nothing if I am not.”

He looked at Coulibaly. “I grow millet. My father grew millet. His father grew millet. Millet does not grow in red clay. You are offering me land that cannot do what

my land does.” Coulibaly’s jaw moved. The movement of a man arranging words he had been told to say and finding that the arrangement did not fit the room. “Mr. Traoré, this is the most generous resettlement package in Kessaran history. The president himself.”

“The president has not been to this field. The president has not tested this soil. The president does not know the name of the tree he is asking me to leave.” He said this without heat. The voice was the voice, low, steady, the voice that did not need volume because the weight was in the words, not the air behind them. “I do not doubt that the president is a good man. A good man can still ask for something that is not his to take.”

He stood and walked to the edge of the field. Not away from them, toward something. They followed because following was the only option when Ousmane moved toward something. His pace set the terms.

He stopped at the stone. Aïssatou’s stone. Red-brown. Flush with the earth. Thirty meters from the tree.

“My wife,” he said. “Ten years in this ground.”

He pointed north. “My father. At the base of the tree.

Twenty-one years.” He pointed behind the compound. “My mother. Beside the kitchen house. Thirty years.”

He looked at Coulibaly. “You are offering me twenty-two million francs to dig up my wife, put her bones in a box, put the box in a truck, and drive her to a field she never worked, in soil she never touched, beside people she never knew. You are offering me twenty-two million francs to tell my mother’s bones that the kitchen house she cooked in for forty years has been removed to make room for a railway. And you are offering me twenty-two million francs to cut down a tree that my grandfather carried as a seedling for three days and planted the morning this country was born.”

He let the number stand in the air.

“Twenty-two million francs. The price of a family. Tell me, how did you calculate it? What is the formula? What is the cost per grave? What is the market rate for a baobab tree that is sixty-three years old? I would like to know the mathematics, Director. Because my mathematics do not produce this number.” Cissé was writing. She wrote everything. It was her job, the recording of what the government said and what the citizens said in return. Her handwriting was small and even and it captured everything and changed nothing.

Coulibaly looked at his shoes. They were good shoes. The shoes of a man who worked in an office with a chair and a desk and an air conditioner and a view of a parking lot. The shoes had not been designed for standing in a millet field while a farmer asked questions that the shoes' owner could not answer.

"The offer is open for thirty days," Coulibaly said.

"You have thirty days," Ousmane said. "I have the rest of my life. And after my life, my son's life. And after his, his son's. We are not talking about the same amount of time." They left. The car pulled away. The engine sound faded down the road and the silence of the field returned, not empty silence but full silence, the silence of a place that had held a conversation and absorbed it and would hold it in its walls and its soil and its roots until the next conversation came. That evening, the diviner came.

Ousmane did not send for him. Dramane arrived the way weather arrives, without appointment, without announcement, present because conditions required him. He appeared at the edge of the compound at dusk, when the light was the color of old honey and the shadows were long and the air had begun its evening cooling. He walked to the baobab without asking, because the tree was not property and did not require permission. Seventy years old. Maybe older. He wore simple cloth, undyed cotton, the color of the fabric itself, the brown-white of raw fiber. Bare feet. His feet were wide and flat and hard, the soles thick as leather, the toes spread by a lifetime of walking without shoes. He moved across the ground the way water moves, finding the path of least resistance, flowing around obstacles, arriving where he was going without the appearance of effort.

He opened his bag on the ground between the roots. Seventeen cowrie shells. A piece of kola nut. A handful of sand from the sacred grove. He arranged them with a care that was not hesitation. Each shell placed at a position in a circle around the kola nut, each one flat-side or curved-side up in a pattern that meant nothing to Ousmane and everything to Dramane.

The fire Ousmane had lit against the evening chill threw moving shadows across the arrangement. The shells seemed to shift in the flickering light, the pattern breathing. Dramane held the seventeen shells in both palms. He closed his eyes. His lips moved, words too quiet to hear, words in a language older than Dioula, older than French, older than Arabic, a language that existed before any of the languages people spoke in Kessara and that survived inside the practice the way a seed survives inside a dried fruit. He cast them. They fell on the hard-packed earth with a sound like the first drops of rain on a tin roof, light, scattered, each shell landing at its own pitch. They scattered into a pattern. Dramane leaned forward. He studied the pattern. The fire

moved and the shadows moved and the shells held still. He touched one with his forefinger, the third from the left, curved-side up, and moved it a fraction. A correction or a confirmation. Ousmane could not tell, and what went unsaid was part of the arrangement between them. He did not need to understand the shells. He needed to be present while they were read.

“The grove is inside their fence,” Dramane said. “I know.” “The spirits do not understand fences.”

He gathered the shells. One at a time. In an order that was not the order they had fallen, a different sequence, a returning, each shell placed back in the bag with the same deliberation with which it had been placed on the ground. He stood. His knees did not crack. His back did not protest.

“The land will be here after the machines,” he said. “It was here before the maps. The tree may go. The graves may go. But the land does not go. The land does not leave.”

He walked into the darkness toward the grove. His bare feet on the path. His cloth bag against his hip. His back straight against the failing light. He had work to do, offerings to place, words to speak, tending to perform. Work that had nothing to do with referendums or resettlement packages or the price per hectare of a family’s history.

Ousmane watched him go. The darkness took him completely, without negotiation, leaving behind only the knowledge that he had been there and the trust that he would come again when conditions required him.

Ousmane sat on the bench in the compound with Ibrahim’s phone pressed to his ear. The kerosene lamp. The radio off. He had turned it off after dinner because the voices on it were talking about his field and his tree and his stone without knowing his name, and listening to strangers argue about your life was a kind of pain he did not have the energy for tonight.

He looked at the screen. Ibrahim’s number. His thumb rested on the green button. He did not press it. Ibrahim had told him not to call. If they see calls from Kessara, they will know.

The silence from the phone was its own kind of weight, heavier, in some ways, than bad news, because bad news at least arrived. Silence just sat there.

The screen glowed in the dark compound, a small blue rectangle, the only electric light in the yard. On the screen, Ibrahim’s name. The name he and Aïssatou had chosen in the week after the birth, Ibrahim, the prophet who was asked to sacrifice his son and who trusted God enough to raise the knife, and God had stayed his hand. The

name was a prayer. The prayer was for a son who would be tested and who would be saved. The prayer was twenty-six years old and the test had come and the hand had not been stayed.

He put the phone on the bench. He placed his hand on his chest. The leather pouch. The verse, the seeds, the soil. In his shirt pocket, the folded map. The line through the stone.

The compound was dark. The stars were out. The night sounds: insects, the roof ticking, the dog sighing.

He did not sleep for a long time. When he did, he dreamed of rain. Not the real rain, the rain he remembered from childhood, when the storms came heavy and the fields flooded and his father stood in the doorway and watched the water and said: "The earth is drinking."

The earth was drinking. The fields were full. The millet was tall. The tree was young and his father was alive and his mother was cooking and the world was a place where the ground gave back what you gave it.

He woke before dawn and the ground was dry.

Chapter 21

Fatou returned to the Bassam Corridor on Day 4. This time she went further.

She had been here two days ago, Kounda, the chief in his white boubou, the school teacher who had not been paid since January, the women at the well. She had filed a dispatch from those interviews. But she had stayed on the road, visited one village, and driven back. The corridor was longer than a day trip. The story was deeper than one village.

Moussa drove. The borrowed Peugeot. They left at six, before the heat. The highway carried its usual traffic, trucks hauling cement and rice between the capital and the interior, their flatbeds loaded and listing on the curves. The laterite began where it always began, the tires shuddering off the asphalt, the red dust rising. Three villages today. She had chosen them from the resettlement map, one near the coast, one in the mid-corridor, one at the edge of the plateau. Three points on a line.

The first village was not Kounda. This chief was older than the last, eighty, perhaps, but he wore the same white boubou, sat on the same kind of low wooden stool, and spoke in the same careful French. She wondered whether the boubou was the uniform of the position, the way a judge wears robes. Whether all village chiefs in the corridor had rehearsed the same sentences, or whether the sentences were the same because the situation was the same. "We are not against progress," he said, and Fatou wrote it down because the chief in Kounda had said the same thing, nearly word for word, two days ago. A school. A clinic. A road. The list of needs was identical. The deal did not address any of them.

She noted this in the margin of her notebook: Same words. Same needs. Different village. The pattern is the story.

The second village had no chief available. The women were there.

Eight of them, in the shade of a mango tree, shelling groundnuts into a dented metal basin that had been repaired more times than it had been washed. Fatou joined them on the ground. Moussa translated when the French gave way to Dioula.

Kadiatou spoke first. Forty-three. She sold groundnuts at the junction market.

"They keep asking us what we think," Kadiatou said.

"Journalists. Government people. NGOs. Campaign workers. Everybody wants to know: what do the village women think about the deal?"

She cracked a shell. The nut dropped.

"Nobody asked before. Nobody came here before. For forty years, nobody asked. Now they ask every day. Three times this week."

She looked at Fatou.

"That is how I know it does not matter what we think. When they start asking, it means they have already decided. They ask so they can say they asked."

Fatou wrote it down. She underlined it. The cleanest sentence she had heard all week.

Another woman spoke. Older. Quieter. She raised her eyes and looked at Fatou for a long time before speaking.

"My son went north three years ago. To find work."

The air between the women changed. They all knew this story. They all carried a version of it.

"He sends money sometimes. Not every month. The money comes through a service I do not recognize. He does not say what kind of work."

Her hands stopped moving. The first time in the conversation that any of the women's hands had stopped.

"I do not ask. If I ask, maybe the money stops. If the money stops, my daughter does not finish school. So I do not ask." Fatou's pen was on the paper but the pen was not moving. She was listening with a part of herself that journalism had not trained, the part that recognized this woman's voice because it sounded like her own mother's. The careful flatness. The practiced control. The sound of a woman who has sealed something shut.

She had heard this same pattern two days ago in Kounda, a different woman, a different son, the same silence around the same question. The corridor was producing the same story in every village. Not because the women were coordinating. Because the machine that took their sons was the same machine everywhere, and the silence it left behind had the same shape.

The woman picked up the next groundnut. Her hands resumed. In the third village, something else happened.

She was interviewing a health worker, a woman in her thirties who ran the village's only dispensary with expired supplies and a logbook she kept in perfect order because the order was the only thing she could control. Fatou was asking about water access when an elderly woman approached.

She moved slowly. A walking stick. She studied Fatou's face the way you study a face you are trying to place.

"You are Mensah," the woman said. In Dioula, then in French. "Your father was Amadou Mensah."

Fatou's pen stopped.

"You knew my father?"

"I knew your mother. We were neighbors in Port Sélani. The Plateau district. Before you left."

The Plateau district. Her mother's voice, two days ago, on the phone from Toronto: Stay away from the Plateau district. The shuttered Ministry of Mines. The padlock rusting in the streetlight. "Can we talk?" Fatou asked. "Privately?"

They moved to a bench outside the dispensary. The woman's name was Kadiatou Konaté. Seventy-eight. She had moved to this village fifteen years ago to live with her daughter's family. "Your mother was a good woman," Madame Konaté said. "She made the best thieboudienne on the street. Your father cooked too. He made it differently, with more tomato, and he argued with your mother about the right amount."

Fatou's chest tightened. She could see it, her father at the stove in the Toronto apartment, the sleeves rolled, the tomato paste, the argument about proportions that was not an argument but a marriage.

"And she was afraid, Fatou. Every day, for the last year before you left."

"Afraid of what?"

Madame Konaté looked at her. The look of an old woman measuring whether the young woman across from her is ready to receive what she is holding.

"Come back when you have more time," Madame Konaté said. "This is not a short story."

She touched Fatou's hand.

"Your mother was right to be afraid."

Fatou sat on the bench after Madame Konaté left and wrote four sentences in her notebook. Not for the dispatch. For herself. 1. My mother knew something about the Ministry of Mines. 2. We left because she was afraid. 3. She has never told me what she was afraid of. 4. Madame Konaté knows.

She closed the notebook. She carried those four sentences back to Port Sélani like stones in her chest. The Ministry of Mines. The Plateau district. Her father, the quiet man who cooked fish on Sundays and one day said they were leaving and never explained why.

She had come to Kessara to cover a referendum. Something else had found her, older than the deal, older than the vote. Something that had started in a building that was now chained shut, twenty-six years ago, when she was too young to understand it and her mother was too afraid to explain it.

She called her mother from the car. The phone rang three times and went to voicemail. Her mother never let it go to voicemail. Her mother answered on the second ring every time, the discipline of a woman who had trained herself to be reachable because not answering meant something had gone wrong.

Three rings. Voicemail.

She tried again an hour later. Same.

She left a message. "Mama, call me back. I met someone who knows us. From the Plateau."

She did not say Madame Konaté's name. But her mother would hear the Plateau and the word would do its work, the same work it had been doing since they left, the same locked room in the family's history that no one opened.

Moussa drove. The laterite gave way to asphalt. The dust settled. The city appeared on the horizon, cranes and minarets and the half-finished towers and the ocean beyond.

He did not ask what Madame Konaté had said. He had been watching Fatou since Day 1. He had seen her photograph the Ministry of Mines twice. He was a man who paid attention, and paying attention meant knowing when silence was more useful than questions.

She looked at the city in the windshield. The notebook on her lap was full of other people's words, the chief's careful French, Kadiatou's diagnosis, the mother's silence. Professional words that would become a dispatch.

But beneath them, four sentences in her own handwriting. Not professional. Not filed. Hers alone, waiting for the rest of the story to arrive.

Chapter 22

The intelligence briefing arrived at eight in the morning, and Diallo read it standing in the kitchen with his coffee cooling on the counter. He always read the briefings standing. Sitting down with a classified folder implied leisure, and there was no leisure in what the folders contained. Standing kept the body alert. Standing kept the reading fast. Standing kept the information at arm's length, where numbers stayed numbers until he was done with them. The folder was thin today. Two items. His chief of intelligence, Colonel Diarra, a man who had served four presidents and who never confused intelligence with advice, had organized the contents in order of operational priority. Item one: the Granite Group. The estimate had been revised upward. Two hundred and fifty Kessaran nationals, possibly more, currently serving with private military operations across two neighboring countries. The number had been two hundred on Monday. The increase was not a sudden recruitment surge. It was a correction. Colonel Diarra's sources had refined their counting methodology, which meant the number had probably been higher than two hundred for months and the previous estimate had been wrong.

Two hundred and fifty young men. Recruited from the drought provinces, the same northern districts that Minister Keïta had described emptying into the displacement camps. The same communities where the rains had failed for two consecutive seasons and the farming economy had collapsed and the young men had faced a choice between moving south to the camps or moving north to the border. The recruitment pitch was in the file. Diarra's people had obtained a copy, printed on cheap paper, distributed at bus stations and market towns in the border region. Eight hundred dollars a month. Meals. Training. Brotherhood. The word "brotherhood" was in the pitch. Not "employment" or "contract" or "opportunity." Brotherhood. The word that young men without fathers or futures or the daily structure of meaningful work needed to hear. The word that filled the space where family used to be. Eight hundred dollars was more than a teacher earned. More than a nurse. More than a junior clerk in a ministry office who stamped documents and processed forms and went home at five to a rented room in the Médina. The salary was the argument. The brotherhood was the

hook.

And the desert was the fence. Once you were in, the twelve hundred kilometers of nothing between the camp and any recognizable life was the contract's enforcement mechanism. No signature required. Geography did the work.

Diallo read the number. Two hundred and fifty. He thought about the number as he always did, as a fact that pointed at a system. The system was clear: the drought produced displacement, displacement produced desperation, desperation produced recruits, recruits produced revenue for a company that was registered nowhere and accountable to no one and that operated across borders the way weather operates across borders. The system was self-sustaining. It fed on the same failure that the deal was designed to address, the failure of a country to provide its young men with an alternative to leaving. The deal would build roads and railways and processing facilities. The deal would create jobs, fifty thousand or twelve thousand, depending on whose presentation you believed. The deal would generate revenue that could fund hospitals and schools and the agricultural extension programs that might, in ten or fifteen years, make the northern provinces viable again. The deal would also create a Special Economic Zone with private security provisions that were, in their legal structure, indistinguishable from the contracts the Granite Group used to operate in six other countries.

He closed the page. Item two: displacement.

Forty-three thousand people in the camps now. The number had been forty thousand on Monday. Three thousand new arrivals in three days, families from the northern provinces, walking south with what they could carry, arriving at camps that were already at three hundred percent capacity. Cholera confirmed at Camp Bassam. Seven cases. Two deaths. The health minister had requested an emergency meeting. The minister of health would ask for money. The money was not available. The money was servicing the debt. The debt was the reason the deal was on the table. The deal was the reason the referendum was happening. The referendum was in three days. The circle closed on itself the way all circles close, seamlessly, inevitably, each point leading to the next, the logic unbreakable and the outcome unbearable. You could enter the circle at any point and follow it around and arrive back where you started and nothing would have changed except your understanding of how trapped you were inside it. Forty-three thousand people in camps. Seven with cholera. Two dead. Three days until a vote that might, if the Yes prevailed, if the deal went through, if the restructuring was implemented, if the investment arrived on schedule, if the jobs materialized, if the revenue targets were met, might, in fifteen years, produce an

economy that could absorb these people back into something resembling a life. Fifteen years. The woman who died of cholera yesterday did not have fifteen years. She had yesterday. He closed the briefing. He picked up his phone.

The third item of the morning was not from Colonel Diarra. It was from his son. A link from Ibrahima, sent at six AM Paris time, midnight in Port Sélani: It's published. I'm sorry, Papa. But I had to. Diallo opened the link. Le Monde. Opinion section. Title: "The Referendum Kessara Does Not Need." He read it standing in the kitchen. The coffee was cold. The light through the window was the same gray-blue as every morning, the cranes, the ocean, the city. The same view he had seen on Sunday when he shaved and on

Monday when the leak arrived and on Tuesday when the observers came. The view did not change. What he carried while looking at it changed. The op-ed was three thousand words. Ibrahima's French was elegant, the French of Sciences Po, polished, structured, the sentences building toward their conclusions with the patient structure of a man who had been taught to argue in rooms where argument was an art form. He quoted Fanon: the section on national consciousness and the failure of post-colonial states to achieve genuine independence. He quoted Sankara: the speech about debt as a tool of domination. He quoted Nkrumah, Cabral, Lumumba. The pan-African canon, deployed with precision. He did not quote his father. The argument was clean. The referendum was a false choice, democratic cover for an economic surrender. The SEZ provisions created a parallel state. The revenue terms transferred wealth for a generation. The technology transfer clause, and here Diallo paused, because Ibrahima had found page 78, was the deal's only defensible provision, and it was insufficient to justify the sacrifice of sovereignty required to obtain it. The analysis was sharp. The prose was elegant. The argument was the work of a man who had never stood in a hospital where the insulin ran out. Who had never sat across from Asante while Asante laid out the bond math. Who had never looked at a number, fifty-two days, four hundred and eighty million dollars, and understood that the number was not a statistic but a countdown, and that when the countdown reached zero, the hospitals would close and the schools would close and the nurses would leave for Dubai and the teachers would leave for Senegal and the country would enter the darkness that default brings, not the darkness of war but the darkness of abandonment, the lights going out one ministry at a time, the phones disconnecting one office at a time, the government pulling back from its people the way a tide pulls back from shore, slowly at first, then all at once.

Ibrahima knew the theory. He did not know the weight.

Diallo closed the phone. He looked at the view. The cranes. The ships. The ocean that did not care about referendums or bond payments or the gulf separating a father in a kitchen and a son in a newsroom who had just published the most articulate argument against his father's life's work that anyone in the family had ever made.

He did not call Ibrahima. He did not text. He finished his coffee, cold, bitter, the grounds settled at the bottom of the cup in a dark residue that he rinsed into the sink. He put the cup on the drying rack. He went to the office.

Three days.

Chapter 23

Chen Liwei returned to the Bassam Corridor for the second time, and this time she went further. She stopped at the staging area first. Seventeen containers arranged in a horseshoe at the corridor's edge, the site office trailer on the east end, the equipment still tarped. The project had not broken ground, would not break ground until the referendum result cleared the bond conditions. But the staging area was operational. Site manager. Survey crew. Two logistics coordinators. And, since Tuesday, Engineer Xu. Xu Mingzhao was forty-two. He had come from Zhonglu's Kenya office for the corridor survey verification. He wore his hard hat on-site and his suit in the trailer and conducted both roles with the efficiency of a man who saw no contradiction between them. She found him at the plan table. Survey overlays. He looked up.

"Ms. Chen. You're going back out?"

"Kilometer twelve. There are discrepancies in the drainage flagging."

"I saw your correction notes. Good work." He turned back to the survey. "The earthworks contractor arrives Thursday. They'll need the revised gradients before Friday."

"I'll have them." She put her bag on the chair. "The well at the fifth community. The hydrological concern from Tuesday's walk, the aquifer lens under the sub-grade at kilometer five. The drainage mitigation plan needs to account for it." He found the relevant sheet. He scanned it. "It's flagged."

"It's flagged as a drainage variable. It needs to be flagged as a community water source. The drainage mitigation can't compromise the well draw." Xu looked at her. A pause of the kind that held a calculation.

"The well is a resettlement item, Ms. Chen. Once the communities relocate."

"The resettlement timeline is eighteen months from groundbreaking. Drainage work at kilometer five starts in week three. The communities will still be there. They'll still be drawing from that well." He was quiet. She recognised the quiet. She had produced it herself, twice in the last two years, when a specification conflict had no clean answer and the available answers all created other problems.

"I'll flag it for the project engineer," he said.

“The project engineer is in Shenzhen.”

“I know where he is.”

She picked up her bag. “Twelve weeks of construction at that section before resettlement is completed. I’ll note it in the drainage addendum. But the project engineer needs to see it before Friday.” She left. Mamadou was waiting. They drove south. She told Mamadou to drop her at the kilometer-twelve marker, the grove, where the alignment diverted, and drive ahead to the baobab at kilometer fourteen. She would walk to him. Mamadou nodded. He had stopped asking why she walked alone. He was learning when to wait.

“The groundnut woman at the last village,” Liwei said. “Is she there today?”

“Wednesday. Market day at the junction. She will be there.” “Good. I’ll walk to her.”

“That is eight kilometers, Ms. Chen.”

“I know how far it is.” She got out. The car pulled away. The dust settled. She was alone in the corridor with her backpack, her notebook, and the deal text printed on paper that was starting to curl at the edges from the humidity.

She walked south from the grove. The survey flags were her guide, orange on wire stakes, every fifty meters, the same flags she had followed on Tuesday. She knew them now. She was beginning to know the ground beneath them too, the places where the laterite hardened into ironstone, the places where it softened into clay, the drainage channels that the topographic survey had missed because the measurement intervals were too wide. She was accumulating a physical memory of the corridor that the survey binders could not contain, and the accumulation was doing something to her that she did not have a name for yet. The morning was cooler than Tuesday. A thin layer of cloud had come in from the coast overnight, not rain cloud, not anything that would produce moisture, just a veil between the sun and the ground that lowered the temperature by three or four degrees. Enough to make walking comfortable. Enough to let her think without the heat pressing on her like a second body. She carried the deal text in her bag. She had read it before, in the warehouse, on the screen, in the clinical light of the converted fish plant. But she had not read it here. She had not read it while standing on the ground the words described. And reading a document in the place it applies to is a different act from reading it at a desk, the way walking an alignment is different from studying a survey. The ground adds weight to the words. The words acquire mass. A clause about “resettlement of affected communities” weighs nothing in a warehouse. It weighs everything when you are standing in a community that will be affected. At kilometer fourteen, the field opened and the

baobab appeared.

She had been here on Tuesday. She had put her hand on the bark. She had eaten groundnuts in the shade. She had looked at her drawings and seen that the center line passed through the trunk. She had walked away. She had not resolved anything. She had simply noted the discrepancy between the drawing and the feeling. The drawing said the tree was a removal item; the feeling said the tree was something else, and she had filed the discrepancy in the place where engineers file things that do not have engineering solutions: the part of her notebook marked with a question mark and no answer.

She walked to the tree. She sat at the base, her back against the trunk. The bark pressed into her shoulders through her shirt, rough, warm, the texture of something that had been alive for longer than she had been an engineer and would be alive after she stopped being one. She looked up. The canopy spread above her in every direction, branches dividing and dividing again, each fork a decision the tree had made decades ago about where to send its weight. An engineer would call this load distribution. The tree did not call it anything. The tree simply grew toward the light and let the structure follow, and the structure was better than anything her profession had produced, because the structure had been tested by decades of wind and drought and the mechanical stress of holding several hundred tons of wood upright on a single trunk without reinforcement, without maintenance, without a budget. She had seen baobabs across the continent. In Kenya, along the Mombasa road, trunks so wide that people had hollowed them into storage rooms and bus shelters. In Ethiopia, near the Omo Valley, specimens that the park rangers said were a thousand years old, a number she had treated with engineering skepticism until she saw the trunks, the bark layered like geological strata, the wood so dense and fibrous that a chainsaw blade would dull before reaching the heartwood. She had read about the oldest ones, carbon-dated past two thousand years. Some researchers claimed twenty-five hundred. Trees that had been growing when Rome was a republic. Trees that had survived every empire that had ever crossed this continent, the Malians, the Songhai, the Portuguese, the French, the British, and that would survive this one too, if they were left to do what they did, which was stand. This tree was young by those standards. She judged from the trunk, wide enough that she could not reach around it, but not yet the massive girth of the ancient ones. Less than a hundred years, she guessed. A sapling in baobab time. It had barely started. In five hundred years, if it was left alone, the trunk would be three times this width. In a thousand years, people would carve rooms inside it. In two thousand years, it would be one of the ancient ones, a landmark, a

monument, a thing that tourists flew across oceans to photograph. The railway she was building would not last two thousand years. Railways did not last two thousand years. The steel would fatigue. The concrete would spall. The ballast would shift. In a hundred years, less than the lease term, the rail bed would require replacement. In two hundred years, the technology would be obsolete. In five hundred years, the railway would be archaeology. A raised line of crushed stone running through a landscape that had moved on to whatever came after railways, the way this landscape had moved on from whatever came before farms. The tree, if left, would still be here.

She was being asked to remove a living thing that could outlast every structure her profession had ever built, to make room for a structure that would not survive a fraction of the tree's natural life. The engineering math was simple: the permanent thing was being destroyed to make way for the temporary thing. No engineer would accept this calculation in a design review. The design review would send it back. The numbers did not support the decision. But the design review did not account for the tree. The design review accounted for the gradient, the drainage, the bearing capacity, the cost per kilometer. The tree was a line item. Removal cost: negligible. Half a day. She took out the deal text. She turned to Article 7.

She had read Article 7 in the warehouse. In the warehouse, the clause was about jurisdiction, which legal system governed the corridor, which courts heard disputes, which labor standards applied. Important. Technical. The kind of clause that lawyers argued about and engineers implemented and nobody lost sleep over because the implementation was someone else's problem. Here, sitting against the tree, with the millet stretching around her and the compound visible in the distance and the sound of chickens somewhere behind the low wall, the clause read differently. Security within the corridor shall be provided by a contracted entity designated by the project operator, subject to coordination with the

Kessaran National Gendarmerie.

"Contracted entity." She had read these words before. She had parsed them as access control, fencing, guard stations, perimeter protocols. Engineering considerations. But sitting on the ground inside the corridor, the words produced a different image. Armed men. Not Kessaran soldiers, who were at least nominally accountable to a government that was at least nominally accountable to the people whose land this was. Private soldiers. Accountable to Zhonglu. Operating under Chinese security protocols. Inside Kessara. On Kessaran soil. She thought about the camp she had heard about, the one the radio mentioned without naming, the one that everyone in the capital knew about and nobody in the capital discussed. Private

military contractors in the northeast. Recruiting from the drought communities. The same drought communities the corridor passed through. The same young men. The deal's private security clause did not name the Granite Group. It did not need to. The clause was a door. It did not specify who would walk through it. It specified only that the door would exist and that the project operator would hold the key. She closed the document. She leaned her head back against the bark. The sky through the canopy was white, the cloud layer filtering the sun, the light diffuse, shadowless. A helicopter crossed overhead, low enough that the rotor sound scattered the weaverbirds from the near branches. It followed the line of the corridor south and disappeared. A weaverbird was building in the branch above her. The sound of grass being pulled through grass, a quiet, industrious sound, the sound of something being made. She ate her lunch. Rice and groundnuts, bought at the market town on the drive in. She ate slowly. The groundnuts were warm from the bag. The rice was cold. She ate with her palms, something she had learned in Ethiopia, on her first project, when a foreman had watched her struggle with chopsticks over injera and had laughed and taken her hand and pressed it into the food and said: "The hand knows what the mouth needs. Let it work."

She had never gone back to chopsticks in the field. The hand always knew. A boy was watching her from the edge of the millet. She had seen him on Tuesday, tall, quiet, standing at the boundary between the cultivated rows and the fallow ground. Same boy. Same position. Same steady, unsurprised attention. He watched her the way you watch weather, noting it, tracking it, not reacting to it because weather did what weather did and reacting was not useful. She raised her hand. He did not wave back. He did not leave. He just watched. She finished eating. She brushed the rice from her fingers. She packed her bag. She folded the deal text and put it away. She took one more look at the tree, the trunk, the bark, the branches spreading above her, the weaverbird still working, and she stood. She walked back toward the survey flags. South. The way she had come. The orange markers leading her out of the field the way they had led her in, a line of small bright claims planted in ground that had not asked to be claimed. She glanced back once.

A man had appeared at the far end of the field. He was walking from the compound behind the low rise. He carried a hoe over his shoulder, the blade catching the white light, flashing once. He was walking toward the baobab. Sixty meters away. She could not see his face. He could not see hers. The boy turned to meet him. The man put his hand on the boy's shoulder. Father and son. They walked together toward the tree. The man's pace was slow, the pace of someone who had been walking this field his entire

life and would walk it tomorrow and the day after and would not be hurried by schedules or deadlines or the small bright flags that marked the edge of his future.

Liwei watched for three seconds. Then she turned and walked south.

She did not know the man's name. She did not know that his wife was buried thirty meters from where she had been sitting. She did not know that the hoe he carried had been his father's, She did not know that the boy beside him cooked porridge every morning with a spoon that had been his mother's, or that the man had received a phone call two nights ago from a son who could not come home and that the phone call had made his hands shake for the first time in his life. She knew only what the survey flags knew: that the center line passed through this field, and the field contained a tree, and the tree was scheduled for removal.

She walked on. The flags led her south. The dust rose with each step and did not settle.

Chapter 24

Aminata arrived in the corridor by helicopter, borrowed from a mining company that supported the No campaign and asked only that its name not appear anywhere. She noticed this. She always noticed these things. A mining company lending a helicopter to a campaign fighting against mineral exploitation. The helicopter was a French-made *Aérospatiale*, military surplus, repainted civilian white, the company logo on the tail covered with a magnetic panel that Binta had sourced from a sign shop in the Médina. The panel was temporary. Everything about the arrangement was temporary, the support, the secrecy, the pretense that a lithium mining company was lending its aircraft to a sovereignty campaign out of civic conscience rather than commercial strategy.

She sat in the back and watched the corridor pass beneath her. From the air, the landscape was a different argument. The millet fields were geometric, rectangles and squares and irregular polygons, each one a family's plot, separated by paths that followed no grid but the logic of walking between neighbors. The compounds were clusters of brown and silver, mud brick and corrugated iron, the architecture of a people who built with what the ground gave them. The baobab trees stood alone in the fields, each one visible from altitude as a dark circle of canopy surrounded by pale crops. From up here they looked like periods at the end of sentences, small, deliberate, marking where something stopped. The survey flags were visible too. A line of orange dots running through the patchwork, straight as a laser, cutting across the field boundaries and the paths and the compounds with the indifference of a line that had been drawn on a screen by someone who had never looked down from this altitude and seen what the line would cross. She could see both things at once, the pattern of lives and the line through them. From the air, the deal was a geometry problem. On the ground, it was something else.

The helicopter landed in a field outside a market town. Dust. Noise. A crowd already gathering, students from Port Sélani who had traveled three hours by bus, villagers from the surrounding communities, market women who had closed their stalls to attend. Four hundred people. Banners in French and Dioula. A sound system

running off a generator that someone had borrowed from a church. Awa Traoré was at the front.

Aminata saw her before she heard her. A young woman standing on a low concrete wall at the edge of the gathering, no microphone, no platform, her voice carrying across the crowd by the force of conviction and the acoustics of a body that had learned to project in rooms where projection was the only amplification available.

She was leading a call-and-response. The crowd answered her. The rhythm was tight. She had trained these people, or they had trained themselves, or the rhythm was simply the sound that a group of people makes when they agree about something so completely that the agreement becomes music.

“Whose land?” “Our land!” “Whose courts?” “Our courts!” “Whose future?” “Our future!”

Aminata stood at the edge of the crowd and watched. She did not announce herself. She did not move to the front. She watched. She recognised something in Awa. Not the face. She had never seen this woman before. Something else. The posture. The refusal to stand anywhere but the front. The anger that had been sharpened into usefulness, not the raw anger of someone who has just learned something terrible, but the honed anger of someone who has been quiet for twenty years and has decided to stop. Twenty years ago, Aminata had been this woman. Before Oxford. Before The Hague. Before the Foundation. Before the compromises that accumulated like silt in a river, each one small enough to ignore until the water ran a different colour and you could not remember when the change had started. This woman had not yet accumulated silt. Her water was clear. Aminata envied it and feared for it in equal measure, because clarity was the thing that Kessara consumed first, before it consumed your time or your health or your faith, it consumed your clarity, and once the clarity was gone, the rest followed. She introduced herself after the rally. The crowd was dispersing. The generator was being loaded back onto a truck. Awa was talking to two students, organising, always organising, the logistics of the next action already in motion while the current one was still cooling.

“Ms. Traoré.” Awa turned. Her handshake was firm. Her eyes were direct. She did not seem impressed. This was, Aminata noted, the correct response. Being impressed by politicians was the first step toward being used by them, and this woman did not intend to be used.

“Ms. Kourouma. I read your legal brief on the SEZ provisions. You’re right about the jurisdictional issues.”

“Thank you.”

“But you missed something in Article 12.”

Aminata raised an eyebrow. Nobody told her she missed things. The eyebrow was involuntary, the facial response of a woman who had spent twenty years being the person in the room who had read the document most carefully and who had just met someone who had read it more carefully still.

“The resettlement valuation committee,” Awa said. “Three Zhonglu appointees. Two Kessaran. The committee that determines compensation for every family in the corridor, every farm, every house, every grave, has a built-in majority for the company doing the taking.” Aminata had read Article 12. She had marked the resettlement provisions. She had flagged the compensation structure. She had caught the three-to-two committee ratio. She had used it in her speech two nights ago. But Awa had found something she had missed: the committee chair held a casting vote, and the chair was appointed by the project operator. Three-to-two became four-to-two with a single clause, buried in an annex that referenced an annex that defined the committee’s formation process, and the formation process was written in the kind of contractual language that was designed to be read by lawyers who billed by the hour and not by twenty-two-year-old students who read for free because the stakes were personal. Awa had found it. Aminata had not. “Come work for me,” Aminata said. “After the vote.”

“I have an exam on Thursday. Two days from now. I’m going back for it.”

Aminata laughed. The sound surprised her, a real laugh, not the performance laugh she deployed in interviews and donor meetings, but the involuntary kind that escapes because something is true and unexpected. A twenty-two-year-old woman who had just out-read a Hague-trained lawyer was turning down a job offer to go sit an exam. The priorities were absurd and entirely correct. “You remind me of someone,” Aminata said.

“Who?” Aminata almost said: my brother. She did not say it. The sentence would have required an explanation that she was not prepared to give to a stranger in a field, and the explanation would have opened the drawer she kept closed, and the drawer was not for opening in public.

“Someone who read the fine print,” she said. On the helicopter back to Port Sélani, Khadija called. The Foundation’s board of directors, the full list, cross-referenced with corporate registrations and exploration licences.

Aminata put the phone on speaker. The helicopter noise was loud enough that the pilot could not hear, and Khadija’s voice came through the static with the flat precision of a woman delivering findings she had verified three times. “Three of

eleven board members hold executive positions at lithium mining companies with active or pending licences in West Africa. This we knew.” “And?”

“A fourth. I missed her the first time. Dr. Sarah Addington. She sits on the advisory committee of a rare-earth minerals investment fund. The fund has invested heavily in Congolese cobalt. She joined the Foundation board eighteen months ago, six months before the Kessara deal was announced.” Four out of eleven. Still a minority. Still, technically, not a controlling interest. Still, technically, compatible with the Foundation’s stated mission of supporting democratic governance. But the pattern was no longer a pattern. It was a picture. And the picture showed a Foundation whose board included four people with direct financial interests in the same category of minerals that the Kessara deal was designed to extract. The No campaign was not just about sovereignty anymore. Aminata could not pretend it was. The people funding her fight against Chinese mineral exploitation had their own mineral interests. Different country. Different flag. Same ground.

She looked out the helicopter window. The corridor passed beneath her, the fields, the compounds, the baobab trees like dark periods in pale sentences. The survey flags were invisible from this altitude. The line was invisible. But the line was there, and the people who lived on both sides of it were there, and the people who were funding both sides of the argument about the line were sitting in offices in Washington and Beijing and London and none of them had ever walked this ground or met the people who lived on it. The helicopter banked toward Port Sélani. The ocean appeared. The cranes. The port. The ships. She thought about Awa. The clear water. The unaccumulated silt. Twenty-two years old, reading Article 12 at a speed that the Oxford-trained lawyer had not matched, refusing a job offer to take an exam. The young woman who read contracts the way Aminata had once read them, before she learned what the fine print cost.

Aminata would not tell her. Not yet. The knowledge would change the water. The knowledge always changed the water. And Awa deserved a few more days of clarity before the silt arrived.

Chapter 25

Ibrahim left the camp at three in the morning because three in the morning was when the guards changed and the guards who were leaving were tired and the guards who were arriving were not yet awake. He had watched the rotation for three weeks. Every night. Lying in his bunk, eyes open, counting. The shift changed at oh-three-hundred. The outgoing guards walked to the mess tent. The incoming guards walked from the barracks. For ninety seconds, the gate was covered by men whose eyes had not adjusted. The outgoing still carrying the night's dilation, the incoming still carrying the barracks' fluorescent. Ninety seconds of impaired vision. Enough to cross thirty meters of open ground if you moved low and did not run, because running at night drew attention the way a thrown stone draws attention. The motion itself was the alarm.

Three years of training had taught him how to move in the dark. Three years of training had taught him many things. How to strip and reassemble a rifle in under a minute. How to walk a patrol grid without drifting. How to breathe in confined spaces, slow in, hold, slow out, rationing the air the way you ration water, making it last. How to sit still for hours while something inside you screamed to move. How to see a person as a shape in a scope and not think about the shape's mother. He had learned all of it. He was using it now to leave the people who had taught him. The training was eating itself. He took three things. The water bottle, two liters, military issue, the cap screwed tight. The cash, thirty-two hundred-dollar bills pressed flat in the lining of his right boot, earned over three years at eight hundred a month minus the deductions for food and equipment and the "security contribution" that nobody had explained and nobody questioned because questioning was not part of the contract. And the photograph. The photograph was creased. It had been folded and unfolded so many times that the fold line ran through his sister's face, Awa, sixteen in the picture, standing in front of the secondary school on her graduation day. The whole family. His father in the back, taller than everyone, trying not to be. His mother beside his father, alive in the photograph, her hand on Sékou's shoulder, Sékou eleven and serious. Fatoumata on the left, already married, already carrying the expression she

would wear for the rest of her life, patient, watchful, the oldest daughter's face. And Ibrahim himself, twenty, standing at the edge of the group, one foot slightly behind the other, as if he were already preparing to leave. Six years ago. Everyone smiling. He was the only one who was not looking at the camera. He was looking at something off-frame. He could not remember what. A bird. A girl passing on the road. The future, maybe. The thing that was pulling him before he knew its name.

He put the photograph inside his shirt, against his chest, beside the skin. The photograph was warm in ten seconds. It would stay warm until he stopped being warm. The supply trucks came every four days from a depot across the border. They arrived full, fuel, food, ammunition, replacement parts for the vehicles, cartons of cigarettes, crates of bottled water. They left empty. The drivers were contractors, not Granite Group, not Russian, just men who drove trucks and picked up their cash at the depot and did not discuss what the trucks carried or where they went. Truck drivers in this part of the world knew the price of questions. The price was the job. The trucks left at four in the morning. Two trucks. The gate guard checked the cab, driver, manifest, signature. He did not check the bed. The beds were empty. Nobody checked empty beds. The assumption was that nothing worth guarding was leaving. The assumption was wrong.

Ibrahim climbed into the second truck at three-forty. He pulled himself over the tailgate, one motion, quiet, the muscles in his arms doing the work, his boots finding the bed without sound. He lay flat. He pulled the tarpaulin over himself, a heavy canvas sheet that smelled of diesel and rust and something organic he did not want to identify. He arranged it so that a fold near his face allowed air. Not much air. Enough. The truck pulled out at four-twelve. The engine was loud, a diesel, old, the rattle of a motor that had been running hard for years without the maintenance it deserved. The gate guard waved it through. Ibrahim heard the wave, not the gesture but the sound of the guard's hand hitting his thigh afterward, the casual slap of a man completing a routine task. And then the road. The truck moved. The tarpaulin pressed against his face. The bed vibrated beneath him, metal, ridged, the surface shaking with every rut. He braced his elbows and his knees to keep from sliding, his body a cross shape on the floor of the truck, holding position. Six hours. He did not move.

The sun came up. He knew this not by sight but by heat. The tarpaulin absorbed the sun the way a pot absorbs a fire, slowly at first, then all at once, the temperature climbing until the air beneath the canvas was thick and wet and barely breathable. He sipped water from the bottle. Small sips. He counted what was left. Six mouthfuls. Maybe seven. Through a tear in the tarpaulin, a small rip near the tailgate, the canvas

fraying. He could see a strip of sky. Blue. Flat. The sky of the Sahel, which was not the sky of his father's field but was the same blue, the same emptiness, and the difference was only in what was beneath it. His father's sky was above millet. This sky was above sand. He thought about the sky over the compound. The stars. His father teaching him, not as survival training but as farming knowledge. The planting stars. The harvest stars. The star his grandmother called "the Farmer's Wife" because it appeared at the beginning of the growing season and disappeared at the end, as if it had gone inside to rest. He had not thought about stars for three years. In the camp, the floodlights drowned them. The camp had no sky. The camp had a ceiling of white light and beyond the light, nothing.

The truck stopped. Voices. A language he did not know, not French, not Dioula, not the Russian that the senior officers spoke among themselves, the language that sounded like gravel being sorted. This was something else. A border language. A depot language. He waited. The first truck was being unloaded. He could hear it. Shouts, the clang of crates, a forklift's beeping. The second truck, his truck, was not being unloaded because the second truck was empty. Empty trucks were parked. Parked trucks were left alone. This was the plan. The plan was not good. It was the only one he had. He dropped from the bed. One motion. Over the tailgate, boots on dirt. He did not look around. Looking around was hesitation and hesitation was a signal. He walked. North. Away from the depot. Through scrub brush and dry grass and over ground that was hard and cracked and hot under his boots.

He walked until the depot was a sound behind him and then a silence and then nothing. Then he ran. Two hundred meters. Enough to clear the sight line. Then he walked again because running in the open was how you got seen, and getting seen was how you got caught. Eighty kilometers to the border. He had calculated the distance from the maps in the operations room, maps he was not supposed to study but had studied anyway, because three years in a camp teaches you that the people who survive are the people who know the exits. The terrain was scrub. Low bush, dry grass, the occasional acacia tree. The ground was hard, laterite, the same soil his father farmed, the same red-brown earth, but drier here, older, less worked. No millet grew here. Nothing grew that a farmer would recognize as a crop. Nobody had farmed this ground in a long time. Maybe never.

He walked south. The sun moved overhead. His shadow shortened and then lengthened on the other side. He drank. Small sips. The water was warm, body temperature by noon, the bottle pressed against his ribs where the heat was the heat.

By midafternoon his lips were cracked. The skin on his forearms was tight and dry. His legs were heavy, not tired but weighted, as if the heat had added mass to his bones. The horizon did not move. He walked. The ground passed beneath his boots. The horizon stayed where it was. He walked some more. He thought about what he had done. The training taught you to put things in rooms. Separate rooms. Close the doors. The room where you kept the operations, the convoys, the checkpoints, the villages that were there in the morning and different in the evening. The room where you kept the sounds, the sounds that the body stores differently from other sounds, the ones that arrive at night without warning and play behind your eyes while you lie rigid in your bunk, breathing slow, because the breathing is the only thing you can control. The room where you kept the faces.

He did not open the room with the faces. Not today. Not while walking. The walking required his body and the faces required his body too. They arrived not as pictures but as physical events, a tightening in his chest, a heat in his hands, the nausea that was not sickness but memory, the body remembering what the mind had filed. He could walk or he could remember. He could not do both. But the rooms leaked. That was the thing nobody told you. The doors did not seal. The things you put away came back, not through the doors but through the walls, seeping, the way water seeps through concrete that looks solid but is not. He would be eating and a taste would bring a sound. He would be sleeping and a sound would bring a face. He would be walking, like now, like this, and the ground beneath his boots would feel like a different ground, a ground he had crossed in a different country for a different reason, and his hands would remember what they had held and his stomach would tighten and the walking would become something he did not with his legs but against his own body.

Three years. He was twenty-six. He had left his father's farm at twenty-three because the farm could not hold him and eight hundred dollars a month was more than the farm produced in a year. He had not left for violence. He had left for money. The violence came after. It came in slowly, then all at once, and it didn't come off. He was leaving now. He told himself it was not courage. The man in the second week, the one who said "I will not" and was beaten and said it again and was beaten again and was taken somewhere and did not come back. That was courage. Ibrahim had said nothing. For three years he had said nothing and done what was asked and sent the money home and the money paid for Awa's university and the money paid for the medicine and the money was clean in the village because nobody in the village knew where it came from and not knowing was the soap that washed it.

He was not brave. He was late. The leaving was not strength. It was the moment when the weight of staying finally exceeded the weight of the desert. The desert was eighty kilometers. The staying was the rest of his life. The math had tipped. And beneath the math, the thing he could not calculate: his father's face. What would it look like when Ibrahim walked into the compound. Not the first moment. The first moment would be joy, he knew this, the joy of a father seeing a son alive. But the second moment. The moment after. When the joy settled and the questions began and the answers had to come from behind the leaking walls and the faces behind the doors. His father had never raised his voice. His father had stopped trucks with quiet words. His father had carried a stone on his back for two kilometers because his wife deserved a marker. What would his father's quiet voice say to a son who had done things that quiet voices cannot speak about?

He did not know. He walked south and he did not know. Not knowing was heavier than the heat. He had joined because eight hundred dollars was more than the farm produced in a year. He had stayed because leaving was not offered. He was leaving now because staying any longer meant he would not recognize himself when he got home. Three years of doing what they told him to do, and the man who had left his father's farm was disappearing. If he waited any longer, there would be nothing left to bring back. He did not know if it was already too late. He would find out when he reached the compound and saw his father's face in the second moment after the joy.

By sunset he found a village. Five houses. A well. A goat pen. A woman cooking over a fire outside the last house.

He stood at the edge of the village and waited. You did not walk into a village uninvited. You stood at the edge and waited to be seen, and the seeing was the invitation. The woman looked up. She looked at him for a long time. She looked at his boots, military boots, the kind that do not come from shops, the kind that announce what the wearer has been doing the way city shoes announce what the wearer has not. She did not ask about the boots. She had seen boots like these before. The boys who went north came back in boots like these, when they came back. He held out a hundred-dollar bill. She looked at it. She looked at him.

"Water," he said. "Food. A place to sleep behind your house." She took the bill. She did not examine it. She did not bargain. She filled a yellow jerrycan from the well and set it beside the fire and went back to her cooking and the transaction was complete. Not because she was mercenary but because she understood, as every woman in every village between the camps and the border understood, that a young man in military boots offering American dollars for water and a place to sleep was a

young man who needed to not be asked questions, and not asking was a kindness she could afford. She gave him water and a bowl of rice with groundnut sauce. He sat on the ground behind her house, his back against the mud-brick wall, and he ate. The sauce was groundnut. The rice was white. The meal was simple, the kind of meal his mother had made every evening and that Sékou made now, the same proportions, the same taste, the combination of groundnut paste and salt and oil that was not a recipe but a region, a latitude, a place on the earth where this exact combination of ingredients meant home. The first bite undid him. Not the taste. The taste was familiar. What undid him was the recognition that followed the taste: the boy who had eaten this food every evening of his life, sitting on the ground in the compound with his legs crossed and his mother's voice calling from the kitchen house, that boy was gone. The boy had walked to a bus station and climbed onto a bus and crossed a border and the border had not been a line on the ground but a line inside him and he had crossed it and the boy had stayed on the other side and the man who came back was someone the boy would not have recognized.

He put the bowl down. He pressed the heels of his hands against his eyes. The burning was not tears. He had not cried in three years, the camp had cured him of crying the way it had cured him of asking and wondering and sleeping with the light off and sitting on the ground and eating with his hands and all the small human things that the camp replaced with routines and protocols and the emptiness of a man who does what he is told. But the burning was close enough to tears that his hands were wet when he took them away, and the wetness surprised him, because he had not known there was still water in him that was not rationed. He picked up the bowl. He ate the rest. He ate slowly. Each bite was the compound and the field and his mother's hands and the evening radio and Sékou's quiet breathing on the other side of the room and Awa's voice arguing with their father about something. She was always arguing, always pushing, always standing in front of something and refusing to move, his father's daughter through and through. He missed them. Below the throat, above the heart. The place where the boy who had eaten this food still lived. Small. Quiet. Waiting. The boy was still there. He had not been killed. He had been folded. Folded so tightly and pressed so far down that Ibrahim had believed, for months at a time, that the boy was gone. But the groundnut sauce had found him. The taste had reached the place where the fold was and had pressed against it and the fold had opened, just slightly, just enough to let the burning through. Going home. Unfolding slowly, carefully, the way you unfold a photograph that has been creased so many times the image is almost gone. You unfold it and the image is damaged but it is there, faded,

lined, the colors wrong, but the faces recognizable. Still there. Still the same family. Still looking at the camera, or off-frame, or at the future, or wherever they were looking on the day the photograph was taken, before any of them knew what was coming. He lay on the hard ground. The stars above him. The planting stars. The harvest stars. The Farmer's Wife in the east, right on schedule. His father's sky. He slept on the hard ground and he dreamed about rain falling on millet. The sound of rain on broad leaves, a sound like applause, his mother had said once, the earth clapping for itself. In the dream the millet was tall and the rain was heavy and his father was standing in the compound doorway watching the water and the water was reaching the roots and the roots were holding. He woke before dawn. The stars were fading. The woman was already at the fire, heating water. She did not look at him. She did not need to. He was alive. That was the information the morning required. He drank. He stood. He walked south. Toward the border that the French had drawn in 1923 through land where people had been walking back and forth for a thousand years and would walk for a thousand more, whatever the maps said.

Chapter 26

Dramane cleaned the lamp before he left. Shea butter, not kerosene. A cotton wick his wife had braided before she died. He filled the reservoir, trimmed the wick with his fingernail, and walked to the grove barefoot in the dark.

The path was six hundred meters. He had walked it ten thousand times. His feet did not need light. The lamp was not for him. It was for the trees.

He entered at the guardian tree and knelt. Kola nut, split. Millet from Ousmane's field. Water poured at the roots. The words he spoke were not in any written language. They had been taught to him by his teacher, who had learned them from his teacher, and so on back through a chain of voices older than the mosque, older than the borders, older than the name Kessara.

He set the lamp between the roots of the oldest tree and sat cross-legged on the swept ground. From his bag he took the gourd. The bark tea inside was bitter and warm, brewed from the root of a tree that grew only at the grove's eastern edge, harvested once a year, dried in the shade. His teacher had called it "the listener." Not because it made you hear things. Because it made you quiet enough to be heard.

He drank. He closed his eyes. He waited.

The grove came to him as it always did, not as a vision but as a thickening. The air grew dense. The sounds of the night receded. The insects, the wind, the distant generator in the village. They pulled back, and what was left was the sound beneath sounds. The hum of the ground. The slow breathing of roots drawing water from thirty meters below. The trees exhaling into the canopy.

Then the pictures.

His mother at the base of this tree, harvesting shea nuts, her cloth tied at the waist. Her hands moving in the branches. She was singing, a song he had not heard in forty years, and the melody arrived whole, every note. Behind her, the grove was younger. The trunks thinner. The canopy had gaps where the sky came through, and the sky was a blue he had forgotten existed.

The picture shifted. His teacher, seated where Dramane now sat, the same lamp between the same roots. Night. The teacher's lips moving. The words were the same

words Dramane spoke now. He could see them leaving his teacher's mouth and arriving at his own, the chain unbroken, the sound passing through time like water through stone. His teacher looked up. Directly at him. As if he could see forty years forward, through the dark, through the bark tea, through whatever wall separated the living from the remembered. His teacher nodded. Once. Then turned back to the offering and continued.

Then the grove emptied.

This was the part Dramane dreaded. Each time he drank the listener, the last picture was the same. The trees gone. The ground flattened. A surface he did not recognize. Gray, hard, without texture. Machines had been here. The offerings were under the surface, pressed into the earth by a weight the earth had never been asked to carry. The kola nuts and the millet and the water and the words, all of it sealed beneath something that did not breathe. He could feel the roots still reaching. Beneath the gray surface, the roots were still there, searching for water that was no longer in the right place because the water table had been cut by something deeper than roots. The roots reached and reached and found nothing and the reaching was the worst part, not the destruction but the reaching afterward, the ground still trying to grow what had been taken from it.

He opened his eyes. The lamp was guttering. The shea butter was nearly spent.

He sat in the grove for a long time after the pictures left. The sorrow was heavy, a physical thing, settled across his shoulders like wet cloth. His teacher had told him that the listener showed what was needed, not what was wanted. The destruction was coming. The tea had shown him this every time for three years, and three years was long enough to know that the pictures did not lie.

He gathered the cowrie shells from his bag. Seventeen. He did not cast them tonight. Tonight was for listening, not asking. He held them in his palm and felt their weight, smooth, old, carried by hands before his. He put them away.

He would not leave. The grove would fall and he would be standing in it when it fell. This was not courage. This was the arrangement. A custodian does not leave the thing he tends because the thing is threatened. A custodian stays. That is what the word means.

He lay on his side on the swept ground, his head on his arm, the empty lamp beside him. The trees held their canopy above him. The stars moved in the gaps between the leaves. He slept, not deeply, not well, but the sleep of a man who has seen what is coming and has chosen to rest anyway, because the morning would need him and the morning was close.

He dreamed of nothing. The listener had taken the dreams. What was left was a quiet too heavy for any dream to lift.

* * *

<div align="center">

DAY 5: THURSDAY

“The Fracture”

</div>

“If you are neutral in situations of injustice, you have chosen the side of the oppressor.” — Desmond Tutu

* * *

Chapter 27

The city woke wrong.

Fatou knew it before she left the hotel. The woman who made Nescafé at the corner stall every morning was not there. Her plastic cups were stacked. Her whisk was dry. The charcoal stove was cold. In five days, Fatou had never seen the stall closed.

The shops on the block had not opened. Not closing early, not opening at all. The metal shutters were down from the night before, padlocked, the owners having decided sometime between last evening and this morning that today was not a day for business. In a country where missing a day's sales meant missing a day's meals, the shutters were a statement. The shopkeepers knew what was coming the way farmers know weather. They had lived through rallies before. The ones closest to the vote were the ones to fear. Aminata's speech on Tuesday had drawn fifteen thousand people. Everyone knew what that meant. Not just that the No campaign had momentum, that the president had been challenged in public, by name, in his own capital. And everyone in Kessara knew what happened when you challenged the people in power. The power did not argue back. The power answered. The shutters were not closed because of the referendum. The shutters were closed because the answer was coming and the shopkeepers did not want to be standing behind their counters when it arrived. The radios were on. Every doorway, every compound gate, every parked taxi, the same voices coming from different speakers, the national station running call-ins since dawn. Fatou could hear them overlapping as she walked to the curb. A man's voice, angry: the deal was theft. A woman's voice, just as angry: the deal was survival.

The host trying to moderate and failing, because there was nothing moderate about what the country was deciding and pretending otherwise was its own kind of lie.

Two men stood outside a compound gate, arguing. They were neighbors. She could tell from how close they stood, the shared language of men who had known each other for years. But the argument had turned them rigid. One was voting Yes. One was voting No. Yesterday they had disagreed the way friends disagree, over tea, with

gestures, with room to change the subject. This morning the disagreement had hardened. She could see it in how they held their shoulders. The vote was in two days and the choice had begun, and it was turning people who shared a wall into people who could not share a conversation.

She saw the same thing at the next corner. A woman and her sister-in-law, voices rising. At a taxi rank, three drivers standing apart from a fourth, the fourth holding his phone like evidence. Moussa picked her up at seven. Both hands on the wheel. “The jakartamen are not working,” he said.

She looked. The motorbike taxi drivers who usually swarmed every intersection were gathered at a phone repair shop, eight of them around a single screen. Not talking. Just looking. “What are they watching?”

“Doesn’t matter. They’re not working. That’s the message.” They drove toward the industrial district. The Yes campaign was holding a rally at ten. Fatou had press credentials. The gendarmerie were at every intersection, sandbags, helmets, rifles on shoulders. The rifles were old. The eyes behind them were young. Three thousand people at the rally. Maybe four. Port workers. Market women. Taxi drivers. People who had done the math on their own lives, school fees, clinic costs, the price of rice, the salary that covered nine months and left three empty, and decided that a job was worth more than a word like sovereignty.

The stage was a flatbed truck. A government minister was speaking. Not Diallo, a junior minister whose job was to be loud. He was loud. He was saying “jobs” the way Aminata had said “sovereignty”, as a hammer, trusting repetition.

Counter-protesters gathered at the edge. Two or three hundred. Mostly young. No campaign signs. Chanting. The gendarmerie stood between them and the rally, a line of helmets and shields, twenty meters of pavement between two groups of people who had been neighbors last week.

Fatou was in the press area. Phone recording. Notebook in her pocket.

The rock came from the middle of the crowd.

She did not see who threw it. A dark shape crossing the space between the counter-protesters and the gendarmerie line. It hit a police shield. The gendarme stumbled. One step back. The line lost its shape for half a second.

Someone screamed. A bottle shattered on pavement. The line between the two crowds dissolved, not all at once but in sections, one breach opening the next.

Tear gas. She smelled it before she saw it. A chemical sharpness in her throat, her nostrils, the corners of her eyes. The canister hit the pavement thirty meters to her left and the white cloud moved with the wind, which was blowing toward her.

Her eyes burned. She pulled her shirt over her mouth. She kept recording. The phone was shaking but the camera was steady because she had trained this, in Khartoum, in Nairobi, the discipline of keeping the lens stable while the body behind it wanted to run. People were running. Not in one direction. The chaos of a gassed crowd, everyone following the same instinct: away.

Then the gunshot.

A single sound. Sharp. Flat. Not like the movies. Shorter. Duller. The sound that stops everything.

The entire square held still. Every body frozen. Every foot stopped. The gas still drifted but every person was motionless for a fraction of a second, the fraction of a second between hearing the sound and understanding what it meant.

Then a boy fell.

Twenty meters from her. White shirt. Empty hands, no sign, no rock, no bottle. He was nineteen. She did not know this yet. She knew only the white shirt and the stain spreading below his right collarbone, dark through the cotton.

She ran toward him. Not away. Toward. The press rope was down. The credentials were useless. If nobody records what happens, then what happened becomes whatever the most powerful person says it was.

A woman was already kneeling beside him, pressing a headscarf against the wound. The cloth was soaked. The woman was talking to him in Dioula, “Stay with me, stay, look at me”, the words arriving in a rhythm that was not speech but prayer.

Fatou knelt. She held the phone. She recorded. The boy’s face. The woman’s hands. The blood on the white shirt.

The ambulance took twenty-two minutes.

She knelt on hot pavement for twenty-two minutes. Her eyes streaming from the gas. The woman pressing harder. The boy’s breathing going shallow, rapid. His eyes on the sky.

They put him on a stretcher. His hands hung over the sides, open, empty, the fingers loose. The image that would be on every front page: a boy with nothing in his hands.

The hospital was two buildings sharing one fence. MSF on the left, three French doctors, equipment that worked, a generator that never failed. The government hospital on the right, two doctors for six hundred beds, no working X-ray since March.

Youssef Coulibaly, she learned his name from a nurse, was taken to the government side. MSF handled infectious disease. Not trauma.

Dr. Touré was on duty. Fifty-seven. He had been offered three jobs abroad this year. He stayed because someone had to. Dr. Diarra was beside him, thirty-one, trained in Bamako, the kind of young doctor who stays not from obligation but from a fury she could not yet name.

They worked on Youssouf for ninety minutes. The bullet had passed through his lung. He needed blood. The right type was in the MSF freezer across the fence, forty meters away, through a gate, across a courtyard.

Thirty-eight minutes. That was how long forty meters took when the forty meters included a gate and a sign-out sheet and a protocol and a refrigerator that required a key and a key that was in a drawer that was in an office that was locked because the doctor whose office it was had driven to Camp Bassam that morning to treat the cholera cases and had not come back.

Thirty-eight minutes. Forty meters. A locked drawer. A missing key. The deal promised to rebuild this hospital. The deal had not built it yet. The boy was dying in the system the deal was supposed to replace, and the system could not keep him alive long enough for the replacement to arrive.

Youssouf Coulibaly died at 2:43 PM. Nineteen years old. Architecture student. He wanted to build houses that ordinary people could afford. He had told his study group a month ago: “What is the point of a country if the people in it can’t afford a roof?”

Fatou was in the corridor when he died. She called her editor. “I have footage. A nineteen-year-old student was shot and killed. Gendarmerie fire during a confrontation at the Yes rally.” “The name?”

“Youssouf Coulibaly. Architecture student.”

“File everything. We’re leading with it.”

She filed. She leaned against the corridor wall.

A woman came down the corridor. Small. Wearing a dress that had been clean that morning. She was wearing house shoes, foam slippers, the kind you wear from the bedroom to the kitchen. She had gotten the call and she had left. She had not changed her shoes. She had not picked up her bag. She had walked out of her house in the shoes she was standing in when the phone rang.

She knew before anyone told her. The faces in the corridor told her. Her legs gave and a nurse caught her arm and lowered her to the bench outside the room where her son lay under a sheet. Mariame. Youssouf’s mother.

Fatou’s hand moved toward her notebook. The trained reflex, ten years of interviewing people in the worst moments of their lives. The hand knew what to do.

She stopped it. She put it in her lap.

She did not take out her phone. She did not ask a question. She sat beside her.

The corridor was quiet. The fluorescent light hummed. Outside, the city was dark and sealed. Inside, two women on a bench, one who had come to record and one who had come to collect her son, and neither of them speaking, because the thing that had happened did not have words yet and might never.

Chapter 28

Diallo heard the shot at 11:47 AM. Not the sound, the report. Koné was in the doorway within minutes.

"Shots fired at the rally site. Gendarmerie confrontation with counter-protesters."

"Casualties?"

"One down. Being transported to the hospital now."

Diallo stood. The generator hummed beneath the floor, the steady, expensive sound of a building that made its own electricity while the city rationed its own. He hardly noticed the sound most days. Today it sounded like a wall.

"Get me Colonel Diarra. Get me the minister of security. And get a screen in here."

By noon he had the video. Thirty-seven seconds. The gas. The crowd breaking. Then the sound, short, flat, a sound he had heard once before, twenty years ago, when he was a professor and the military government was in power and a different student had died in a different square.

A boy falling. White shirt. The stain.

He watched it twice. The first time, the politician processed it, crowd density, gendarmerie position, direction of fire, media exposure, the opposition's response window. The second time, the man processed it. A boy with nothing in his hands. The same age as the students Diallo had taught in lecture halls before politics found him. The same age Ibrahima had been when he left for Paris. He put the phone down carefully. The politician's hands were steady. The man's chest was tight.

"His name?"

"Youssouf Coulibaly. Nineteen. Architecture student."

Architecture. A boy who wanted to build things. Shot at a rally for a deal that was supposed to build things.

At 12:40, the first hospital update. Koné reading from his phone, the information arriving from Colonel Diarra's people at the scene. "He's at the government hospital. Two doctors working on him. Bullet passed through the lung. They need compatible blood." "MSF is next door."

"MSF handles infectious disease. Not trauma. The compatible units are in the MSF freezer, forty meters from the operating room. But the office with the refrigerator key is locked. The doctor whose office it is drove to Camp Bassam this morning to treat the cholera cases. He hasn't come back."

Diallo stopped moving. Camp Bassam. Seven cholera cases. He had read that number in this morning's intelligence briefing. The same briefing that reported the displacement camps at three hundred percent capacity. The same system, stretched in every direction at once. The cholera doctor was saving lives at the camp. The blood was behind his locked door. And a boy was bleeding on a table forty meters away because there were not enough doctors and not enough keys and not enough of anything in a country that had been running on not-enough for so long that not-enough had become the infrastructure.

This was the system. This was what the deal was supposed to fix. And this was why he had called the referendum, because he had promised Mariama he would fix this. Four years ago, from the door of the helicopter that carried her to Paris because this hospital could not tell him what was killing her. Was he fixing it? The CT scanner was still broken. The boy was still on the table.

At 1:15, an update. They were trying to reach the MSF administrator for an override key. The boy was still alive. Still on the table.

"Why didn't they break the damn door down?"

Koné said nothing. The outburst hung in the room. Diallo heard himself, heard the man's voice coming out of the politician's mouth in a building where doors were never broken down because protocol was the only thing holding the building together. The deal would create money to repair a broken door. But the boy on the table was not something money could repair.

Diallo stood at the window. The cranes. The ocean. The presidential residence had been built to face the water because the water was calm. He was beginning to understand that the view was the problem, that a man who looked at the ocean long enough could forget that the city behind him was on fire. The generator hummed. His building made its own air, its own light, its own temperature. An island in the same city where a boy was dying for want of a key. At 1:38, the blood arrived. Thirty-eight minutes for forty meters. At 1:50, Koné again. "He's in surgery. Critical. They're working." Diallo called the emergency cabinet for three o'clock. Then he sat at his desk and did not read the procurement reports and did not look at the ocean and did not do anything except wait, because waiting was the thing the presidency required most often and prepared you for least.

At 2:47, Koné came back. He did not need to speak. His face had already delivered the report.

"He's gone?"

"Yes, Mr. President. 2:43."

Diallo closed his eyes. For the first time all day he let the man sit alone without the politician standing over him. A boy had just died in the hospital his wife had nearly died in. The system that killed the boy was the system the deal was supposed to replace. The deal was the reason the boy was at the rally. The rally was the reason the gendarmerie were in the square. And the referendum was the current that had carried all of them, the boy, the gendarme, the rock, the gas, the bullet, the locked door, to this point. Diallo could no more stop it now than a man caught in a riptide could stop the ocean.

He opened his eyes.

The cabinet room was cold. Fourteen ministers entered a temperature that did not let them settle.

The minister of security defended the gendarmerie. Rocks. Bottles. Protocol.

"A warning shot," the minister said. "That went wrong." "A warning shot does not hit someone in the chest," Diallo said. The room went quiet. The quiet of men who knew what was true and did not want it said aloud, because saying it moved the conversation from "tragic accident" to "accountability," and accountability was a room nobody wanted to enter two days before a vote.

The minister of justice demanded an investigation. The minister of information wanted to control the story. The minister of health delivered the numbers, two doctors for six hundred beds, no X-ray since March, compatible blood forty meters away behind a locked door, thirty-eight minutes, a key at Camp Bassam because the doctor who held it was treating cholera. Because the displacement camps were overflowing. Because the drought had broken the north. Because the north had been underfunded for twenty years. Because the money was servicing the debt. Because the debt was the reason the deal was on the table. The minister did not draw the chain. He did not need to. Everyone in the room could see it. Asante spoke last. He did not mention the boy.

"Fifty-two days, Mr. President."

"Not now, Kofi."

"The market will react. If international coverage frames this as instability."

"A boy is dead, Kofi."

Asante stopped. His hands, which had been reaching for the single sheet of paper he always carried, returned to the table. In four years, Diallo had never stopped Asante

from speaking. Stopping was the man breaking through the politician's surface, just for a moment, like bone through skin.

The meeting ran until midnight. He issued a statement at ten. "Profound sorrow." An investigation ordered. He knew what the investigation would find. Too many accounts. Not enough evidence. No one charged. He ordered it anyway, because ordering it was the minimum a government owed a citizen it had failed to protect. After midnight. The building empty except for the generator and the guards.

He looked at the photograph on the shelf. Mariama. Her hand on his arm at the inauguration. "Now the real work."

The deal was supposed to be the real work. And the deal had pulled a nineteen-year-old architecture student into a square where the gendarmerie were waiting, and the current that Diallo had set in motion when he called the referendum had carried them all past the point where swimming mattered. The current was still pulling. Two days until the vote. A boy under a sheet. A bond payment in fifty-two days. And no way to swim against what he had started. He sat in the dark. The generator hummed beneath him.

Somewhere in the city, candles were burning in a courtyard where people had gathered because gathering was the only thing they could do.

He did not know if the referendum could still hold what was now inside it. He sat in the dark and he did not know.

Chapter 29

Aminata heard the news from Oumar, who called and said it flat: "A student. Shot at the Yes rally. Dead. Gendarmerie fire." She asked for the name. She asked for the age. She hung up. She went to the bathroom and vomited.

The lock didn't work. The light was a bare bulb. She knelt on the tile and her body emptied itself, and emptying was not strategy. It was the body remembering Moussa. Student. Shot. Dead. The words were twenty-eight years old. Her body recognized the combination before her mind could catch up.

She washed her face. Warm water, cracked mirror. Forty-five years old, eyes red, water on her chin. She looked at herself and saw a woman who had built a career on the principle that the state should account for its violence, and who had put people in the square where the violence happened. Her rally. Her words. Her language of sovereignty and resistance, handed to fifteen thousand people who carried it into a confrontation with armed gendarmes. She did not pull the trigger. She knew this. The knowledge was precise and useless. She had not fired the gun. She had filled the square. And the square had produced a body.

She went back to her office. She closed the door. She sat at the desk.

She tried to write a press release. The template was on her desktop. She typed: The DFA condemns in the strongest possible terms the disproportionate use of force by the Kessaran National Gendarmerie... She stopped. "Strongest possible terms." "Disproportionate use of force." The correct words. The words every opposition party uses when the state kills a citizen. She had written these words at The Hague, in reports that were filed and catalogued and read by people in Geneva who nodded and moved to the next file. Professionally adequate. Humanly empty.

She deleted the sentence. She closed the template.

She opened a blank document and wrote the thing the template could not hold.

She wrote his name. Youssouf Coulibaly. Nineteen. Architecture. She wrote that he wanted to build houses ordinary people could afford. She wrote: "He went to a rally because he believed that showing up matters. He is dead because someone fired a gun and the bullet went where bullets go."

She wrote about the square. No "disproportionate." No "condemn." Just what happened in the order it happened, the gas, the rock, the running, the sound. The order was the argument. She wrote for forty minutes. Twelve hundred words. A speech, not a statement. Every sentence true. Every sentence landing where she aimed it.

Then she read it back.

The speech was the best thing she had ever written. And reading it made her feel dirty.

Not because it was dishonest. Every word was real. The grief was real. But the grief was also useful, and she could feel herself using it, shaping the sentences, choosing which details to lead with, knowing that Youssef's age and his ambition and the white shirt would move the polls four to six points toward No. She knew this the way a lawyer knows a verdict before the judge reads it. The evidence was the evidence. The speech would do what speeches do. And a boy who wanted to build houses would become the vehicle for her campaign's final argument.

She sat with that. The grief and the calculation, sharing the same body. Both real. Neither canceling the other. This was the precise knowledge that politics teaches you and that no training prepares you for: that you can mourn someone and use their death in the same hour, and the mourning does not make the using clean, and the using does not make the mourning false.

Nobody comes out clean. That was the lesson of every political system she had ever studied, every courtroom she had ever sat in, every campaign she had ever run. The system is polluted. You work inside it because the alternative is leaving it to the people who polluted it. But working inside it means your hands get dirty too, and the dirt does not wash off with good intentions, and the woman in the cracked mirror knows this and the woman at the desk knows this and they are the same woman and she is writing a speech about a dead boy and the speech is going to work.

Her phone buzzed. Derek. The Foundation wants to offer additional media support. International press coordination. A boy was dead and the Foundation was offering to help her manage the coverage. She did not reply. She put the phone face-down on the desk.

She thought about Moussa. Not the photograph. She did not need to open the drawer tonight. She needed the absence. The chair at the table that was never removed.

Moussa would have been in the square today. Not on the stage, on the ground. He would have been near the edge of the crowd, where the trouble was, because Moussa always went to the edge. He might have been standing near Youssef. He might have

been wearing a blue shirt.

Twenty-eight years between her brother and this boy. Different governments, same grief. A young man who went somewhere and did not come back. A family that would sit at a table tonight and look at an empty place.

She closed the laptop. The office went dark. She sat in the dark and did not cry. She had cried for Moussa twenty-eight years ago and crying had not brought him back. Not crying was not strength. It was exhaustion. She had used up her crying on a previous boy in a previous decade and did not have enough left for this one. She put the speech in her bag. She went home.

Hawa was asleep. Twelve years old. Breathing softly, the covers at her chin, one foot sticking out. Aminata stood in the doorway and watched her daughter sleep.

She did not wake her. She went to the kitchen. She drank a glass of water. She washed the glass. She put it on the rack. She went to bed.

Tomorrow she would deliver the speech. She would mean every word. And the meaning and the use of it would sit together in her chest, and neither one would be false, and neither one would be clean.

Chapter 30

Ousmane heard the news on the evening radio. He was in the compound. The day's work was done, the weeding, the water, the checking of the millet that was shorter every morning and drier every afternoon. Sékou was cooking.

The pot on the fire, the wooden spoon, the smell of groundnut paste that had been the smell of this compound for as long as the compound had existed. The radio was on the shelf inside the doorway, turned low, the evening news. A voice Ousmane had been listening to for fifteen years, a man who read the news the way farmers read weather, noting the changes, reporting the pressure, keeping his own opinions below the surface.

Tonight the voice was different. Tight. Controlled, but only just. A student shot in Port Sélani. A rally. Tear gas. Gendarmerie fire. The details came in pieces. The host reading from reports that were still being confirmed, the language careful, the caution of a man who understood that getting the story wrong was worse than getting it late. A nineteen-year-old. Architecture student. Shot below the collarbone. Died at the hospital.

Ousmane stood in the compound doorway. Sékou was beside him. They listened together, without discussion, without arranging themselves, two men standing in a doorway because the doorway was where the news had stopped them.

A boy. Nineteen. The age Ibrahim had been when he finished secondary school and worked the farm for a year and then walked to the bus station with a bag.

The radio host read the name. Youssouf Coulibaly. Ousmane did not know the name. But the name sounded like every name in

Kessara, familiar, common, the name of someone's son, someone's grandson, someone's student, the kind of name you heard shouted across a market or called from a compound door at dusk. A name that belonged to a living person that morning and belonged to a dead person now.

"Sékou."

"Yes, Papa."

“Go check if Amadou’s radio is on. He may not have heard.” Sékou went. Ousmane reached for the phone. He called Awa. The phone rang. Each ring was a year of his life.

One. Two. Three. Four. Five.

Six.

“Papa.”

“Are you safe?”

“I’m safe. I wasn’t there. I was at the university.”

His hand found the doorframe. He held it. The wood was rough under his palm, the same wood, the same doorframe, the same hand. The hand stopped shaking because the doorframe held it, and the doorframe held because his father had built it from timber that was stronger than what a hand could break.

“Don’t go to any more rallies.”

“Papa...”

“Awa. Please.”

Quiet on the line. Not the quiet of obedience, the quiet of a daughter deciding how much truth her father’s voice can carry tonight. She had learned this from her mother. The measured quiet. The weighing.

“I knew him, Papa. Youssouf. He was in my study group. He wanted to be an architect.” Her voice changed, not breaking but thinning, the sound of a voice that was carrying more than its thickness allowed. “He wanted to build houses for people who couldn’t,” She stopped. She put the voice back together the way she put everything back together, fast, before anyone could see the seam. “He wanted to build affordable houses.”

“Come home.”

“I can’t come home.”

“Come home, Awa.”

“If I come home now, they win. Whoever fired that gun, whoever put those gendarmes in that square with those rifles, they win. They win if we all go home.”

He wanted to tell her that winning and losing were words for politicians and campaign offices and radio call-in shows, and she was his daughter, and daughters were not supposed to stand in squares where rifles were pointed, but she was his daughter and he could not argue her out of her conviction any more than she could argue him out of his fear. They were both right. Being right was not the same as being safe. “Be careful.”

“I will.”

She hung up. He stood in the doorway. The stars were out. The radio was still talking. The host now reading reactions, the opposition statement, the government's response, the voices running together, except tonight every voice was talking about the same boy.

The compound was quiet after the call. Sékou came back. Amadou had heard, Amadou's wife was praying, the village was absorbing the news as villages always do: slowly, at a distance, with the settled skepticism of people who have learned that the capital produces noise and the noise does not always reach the ground. But this noise had weight. A boy. Nineteen. A student. The village had sent its own students to Port Sélani, Awa, and before her, three others from the next compound, and a girl from Amadou's family who was studying nursing. The capital held their children. The capital was supposed to be the place where the children went to become what the village could not make them. Tonight the capital had killed one of them.

Sékou washed the dinner bowls. The scraping of the spoon against the pot. The water against the metal. The sounds of a compound that continued because compounds continue, the fire burns down, the bowls are washed, the radio is turned off, and the silence of the evening arrives whether the evening deserves silence or not.

Ousmane walked to the baobab.

The field was dark. The moon was not up yet. It would rise late tonight, past midnight. He walked by feel, the path in his feet, the steps uncounted because his feet and the ground knew each other too well for numbers. The air smelled of dry millet and the faint chemical sharpness of diesel, not from the field but from the road, the junction, where the trucks that had been coming and going all week were parked at the staging area. Equipment. Machines. The advance guard of the thing the vote was supposed to decide. He reached the tree. He put his hand on the bark. Warm from the day. Rough under his palm. The tree was the same tree it had been this morning and the morning before and every morning since his grandfather placed the seedling in the earth. He needed the sameness tonight, because everything else was different, the radio, the news, the daughter in a city where students were shot, the son in a desert where soldiers were hunted. The tree did not change. And its constancy was an answer to a question he had not asked. At the edge of the field, the survey flags were visible. Not by color. The orange was invisible in the dark. By shape. Small vertical lines against the horizontal ground, catching the starlight. A row of small, patient claims marching through his field toward the escarpment.

He stood under the tree and looked at the flags and thought about the boy. Youssouf.

Architecture. Houses that people could afford. Nineteen years old. The same age Ibrahim had been when he left. The same age Awa had been when she arrived at the university and started standing in front of rooms and refusing to move. Nineteen was the age when Kessara either kept its children or lost them, and the keeping and the losing happened in the same year, sometimes in the same week, and the country did not know which one it was doing until the year was over and the count was taken.

At eleven-forty, the phone rang.

He was on the bench. The kerosene lamp was out. The stars were bright. The chirp cut the compound silence the way it had cut it three days ago, a sound that did not belong, a sound from a machine that carried voices across distances the human voice was not built to cross.

“Papa.”

Ibrahim. But different from three days ago. The strain was still there but beneath it, something else. Movement. Wind. The sound of a man who was not sitting still but walking, or riding, or being carried across the ground.

“Ibrahim. Where are you?”

“I’m out, Papa. I left. I’m across the first border. Moving south.” The words entered Ousmane’s body and landed in a different place from where the last call’s words had landed. The last call had landed below the ribs, in the place where grief and fear share a room. This call landed higher, in the chest, behind the sternum, in the place where the body holds the things it is afraid to believe. “Are you hurt?”

“No. Tired. I walked, I don’t know how far. Two days. A woman gave me food. A truck driver gave me a ride. I’m in a town. I’m using a phone at a market stall.”

A woman gave him food. A truck driver gave him a ride. The ordinary kindness of strangers on a road, the same kindness that had existed on every road in West Africa since before the borders were drawn, the kindness of people who saw a young man walking and did not ask where he was coming from because asking would have required an answer and the answer was not their business. “Ibrahim. Come home.”

“I’m coming, Papa. Two days. Maybe three. I need to cross the border into Kessara and find a road south.”

“The border at the Kounda crossing. You know it. We went there when you were small. Your mother bought cloth.”

“I remember.”

“Cross there. The road south goes through the junction. From the junction, walk west. You know the path.”

“I know the path.”

Quiet. The connection holding. The satellite overhead, carrying the silence between a father and a son who were both alive and both afraid and both trying to say what neither of them had words for. “Papa. I heard about the shooting. On the radio at the market. The student.”

“Yes.”

“Is Awa...”

“Awa is safe.”

“Papa. Is it going to get worse?”

Ousmane looked at the stars. The planting stars. The harvest stars. The stars that his father had used to navigate and that Ibrahim had used to walk through the desert two nights ago, the same stars, the same sky, seen from different kinds of darkness. “I don’t know, Ibrahim. Come home.”

“I’m coming.”

The line held for another moment. Then it cut, not the sudden death of three days ago but a thinning, the voice fading, the connection thinning, then gone.

Ousmane held the phone. The phone was warm. The warmth was his son’s voice, still in the circuits, still traveling, still reaching toward him through the dark.

Sékou was standing behind him. The satellite chirp had brought him out. “Ibrahim?”

“He’s coming home.”

Sékou said nothing. He stood beside Ousmane under the tree. The word “home” was enough.

Two children. One in a city where students were being shot. One crossing a country where soldiers were being hunted. And here, between them, a man under a tree, holding a warm phone, standing on ground that did not know about referendums or bond payments or the price of coltan, ground that knew only what had been planted in it and what had grown and what had been buried and what was coming.

The radio was off. The lamp was off. The compound was dark. The stars turned. And Ousmane stood under the tree that his grandfather had planted and held a phone that held the warmth of his son’s voice and waited for a morning that, for the first time in five days, he wanted to see.

Chapter 31

Awa organized the vigil in four hours.

Phone calls. The MJS group chat, fifty-two people now, the original group from the meeting four days ago, minus two who had gone home to the corridor, plus eleven who had joined since the leak. She typed with her thumbs, standing in the dormitory hallway, her back against the wall, the concrete cool through her shirt. She typed the way she spoke, short sentences, no wasted words, the instructions clear enough that the person receiving them could act without calling back.

Vigil tonight. Hospital courtyard. 8 PM. Bring candles. Bring photographs. Do not bring signs. This is not a rally. This is a name. Ibrahima Sow, logistics, buses, the machinery of protest, called back in three minutes.

“The hospital courtyard is public space. We don’t need a permit.”

“Get one anyway. If they arrest us, I want them arresting us with a permit in my hand.”

“Awa, it’s six PM. The permit office closed at four.”

“The district administrator is Pastor Koné’s cousin. Call Pastor Koné. He’ll call his cousin. His cousin will write the permit on his kitchen table and stamp it with the district seal he keeps in his briefcase. I’ve seen the briefcase. The seal is in the front pocket.” A pause. Then: “How do you know what’s in the district administrator’s briefcase?”

“Because I pay attention, Ibrahima. Call him.”

The seal. A piece of carved rubber in the front pocket of a man’s briefcase. The entire legal difference between a prayer vigil and an illegal gathering, between four thousand people mourning in peace and four thousand people being dispersed with tear gas, was a circle of rubber pressed into ink pressed into paper on a kitchen table. The system was absurd. The system was also the only thing between them and the batons, and tonight that was enough.

She called the copy shop, the owner whose nephew was in the movement. He stayed open past closing. She sent him the photographs, Youssouf’s face, pulled from his social media, the graduation picture where he wore a tie for the first time and

looked like he was trying not to laugh. She ordered five hundred copies. The owner said he could do three hundred by seven-thirty. She said five hundred by seven-forty-five. He said he would try. She said she would come get them at seven-forty-five and the attempt would be done by then.

She called the pastor whose church was near the campus. He opened his generator for the sound system. She called Aïssata from the women's caucus, who called the women's network, who called the market women, who called their daughters, and the chain moved through the city in minutes, through channels that no government and no campaign and no intelligence service could map because the channels were not channels.

They were friendships. They were the woman who sold you tomatoes calling the woman who braided your hair calling the woman whose daughter was in your study group. The infrastructure of women who talked to other women, and the infrastructure was invisible, and nobody had ever considered it worth mapping, which was why it worked.

By seven-forty-five, Awa had a permit, a sound system, four hundred and sixty-three photographs, the copy shop owner had run out of toner for the last thirty-seven, a courtyard, and the beginnings of a crowd.

By eight PM, two thousand people stood in the courtyard of the hospital where Youssouf had died. By nine, four thousand. They came with candles, the cheap kind, sold at the market for fifty francs, the kind that burned for two hours and dripped wax on your hand.

They came with the photographs from the copy shop, Youssouf's face, the graduation picture, the tie, the smile that was trying not to laugh. They carried the photographs the way you carry a picture of someone you love, in front of them, face out, the image speaking for the person who could no longer speak for himself. The gendarmerie watched from the street. A line of helmets. A line of shields. The same formation, the same rifles, the same boots that had been in the square that afternoon. They did not enter the courtyard. Someone in the command structure had made the one correct decision of the day: do not give the crowd a second reason to be here.

The candles made the courtyard glow. Four thousand small flames in the dark. The power was out in this district, the generators silent, and the candles were the only light. The flames moved in the slight breeze, each one flickering at its own rhythm, and the combined effect was a surface of light that breathed, that pulsed, that was alive in the way that four thousand people holding fire in the dark are alive, not as individuals but as a single act of insistence. We are here. We remember. We will not

go home. Awa stood on a low wall at the edge of the courtyard. No microphone. The sound system was behind her, but she did not use it. Her voice was her voice and her voice was enough and the four thousand people who had come to this courtyard had come to hear a human being speak, not a speaker system.

She did not talk about the referendum. She did not talk about sovereignty or the deal or the CFA franc or the minerals or Article 7 or Article 12 or the resettlement committee or the bond payment or the fifty-two days or the twelve billion dollars. She talked about Youssouf.

“His name was Youssouf Coulibaly. He was nineteen. He was from the Médina. His mother’s name is Mariame.”

Four thousand people breathing and not speaking. The candles flickering. The hospital behind them, lit by its own generators, the windows yellow rectangles in the dark building, the rooms inside still working, Dr. Touré still on duty, Dr. Diarra still beside him, the system that had failed Youssouf still functioning because functioning was all it could do.

“He was studying architecture because he wanted to build houses that people could afford to live in. He told me this in our study group last month. He said: ‘Awa, what is the point of a country if the people in it can’t afford a roof?’”

She stopped. She looked at the candles. Thousands of them. Small, flickering, cheap, each one held by a hand that had paid fifty francs for the right to stand in the dark and remember a boy. “Youssouf stood in that square like a candle. Like the ones you are holding now. He was there because he believed his presence mattered. A gendarme, following orders from leaders who were not even in the square, decided that candle was a threat. He pulled the trigger and extinguished it. But look around you. You cannot put out one candle and get darkness. You get hundreds more.”

Her voice cracked. She let it crack. She did not smooth it or recover or perform strength.

She was twenty-two years old and her friend was dead and the crack in her voice was the truest sound anyone in the courtyard had heard all day, truer than the radio hosts, truer than the government’s statement of “profound sorrow,” truer than the opposition’s press release. The crack was not weakness. The crack was what honest sounded like.

“I am not going to tell you what to think about the referendum. I am not going to tell you how to vote. I am going to tell you his name. Youssouf Coulibaly. Say it.”

Four thousand voices. “Youssouf Coulibaly.”

“Again.”

“Youssef Coulibaly.”

The name filled the courtyard and spilled over the walls and reached the gendarmerie line and the gendarmes heard it and did not move. The name reached the hospital windows and the doctors heard it and continued working. The name reached the street and the shuttered shops and the dark houses and the people inside who had not come to the vigil heard it through their walls and their closed shutters and their fear. “Don’t forget it. Don’t let anyone turn it into a statistic or a headline or a talking point or a campaign slogan. He had a name. He had a mother. He had a plan. He wanted to build something. Remember that. When they ask you to vote on Saturday, for or against, yes or no, this side or that side, remember that a boy who wanted to build houses is not here to vote. Remember his name. That is all I am asking. Remember his name.” She stepped down from the wall. Someone caught her arm because her legs were shaking, the shaking that arrives after the voice has done its work and the body finally admits what it cost. The candles flickered in the courtyard. The gendarmerie stood at the perimeter and did not move.

After the vigil, she walked toward the campus with three friends. The streets were dark.

Power out across the district. Their phone flashlights made small circles on the pavement, four white discs moving through the darkness, the only light on the street.

A car passed slowly. White sedan. No plates she could see, or plates she could not read in the dark, which amounted to the same thing. The car went past them, slowed, stopped a hundred meters ahead, and idled. The engine running. The taillights red in the darkness.

Then it pulled away.

Mariama, not Youssef’s mother, a different Mariama, the name was common in Kessara, grabbed Awa’s arm. “Did you see that?”

“I saw it.”

“Awa.”

“I saw it.”

They walked faster. The car did not come back. But the car had been there. And Awa had been living with that kind of attention since Sunday, when the first message arrived: We know where you live.

She thought about Ibrahim. Her brother who went north and could not leave. She was here, in the south, and they were telling her to go. The same country, the same system, applied in opposite directions: it took the ones who tried to leave and it followed the ones who tried to stay. Ibrahim was running south toward the border.

Awa was walking north toward the dormitory. Both moving through the dark. Both being watched. At the dormitory, her key card worked. The lock clicked. The door opened. The desk chair was at a different angle. Pulled out, not pushed in. The way it was when someone had been sitting in it, someone who was not her, someone who had entered her room with a key that was not her key, and had sat at her desk and looked at her papers and her laptop and her books. They had left the chair pulled out either because they were careless or because they wanted her to know.

Her papers were there. Her laptop was there. Nothing missing. But someone had been in the room. She could tell the way you can tell when a person has been in your house, not by what's gone but by what's moved. The air itself had been rearranged.

She locked the door. She pushed the desk chair under the handle, the back of the chair wedged beneath the door handle, a barricade that would not stop a determined entry but would make noise, and the noise was the warning, and the warning was all she had.

She lay on the bed. Clothes on. Phone charging. The screen the only light.

She did not sleep. She lay in the dark and listened to the building, the footsteps in the hallway, the doors opening and closing, the sounds of a dormitory full of students who were sleeping and studying and arguing and living inside the same ordinary evening, except that for Awa the ordinary had ended the moment she stood on that wall.

She was not afraid.

Her friend was dead. Someone had been in her room. A car with no plates had followed her through the dark. She was lying on a bed with a chair under the door handle and the light of a phone screen on her face, and she was not afraid.

She kept telling herself this. It had been easy on Sunday, when the threat was five words on a screen. Tonight the threat had a car and a key and a chair at the wrong angle, and the telling took more effort than it had four days ago. She would not admit this to anyone, not to her father, not to her friends, not to the four thousand people who had said a name because she asked them to.

Her hands would not stop shaking. Her jaw would not unclench. The chair under the door handle was not enough and she knew it. Four thousand people had placed their grief on her tonight and she had held, but holding had cost her, and in the dark she could feel exactly how much.

Two days until the vote. A country that had just killed one of its own children for the crime of showing up. And a twenty-two-year-old in a locked room, trying to hold steady.

Chapter 32

Sokolov received the situation report at ten PM and read it at the desk with the curtains drawn.

The hotel room was dark except for the laptop screen. The air conditioning ran at a temperature he had set on Sunday and had not adjusted since, because it was cold enough and Sokolov did not adjust things that were cold enough. The room smelled of nothing. He preferred rooms that smelled of nothing. Smell told you things he did not want to know, cleaning products, previous occupants, the must of a building aging in tropical heat.

The situation report was from Touré. Three paragraphs. Captain Touré wrote the way he spoke, carefully, neutrally, with the trained precision of a man who understood that the written word was evidence and evidence was permanent. The paragraphs contained: the shooting (gendarmerie fire, one fatality, student, nineteen), the government response (investigation ordered, statement issued), and the street situation (protests forming at hospital, crowd estimated at three to four thousand, gendarmerie perimeter holding). Three paragraphs. One dead. Three to four thousand in the street.

Sokolov read the numbers as he always did: as positions on a map he had been building for six months, Kessara's stability, its pressure points, the places where the ground would crack first. He had predicted the crack. In his operational model, a document on his encrypted laptop that nobody would ever read, he had written: Probability of civil unrest incident prior to referendum: 74%. Optimal timing for maximum contract leverage: 48-72 hours before vote.

The shooting had occurred fifty-one hours before the vote. Within the optimal window. The model held.

He did not feel satisfaction. Satisfaction was an emotion. Sokolov did not trade in emotions. He felt confirmation. The storm had arrived on schedule.

He opened the personnel database. Ibrahim Traoré's file. The camp commander had updated the status eight hours ago: Failed to report for morning detail. Absent 72 hours. Status: presumed desertion.

Seventy-two hours. Three days. The standard protocol for desertion was a forty-eight-hour monitoring window, after which the file was flagged and the regional asset was notified. Ibrahim Traoré had passed the window. His file was flagged. The regional asset, van der Merwe, had been notified.

Sokolov typed a single update: No pursuit. Write off.

Replacement recruit authorized.

One recruit. In seven countries of operations, three thousand personnel, the loss of one twenty-six-year-old Kessaran farmer's son registered as a line adjustment in a staffing model. Ibrahim Traoré would go home to his father's farm. He would carry whatever he carried. He would not talk about it because the men who left never did. Their shame was more effective than any contract. The Granite Group did not need non-disclosure agreements. The men silenced themselves.

He closed the file.

He stood at the window. He pulled the curtain aside, one hand, a narrow gap, enough to see without being seen. The habit of a man who had spent twenty-three years looking at the world through gaps.

Below, the city was dark. Power out across the district. But the hospital courtyard was lit, not by electricity but by fire. Thousands of candles. Small flames. The crowd was visible as a field of light in the blackout, the individual flames merging into a single luminous surface that pulsed with the movement of the people holding them.

He watched the candles the way he had watched the mosque on Sunday morning, as logistics. The crowd was organized. The perimeter was holding. Someone down there was running the operation, the sound system, the speakers, the flow of people in and out. He had read about the student organizer in Touré's report. A woman. Twenty-two. She had spoken without a microphone and four thousand people had repeated a name.

He respected the logistics. He noted the organizer's efficiency. He filed both observations in the part of his mind that sorted people into two columns: useful or not. The woman was capable. The crowd was disciplined. These were facts. What the facts meant depended on who was buying.

The candles flickered. Four thousand small flames held by four thousand hands in the dark. From seven floors up, through a gap in a curtain, the vigil looked like a city seen from an aircraft at night, a cluster of light in a vast darkness, beautiful and distant and entirely separate from the room where he stood.

He let the curtain fall.

He took out the folding knife. Carbon steel. Worn handle. He sat at the desk and cleaned his fingernails. Left hand first, then right. One finger at a time. The blade moving in small, precise strokes beneath each nail. The morning ritual performed at night, because the day had gone as planned.

Tomorrow the country would mourn. The day after, the country would vote. The vote would produce a result. The result would produce a reaction. The reaction would produce a contract. The sequence did not require his belief or his participation. It required only that he be in the right place when the contract came, and contracts always came after cracks. This one was fifty-one hours old and deepening.

He finished his fingernails. He closed the knife. He placed it on the nightstand beside his phone. He set the alarm for five AM. He slept. Eight hours. The same eight hours he slept every night, in every country, in every room. The candles burned in the courtyard below. The crowd did not go home. And the man in the room on the seventh floor slept completely, efficiently, without dreaming.

Chapter 33

Ambassador James Hartley poured himself a glass of Macallan and sat at the secure terminal to write a cable he did not want to write. The twelve-year, not the eighteen. He kept the eighteen for good news, a treaty signed, a hostage released, his daughter's wedding. The twelve was for nights like this. Sorrow always meant he drank more, and drinking more of the eighteen felt like waste. He was a fifty-seven-year-old man who had spent thirty of those years as a career diplomat, twenty-five of them in Africa. Georgetown education, fluent French, four African postings, two Middle Eastern, one South American. He was good at his job. His job was to observe, report, and recommend, in that order, never reversed, and tonight all three verbs felt heavier than usual. The study was in the ambassador's residence, a colonial house behind walls and a marine guard post. Built in 1947 by a French administrator who planted bougainvillea along the veranda. The Americans kept the ceiling fans running. The wood paneling had been shipped from Lyon. Hartley sat in a room built by men who came to extract and called it civilization, and he was about to write a cable that would serve the same purpose in different language. He opened the terminal. Green text on black screen. The cursor blinked.

He typed the header: SUBJECT: KESSARA, POST-INCIDENT ASSESSMENT AND REFERENDUM OUTLOOK CLASSIFICATION: SECRET/NOFORN He drank. The Macallan was warm going down. At fifty-seven he was starting to feel the weight of his words differently. Not the craft of them. The craft was automatic after thirty years. The weight. A boy had been shot today. Nineteen years old. Architecture student. White shirt.

White shirt. His nephew Tyler in Tempe, Arizona wore white t-shirts every day, said it was the only way to survive the heat. Tyler was twenty. Close enough. What if it had been Tyler standing in a square when someone with a rifle decided he was a threat? Could Hartley sit in a study with a glass of Scotch and type "lethal incident" if the boy under the sheet looked like his sister's son? He put the glass down. He picked it up again.

The job description he'd been given, not the formal one from State, but the real one, delivered over lunch by the undersecretary who'd recommended him for the post, had been three sentences: Advance the strategic interests of the United States of America. That means mineral procurement. Find a way to reduce our dependence on the Chinese monopoly on rare earths.

Three sentences. Twenty-five years of postings reduced to one lunch and three sentences. The Bassam Corridor contained deposits that could reshape the global supply chain. The Chinese deal would lock them up for ninety-nine years. Washington did not care whether Kessara voted Yes or No. Washington cared about access. The cable's job was to explain how America got access regardless of the outcome.

He typed.

1. SITUATION SUMMARY: On [date], one civilian fatality resulted from a security force response during a pro-government rally in the industrial district of Port Sélani. The deceased, a 19-year-old male university student, was struck by a single round during a confrontation between rally attendees and opposition counter-protesters. The Kessaran National Gendarmerie has characterized the discharge as accidental. An investigation has been ordered by the President.

He looked at it. "One civilian fatality resulted from", not "a gendarme shot a student." "Security force response", not "a man with a rifle fired into a crowd." He had typed "killing" in the first draft. He watched the word sit on the screen for three blinks of the cursor, then pressed backspace seven times and replaced it with "lethal incident."

He typed the scenarios.

2. SCENARIO ANALYSIS: SCENARIO A (YES prevails): Recommend continued engagement to shape deal implementation. Pursue bilateral mineral access within SEZ framework. SCENARIO B (NO prevails): Recommend immediate bilateral discussions on critical mineral access. Position successor development programs in Bassam Corridor. SCENARIO C (Referendum postponed): Recommend public support for postponement as "responsible governance." Use delay to advance mineral access before Chinese renegotiation.

Three scenarios. In each one, the word "mineral" appeared. In none of them did the word "sovereignty" appear. He had not deleted it. He had not considered it. Sovereignty was the word the Kessarans used. The cable used "access."

He typed the final section.

3. COMMENT: Regardless of referendum outcome, USG strategic interest in Bassam Corridor mineral deposits remains paramount. Current instability, while

regrettable, does not alter the fundamental assessment that engagement with the winning coalition is the optimal path to securing critical mineral access. He changed "regrettable" to "concerning." He changed it back. "Concerning" might trigger a human-rights inquiry from a desk officer in Washington, and a human-rights inquiry would slow the mineral discussion. "Regrettable" expressed the minimum acknowledgment of a death without opening a door he could not close.

He left "regrettable."

He encrypted the cable and pressed Send. The green progress bar crossed the screen. The words he had chosen would travel through encrypted channels to a server in Virginia, to a desk where a junior analyst would summarize them for a senior analyst who would summarize the summary for a director who would glance at the subject line, say "Kessara," and move to the next file. MESSAGE SENT.

The training and the routine had written the cable once he got past the block. They always did. Thirty years of practice meant the language assembled itself, the passive constructions, the strategic frameworks, the careful absence of anything that could not be defended in a hearing. The machine worked. It always worked. He poured himself one more glass. The twelve-year. He settled back into the leather chair and read the cable again from the top. One civilian fatality. Regrettable. Mineral access paramount. A boy who wanted to build houses, converted into three scenarios and a recommendation. Tyler in Tempe wore the same white shirts. Tyler wanted to be an engineer. Tyler and Youssouf were separated by the town they were born in and the passport they carried. That was all. And men like Hartley spent their careers making the Tylers of the world safe, knowing that the cost of that safety was a system that treated the Youssoufs as expendable. He had known this for twenty-five years. Tonight the knowing sat differently.

He sat in the leather chair in the paneled study in the residence behind the walls. An oasis in a city of chaos. The ceiling fan turned. The Scotch was warm in his hand. Outside, a country was burning candles for a boy whose death he had just filed under "regrettable," and filing was his job, and the job was necessary, and the necessity did not make the chair comfortable, and the chair had never been less comfortable, and the Macallan was not helping.

He finished the glass. He did not pour a third.

[End of Day 5: "The Fracture"]

* * *

<div align="center">

DAY 6: FRIDAY

“The Silence”

</div>

“The struggle of man against power is the struggle of memory against forgetting.” — Milan Kundera

* * *

Chapter 34

Diallo stood at the kitchen window at six AM and the city was quiet. Not sleeping quiet. Held quiet. The markets had not opened. The shutters were down. The schools were closed. The jakartamen were not at the intersections. The only sound was the muezzin, the five-twelve call rising from the minaret and traveling across rooftops that had nothing to compete with it. No engines, no horns, no generators. Just the voice and the city receiving it, and the calm was beautiful and haunting and completely misleading.

The calm was fear. The calm was a country holding its breath because a boy had been shot yesterday and nobody knew what came next. The shopkeepers had decided before dawn that today was not safe for commerce. The taxi drivers had decided before dawn that today was not safe for roads. The mothers had decided before dawn that today was not safe for children. And the decisions had been made quietly, privately, in compounds and kitchens, the way Kessara always made its real decisions, not through announcements but through absence.

Diallo felt the uncertainty in the city because it mirrored his own. The cranes at the port were still. The construction sites were dark. The ocean was audible for the first time since he took office, waves against the seawall, the sound that was always there but always buried under the noise of a city trying to function. This morning the city had stopped trying. In the hospital courtyard, the vigil candles had burned down to wax on the pavement. The photographs from the copy shop, Youssouf's face, the graduation picture, were in pockets and bags across the city, traveling home with people who would carry them tomorrow when they walked to the polling stations.

He had declared a national day of mourning at six AM, before the cabinet was awake. One paragraph, written in longhand on presidential stationery: In honor of Youssouf Coulibaly, who was nineteen years old and wanted to build houses, the Republic of Kessara observes a national day of mourning. All government offices, schools, and non-essential services are suspended. Flags will be lowered to half-staff. The nation grieves with the family of the deceased.

He had included the detail, "who was nineteen years old and wanted to build houses", because without it the declaration was about a category. With it, the declaration was about a person. His chief of staff would say it was not protocol. Diallo was tired of protocol.

He drank his coffee and looked at the flags being lowered on their poles and thought about the things that were clouding his judgment this morning. The election observers had requested a forty-eight-hour postponement to assess security. The investigation he had ordered was already turning into every investigation Kessara had ever conducted, too many accounts, too little evidence, the machinery of official inquiry grinding toward the same conclusion it always reached, which was no conclusion at all. He could feel the whitewash forming and he was the one who had ordered it and the ordering made him complicit and the complicity sat in his stomach beside the cold coffee.

And the deal. The imperfect deal. The deal that was supposed to fix the hospitals and build the roads and generate the revenue and that had also created the conditions under which a nineteen-year-old architecture student was shot in a square. The deal that was the reason for the referendum that was the reason for the rally that was the reason for the gendarmerie that was the reason for the bullet. Every link in the chain led back to the piece of paper he had put before the country, and the country was supposed to vote on it tomorrow, and a boy was dead, and Diallo was standing in his kitchen wondering whether the question on the ballot was still the right question or whether the question had been overtaken by its own consequences.

Asante arrived at eight. He did not knock. He appeared in the doorway carrying the single sheet of paper he always carried, the bond math, the countdown, the numbers that did not care about mourning days.

"Not today, Kofi."

"Today is the only day that matters, Mr. President."

Diallo looked at him. Asante was the same man he had been on Monday, composed, certain, a man who saw the world as a ledger and believed in the ledger with the conviction of a priest. And looking at Asante, Diallo felt something shift. Not agreement. Recognition. Asante was the reason the referendum existed. Not the man, the type. The finance minister who saw the debt and the bond payment and the default timeline and who could not see anything else because the numbers were too large and too urgent to share the frame with a boy under a sheet. Asante was the caricature of the problem and also the only person in the building who understood the math well enough to solve it.

"The bond payment," Asante said. "One point two million dollars. Forty-nine days. If the referendum does not proceed tomorrow, the restructuring timeline collapses. If the timeline collapses, the deal collapses. If we default."

"I know what happens if we default, Kofi."

"Then you know the vote must proceed."

"The AU observers want forty-eight hours."

"If we grant forty-eight hours, the bond market reads it as instability. The spread widens. The restructuring cost increases." "I did not ask you for the cost. I told you what the observers requested."

Asante was quiet. The sheet stayed in his hand. And in the silence Diallo heard the argument that Asante was too disciplined to make aloud but that the numbers on the sheet made for him: a plan with a clear outcome, however imperfect, has to survive its worst day. If one death, one terrible, unjust, unforgivable death, was enough to cancel the referendum, then the referendum had never been real. The sacrifice would become empty. The boy's death would have changed nothing except the date on a calendar, and the debt would still be there, and the hospitals would still be broken, and the next boy would still be standing in the next square. Diallo put down the coffee cup.

"The vote proceeds tomorrow."

Asante exhaled. A single breath, the closest thing to emotion Diallo had seen from him in four years.

"The observers?"

"I will speak with Dr. Ndiaye myself. Full observation. The investigation proceeds in parallel. The mourning is today. The vote is tomorrow. Both things happen because both things must happen." He paused. "And the fact that a country has to mourn and vote on consecutive days is a failure that belongs to me." Asante left. The sheet left with him. The study was empty. Diallo stood at the window. The quiet city. The still cranes. The ocean he could hear because the city had gone silent. Tomorrow three point two million people would walk to polling stations and mark a ballot, Yes or No, and the question would carry inside it everything the week had produced: twelve billion dollars, a dead student, a sacred grove, a farmer's field, a locked hospital door, a mother in house shoes. All of it inside two words on a piece of paper. The question was too small for what it held. But the question was the question. And tomorrow the country would answer it.

Chapter 35

Chen Liwei woke on the mourning day and looked at the boots beside the door and the boots still had the orange dust of the Bassam Corridor on them.

She had not cleaned them. This was unusual. She cleaned her equipment daily, the engineer's habit, the maintenance of tools being the first discipline her professor at Tsinghua had taught and the last one she would abandon. Professor Huang. The workshop in Building 14, winter of her second year, the smell of charcoal heaters warming the room while the Beijing wind rattled the windows and the bicycle bells rang on the path below.

Huang had picked up her surveying rod, run his thumb along the barrel, and handed it back without speaking. She cleaned it. She had been cleaning her instruments ever since, every evening, the way Huang had taught her: as preparation, as respect, as the acknowledgment that the tool would be needed again and should be ready.

She had not cleaned them because cleaning them would remove the dust, and the dust was evidence, and she was not ready to remove the evidence.

She sat on the edge of the bed. The room was quiet. The hotel's generator ran at a frequency so constant it had become the silence, not the absence of sound but the presence of a sound so uniform it ceased to register. The mini-fridge cycled. The air conditioning maintained its temperature. The room was acoustically dead, a term from her university acoustics class, meaning a space that absorbed sound rather than reflecting it, a space designed to contain its own noise without releasing it to the world outside. She had been living inside an acoustically dead space for six days, and the deadness had been comfortable, and the comfort was part of the problem. The contract was acoustically dead too. She had not thought of it this way before, but sitting on the edge of the bed in the generator's hum, the connection arrived with the clarity of an equation balancing. Ninety-three pages of legal language designed to absorb the noise of the displaced, the protests, the petitions, the farmer who said "no" to twenty-two million francs, without reflecting any of it back to Beijing or the Palace. "Respectful relocation." "Social impact mitigation." "Stakeholder engagement protocols." Each

phrase a sound-absorbing panel, installed in the document the way acoustic foam is installed in a studio, ensuring that the noise of the people inside the corridor never reached the people signing the contract.

She checked her phone. The mourning declaration. Government offices closed. Schools closed. Non-essential services suspended. Her office, the converted fish plant at the port, would be closed. Mamadou would not be driving. The handlers who accompanied her to the corridor, the Zhonglu logistics team, the clipboard-carrying men in hard hats who walked beside her and took notes and ensured she saw what the schedule allowed her to see, would not be working.

She could go alone.

She rented a car at the hotel desk. A small Toyota, dented, air conditioning broken, the kind of vehicle that a mid-level engineer rented when the company car was unavailable and the expense report would not be questioned. She drove east. Highway to kilometer eighty-seven. Asphalt to laterite. The transition she knew by feel now, the shudder of the tires, the red dust rising. The corridor was different today. Not the landscape. The landscape was the same millet, the same laterite, the same sky. The difference was in the people. At the first junction, the market was open. The mourning day was a capital decree, and the capital was two hundred kilometers away, and the market women had vegetables to sell and the vegetables did not observe mourning. But the radio at the tea stall was louder than usual, and the men sitting around it were not talking. They were listening. The radio was playing a recitation, Quran, the suras for the dead, and the men were listening with the held stillness of people receiving information through a frequency that no analysis could reach. She drove to six communities. She visited them in order, south to north, following the center line, the same alignment she had walked with survey flags and satellite coordinates and the engineering drawings that converted each village into a set of measurements. Today she did not measure. Today she looked. The first community was Kounda. The chief she would never meet, a man whose interview with Fatou she would never read, had organized his village around a well. The well was at the center. The compounds radiated outward in concentric rings, each ring a generation, the oldest structures nearest the water, the newest at the edges. The pattern was not random.

The pattern was hydraulic. The village had organized itself around its water source the way a city organizes itself around its port, the logic identical, the scale different.

The center line passed through the second ring. Through three compounds. Through a granary. Through the well's drainage channel. The survey had noted these structures as "obstructions requiring removal." She had read the note. She had not,

until today, walked the second ring and counted the doors.

Seven doors. Four compounds. Approximately thirty-one people, based on the average household size in the Bassam region. Thirty-one people whose homes were classified, in her engineering documents, as “obstructions.”

She wrote it down. Not in the survey format, not “Structure Type: residential, Quantity: 4, Status: scheduled for removal.” She wrote: Four families. Thirty-one people. The well drainage runs through the compound of a woman who was hanging laundry when I arrived.

She did not speak to me. She watched me the way people watch weather.

The second community had a school. One room. Tin roof. The teacher was not there. The mourning day. The door was open. She looked inside. One blackboard. Thirty desks. She counted them, the counting being the thing her hands did when her mind was working on something else. The desks were wood, hand-built, each one slightly different from the next because each one had been made by a different father for a different child. On the blackboard, in chalk: a multiplication table. Incomplete. The lesson had ended mid-column. She measured things. She could not help it. The hands measured while the eyes looked.

The mud-brick walls were thirty-two centimeters thick. Good thickness for thermal mass. The walls would absorb heat during the day and release it slowly at night, keeping the room cooler than the outside air by three or four degrees. Whoever built this school understood thermal regulation without knowing the term. The tin roof was pitched at eighteen degrees. She estimated by eye, confirmed by the shadow angle, steep enough to shed the rains but shallow enough that the wind load during harmattan season would not lift the panels.

The builder had calibrated the angle to the local weather. The replacement school in the resettlement zone would be built by a contractor using standard specifications from a manual. The manual would not include the eighteen-degree pitch because the manual was written for a different climate in a different region, and the difference between eighteen degrees and the standard twenty-two would mean four more panel failures per rainy season and one complete roof loss every five years.

She wrote: School roof pitched at 18°. Local calibration to wind/rain conditions.

Replacement specification uses standard 22°. Nobody will know the difference until the first storm.

The center line clipped the eastern wall of the school. In the engineering documents, the school was a rectangle with coordinates. The rectangle would be removed and a replacement school would be constructed in the resettlement zone,

“equal or superior in specification.” Equal or superior. The documents did not specify how you replace thirty desks that were each built by a different father. The documents did not account for the multiplication table on the blackboard, unfinished, the chalk dust still visible, the lesson suspended between the seven-times and the eight-times the way the country was suspended between the vote and its consequences. She wrote: School. One room. Thirty desks, hand-made. Replacement specification does not account for the fact that each desk is a different shape because each desk was built by a different person for a different child. The specification accounts for desks. It does not account for this.

At the fourth community, she found the cemetery. She had known it was there. The survey noted it as “cultural site requiring respectful relocation of human remains.” She had read the phrase. She had not stood in the cemetery.

Fourteen graves. Flat stones. Some with names carved into the laterite. Some without. The stones were the same red-brown as the soil, the same red-brown as the escarpment they had been cut from, the same red-brown as the dust on her boots. The cemetery was not fenced. It was not separated from the fields. The graves were in the fields, between the millet rows, beside the paths, part of the landscape the way the trees were part of the landscape. The dead were not removed from the living. They were beside them. The center line passed through four of the fourteen graves. She had known this. The survey coordinates were in her file. She had seen the coordinates on the screen in the fish plant, the four dots on the alignment map, each dot a “cultural site.” She had not known that the dots were stones and the stones had names and the names were carved by people who were alive, who walked past them every day and who would, when the “respectful relocation” began, be asked to watch their dead be unearthed and moved to a place the dead had never been.

She wrote: Fourteen graves. Four on the center line. “Respectful relocation” is a phrase that contains no respect. It is a logistical term for the movement of human remains from one location to another. The term was coined by people who have never had to relocate their own dead.

The fifth community had a water system. Not the municipal kind, three hand-dug wells, positioned at intervals along the village’s east-west axis, each one lined with concrete rings that had been poured by the villagers themselves using a mold they shared between six communities. She measured the depth of the nearest well by dropping a stone and counting. Four seconds.

Approximately forty meters. The water table here was accessible, not deep like the resettlement zone, where the water sat at twenty meters or more and required diesel

pumps. Here, a woman with a rope and a bucket could reach water without fuel, without machinery, without a monthly payment to a diesel supplier who might or might not deliver. The center line passed between the second and third wells. The construction corridor, the forty-meter clearance zone on either side of the alignment, would destroy the second well. The third well was outside the corridor by eleven meters. Eleven meters. She paced it.

Eleven meters was what separated a community keeping its water and losing it, and the distance had been set by an alignment engineer in Beijing who had drawn the line based on gradient analysis and turning radius and had not known, could not have known, that eleven meters to the east a well existed that served ninety people.

She wrote: Second well inside the corridor. Third well outside by 11 meters. Community water access reduced by 33% unless alignment is shifted 15 meters east. Cost of shift: approximately \$40,000 in additional grading. Cost of not shifting: one well serving 90 people. The alignment was not designed to destroy the well. The alignment was designed without knowing the well existed. The sixth community was the one nearest Ousmane's farm, though she did not know this.

She recognized the field. The baobab visible in the distance, the millet rows, the compound behind the low rise. She did not go to the tree. She did not need to. She had sat beneath it. She had felt its bark. She had looked up into its canopy and calculated its age and watched a man walk toward it with a hoe on his shoulder, sixty meters away, and she had turned and walked south and the turning was still inside her, the way a missed calculation stays inside an engineer, not as guilt but as an unresolved variable.

She parked at the edge of the field and did what she had been doing at every stop: she ran the numbers. Not the project numbers. Those were in the binders. The real numbers.

The deal promised fifty thousand jobs. She had built the presentation that claimed fifty thousand. She had also built the footnote, white text on white background, point-six font, that acknowledged the baseline methodology counted "indirect employment multiplier effects" at a ratio of 3.2, which meant the actual direct employment was approximately twelve thousand, which meant thirty-eight thousand of the fifty thousand jobs existed only in an economic model that assumed conditions the corridor itself would disrupt.

Twelve thousand jobs. Against forty-three thousand displaced. The ratio was 1:3.6. For every job created, 3.6 people lost their homes. She had not calculated this ratio before today because the calculation had not been requested, and engineers calculate

what is requested, and the request had been for the jobs number, not the displacement-to-employment ratio.

She calculated it now, sitting in a rented Toyota at the edge of a millet field, and the ratio was clear and it was damning and it was math, which meant it was not an opinion and could not be argued and would, if it appeared in the twelve pages, change the document from an observation into an indictment.

She wrote the ratio down.

She also wrote: The deal's Economic Impact Assessment uses a wage multiplier of 3.2 applied to a base employment figure of 15,600. This multiplier assumes consumer spending patterns consistent with established urban economies. The corridor communities are not established urban economies. They are subsistence farming communities where consumer spending is seasonal, non-monetary, and dependent on soil conditions that the corridor itself will alter. The multiplier is not wrong. The multiplier is fiction applied to a real place.

She sat in the car. The engine off. The field in front of her. The baobab in the distance. A bird was building in its branches. She could see the movement, the small body working at the edge of the canopy, the same weaverbird she had watched on Tuesday. She thought about her mother's hands. The factory in Chengdu. The hands that had assembled components for twenty-three years and that had paid for Liwei's education and that had looked, when her mother held them under the kitchen light, like the hands of a woman twenty years older. Her mother had built things too, circuit boards, small ones, the kind that went into appliances that were sold in countries her mother would never visit. Her mother had never questioned the purpose of the building. The building was the job. The job paid the tuition. The tuition produced the engineer. The engineer was now sitting in a car in West Africa looking at a field that her engineering would destroy.

The chain was unbroken, from her mother's factory work to her own survey coordinates, the same system, the same logic: build what you are told to build, count what you are told to count, do not count what you are not told to count. The system produced bridges and railways and processing facilities. The system also produced the white-on-white footnote and the 3.2 multiplier and the phrase "respectful relocation of human remains." The system was not evil. The system was efficient. Efficiency was the absence of questions, and the absence of questions was what her profession called

"scope," and scope was defined by the client, and the client had not included the well at the fifth community or the thirty desks at the school or the names on the stones in the scope.

She was adding them now. The twelve pages were the addition of things the scope had excluded. The addition was not authorized. The addition was engineering.

She drove back at dusk. The corridor behind her. The laterite giving way to asphalt. The city appearing on the horizon, cranes still, port working, the skyline the same skyline she had seen every evening for six days. At the hotel, she showered. The water ran orange. The dust of six communities leaving her skin and circling the drain and disappearing into the plumbing of a five-star hotel. A hotel connected to a municipal water system that served thirty percent of the city. The deal was supposed to extend it to sixty percent, funded by revenue from the corridor, the corridor that ran through the well at Kounda and the school with thirty desks and the cemetery with fourteen graves and the second well that served ninety people.

She sat on the bed. She opened her notebook. She wrote for three hours.

Twelve pages. Not engineering notes. The engineering notes were in the survey binders, in the CAD files, in the alignment documents that would travel to Beijing and be reviewed by men in offices who would see coordinates and tolerances and construction schedules and would never see the woman hanging laundry or the multiplication table or the names on the stones.

These twelve pages were something else. They were a parallel survey, the same corridor, the same alignment, the same center line, measured by a different instrument. The instrument was not a GPS unit or a theodolite or a satellite. The instrument was a woman who had walked the ground and used her eyes and her fingers and the part of her training that her profession did not acknowledge but that every good engineer possessed: the ability to see what the drawings did not show.

Elsewhere in the same hotel, seven floors up, a man named Sokolov was sleeping. He also processed the world through numbers. He also calibrated human behavior into variables and plotted outcomes on surfaces he had mapped with precision. The difference between them was not intelligence or training or method. The difference was that Sokolov's calculations excluded the variable that Liwei's calculations had, today, included: the people inside the numbers. He counted bodies the way a logistics officer counts cargo. She had spent six hours counting doors.

She thought about the architecture student. Youssouf. She had heard the name on the radio. Nineteen. He wanted to build houses. She was thirty-four and she built railways and bridges and port facilities and the things that connected cities to the resources that kept them alive. He was nineteen and he wanted to build houses, the small things, the human-scale things, the roofs over the heads of the people the railways displaced. They were in the same profession. They worked with the same

physics, load, stress, material, tolerance. He was dead and she was in a hotel room writing twelve pages that nobody had asked for, and the twelve pages were the first honest engineering document she had produced since arriving in Kessara, because honest engineering accounted for all the loads, including the ones the client did not want measured.

She closed the notebook. She placed it on the nightstand. She turned off the lamp. The boots were by the door. She had not cleaned them. She would not clean them tonight. The dust was the corridor and the corridor was the evidence and the evidence would stay on the boots until she decided what to do with the twelve pages, and the deciding was not tonight's work.

The dust had its own inertia. In physics, inertia is the resistance of an object to any change in its state of motion. A body at rest remains at rest, a body in motion remains in motion, unless acted upon by an external force. The orange dust on her boots was at rest. It was resisting the external force of the hotel's cleanliness, the contract's language, the referendum's binary question. The dust did not know about Yes or No. The dust was laterite, iron oxide, aluminum hydroxide, the geological residue of a billion years of weathering. It had been on this ground before the baobab was planted and before the borders were drawn and before the deal was drafted, and it would be on this ground after the railway was built and after the railway rusted and after the rust returned to the soil it came from. The dust was patient the way only geology is patient, not waiting for anything, not resisting anything, simply being present, being evidence, being the ground.

Tomorrow was the vote. The vote would determine whether the center line became a railway or remained a line on a map. Either way, the twelve pages existed. Either way, she had walked the ground and counted the doors and read the names on the stones. The counting and the reading were done. They were in her notebook and in her body and in the orange dust on the boots she had not cleaned, and leaving it dirty was the first act of something she did not yet have a word for, something that was not defiance and not rebellion but was simply the refusal to make the evidence disappear.

Chapter 36

Fatou drove back to the corridor on the mourning day because Madame Konaté had said "come back when you have more time" and today the roads were empty and the country was still. She had not slept well. Her footage was on every screen in the world, twelve million views, her name in the chyron, GPS London running it as the lead. The recognition she had been working toward since Columbia had arrived, and it tasted like ash. A boy had died and her career had advanced and she could not separate the two things because they were the same event.

Moussa drove. He did not ask where they were going. He had stopped asking days ago.

The corridor was quiet, the laterite road, the dust, the millet fields on either side. She had driven this road three times now and was starting to recognize it, this curve, that tree, the dip at kilometer ninety-four. The fields were still. No wind. The millet was not moving. The whole landscape had the look of a place waiting for something it could not name. She had seen this in other countries. The land registers what the people feel before the people say it. She was not here as a journalist today. She had not brought her press credentials or called her editor. She was here as Fatou Mensah, daughter of Amadou Mensah, who had left this country twenty-six years ago and had never said why.

Madame Konaté was on the bench outside her daughter's house. Yellow wrap today. Her hands folded in her lap. She watched Fatou approach without surprise. She had expected the return. "Sit," she said.

Fatou sat. The bench was warm from the sun. A hen crossed the yard with four chicks behind her.

Madame Konaté did not mention the shooting or the mourning day. She looked at Fatou's face the way she had looked at it two days ago.

"You have your father's forehead," she said. "And your mother's mouth. Very Mensah."

"Madame Konaté. You said my mother was afraid."

"Yes."

“Afraid of what?”

The old woman looked across the yard.

“Your father worked at the Ministry of Mines. He was a senior clerk. Not a minister, not a director, the man who stamped the papers. Every licensing document, every exploration permit, every royalty agreement between a mining company and the government of Kessara passed through his hands.”

She paused.

“In 1997, a French company applied for an exploration license in the northern provinces for coltan. The application looked routine. But the royalty terms were wrong. Not wrong by accident. The terms gave the company ninety-one percent of the extraction revenue. Kessara received nine. The standard rate was seventy-thirty. Your father checked. Every calculation, every sub-clause, every appendix. The numbers all favored the company by the same margin. An error that is consistent across forty pages is not an error. It is an arrangement.”

“He reported it?”

“He wrote a memorandum. He gave it to his director. Two weeks later, the license was approved. Terms unchanged. Ninety-one to nine. His memorandum was not in the file. He asked his director. His director said he did not recall it.”

Fatou’s notebook was in her bag. She did not take it out. “Your father went to the inspector general. He brought a copy. Your father was a man who kept copies. The inspector general listened. He thanked him. He said the matter would be investigated.”

“And?”

“Three days later, your father came home and there was a man sitting in the living room. A man your mother did not know, polite and unhurried. He said he was from the Ministry of Internal Security. He said your father’s concerns had been noted and the matter was resolved. He said it would be best for the family if the concerns were not raised again. He drank the tea your mother made him. He spoke the way you speak about weather, calm, factual, as if the consequences were natural and not a choice. He left. He did not leave a card.”

“When was this?”

“2004. You were twelve.”

“And the next day?”

“The next day a white car with government plates was parked outside your parents’ compound. It sat there all morning. Nobody got out. It came back the next day. And the next. By the fourth day your mother stopped sending you to school. She kept the curtains drawn.”

Madame Konaté looked at her hands.

“This is how it has always worked in Kessara, child. Before independence, the French perfected this method. The warning was always subtle, a visit, a car, a suggestion delivered over tea. But the consequences were not subtle. The people who did not comply disappeared. Killed or locked away in places their families would never find. Everyone knew this. The French never announced it and never denied it. They advertised the threat quietly and carried it out in silence, and the silence was deafening because every neighbor understood what an empty house meant. After independence, the new government inherited the method. Different flag on the building, same car outside the compound. Your father grew up hearing the stories. He knew what the car meant. Your father understood what the car meant. He had grown up hearing the stories.”

Six months later, Fatou’s family was on a plane to Toronto. Her father carrying her through the airport. Her mother with the suitcases, packed with soft things only, her mother had told her years later. “I packed only soft things because I was afraid the suitcases would be searched and I did not want anything hard that could be mistaken for something else.”

“Your mother came to me the morning after the car,” Madame Konaté said. “She was shaking. Not crying, just shaking. She said: ‘Kadiatou, I am afraid every time he goes to work and I am afraid every time he comes home and I cannot live in a country where I am afraid of both directions.’”

Both directions. Going and coming. Fatou heard her mother’s voice in Madame Konaté’s mouth.

“Did anyone else know? About the memorandum?”

“People knew. People always know. But knowing and speaking are different things in Kessara. They have always been different things.”

Madame Konaté went inside and came back with sweet hot tea. They drank in the quiet of the yard.

“Your father was a good man,” Madame Konaté said. “He saw something wrong and said it was wrong. The country punished him for it. Not with violence. With the car. With the visit. With the patient suggestion that compliance was safer than honesty. The patient threat is worse than the loud one, because the loud one ends and the patient one does not.”

Fatou looked at her hands. The same hands that had held the camera, that had pressed the phone against the pavement while a boy bled. Her father’s hands. The hands that had stamped papers and written the memorandum and kept the copy and

carried a twelve-year-old through the airport.

She had come to Kessara to cover a referendum. She had found her father's story instead. And the story was not separate from the referendum. It was the prequel. The same ground, the same minerals, the same arrangement between foreign companies and government officials. 1997 to 2026. Twenty-nine years. Different company, different buyer, different clerk. Same terms. Same visit. She drove back. At the hotel, she called her mother.

"Mama. I went to the corridor. I met a woman named Kadiatou Konaté."

Her mother said nothing.

"She told me about Papa, the Ministry of Mines, the memorandum, the man in the living room, the car outside the compound."

Her mother was quiet for a long time. Fatou could hear her breathing, the measured breathing she had heard her entire life, the breathing of a woman who controlled her voice by controlling her lungs.

"I packed only soft things," her mother said. "Do you remember?"

"I remember."

"Your father did the right thing. He saw something wrong and he said so. He lost his country for it. He lost his language and his friends and the kitchen where he argued with your grandmother about the recipe for thirty years. He lost everything except us." "Why didn't you tell me?"

"Because you were safe. Because Toronto was safe. I would not let anything narrow that safety. Not for a story. Not for the truth. Not for anything."

"Mama. I'm covering the same story. Same arrangement.

Different company, different mineral."

Her mother was quiet again.

"Then be careful," she said. "And keep copies."

Fatou sat on the hotel bed. Her phone was charging on the nightstand. Thirty-seven seconds of footage. A boy in a white shirt. The sound. The silence after. Everything that had happened since, the mourning declaration, the diplomatic cables, the press releases, had been a translation of those thirty-seven seconds. And each translation had made the original smaller.

Her father had kept a copy of the memorandum. Her mother told her to keep copies.

She backed up the footage to three separate servers. She kept copies.

Chapter 37

Aminata delivered the speech at ten AM on the steps of the party headquarters, and every word was true, and every word did exactly what she had designed it to do.

Four hundred people. Not the fifteen thousand of Tuesday. The mourning day had thinned the crowd to the ones who could not stay home. The press was there, local and international, the cameras that Fatou's footage had summoned from Dakar and Abidjan and Paris.

She spoke without notes. The twelve hundred words she had written on Thursday night were in her body now. She spoke about Youssouf. She said his name, his age, what he studied, what he wanted to build. She did not say "disproportionate force." She said: "A boy went to a rally and did not come home."

The crowd was still. Not Tuesday's tense stillness. This was the stillness of people holding something heavy and afraid to shift. She finished. Khadija was at her elbow.

"That will move the numbers," Khadija said.

"I know."

She had meant every word. The words would move the polls four to six points toward No. She had been living in that contradiction for five days and it was getting harder to carry. At noon, she called Derek. Door closed. The party headquarters ran on a small generator that sounded like it was about to give up. "Derek. I need to discuss the Foundation's board."

"Of course. What specifically?"

"Four of your eleven board members hold executive positions at lithium mining companies or rare-earth investment funds. Dr.

Addington joined eighteen months ago, six months before the Kessara deal was announced. I want to know whether the Foundation's support for the No campaign is a principled position or a commercial strategy."

Derek was quiet.

"Aminata, the Foundation's mission is to support democratic governance. The board composition reflects."

“The board composition reflects a financial interest in disrupting Chinese mineral access. If the No wins, the corridor is delayed. If the corridor is delayed, your board members’ competing interests benefit. I am asking whether I am running a sovereignty campaign or a market-access campaign for a different set of mining companies.”

“That is a very reductive reading of.”

“Derek. A nineteen-year-old architecture student is dead. Tomorrow three million people vote on a question I helped frame. If the framing was funded by people whose interests are not Kessaran, I need to know that before I ask the country to trust me.” Derek was quiet for a long time.

“The Foundation’s position is that the Kessara Gateway Partnership represents a significant challenge to democratic sovereignty,” he said. “That position is shared by the board, including the members you’ve identified. Their professional backgrounds do not invalidate the position.”

“Their professional backgrounds explain the position, Derek. There’s a difference.”

She hung up.

She had known. Since the helicopter. Since the magnetic panel covering the mining company’s logo. She had taken their money because the alternative was no campaign, and no campaign meant the Yes would win unopposed. The compromise had been easy to justify at the time. Each one after it had been easier. She had studied this pattern at The Hague. She had just never expected to be the case study.

She sat in the dim office and thought about what Derek had said and what he had not said, and she realized that the thing she had been chasing all week, justice, accountability, the right words in the right order, was only half of what the country needed. Justice demanded a cost. It cost the person who delivered it and the person who received it, and in a country that had been paying costs for generations, the people were tired of paying. What lasted, what actually changed things, was not justice but mercy. Forgiveness. The willingness to look at the imperfect system and the imperfect people inside it and choose to move forward instead of backward. In Kessara this was not philosophy. It was survival. Every family she had ever known practiced it, the uncle who was forgiven, the debt that was quietly cancelled, the neighbor who was welcomed back after the betrayal. Mercy was the blanket the country wrapped around itself to get through the cold nights, and the cold nights were frequent, and the blanket was thin, but it was all they had and it worked because they shared it.

She went home at seven. Hawa was at the kitchen table doing math homework, the pencil moving across the paper with the focused quiet of a child who has been told that school continues even when the country stops.

Aminata stood in the doorway and watched her daughter work. The frown Hawa made when a number did not cooperate. It was the same frown Moussa used to make, the family resemblance so sharp it caught Aminata off guard sometimes. Hawa had never met her uncle. Hawa was twelve. Aminata had been twelve once, in a kitchen not so different from this one, frowning at her own homework while her mother cooked and Moussa argued with their father about football. The world had been just as chaotic then, a military government, the economy failing, the same arguments about sovereignty and foreign companies, but she had not known it. That was the gift of youth. You lived inside the chaos without understanding it, and not understanding was a kind of grace, and the grace ended the day you did understand, and after that you spent the rest of your life trying to protect the people who still had it.

She cooked dinner. Rice and fish. The pot was old and blackened at the bottom from years of direct flame. She cooked the way her mother had taught her, oil first, then onions, then tomato paste, then the fish laid in a single layer so each piece touched the bottom. The smell of the onions in the oil was her mother's kitchen. It was every kitchen she had ever stood in as a child, and it would be Hawa's memory someday, the smell that meant home before home became complicated. She would teach Hawa this recipe when Hawa was ready to learn, and teaching would carry inside it everything the recipe carried: her mother's hands, her grandmother's hands, the long chain of women who fed their families while the country argued about its future outside the kitchen window.

They ate at the table. Hawa talked about school. A boy in her class had been crying because his cousin was at the rally and the teacher had let him go home. Hawa did not ask about the referendum. She asked about the fish. "Did you put lemon? It tastes different tonight", and Aminata said yes, and the conversation about lemon was the lightest thing in the apartment and she held onto it. Wisdom, she thought, was supposed to be a gift, but it always arrived with sorrow and took innocence as payment. Hawa still had her innocence. The lemon was proof.

After dinner, Hawa went to her room. Aminata washed the dishes, dried them, put them away, wiped the counter. She left the small light above the stove on because Hawa sometimes got water at night and did not like the dark.

Her voter identification card was on the table beside the salt shaker, where she would see it in the morning. Her face on it, a younger face, photographed four years

ago, before the campaign, before the Foundation, before the helicopter. That woman had not yet been asked to choose between clean money and no money. Tomorrow she would take this card to the polling station, stand in line, enter the booth, and mark the paper. No. Because the deal was still a surrender even if the opposition was not pure. Because Youssouf was still dead even if the people mourning him had their own reasons. But she would carry mercy into the booth alongside the justice. The country would need both when the counting was done.

She turned off the stove light. The apartment went dark. Hawa was breathing softly in the next room. Tomorrow was the vote. She sat in the dark kitchen with her voter card and her blackened pot and her daughter's breathing, and for the first time all week she felt something that was not anger or grief or strategy. She felt tired. And the tiredness was honest, and honest was enough for tonight.

Chapter 38

Awa arrived at the farm at three in the afternoon. She had taken the morning bus from Port Sélani, four hours on hard seats, the road rough after the asphalt ended. Her phone was dead because she had forgotten to charge it at the dormitory, which meant four hours without messages, without the MJS group chat, without the polling numbers. Four hours of engine noise and dust. She had not realized how much she needed the silence until it was given to her. The bus dropped her at the junction. She walked the last three kilometers on the path she had walked to school for twelve years, the same path her father walked to the market and her mother had walked to the well. She passed Amadou's compound, smoke from the kitchen house, a radio playing Quran recitation.

She turned the corner and saw the compound. The mud-brick wall, the iron roof, the neem tree at the gate. And her father, standing at the edge of the millet field with a hoe on his shoulder, watching her come.

"Awa."

"Papa."

She walked into his arms. He held her and the hoe fell to the ground and his shirt smelled of sweat and woodsmoke and millet pollen, and the smell was home, and home was the place where her body stopped running.

They sat under the baobab. Sékou brought water. He looked at his sister with the expression of a younger brother who has been watching the news and is trying to reconcile the woman on the screen with the girl who used to steal his porridge.

"You look tired," Sékou said.

"I am tired."

"You look like you've been fighting the government."

"I have been fighting the government."

"Is the government tired too?"

She almost laughed. The laugh was there, in the back of her throat, but it could not quite arrive. Too much had happened since Thursday.

Sékou went back to the kitchen. She could hear him preparing food, the fire, the pot, the spoon. Her father and brother kept the compound running with the quiet competence of men who had been taught by a woman who died and who honored her by remembering how she did things.

Ousmane looked at his daughter. She noticed his hands on his knees, the fingers slightly curled, the thumbs pressed together. She was sitting the same way. The same hands, the same curl. She had stood on walls and led chants and spoken to four thousand people, but the hands beneath the voice were her father's hands, and the stubbornness that kept her on the wall when the car followed her home was the same stubbornness that kept him in this field when the compensation men came.

"The boy," Ousmane said. "The student."

"Youssouf. He was in my study group."

"You knew him."

"I knew him, Papa. He wanted to build affordable houses. He said that in our last meeting."

Ousmane was quiet. He looked at the millet, the stalks barely moving in the afternoon breeze.

"A young man who wants to build things and is killed before he can build them," he said. "That is not a political problem, Awa. That is a farming problem. A seed that does not reach the soil. A season lost. The field does not care who crushed the seed. The field only knows the harvest is smaller."

Awa wanted to argue. The lawyer in her wanted to say that it was a political problem, that the chain of cause was traceable, that tracing was justice and justice was what the ballot was for. She did not argue. Her father was speaking from a longer clock. His clock measured in seasons and graves. It included her and extended past her.

"Awa. There is something I need to tell you about Ibrahim." She felt the shift before he spoke. The quiet between them changed.

"Ibrahim was not working in the mines."

"What do you mean?"

"He was with a military company. Across the border. They trained him. They used him. He could not leave." Ousmane looked at his hands. "He called me. Twice. Two nights ago he said he was out. He escaped. He is walking south. He is coming home."

"Coming home."

"Yes."

"Papa. What was he doing?"

“He would not say. He said: ‘Tell Awa I am sorry. For what I have become.’”

Ousmane looked at the millet.

“Do not judge him, Awa. He left because the farm could not hold him. Eight hundred dollars a month. The farm does not produce that in a year. A young man who is hungry and whose father’s field is shrinking does not ask what they will want him to do for the money. He finds out later. Ibrahim found out late, but he found out, and now he is walking home.”

Awa sat very still. Ibrahim. Her brother who had left at twenty-three. Who sent the money that paid for her university. Who called less and less, then stopped. She had told herself he was working in the mines, that the signal was bad, that the silence was just distance. The silence was not geography. The silence was a camp and a fence and a phone that was taken and a word, “brotherhood”, printed on cheap paper at bus stations.

Eight hundred dollars a month. Her tuition, her textbooks, her dormitory room, all of it paid for by whatever Ibrahim had been asked to do in a desert she could not name. The campaign she was running, the law she was studying, the constitutional arguments she made on walls and in courtrooms, all of it built on money her brother had earned doing things he could not tell her about. “Papa. Is he safe?”

“He is walking. Two days. Maybe three.”

“And when he gets here?”

Ousmane looked at the baobab. His grandfather’s tree. Still young, really, sixty-three years. It was the country that had aged faster.

“When he gets here, he is home. That is all. He is home.” He said it simply because forgiveness was simple to him. Not a concept he would have used that word for, but something he practiced every day, in the field, where the morning forgave the night, in the family, where the ones who left were received by the ones who stayed, and receiving was not conditional.

They sat under the tree as the afternoon turned to evening. The light went from gold to amber to the deep orange the escarpment threw across the fields before dark.

“Papa. Are you going to vote?”

“Yes.”

“Which way?”

He looked at her. Not evasion. Privacy. His decision was made and it belonged to him, the last thing the deal had not taken. “I am going to vote the way the field tells me to vote,” he said. “The field has been talking all week. I have been listening.” She did not ask again. She sat beside him and was quiet, and the quiet was new, not the

coiled quiet of a woman preparing to speak but the uncertain quiet of a woman who had spent six days being certain and was now, for the first time, unsure whether her certainty had been earned or just loud. She had spoken to four thousand people. She had said a boy's name. And now she was sitting beside a man who had been fighting the same fight for forty years without once raising his voice, and her brother was walking through the dark because the country's arithmetic had consumed him, and the question she could not answer was whether her voice was clarity or just volume.

She put her head against her father's shoulder. His shirt was rough, warm from the sun. He put his arm around her.

Tomorrow was the vote. Tonight they were under the tree. And the tree was enough.

Chapter 39

The mosque held six thousand people for the Friday prayer on the mourning day. The overflow filled the courtyard and spilled into the street, where loudspeakers carried the suras to people who had not been inside a mosque in months but who were here today because a boy was dead and the week had broken something that needed a larger space than their compounds could hold.

Thierno Bâ watched them through the wooden screen behind the mihrab. Six thousand people shoulder to shoulder in a hall built for three thousand, the heat of the noon sun on the iron roof, the ceiling fans stirring the warm air without cooling it. He adjusted his robes. His hands were slow today. Not trembling. Slow. The sermon he was about to give was the shortest he had ever written and the hardest.

The prayer ended. He gripped the minbar and looked at the congregation.

“I have been silent,” he said. “For six days, I have not spoken about the referendum. Many of you have come today hoping I will stand before you and say: God has spoken. Vote this way. And the voting will be righteous because the imam said so.”

He paused.

“I did not speak because I did not know what to say. That is the truth, and I give it to you because you deserve the truth from this pulpit. I am your imam. I have buried your parents and named your children and sat beside your beds when you were sick. But this week I sat in my study and listened for God’s voice, and what I heard was my own breathing and a city that was frightened.” He released the minbar.

“The Prophet, peace be upon him, said: ‘Tie your camel, then trust in God.’ Tomorrow you will walk to the polling station. That is tying the camel. The trusting comes after. But the tying is yours. God gave you a mind and He expects you to use it. He did not send the Quran so that your imam could read it for you and hand you the answer. He sent it so that you could wrestle with the questions yourself and come to Him honestly, even if you come confused. Especially if you come confused. The confused prayer is the most sincere prayer, because the man who is confused has not yet lied to himself about knowing.”

He looked at the front row. Farmers. Teachers. The cloth merchant. The mechanic whose son was in the displacement camp. "I will not tell you how to vote. That is not cowardice. That is respect, for the mind God gave you, for the judgment you carry, for the fact that you have survived drought and debt and the disappearance of your sons, and you survived these things not because an imam told you how but because you decided how, each of you, in the privacy of your own conscience. Tomorrow you will vote with whatever you carry, your anger, your hope, your grief. You will not vote as my followers. You will vote as God's creatures. And the ballot is not a prayer. The ballot is a piece of paper. The prayer is what you bring to it."

He sat down. The congregation sat in silence for a long time, the silence of people who had come expecting guidance and received instead the heavier gift of their own judgment.

At midnight, Diallo came.

He came without guards, without Captain Ndoeye. He drove himself through dark streets, no power in the district, no streetlights, just headlights on an empty road.

Thierno Bâ heard the car and opened the door. Diallo stood in the courtyard under the stars.

"Thierno."

"Mr. President."

"Tonight I am not the president. Tonight I am a man who needs tea."

Boubacar prepared the attaya. Three rounds.

The first round was bitter, strong tea, little sugar, the taste of something that wakes you by refusing to comfort you. The two men sat in the study, Diallo in the visitor's chair, Thierno Bâ behind the desk where the survey map lay beneath a copy of the Quran. They drank in silence. The first round was for proving you were serious. "I heard your sermon on the radio," Diallo said.

"And?"

"You told four million people that their imam does not know how to vote."

"I told four million people that their imam will not decide for them. There is a difference."

"The difference is the reason I am here."

Thierno Bâ studied Diallo's face. He had known this man for thirty years, as a professor with ideas and a briefcase, as a candidate, as a president. He had watched the office settle on Diallo's shoulders and watched the shoulders accept it. He could see the weight tonight. The weight had changed shape since Monday. It was no longer the weight of a man carrying a policy. It was the weight of a man carrying a death.

"I need to know, Thierno. Not the president asking the imam. The man asking the man. Is this deal the right thing?"

Thierno Bâ poured the second round. Sweeter now, more sugar, the bitterness softened. The second round was for the conversation itself.

"When I was young," he said, "a man came to my father with a donkey that was lame. He asked my father to pray over the donkey. My father looked at the hoof. He said: 'The hoof is split. Take the donkey to the blacksmith. The blacksmith will trim the hoof. Then bring the donkey back and I will pray for its strength.' The man was angry. He wanted the prayer first. My father said: 'God heals. But God also made blacksmiths. Use both.'"

Diallo waited. He had known Thierno long enough to know the story was not finished.

"The country has a split hoof, Moustapha. You are offering it to the Chinese blacksmith. The blacksmith may be skilled. The price may be fair. But the people are not asking about the blacksmith. They want the ballot to be a talisman, a gris-gris they carry into the booth that will fix the school and the hospital and bring back the boy and stop the drought and make the sons come home. They are asking a piece of paper to do what only their own labor and patience and grief can do."

"But this time is different," Diallo said. "The donkey is not lame. The donkey is being sold."

"Yes."

"And the people I am asking to approve the sale are the people who depend on the donkey."

"Yes. And you are asking them to trust the buyer because you trust the buyer, and your trust is built on numbers you have studied, and their trust is built on a life you have not lived. We say in Fulfulde: 'The man who has never carried water does not know how far the well is.' You have studied the well, Moustapha. You have measured it. But you have not carried the bucket on your head for forty years."

Diallo felt the words land. He wanted to argue. He had the arguments, the bond math, the restructuring, the fifty-two days. But the arguments sounded different in this study than they did in the cabinet. The cabinet was built for arguments. This study was built for truth, and truth was quieter and less cooperative.

"I have watched this for fifty years," Thierno said. "Every election, every crisis, every new partner, the French with their civilization, the Americans with their democracy, the Chinese with their infrastructure. Each time, the people come to me and ask: 'Thierno, is this the right one?' And I say: 'There is no magic. There is work."

There is the field. There is the rain. There is God, who does not choose sides in referendums.”

A part of Diallo’s mind, the part that never stopped working, noted it: God does not choose sides in referendums. A line for a future speech. He filed it and was immediately ashamed. The shame was proof that he could not stop being a politician even here, even now, even sitting across from a man who had asked nothing of him except honesty.

“You are ashamed of yourself tonight,” Thierno said. Not a question.

Diallo looked up.

“Good. The Prophet said: ‘Shame is part of faith.’ A leader who cannot feel shame is a leader who has forgotten whom he serves. Your shame tells me you still remember.”

“Remembering does not fix the hospital.”

“No. But forgetting would be worse. The Quran says: ‘Do not let the hatred of a people prevent you from being just.’ You have been just, Moustapha. Imperfect, but just. The deal is imperfect. The vote is imperfect. The country is imperfect. We say: ‘A crooked stick still casts a straight shadow at noon.’ You have been trying to stand at noon. That is all God asks of a man, not that he be straight, but that he keep trying to find the light.”

Diallo set his glass down. He looked at his hands. The same hands that had signed the referendum decree, that had held Mariama’s hand in the helicopter. The same hands that could not reach through a locked door to a freezer forty meters away. “And the grove?” he asked.

“The grove has survived the French, the British, the military government, two coups, and a famine. It may survive this. It may not. I do not control the grove. Dramane does not control the grove. The grove answers to something older than both of us, and that something does not vote.”

Boubacar collected the glasses and prepared the third round. The sweetest. The round of acceptance. You drank it to show you were ready to leave with whatever you had received, even if it was not what you came for.

“I cannot absolve you, Moustapha,” Thierno said. “You want me to say the deal is God’s will. I cannot. God does not negotiate with referendums. God negotiates with hearts. Your heart is heavy tonight, and the heaviness is proof that you have not stopped caring. That is the only qualification I require from a president.” “We have both failed the donkey before,” Diallo said quietly. “You with your patience. Me with my policy.”

“Yes. And the donkey is still here. Still lame. Still carrying the load. That is the stubbornness of this country, Moustapha. We fail it and it survives us. We disappoint it and it forgives us. We sell pieces of it and it grows them back. Not because the country is strong. Because the people are patient beyond what any leader deserves.” Diallo drank the third glass slowly. The tea was sweet and warm and the glass was small in his fingers.

“Thank you, Thierno.”

“I did not give you an answer.”

“You gave me tea. Tonight that is enough.”

He drove home through the dark city. No streetlights, no generators. The only sound was the engine and, beneath it, the Atlantic against the shore, the sound that had been there before the city and before the country and before any deal. Tomorrow was the vote. He was no longer the architect of the outcome. He was one man with one ballot.

In the study, Thierno Bâ sat alone. Three empty glasses on the tray. The lamp burning low. He had done the only thing an honest leader could do: he had returned the weight to the people who would carry it tomorrow. Returning was not a victory. It was an admission that the weight had never been his to hold.

The lamp went out. The study was dark. The morning was coming, and the morning belonged to the people.

Chapter 40

The riverbed had no water. He walked across it and he was in Kessara. No fence, no guard, just sand and stones and the other side. He stood on Kessaran soil and his legs were shaking. Three days of walking. His feet were raw inside the boots. The blisters had opened on the second day and the boots were wet with what leaked out of skin that had been pushed past what skin was made for. The pain was useful. When the pain was sharp enough it kept the other things out.

When the pain faded the other things came in. The boy with the yellow jerrycan. The sound from the eastern district. His body played them on a loop that did not have a stop button. He would bend over with his hands on his knees and use the combat breathing, slow in, hold, slow out, the one useful thing the trainers had taught him. He used the weapon's breathing to undo the weapon's damage. It was the only joke he knew and it was not funny.

The road south was laterite, red in the moonlight. He knew this dirt. It smelled different from the camp dirt that smelled of diesel and concrete and the chemical they put in the latrines. This dirt smelled like rain even when there was no rain. It smelled like his father's shirt after a day in the field. He breathed it in and the smell reached a place inside him he thought was gone, and the place was not gone. It was folded. Pressed flat from a year of being shut away. But still there.

He turned west at the junction. The path. His feet knew it even in the boots. Past the termite mound he used to kick as a boy. Past the dry drainage channel. Past the neighbor's wall.

The stars were different here. He had been watching them change over three nights of walking, the same stars, but the sky growing wider as he moved south, the constellations sitting in different air. Tonight they looked better. Not changed back. But better. As if the sky itself knew he was closer to where he was supposed to be.

The millet fields in the moonlight. Short, too short. The drought showing in the height. But standing. His father's millet. Planted and weeded and watched and still standing despite everything. He reached out and touched a stalk as he passed. The dry grain brushed his fingers and the feel of it was so ordinary, so completely

unremarkable, that it broke something open in his chest. He used to walk through this field every morning without noticing it. A year away had turned the most routine thing in his life into the thing he had missed most.

The baobab. His grandfather's tree. The dark shape against the sky, the branches spreading in the exact pattern he could have drawn from memory. He put his hand on the trunk. The bark was rough and warm from the day's heat, still releasing it into the night the way the tree had always done, the way it would do long after the referendum and the deal and every argument the country was having had been forgotten. The tree did not know about any of it. The tree knew the rain and the sun and the feet of the people who sat beneath it.

He walked east, thirty meters through the short millet. The low mound of stones. His mother's grave.

He knelt. The stones were cool now. Someone had kept the weeds cleared. Sékou, probably. The small things his family did in his absence, the maintenance of love that continued whether he was there or not.

"Mama."

His voice cracked on the word. He had not spoken aloud in two days.

"I did things I cannot tell you about. I became something you would not recognize. I took their money and I told myself it was for the family and it was, Mama, it was for Awa's school and for Papa's seed money, but the things I did to earn it."

He stopped. He pressed his forehead against the stones. They were smooth and cool against his skin and the coolness was her hand, her palm on his forehead when he had a fever as a child, and the memory was so precise and so far away that it split him open. He cried. Not the combat breathing, not the controlled exhalation that kept the body functional. He cried the way a child cries, openly, without discipline, his shoulders shaking against the stones, his hands gripping the edges of the mound as if the stones could hold him the way his mother had held him. The crying came from a place below everything the camp had built on top of it, below the training, below the operations, below the boy with the yellow jerrycan. It came from the twenty-three-year-old who had gotten on a bus and had not understood that the bus was one-way.

He cried until the tears were spent. Not resolved. Not healed. Spent.

He wiped his face with the back of his hand. He stood. His legs were unsteady but the unsteadiness was different now, lighter. Something had left his body at the gravestone. Not the guilt. The guilt would be there for years, maybe always. But some of the weight he had been carrying for three days, the weight that kept his shoulders

rigid and his jaw locked and his eyes dry. That weight had come out with the tears and soaked into the ground beside his mother's bones, and the ground had received it the way it received everything, without judgment.

He turned toward the compound. The iron roof caught the moonlight. A lamp was on inside. He could hear the radio, low, the evening recitation, suras for the dead that had been playing all day across the country. He could hear Sékou moving in the kitchen, the sound of water being poured, a pot being set down. The small sounds of a household finishing its day. Life continuing. The compound breathing.

He walked to the gate. His hand on the latch. The latch he had opened ten thousand times. He lifted it and the sound it made, the familiar scrape of metal on wood, was the sound of every morning he had left for the field and every evening he had come back and the sound had never meant anything before and it meant everything now.

He stepped into the compound and something fell away from him. Not all of it. Not the jerrycan or the sound from the eastern district or the things he would wake up hearing for months to come. But the armor. The rigid set of his body that the camp had built and that three days of walking had not loosened. It loosened now, in the compound, inside the walls. His shoulders dropped. His fists unclenched. He felt his breath move deeper into his lungs than it had moved in a year and the deepness was the compound doing what the compound had always done: telling his body it was safe. His father was in the doorway. Lamp behind him, face in shadow. Neither of them spoke. Ousmane stepped forward and put his arms around his son and held him and the holding was not careful or tentative. It was the holding of a man who had carried stones and sacks of grain and his wife when she could no longer walk, and the arms knew how to hold something heavy without asking it to be lighter.

Ibrahim let himself be held. His face against his father's shoulder. The shirt smelled of millet and woodsmoke and sweat and the smell was the same smell from the road, the smell that had reached the folded place, and the place was unfolding now, crease by crease, in his father's arms.

Then he saw Awa.

She was standing behind Ousmane, in the lamplight. Her face. Her eyes. She was looking at him the way she used to look at the constitutional law textbook when she found a clause that did not make sense, reading him, searching for the logic, trying to reconcile what she was seeing with what she knew.

He was not ready for her. He had prepared himself for his father, the phone calls, the voice, the rope that had pulled him south. He had not prepared for his sister. Seeing her face was like seeing a photograph of who he used to be, and the

photograph did not match the man standing in the compound in boots that did not belong here, and the mismatch was visible in her eyes and he could not hide from it because Awa had always seen him clearly, even when he did not want to be seen.

“Awa.”

She did not speak. She walked to him and she put her arms around him and the holding was different from their father’s, lighter, fiercer, the holding of a sister who was angry and relieved and afraid and who was not going to let go until she had decided which of those things she was most.

He stood in the compound with his father’s hand on his back and his sister’s arms around his chest and Sékou watching from the kitchen doorway and the lamp burning and the radio playing the suras and the stars overhead and the tree beyond the wall, and he was home.

He was home and he was changed and the change could not be unchanged and the family knew it and knowing did not matter tonight. Tonight he was home. Tomorrow would be harder. Tomorrow the questions would come and he would not have answers for most of them. But tomorrow was tomorrow.

Tonight it was still on his back and the compound smelled like woodsmoke and the gate was closed behind him.

[End of Day 6: “The Silence”]

* * *

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DAY 7: SATURDAY

“The Vote”

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“The ballot is stronger than the bullet.” — Abraham Lincoln

* * *

Chapter 41

Diallo voted at eight-fourteen in the morning at the Lycée Mamadou Konaté, Ward 7, Port Sélani.

The gendarmerie had secured the school before dawn. Two armored vehicles at the intersection, officers at both gates, the perimeter cleared and rechecked twice. After Thursday, nothing was being left to chance. Diallo arrived with Captain Ndoye and four plainclothes officers in two vehicles, less than protocol demanded, more than he wanted. He had argued for driving himself. Ndoye had refused. A president voting two days after a shooting does not drive himself, and the argument had ended there because Ndoye was right and Diallo was tired of being wrong about things that should have been obvious.

The press pool was already inside, six cameras, penned behind a rope line at the back of the classroom. The room smelled of chalk dust and floor wax and the sweat of the people who had been waiting since dawn. Sixty-three voters had arrived before him. The line stretched from the door to the street, watched by four AU observers under a tarp at the entrance, Dr. Ndiaye among them, her notebook open.

He joined the line. Not at the front. He had insisted on this. He would wait like everyone else. The gendarmerie had wanted to clear the queue and let him vote first, and he had told Ndoye that if a single voter was moved out of line for his convenience he would vote last. Ndoye had passed the message. The line was undisturbed. Nobody spoke to him. The woman ahead of him glanced back once, saw who he was, and turned forward without a word. He understood. He was the man who had brought them to this question. The ballot existed because he had negotiated the deal and scheduled the vote, and now the country was answering, and neither side could control what the other produced.

The line moved slowly. The polling officers checked each registration card against the roll, each card, each name, each face compared to each photograph. Methodical and public. The care was the point. The AU observers watched. Dr. Ndiaye's pen moved. The booth was a wooden frame with a blue cloth curtain. The curtain hung from a metal rod that was slightly bent, leaving a gap on the left side. Not entirely

private. The best the country could offer.

The polling officer handed him the ballot. A single sheet, white, two boxes, YES on the left, NO on the right. The paper was thin. He could feel both sides between his fingers.

He stepped behind the curtain.

Seven days. The bond math. The boy. The deal. The grove. The son's op-ed. The locked door at the hospital and the blood that arrived thirty-eight minutes too late. Mariama on the stretcher, looking at him. Promise me you will fix this.

He picked up the pen. He marked the paper.

He folded it, stepped out, and placed it in the padlocked wooden box. The paper slid through the slot and disappeared. The question had left his hands.

The polling officer pressed his right thumb into the purple ink pad, indelible, the dye that would stay on his skin for five days, and pressed it against the register beside his name. He looked at his thumb. The same mark as the teacher and the market woman and the mechanic in line behind him. The same purple.

He walked out into the white heat. The line was longer now, two hundred people, three hundred, stretching around the building. They were not talking. They were standing in the sun, carrying whatever they carried, waiting to enter a wooden booth and mark a piece of paper that weighed almost nothing.

The cameras followed him to the car. He did not wave. He did not make a statement. He got in and Ndoye drove him to the palace. The cranes were still. The ocean was flat. It was eight-thirty-seven. The polls would close at six. The counting would begin at seven. The result would be announced by midnight. He sat at his desk. He looked at his purple thumb. He waited.

Chapter 42

Fatou voted at nine-forty in the corridor, in a schoolroom with thirty desks that had each been built by a different father, and she thought about her own father as the ballot touched her fingers. She had driven out with Moussa at six. The highway was empty but the Saturday quiet felt different from the mourning quiet, lighter, the shutters still down but people moving, walking toward polling stations in ones and twos and family groups with the unhurried purpose of people who have somewhere certain to be. She was not wearing her press credentials. She had left the lanyard and the laminated card on the hotel desk beside her laptop. Today she was Fatou Mensah, daughter of Amadou Mensah, Kessaran citizen.

The schoolroom was the one near Madame Konaté's village, one room, tin roof, a blackboard where the multiplication table was still unfinished, seven times eight waiting for its answer. The desks had been pushed to the walls to make space for the voting station: a table, two officials in orange electoral commission vests, a wooden ballot box, an ink pad. The officials were young and serious, checking each card with the care of people who understood what they were protecting.

The line was short. Forty people. She recognized faces from the junction market, from the groundnut circle under the mango tree. The women in line had Kadiatou's posture, straight backs, patient stances, the expression of people who had been told their opinion did not matter and were standing in the heat to give it anyway. She stood in the line. A child played in the dirt beside the building, drawing lines with a stick, absorbed in something that had nothing to do with the referendum and everything to do with being five years old on a Saturday morning.

She thought about her father. Amadou Mensah. Senior clerk. The man who stamped the papers and read the numbers and saw the arrangement, ninety-one to nine, and wrote the memorandum and kept the copy and was visited by a polite man who drank his tea and left without a card. Her father should be in this line. He should be standing in the heat with his registration card and his careful French and his quiet hands that cooked thieboudienne with too much tomato. He should be making this mark.

He was in Toronto. Twenty-six years away from this line. Driven out by a system that punished the clerk who read the numbers correctly. And now the numbers were back, different minerals, different buyer, same arrangement, and the clerk's daughter was standing where the clerk should have been. Keep copies, her mother had said. Fatou was the copy. Her father's honesty, returned to the country that had expelled the original. The booth was a wooden frame with a blue curtain. She stepped inside.

The ballot. White paper. Two boxes. YES. NO.

She held the paper. She thought about Youssouf in the white shirt. She thought about Madame Konaté on the bench. She thought about the padlock on the Ministry of Mines. She thought about her mother packing soft things into suitcases. She thought about the chief who said "nobody is offering us those things." She thought about Kadiatou: "When they start asking, it means they have already decided."

She marked the paper.

She folded it, stepped out, and placed it in the box. The paper disappeared.

The official pressed her thumb into the purple ink. The ink was cool against her skin after the heat. The dye was indelible, five days on the skin, designed to prevent double voting, which meant every person who left this schoolroom would carry the evidence of their choice on their body for the rest of the week.

She looked at her thumb. Purple. The same shade she had seen on the pavement outside the hospital, where Youssouf's blood had mixed with the water the city sent to wash the square. She would carry both, the footage on her phone, the ink on her thumb. She walked out into the white heat. Moussa was leaning against the car, his thumb already purple. He did not ask how she had voted. He opened the car door.

She got in. She held her thumb up to the light through the windshield. The purple caught the sun. The mark would still be there when she flew back to London. It would be there when she filed her final dispatch. It would be there when she called her mother and said: I voted, Mama. I voted in the country you left.

Chapter 43

Thierno Bâ voted at eleven-twenty, and the voting nearly caused a riot.

He had planned to go early, before the crowds. Boubacar drove. No escort, no security. The brotherhood did not operate that way. But someone had seen the car leave the compound and by the time they reached the school on Rue de la Mosquée, three hundred people were waiting outside the polling station. Not in line. Waiting for him. Phones raised, cameras filming, the crowd pressing against the school's metal fence with the energy of people who believed that watching their imam vote would tell them something his sermon had refused to.

Boubacar stopped the car fifty meters from the gate. "We should go back."

"If I go back, the story tomorrow is that the Grand Marabout was afraid to vote. Drive forward."

The crowd parted. Not because anyone told them to. They parted because they had been parting for Thierno Bâ since they were children and their bodies knew the motion. He walked through them with his hands clasped in front of him, his eyes forward. People reached out to touch his robe. A woman called his name. A man held up a child. The cameras followed him like sunlight follows a moving object, every angle covered, every step recorded.

The polling officers looked terrified. The queue inside the school had frozen, twenty voters standing motionless, watching the imam enter. The AU observer at the door was writing furiously.

Thierno Bâ presented his registration card. The officer checked it against the roll, her hands shaking slightly. He waited. The procedure was the procedure. He would not be treated differently. He stepped into the booth and pulled the curtain closed. The ballot. Two boxes. YES. NO.

He had told six thousand people that he did not know. He had told the president that God does not choose sides in referendums. He had told himself, in the dark study at midnight, that the weight belonged to the people and not to him.

But the booth did not care about sermons. The booth was a curtain and a piece of paper and a pen, and the pen required a mark, and the mark required a decision, and

the decision could not be returned to the congregation or deferred to God or dissolved in tea. The booth was the place where the imam ended and the man began, and the man had to choose.

He stood there longer than any voter before him. Outside the curtain, the polling station was silent. The officers, the observers, the twenty voters in the queue, all of them watching the blue curtain and the shadow behind it, the silhouette of an old man standing very still with a pen in his hand.

He thought about the donkey. He thought about the field. He thought about the boy under the sheet and the president in his kitchen and the farmer whose name he did not know but whose land he had circled on a map. He thought about his father, who would have said: "Pray, and then decide. The prayer is for God. The decision is for you."

He marked the paper.

He folded it, stepped out, and placed it in the box. The polling officer inked his thumb. He looked at the purple and almost smiled. The Grand Marabout, marked like everyone else.

He walked out of the school and the crowd surged forward. Not violently, urgently. They wanted to know. The question was on every face, in every raised phone, in the reporters shouting from behind the fence: Which way did he vote? Which way did the imam vote? The question the sermon had refused to answer, the question the country had been leaning toward all week, surely the thumb would tell them, surely the walk would tell them, surely something in his face would reveal what the ballot had hidden.

He gave them nothing. He walked to the car with the same pace he had entered, hands clasped, eyes forward. Boubacar opened the door. He got in.

As the car pulled away, the crowd began to argue. Some said he had voted Yes, his silence was permission, and permission meant approval. Some said he had voted No, his sermon was a rebuke to the president, and the rebuke meant opposition. Some said it did not matter, that the imam had told them to decide for themselves and the deciding was the point.

The argument would last all day. It would last longer than the counting. It would become, in the weeks that followed, its own kind of sermon, not the one he had given from the minbar, but the one the country gave itself, standing in the heat outside a school, debating what a man's silence meant and whether silence was leadership or abdication or the hardest kind of honesty. Thierno Bâ did not hear the argument. He was in the car, heading home, his purple thumb resting on his knee. He had voted. The vote was private. The privacy was the last gift he could give a country that wanted him to choose for them.

Chapter 44

Aminata walked to the polling station with Hawa at ten-fifteen. Six blocks. Hawa had put on her school shoes even though it was Saturday, combed her hair, and asked if she could come. Aminata had said yes because some things are taught in schoolrooms and some things are taught by standing in a line in the heat and watching your mother vote.

Hawa held her hand. The grip was warm and sure, the grip of a child who has not yet learned to hesitate.

The woman at the corner who sold phone credit nodded as they passed. The mechanic whose shop was shuttered raised a hand, not a wave, not quite, just the gesture of a man who had heard the speech and had not decided what he thought of it. Two university students stopped to shake her hand. She kept walking.

The streets were worn. She noticed it today in a way she usually didn't, the cracked pavement, the drainage ditch choked with plastic, the school wall where the yellow paint had faded to the color of old paper. A woman carried a basin of mangoes on her head, walking to sell them to the people in line. A boy sat on a step repairing a sandal with wire. The poverty was not dramatic. It was ordinary, structural, the kind that doesn't make the news because it never changes enough to be new. These were the people the deal promised to help. These were the people who would pay if it didn't. At the intersection near the school, she saw two Chinese women standing at the edge of the road. They were watching the line of voters the way you watch something you have a stake in but cannot participate in. One of them, shorter, mid-thirties, dusty work boots, was speaking quietly to the other. Aminata heard the taller one call her Liwei. The name meant nothing, but the face did. Liwei looked worried. Not the worry of a strategist calculating outcomes. The worry of a person watching something she cared about and could not control. Her colleague touched her arm.

Aminata looked at them and felt something shift. She had spent the week arguing against the company, the deal, the machinery of extraction. But these two women were not the machinery. They were employees, engineers probably, standing on a street corner in a country that was not theirs, watching the vote that would decide

whether the work they had been doing for months would continue or be erased. They were no different from the government contractors whose companies had profited from Kessara for decades, the same arrangement, the same pattern of foreign money buying local access, the same ordinary people doing their jobs inside systems they did not design. The Chinese company had its private military contractors. The government had the gendarmerie who shot Youssouf. Both systems produced violence. Both employed people who were kind and people who were not. Both promised progress and delivered it unevenly.

There was no clean side. She had known this since the helicopter. But seeing Liwei's face made it physical, not an argument she could make in a courtroom but a woman her own age, standing in the heat, hoping.

She joined the line. Two hundred people. The line moved slowly. People looked at her. They always looked, she was the face from the television, the voice from the rally. Some of them would vote Yes today. She could see it in their faces. Not defiance. Calculation. The calculation of people who needed the hospitals and the jobs and the twelve thousand salaries the deal promised, and who understood that twelve thousand was not fifty thousand but twelve thousand was not zero, and zero was what they had now.

If the No won, what came next? She had the legal arguments but she did not have a counter-offer. She had told them what the deal took. She had not told them what replaced it. Nobody had. The

No was a refusal without an alternative, and the people in this line knew it, and they were voting anyway, each of them carrying their own private arithmetic of hope and fear into a wooden booth. She entered the booth. The blue curtain. The paper. The pen. She marked it. No. Her hand did not shake.

She stepped out and placed the ballot in the box. The official pressed her thumb into the purple ink.

Outside, Hawa was waiting. She took Aminata's hand, the marked hand, and looked at the thumb.

"Does it wash off?"

"No. It stays."

"For how long?"

"Five days."

Hawa touched the purple with her fingertip. The ink transferred, a faint smudge on the pad of a twelve-year-old's index finger. She held it up to the sun.

"Now I have it too," she said.

Aminata looked at the smudge on her daughter's finger. The stain passed from mother to child, the way everything passes, the frown, the recipe, the fight. Hawa would inherit this country whatever the count produced tonight. The schools that opened or closed, the hospitals that worked or didn't, the ground that was sold or kept. All of it would be hers.

They walked home in the heat. Six blocks. Hawa's hand in hers.

Chapter 45

Ibrahim woke to porridge. Sékou had made it. The same porridge, the same spoon-stands-up test. He ate slowly, sitting on the ground in the compound, because his body had forgotten the pace of food that was not rationed and not timed and not eaten standing up between tasks. Sékou watched him eat and said nothing.

Awa was there. She had stayed the night. She sat across from Ibrahim in the morning light and he could see her studying him, trying to match the brother she remembered with the man sitting in front of her. She could see the difference and she was not able to hide that she saw it.

“You’re thinner,” she said.

“Yes.”

“Are you eating?”

“Sékou’s porridge.”

“It’s the same as Mama’s.”

“I know.”

She knew about the military company. Ousmane had told her last night. She carried the knowledge badly. Her composure, built for rallies and courtrooms, was not made for sitting across from a brother who had been broken by the kind of system she had spent the week fighting with legal arguments and constitutional clauses. She had been fighting about sovereignty and minerals. Now the fight had a face and the face was her brother’s and the brother was thinner and the thinness was the cost.

She hugged him. Tight and brief. Her breath caught once and Ibrahim felt it.

“I’m not going to vote,” she said.

Ousmane looked at her.

“I organized the vigil. I gave the speech. I printed four hundred and sixty-three photographs and stood in a courtyard and said a dead boy’s name until my voice broke. I have done more than most to shape this vote.” She paused. “But I spent the week treating the deal like a legal problem and it is not a legal problem. It is a human problem. Ibrahim is the proof.” She looked at her brother. “I was so certain I was right that I never asked who would suffer from my certainty. I don’t know who is right

anymore. I know the deal is flawed. I know the alternative is nothing. I cannot mark a paper when I don't know which answer hurts fewer people."

Ousmane did not argue. Sékou, standing in the kitchen doorway, looked at his sister with the expression of a boy who did not fully understand what was happening but understood that the family was cracked and the crack was older than this week and maybe, this morning, the crack was starting to close.

Ibrahim looked at Awa and felt something he had not expected. Not pity. Admiration. His sister had built a campaign, led a movement, stood on walls and faced down threats, and she was strong enough to say she did not know. He had spent three years following orders because he was not strong enough to refuse them. Awa's refusal to vote was braver than anything he had done in the camp. It was the first act of honest doubt he had witnessed in years, and it made him want to be better than what the camp had made him.

He stood up. "I'll go with you, Papa."

The walk to the polling station was three kilometers. Ousmane, Ibrahim, and Sékou. Three men from the same compound, three different silences. Ousmane walked at the pace of the field, slow, deliberate. Ibrahim adjusted his stride, slowing the military rhythm the camp had trained into his legs. Sékou walked between them, glancing at his brother and then at his father, quietly happy to have them both on the same path.

Ibrahim was wearing Ousmane's spare sandals. The boots were by the door of the compound where he had placed them last night, heels against the wall. He would not wear them again.

"The field is smaller," Ibrahim said, looking at the millet. "The rain is less. Every year."

"What does the vote change?"

"If they vote Yes, the machines come. The tree goes. We go. If they vote No, the rain is still less. The clinic has no medicine. The school has no teacher. Either way, the field needs work." The polling station was in the junction market hall, a covered structure, open-sided, the tin roof held up by wooden posts. No AU observers. No international cameras. A single polling officer at a table with the register and the ink pad and the wooden box. The line was eighty people. The corridor's villages feeding their voters into one station in the heat with no shade except the roof and no water except what people brought. A different country from the schools in Port Sélani with their press pools and their security perimeters. The people in line looked at Ibrahim. They had not seen him in three years. They looked with curiosity and relief and the

careful avoidance of the question everyone wanted to ask and nobody would, because the village offered its returned sons that courtesy. They voted. Ousmane first, then Ibrahim, then Sékou. Each emerged with a purple thumb.

They walked home together. The three kilometers. The path through the fields. The sun white overhead. Sékou walked ahead, kicking a stone along the path as he always did, the habit of a boy who had never left this place and who loved it without knowing he loved it because he had never been anywhere else to compare it to. The stone bounced and rolled and he chased it and kicked it again, and kicking was the most uncomplicated thing any of them had done all week.

At the compound, they sat under the baobab. Ousmane in his place at the roots. Ibrahim beside him, leaning against the trunk, his legs stretched out, not the camp posture, his shoulders loose for the first time in years, his legs stretched out, trying to remember how to sit without being at attention.

Awa brought water. She sat with them. Four people under a tree with three purple thumbs and one unmarked hand, and the unmarked hand was not absence. It was its own kind of vote, the vote of a woman who had fought hard enough to earn the right to say she did not know.

The country was counting. The tree held them while it counted.

Chapter 46

The polls closed at six PM. The counting began at seven. At eight, the country waited.

In the presidential residence, Diallo sat at his desk. The coffee he had poured at seven was untouched. The radio was on, low, the electoral commission's dedicated frequency, broadcasting the count as precincts reported.

In the apartment, Aminata sat at the kitchen table. Hawa was asleep. The stove light was on. The radio was on the counter, low enough not to wake her daughter. Her voter card was beside the salt shaker. Her purple thumb rested on the table.

In the hotel, Fatou sat on the bed with her laptop dark and her phone charging. She had filed her last dispatch at seven-thirty: the count is underway. The next one would say the result.

On the hotel balcony, Liwei stood in the dark. She had spent the morning on the street with her colleague, watching the lines, watching the voters, watching a country decide the fate of the work she had poured herself into for months. The twelve pages were on the nightstand. She was not listening to the radio. She was listening to the city, the generators, the distant traffic, the sound of three million people sitting in their kitchens waiting for a number. In the compound in the Bassam Corridor, the radio was on the shelf. Ousmane was in his chair. Ibrahim was beside him on the bench, his back against the compound wall, the too-big sandals on his feet. Awa was in the doorway. Sékou was behind her. Four people listening to a radio that was telling them, in percentages and precincts, what three million people thought about the field outside.

In the mosque compound, Thierno Bâ was in his study.

Boubacar listened on a small transistor radio in the courtyard, the kind that ran on two batteries and had been sufficient for every announcement the country had made since independence.

In a dark room at the Hôtel Atlantique, Sokolov watched the television crawl, muted, precincts reporting, the numbers rising. His laptop was open. His phone was on the desk.

In the ambassador's residence, Hartley sat with the secure terminal on, the twelve-year Macallan poured, drafting two cables. One for Yes. One for No. Both

began with the same words: “As anticipated.”

The precincts reported. The numbers climbed.

Nine PM. Forty-six percent reporting. Yes was ahead but the margin was unsettled.

Ten PM. Seventy-one percent. The margin narrowed. The rural precincts were reporting now, the corridor, the northern provinces, the places where the deal was not a document but a road through a field, and the rural numbers were different from the capital’s. Eleven PM. Ninety-three percent. The margin narrowed again. Closer than the polls had predicted, closer than either campaign had expected.

At eleven-forty-three PM, the chairman of the electoral commission stepped to the microphone.

“The final result of the national referendum on the Kessara Gateway Partnership. Total ballots cast: three million, two hundred and fourteen thousand, eight hundred and ninety-one. Turnout: eighty-one point two percent.”

A pause.

“YES: fifty-two point three percent. One million, six hundred and eighty-one thousand, four hundred and twelve votes.” “NO: forty-seven point seven percent. One million, five hundred and thirty-three thousand, four hundred and seventy-nine votes.” “The referendum is approved. The Kessara Gateway Partnership is ratified.”

The margin was one hundred and forty-seven thousand votes. Narrow, but large enough that it would not be contested. For a country that had spent seven days tearing itself apart over two words on a piece of paper, the lack of a dispute was a small victory in itself.

In the compound, Ousmane looked at the dark field. He did not speak.

Ibrahim looked at his father. Awa looked at the radio. Sékou looked at the ground.

In the kitchen, Aminata closed her eyes. She opened them. She picked up the voter card and put it in the drawer beside Moussa’s photograph.

In the hotel, Fatou opened her laptop. The screen lit her face. She began to type.

On the balcony, Liwei picked up the twelve pages. The Yes meant the center line would become a railway. The twelve pages were the only document that said what that railway would cost the people in its path. She would send it tomorrow. That was certain now.

In the study, Thierno Bâ picked up the prayer beads.

Ninety-nine names of God, each click continuing in its order regardless of the count.

Sokolov unmuted the television, watched the replay, then picked up the phone and dialed a number that was not Kessaran. “The contract is confirmed,” he said. “Begin

Phase Two.” He hung up, set the alarm for five AM, and slept.

Hartley deleted the No cable and opened the Yes. He read his own first line: “As anticipated, the referendum produced a narrow approval.” He did not change it. He pressed Send. The green progress bar crossed the screen. He finished the Macallan, rinsed the glass, and turned off the lamp.

The radios repeated the result. And again. The country hearing itself, confirming that the speaking had happened.

Outside, the harmattan shifted for the first time in seven days. A dry wind, warm, carrying the fine red dust of the corridor northward across the rooftops of Port Sélani. The dust settled on the polling stations and the hospital courtyard and the palace windows and the iron roofs of the compounds where families sat with their purple thumbs and their radios and their private calculations of what the morning would bring.

Beyond the city, the corridor was dark. The millet fields, the laterite roads, the baobab trees standing in the silence the way they had stood for generations, indifferent to the ballots and the bonds and the cables crossing oceans in both directions.

Beyond the corridor, the country. The borders drawn by men who had never walked the ground they divided, the provinces and the rivers and the escarpments that did not recognize the lines and never would.

Beyond the country, the continent. A thousand negotiations like this one happening in a thousand rooms, the same minerals, the same foreign hands, the same farmers standing in the same fields asking the same questions of governments that changed and changed and changed while the ground beneath them did not. And beyond the continent, above it all, the stars. The same stars Ibrahim had watched for three nights of walking. The same stars Ousmane’s grandfather had navigated by when he carried a seedling south. The same stars that had been overhead when the French drew the first border and when the border was redrawn and when it was redrawn again. The same stars that would be overhead tomorrow night and the night after and the night the railway was built and the night it rusted and the night someone’s grandchild stood in a field that used to be Ousmane’s and looked up and saw them, unchanged, permanent, the only thing in the story that never took a side and never looked away and never, in ten thousand years of people fighting over the ground beneath them, blinked. The night held the country. The stars held the night.

The morning would come.

* * *

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Epilogue

“After”

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Liwei pressed Send at six in the morning, three days before her flight home.

The twelve pages left her laptop and entered the network and traveled to Beijing, and she closed the screen and sat on the hotel bed and waited for the feeling she had expected, relief, perhaps, or the satisfaction of a task completed. The feeling did not come. What came instead was the quiet awareness that she had done what she could and that what she could do was small, but her engineering training had taught her to respect proportion, and this was proportion.

The response arrived two days later: a one-line acknowledgment from the deputy director's office. Received and filed, no further comment. She read it twice and understood that the twelve pages would sit in a folder in a building in Beijing alongside ten thousand other supplementary assessments from ten thousand other corridors in ten thousand other countries, and whether anyone ever opened it again was no longer her decision. She flew home to Chengdu. Her daughter met her at the airport, four years old, holding her grandmother's hand, wearing the red coat Liwei had sent from Port Sélani. The child did not run. She studied her mother's face the way children study faces they have memorized from photographs, comparing the real version to the remembered one, checking for changes. Liwei knelt on the terminal floor and held her and for the first time in months nothing needed to be measured or justified or reported.

Three weeks later, she was reassigned. A water treatment project outside Nairobi. Smaller than Kessara, less contested, the kind of infrastructure work that did not require referendums because nobody argued about clean water the way they argued about railways and mining corridors. She packed the same duffel bag. She did not pack the boots.

In January, the grove boundary was quietly rerouted. An unsigned document in the Ministry of Land Affairs moved the industrial zone line three hundred meters east. Nobody announced why. But someone in Beijing had read something in a supplementary assessment that made the line worth moving, and it had traveled back across the same network the twelve pages had crossed, and the grove was outside the

project.

Liwei did not learn about this for months, and when she did, a passing mention in an engineering bulletin she almost did not open. She sat in her Nairobi office and looked at the ceiling and felt the proportion shift. Small was not nothing. Small was a grove. Fatou could have told her about the grove. Fatou was learning that the connections between things in Kessara ran deeper than any single story, that the coltan license her father had flagged in 1997 and the lithium corridor the referendum had approved were chapters in the same book, written by different hands in different decades but bound by the same spine: foreign mineral, domestic cost, a clerk or an engineer or a journalist who saw the terms clearly and had to decide what to do with the seeing.

She stayed. She rented a room above the Le Réveil office and bought a desk at the market and worked by kerosene lamp when the power failed every evening. She was investigating the Ministry of Mines, the building on the Plateau, the padlock, the 1997 files. She interviewed retired clerks who remembered her father, careful men who spoke in careful sentences and looked at the door while they spoke. The requests she filed were denied. She filed again. Her father had filed again. She had inherited that stubbornness along with his hands.

Her mother called every Sunday.

"Are you safe?"

"I'm safe, Mama."

"Are you keeping copies?"

"I'm keeping copies."

Three copies, three locations, three places the evidence could survive. Her father's instinct, passed forward. The investigation would take years. She had years. She had her father's patience and her mother's discipline and a desk in a room above a newspaper office in the country her parents had been forced to leave, and the desk was enough and the country was hers again, and reclaiming was quiet and daily and would not make the news.

The news Aminata was making was quieter too. The Foundation had cut the funding in October. The board's mineral interests no longer aligned with a lost campaign, and she had called Khadija and said two words: "We start over."

They started over. No helicopter. No borrowed SUV. The buses ran on donations from the market women who sold groundnuts at the junction and who gave what they could because Aminata had stood in the heat and said their names and they remembered. The leaflets were printed at the copy shop where Awa had printed

Youssouf's photograph, and the owner gave her a discount because the owner remembered too. The work was slower and the money was visible and every franc accounted for, which was the promise Aminata had made herself after the helicopter: never again build on a foundation she could not see through.

She told Hawa about Moussa on a Sunday in November. The kitchen table. The stove light on. She took the photograph from the drawer, the blue shirt, the quiet face, and put it between them. "This is your uncle Moussa. My brother."

Hawa picked it up and held it close, searching the face for something she recognized in her own.

"He looks like me," she said.

"You have his frown."

"What happened to him?"

Aminata told her what she could, the organizing, the standing in front of rooms, the day he did not come home. Not the details the state had buried. That was enough for now. Hawa would ask again when she was older. The asking would come in stages, the way all difficult knowledge comes to children, not in a single telling but in layers, each layer settling before the next one is laid down, each one changing the ground slightly, the way seasons change a field. "Is that why you do this?" Hawa asked. "The campaign?"

"Yes. That is why I do this."

Hawa put the photograph on the table and looked at it for a long time without speaking, and Aminata watched her daughter decide how much she was ready to carry, and the deciding was the bravest thing she had seen all year, braver than any speech she had given or any wall Awa had stood on, because it was a child choosing to grow up one conversation at a time and not flinching from the choice. The grove that Liwei's twelve pages had helped to save was three hundred meters from Ousmane's eastern field, and Dramane walked to it every evening as he always had, the path, the lamp, the shea butter flame gold and slow in the darkness. He placed the offerings at the base of the oldest tree: kola, grain, water, millet from a neighboring field because Ousmane's millet was gone. He spoke the words. The grove received them.

The survey flags were gone. The holes where the wire stakes had stood were filling with leaves. Kofi was learning the path and the words and the names of the trees, and the learning was slow because the knowledge was old and old knowledge does not hurry, and Dramane did not hurry it. The grove had outlived the French and the British and the military government and two coups and a famine and now it had outlived a

referendum, and the outliving was not victory. It was simply what the grove did. It stood, and standing was enough.

Three hundred meters west, the baobab did not stand.

The chainsaws came on a Tuesday in December at five in the morning. Ousmane had been awake since four, planting millet seed in the western rows by the light of the kerosene lamp, pressing each seed into the soil with his thumb the way his father had taught him, firm enough to hold, gentle enough not to bruise. He might not harvest this crop. The resettlement notice on the shelf beside the radio said he might not be here in the spring. But the planting was the only thing left that was entirely his, and a man who stops planting has already left, and Ousmane had not left.

He heard the trucks on the road. The heavy diesel, the slow grinding of engines carrying equipment. He stood in the compound doorway in the dark and listened and knew.

They parked at the edge of the field. Four men in hard hats and orange vests. Two chainsaws. The headlights swept across the unplanted eastern rows and came to rest on the baobab.

Ibrahim came out barefoot and stood beside his father. Sékou came out and stood beside his brother. Three men in a doorway watching headlights reach their tree.

The baobab had been there for the entire lives of all three of them. Ibrahim had climbed it at six and fallen out of it at seven and climbed it again the same afternoon. Awa had read under it every day after school, her back against the trunk, her books on her knees. Sékou had carved his name in the lower bark when he was nine. Ousmane had scolded him and the letters were still there, healed into the wood, stretched by years of growth until they looked less like a name and more like a scar the tree had chosen to keep. Their mother was buried twenty paces from the roots. Their grandfather had carried the seedling for three days and planted it the morning the country was born.

The chainsaws started. The sound was a high grinding scream that flattened the morning and entered the body through the chest. It scattered the goats and sent the chickens running against the compound wall. Ousmane felt it in his ribs.

The weaverbirds did not leave. Seven of them, nesting in the upper branches in pouches they had woven from grass and palm fiber, the elaborate architecture of birds who build and rebuild in the same tree year after year. December was dry season, no eggs, no chicks, the nests empty, but the birds stayed. They hopped from branch to branch, turning their heads to watch the men below, agitated but not fleeing. The tree was their home. They had built here and they trusted here, and the trust held them in

the canopy while the chainsaws worked the trunk below.

The bark came off in strips. The wood underneath was pale and wet, moisture the tree had stored for years, the rain from three seasons ago and five and ten, saved for the droughts that came and went. The chainsaws released it. A decade of rain ran down the trunk in dark streaks and soaked into the ground in minutes. The men cut a wedge on the eastern side and started the back cut. The tree groaned, not the sound of wood breaking but something deeper, structural, the sound of sixty-three years of standing beginning to end. The vibration traveled up through the heartwood and into the branches. The weaverbirds felt it before the men did. The branches tilted. The nests swung. And the birds understood, all seven, in the same instant, that the thing they had trusted was falling.

They flew. A burst of wings and alarm calls, scattering south and east, their nests still hanging in the branches, their homes traveling with the tree as it leaned and leaned and then went over, the canopy sweeping through the air, the sound when it hit the ground low and long and final, not a crash but a settling, the sound of something that had been standing since the country was born finally lying down in the country's dirt.

The dust rose and hung in the headlights.

One of the workers' phones rang. A tinny melody in the settling dust. The man pulled it from his vest pocket, answered, turned away. Inside that phone, inside every phone in every pocket on every continent, the rare earths. Tantalum in the capacitors, neodymium in the speaker magnets, lithium in the battery. The minerals beneath this field and every field in the corridor. The minerals the deal was designed to reach. The phone in the worker's hand was the reason the tree was on the ground, and the worker did not know this, and the caller did not know this, and the laughter between them was easy and ordinary. Sékou turned away. Ousmane saw his youngest son's face close like a door and could not reach through it.

The crew cut the trunk into sections and loaded them on the flatbed and drove away. By eight the field had a stump where the tree had been, wide, flat, the rings visible, sixty-three circles darkening in the morning air.

Ousmane walked to it. He put his hand on the cut surface. Still wet. Still warm from the friction of the blade. He stood there with his palm on the wood his grandfather had carried and said nothing because there was nothing to say that the hand was not already saying.

A piece of bark lay on the ground beside the stump, torn loose by the saw. He picked it up. It was the size of his palm, rough on the outside, smooth where the living

wood had been. He put it in his pouch, with the seeds.

Then he went back to the western rows and knelt in the soil and continued planting.

The seed went into the ground. The ground received it. He had no other language left. The seed said it for him: I am still here. And the field heard him, the way it had always heard him, the way it would hear whoever came after him and knelt in this dirt and pressed a seed down and waited for the rain.

Ibrahim worked beside him. One row apart. He did not talk about the camp. Some nights the sounds returned, a truck on the road at a certain hour, a dog barking at a certain pitch, and his body would lock and his breathing would shorten and he would be in two places at once. He would count. The sounds would pass. In the mornings the air smelled like millet and woodsmoke and the smell brought him back each time, a little further back, the folded place inside him unfolding slowly, crease by crease, in the patient company of his father and his brother and the field that asked nothing of him except that he show up and bend and pull and move forward one row at a time.

The boots stayed by the compound door. After three months the corridor's dust had covered them completely, the same red-brown as the wall, the field reclaiming them the way the field reclaimed everything that was left in its care long enough.

The weaverbirds came back in the spring. Not to the stump, to the neem tree at the compound gate, which was smaller and offered less shelter but which was standing. They built. The nests were cruder than the ones they had woven in the baobab, adapted to thinner branches, the architecture of birds who had lost their cathedral and were building a chapel and were building it anyway, because building was what they did and the building would not stop.

On a Friday morning in March, the muezzin called from the minaret at five-twelve.

Thierno Bâ rose for the fajr prayer the way he had risen every morning for fifty-four years. His knees were slower now. The rug was worn thin in the place where his forehead touched, the fabric softened by ten thousand prostrations into something that felt less like cloth and more like the ground itself.

He knelt. The beads were in his hands. Ninety-nine names, each click a word older than the country, the sequence continuing in its order the way it had continued through every government and every crisis and every referendum the country had held or would hold, the names not caring about outcomes because the names were not about outcomes. The names were about continuity. The prayer was about the morning. The morning was about beginning again. Outside, the call was joined by other calls from other minarets across Port Sélani, the industrial district, the Plateau, the port quarter, the neighborhoods where the construction cranes had resumed their turning and the

hospital was open and the schools were open and the Nescafé woman was at her stall with her whisk clicking against the cup, the sound that had been the metronome of the city's mornings before the referendum and that was the metronome again now, because the city had decided and the decision was done and the morning did not care about decisions. The morning cared about coffee.

The calls layered over each other, rising from the minarets and converging over the rooftops, filling Port Sélani with a sound that had been filling it for longer than the cranes and the cables and the deals, a sound that would fill it after the railway was built and after the railway rusted and after whatever came next came and went the way everything came and went except the call itself, which did not come and go but simply came, every morning, at five-twelve, whether the country was ready for it or not.

The sun rose. The light moved west across the city and the corridor and the fields and the stump where the baobab had been and the neem tree where the weaverbirds were building and the grove where Dramane's lamp had burned the night before and the grave where Aïssatou slept and the ground that held everything, the minerals and the bones and the seeds and the rain, and asked nothing in return except that someone keep planting and someone keep tending and someone keep praying and someone keep building, even in the smaller tree, even with the thinner branches, even now.

The muezzin finished. The city breathed. The morning continued.

* * *

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The Mirror

An Afterword

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"Facts do not cease to exist because they are ignored." — Aldous Huxley

Everything you just read is invented. Kessara is not on any map. Ousmane's baobab does not exist. Youssouf Coulibaly never died on a Thursday afternoon in a hospital that could not save him, because Youssouf Coulibaly was never born.

None of it is fiction.

The novel you have just finished is a composite, assembled from real deals, real debts, real countries, real consequences, and real people whose names I changed because a story can sometimes go where a headline cannot. What follows is the world I was looking at while I wrote it. Not all of it. But enough for you to see that the architecture of this novel was not built from imagination. It was built from the news. From the data. From the ground.

I wrote this afterword because I believe you deserve to know what is real. And because I believe that once you know, you cannot unknow it, and that awareness is where the real work begins.

I. The Deal Is Always Real

In the novel, the Kessara Gateway Project is a \$12.4 billion Chinese infrastructure package, a deep-water port, a rail corridor, a processing facility, a Special Economic Zone, offered to a country with \$8.2 billion in debt and no good options. The deal includes a 99-year lease on the port and SEZ land. It promises 50,000 jobs. It requires the resettlement of farming communities in the Bassam Corridor. It is genuinely ambiguous, offering real investment that the country needs, on terms that compromise the country's sovereignty in ways that may take decades to become visible. This deal is real. Not in one place, but in dozens.

The 99-year lease comes from Sri Lanka. In 2017, Sri Lanka leased a 70 percent controlling stake in Hambantota Port to a Chinese state-linked company for 99 years, receiving \$1.12 billion. The port had been built with Chinese loans. When Sri Lanka couldn't service its broader debts, debts owed mostly to Western bondholders, not to China, the lease became the exit. A country traded a century of control over a strategic asset to solve a short-term fiscal crisis.

The story is more complicated than the headlines suggest, and that complication matters. Hambantota was Sri Lanka's idea, not China's. It had been in the country's development plans since 2002. The lease money didn't repay Chinese debt, it went to pay Western creditors. Chinese lending was less than five percent of Sri Lanka's total debt repayments at the time. And 99-year port leases exist everywhere, Australia has leased several ports for similar terms. By 2024, Hambantota had become a functioning transshipment hub handling hundreds of thousands of vehicles monthly.

So was it a trap? Or was it a transaction between a desperate borrower and a willing lender, structured in a way that benefited both parties unequally? That ambiguity, the impossibility of a clean answer, is the reason I wrote the novel the way

I did. Diallo's deal is not a trap. It is not a gift. It is the kind of arrangement that happens when a country with resources and no money meets a country with money and no resources, and both sides know exactly what the other needs.

The rail corridor in the novel draws from Kenya's Standard Gauge Railway, \$3.6 billion of Chinese-funded construction connecting Mombasa to Nairobi. It was supposed to transform the economy. It operates at a loss. The debt remains. Chinese workers were imported over Kenyan objections, creating the same tension that simmers in the novel's SEZ labor provisions: who builds the infrastructure that is supposed to create local jobs?

The mineral extraction component draws from Guinea's Simandou iron ore project, a 650-kilometer railway and deep-water port, much of it Chinese-owned, connecting the coast to one of the world's largest untapped iron ore deposits. China received its first Simandou shipment in early 2026. This is perhaps the closest real-world analog to the Kessara Gateway: a corridor from coast to interior mines, built by Chinese companies, designed to move African resources to non-African markets.

The Special Economic Zone in the novel mirrors Zambia's Chambishi Multi-Facility Economic Zone, one of Africa's first Chinese SEZs, located in the copper belt of a country I know well. I grew up there. Zambia's copper funded Chinese manufacturing for decades. The wealth flowed in one direction. The debt accumulated in the other. In 2020, Zambia became the first African country to default on its sovereign debt during the pandemic. It took four years to restructure.

And Djibouti, a nation smaller than the state of New Hampshire, home to both the largest American military base in Africa (Camp Lemonnier) and China's first overseas military base, separated by a few kilometers of desert. Two superpowers, one tiny country, both claiming to serve its interests. Djibouti's debt-to-GDP ratio exceeds 100 percent, with over 70 percent owed to China. Its port infrastructure, the country's primary economic asset, is substantially under Chinese operational control.

In Nigeria, a single BRI construction contract in 2025, the Ogidigben Gas Revolution Industrial Park, was worth \$20 billion. One contract. In one country. That is the scale the Kessara Gateway deal is meant to evoke. These are not aid packages. They are not charity. They are commercial transactions of a size that reshapes the fiscal reality of the recipient country for decades. And then there are the deals that did not happen. Tanzania's Bagamoyo port, a \$10 billion project that would have been East Africa's largest, was cancelled after the Tanzanian government concluded the terms were too one-sided. The cancellation cost political capital and lost the country a transformative piece of infrastructure. It also demonstrated something the novel's

Diallo understands: the power to say no is real, but it is not free. Saying no to a bad deal does not produce a good one. It produces no deal. And a country with \$8.2 billion in debt and a bond payment due in 60 days cannot eat the principle of sovereignty.

Here is the number that holds all of this together: China's Belt and Road Initiative reached \$1.4 trillion in cumulative engagement across 150 countries by 2025. Africa became its top investment destination that year, receiving \$61.2 billion, a 283 percent increase over the previous year. China-Africa total trade hit \$348 billion. By comparison, total American trade with Africa was \$105 billion, less than a third of China's volume.

These numbers are not good or bad. They are the landscape. They are the field in which every character in this novel is standing, making decisions with incomplete information, under pressure from forces they can see and forces they cannot. The deal in the novel is not a metaphor. It is a Tuesday.

II. The Other Empire in the Room

Ambassador Hartley drinks Macallan and drafts cables and quotes Achebe at dinner parties and genuinely believes that American interests and African interests naturally align. He is, in the novel, the most dangerous kind of imperialist, the kind who does not know he is one.

Hartley is a composite of career American diplomats in Africa, and the system he represents is real.

When the novel's Freedom and Prosperity Initiative pulls its funding from Kessara, it mirrors what happened across Africa beginning in January 2025, when the United States suspended foreign aid worldwide. USAID, which had a budget of \$63 billion in 2023 and provided assistance to approximately 130 countries, was effectively gutted. Nearly 85 percent of funded projects were cancelled outright. In 2023, USAID had allocated \$12.1 billion to sub-Saharan Africa for healthcare, food assistance, and security programs. The suspension eliminated 90 percent of all American foreign aid contracts.

The consequences arrived immediately. The Democratic Republic of the Congo, which had received over 70 percent of its humanitarian assistance from the United States, had 25 million people in need of emergency assistance when the funding disappeared. Fifty countries lost HIV/AIDS services for testing, treatment, and prevention. The World Health Organization projected 10 million additional HIV cases and 3 million HIV-related deaths as a result. In South Sudan, mothers and children

died after being unable to access clinics for life-saving medication. Over 80 percent of food kitchens feeding Sudanese civil war refugees were closed. By December 2025, cholera deaths in the DRC had increased 361 percent. Estimates suggested between 500,000 and one million additional deaths annually from the cuts across Africa. A child under five could die every 40 seconds by 2030 as a result. Approximately 200,000 under-five deaths were projected in 2025 alone.

The United States was not alone. Germany cut over €4.8 billion in development assistance between 2022 and 2025. France reduced its aid budget by over \$1 billion. The United Kingdom cut \$900 million. Across wealthy nations, aid to Africa was retreating at the moment Africa needed it most.

This is the fiscal vacuum that makes the Chinese deal in the novel necessary. When Diallo tells his cabinet that the bond payment is due in 60 days and there is no American money coming, he is describing the reality that dozens of real African leaders faced in 2025. The choice was not between a good option and a bad option. It was between the option that existed and the one that had been withdrawn.

The Alderton Foundation in the novel, the American-funded organization supporting Aminata's No campaign, draws from real organizations that channel American government and private-sector funding into African civil society, opposition movements, and media. Organizations like the National Endowment for Democracy do genuine good: supporting press freedom, election monitoring, legal reform. They also serve as instruments of American foreign policy, funding outcomes that align with Washington's strategic interests. Aminata's dilemma, taking money that serves a cause she believes in, from sources that believe in something different, is a dilemma that real opposition leaders across Africa navigate every day.

And then there is the mineral scramble. The novel's subplot about American interest in Bassam lithium reflects the real-world race for critical minerals. The U.S. Inflation Reduction Act's requirements for domestic or allied-nation mineral sourcing turned African lithium, cobalt, and rare earth deposits into strategic assets overnight. In 2025, as M23 rebels seized territory in eastern Congo, DRC President Tshisekedi offered the United States access to critical minerals in exchange for security assistance. The Washington Accords followed, brokering peace while granting American companies preferential mineral access. A \$9 billion transaction gave a U.S.-backed consortium a 40 percent stake in two of the DRC's largest copper and cobalt operations. The DRC negotiated under extreme military pressure.

The mechanism is different from China's. The objective, secure access to African minerals for non-African economies, is the same.

Hartley's character is designed to illuminate a specific danger, the danger of benevolent imperialism. The novel suggests that this belief, that American and African interests naturally align, is more dangerous than overt exploitation, because it is harder to see and harder to refuse. When China builds a port, the transaction is visible, concrete, steel, a lease agreement with dates and terms. When America funds a civil society organization that supports an opposition candidate whose election would improve American mineral access, the transaction is invisible. It is wrapped in the language of democracy, governance, rule of law. The language is not false, the organizations do genuine good. But the strategic architecture beneath the good is real, and the people receiving the funding are rarely told the full picture.

The novel does not feature direct American military engagement, but it exists at the edges. The United States Africa Command, AFRICOM, maintains over 7,000 military personnel conducting operations across more than 20 African countries, often with minimal congressional oversight and no public debate in the host nations. The United States operates drone bases, training facilities, and intelligence-sharing arrangements across the continent. When the novel's Hartley offers "technical assistance" to Kessara's security services, the offer carries a weight that the diplomatic language is designed to conceal.

And there is the dependency critique, the argument that the aid cuts, devastating as they were, revealed a structural flaw that African leaders had tolerated for too long. Multiple African voices argued exactly this. Nigeria approved \$200 million to offset health aid losses. Ghana directed its finance minister to bridge a \$156 million shortfall. An Al Jazeera editorial was blunt: "Africa's leaders must stop blaming Trump, address corruption, and end the continent's reliance on US aid." Nigeria alone loses approximately \$18 billion annually to financial mismanagement and corrupt procurement, more than the total USAID allocation to the entire continent.

The novel holds this tension without resolving it. The aid is needed. The dependency is real. The corruption is real. The withdrawal is cruel. All of these are true simultaneously. Aminata embodies this contradiction, taking Alderton Foundation money that serves her cause while knowing it also serves Washington's interests, unable to fund the campaign without it, unable to accept it without compromise. Her dilemma is not a fictional contrivance. It is the condition of opposition politics across the continent.

III. The Men with Guns and No Flag

The Granite Group is Wagner. The novel does not disguise this. Wagner Group, now restructured as "Africa Corps" under Russian military intelligence following founder Yevgeny Prigozhin's death in a plane crash in August 2023, has operated across Mali, Burkina Faso, the Central African Republic, Libya, Sudan, Mozambique, Niger, and Chad. The model is consistent: offer security services to governments fighting insurgencies, in exchange for mining concessions, timber rights, and political influence. Wagner's gold mining operations in Mali alone generated an estimated \$250 million in revenue between 2021 and 2024. Colonel Sokolov, who processes people as equipment and food as fuel, is a composite of Wagner field commanders whose operational culture has been documented by journalists and human rights organizations. In Mali, Wagner and Malian troops killed at least 32 civilians and destroyed over 100 dwellings in a single operation in late 2024. In January 2025, at least 10 individuals were killed, including women and a two-year-old child. In 2024, Malian forces and their Russian allies were responsible for more civilian fatalities than the jihadists they were supposedly fighting.

An investigation by the journalist organization Forbidden Stories found that Wagner had abducted, detained, and tortured hundreds of civilians throughout its deployment in Mali. The Tinzaouaten ambush in July 2024, where up to 84 Russian soldiers were killed by Tuareg rebels, was one of the worst known losses. Wagner's response was not to improve its counterterrorism strategy. It was to continue exactly as before, because the mission was never counterterrorism. The mission was access: to gold, to uranium, to political leverage, to the kind of influence that comes from being the only people in the room with guns.

Ibrahim's arc in the novel, a young man who made a rational economic choice and now cannot undo it, is drawn from real testimonies. The Granite Group's recruitment pamphlet in the novel ("housing, meals, salary, skills training, brotherhood") echoes actual recruitment materials documented by researchers. Ibrahim's \$800 per month is based on reported pay scales for Wagner-recruited African fighters, significantly less than Russian contractors receive for the same work, but significantly more than local economies offer. Africa Corps also recruits local residents in the countries where it operates, blurring the line between mercenary and soldier, between security contractor and occupier. The novel frames this recruitment as an extension of the resource extraction model: young African men, like African minerals, are extracted from their communities, processed through training camps, deployed in foreign conflicts, and discarded. This is not metaphor. It is structure.

And here is where the novel's restraint understates the reality. Across the continent, 8,655 children were recruited and deployed in armed conflict in 2023, a figure the United Nations called a "particularly high surge." In the DRC alone, 1,861 children, including 326 girls, were recruited by armed groups. In Mali, 691 cases were verified. Children as young as five were coerced into joining. Roughly 21,000 children have been recruited as soldiers by government forces and armed groups across Africa in the past five years. One hundred and eighteen million African children live within 50 kilometers of an active conflict. One in six is vulnerable to recruitment.

Ibrahim in the novel is 26. He is old enough to have chosen. Thousands of real Ibrahims are not.

The youngest verified recruits in Africa are five years old. Five. The age of a child who has just learned to write their name, who still needs help tying their shoes, who believes that adults can be trusted because the world has not yet taught them otherwise. Armed groups recruit children this young as lookouts, porters, cooks, messengers. As they grow, they become fighters. Girls, who make up an estimated 40 percent of child soldiers globally, are forced into roles as spies, cooks, and fighters, and are frequently subjected to sexual violence and forced marriage. In Burkina Faso, a jihadist insurgency caused a fivefold increase in child soldier recruitment in a single year. At least a quarter of all schools in the country were closed as of October 2023 due to armed groups' war against education. Close the schools and the children have nowhere to go. Nowhere to go makes them recruitable. The pipeline is not accidental. It is designed.

Over 105,000 children have been documented as recruited by armed forces and non-state actors in conflict zones worldwide since 2005. Africa accounts for 40 percent of the global child soldier population. West and Central Africa have the highest verified recruitment rates on the continent.

The novel does not dwell on child soldiers because it is not that story. But the pipeline that recruits Ibrahim, the economic desperation, the absence of legitimate work, the promise of salary and purpose in a landscape stripped of both, is the same pipeline that pulls in children. The Granite Group's "no exit clause" is not dramatic license. Wagner fighters who attempted to leave have been imprisoned, beaten, and in documented cases, executed. The pipeline does not have a return lane.

In Burkina Faso, a country led by a military captain named Ibrahim Traoré, the coincidence of the name with the novel's character is noted, Africa Corps arrived in January 2024. As supporters of the coup entered the capital, some waved Russian flags. The promise was security. The result, across every country where Wagner or

Africa Corps has deployed, has been the same: more instability, more civilian casualties, more extraction, less security. A Rand Corporation analyst summarized the model: "Rather than building the defense capacity of countries they operate in, Russian mercenaries create an insecure climate and then position themselves as indispensable."

The mercenary economy exists because legitimate economies have failed to offer young African men a viable future. The Granite Group is a symptom. The cause is the same resource extraction model the referendum is supposed to address, and the same model the referendum, regardless of its outcome, will perpetuate in new form.

IV. God's Country, Someone Else's God

Pastor Emmanuel Bright's 200,000-member congregation in the novel is modest by real-world standards. Winners' Chapel's Faith Tabernacle in Lagos seats 50,000. The Redeemed Christian Church of God claims over 14 million members in Nigeria alone. In countries where the state cannot deliver basic services, healthcare, education, food security, churches fill the gap. Megachurches across sub-Saharan Africa operate school systems, hospitals, food distribution networks, and media empires. Pastor Bright's church in the novel runs a clinic and two schools. It feeds four hundred families. The congregation votes as its pastor advises because the pastor has earned their trust by doing what the government will not.

This is real, and it is not inherently wrong. Faith communities have provided essential services across Africa for generations, often with extraordinary dedication and at great personal sacrifice. What the novel asks you to see is the wiring behind the wall. American evangelical organizations channel billions of dollars annually into African religious institutions. The Heritage Covenant Alliance in the novel is a composite of real organizations, the Billy Graham Evangelistic Association, Samaritan's Purse, Focus on the Family's international operations, and dozens of smaller groups. These funds arrive with theological and political assumptions: positions on reproductive rights, LGBTQ+ rights, governance models, and economic development that reflect American evangelical priorities rather than local contexts.

Uganda's Anti-Homosexuality Act, signed into law in 2023, prescribing life imprisonment and, in some cases, the death penalty, is perhaps the most documented case of American evangelical influence on African legislation. American pastors and organizations spent years building relationships with Ugandan religious leaders, funding conferences, providing theological frameworks. The law that emerged was

presented as an expression of Ugandan values. Its architecture was American.

The novel does not argue that faith-based social services are predatory. It argues that the infrastructure of faith has become the infrastructure of foreign influence without most congregants being aware of the connection. When Pastor Bright tells his congregation how to vote, he is exercising a form of political power that was built with American money, shaped by American theology, and aligned with American strategic interests. He may believe he is acting independently. The funding suggests otherwise.

The mechanism is infrastructure, not ideology. Meet the real need, the clinic, the school, the food, and the political alignment follows. It is the most effective form of influence because it does not feel like influence. It feels like help.

This pattern is not unique to evangelical Christianity. It is the template for every form of soft power operating on the continent. China builds roads. America funds NGOs. Gulf states fund mosques. Each meets a real need. Each creates a dependency. Each extracts a form of compliance, economic, political, theological, that is never named as the price of the service.

The novel places Pastor Bright alongside Thierno Bâ deliberately. Both are spiritual leaders. Both command the loyalty of hundreds of thousands. Both fill gaps the state cannot fill. The difference is provenance. Thierno Bâ's authority grew from the ground, from fifty-four years of prayer and presence and accumulated trust, funded by nothing except the community itself. Pastor Bright's authority grew from imported infrastructure, clinics equipped with American medical supplies, schools using American curricula, a media operation funded by American donors. One is indigenous. The other is transplanted. Both are real. The novel asks you to see the difference and to wonder what it means when a community's most trusted institution is funded from 8,000 miles away.

V. The Table Where You Have No Chair

In the novel, the United Nations appears through its absence. The African Union observers are polite, professional, and powerless.

Diallo navigates between great powers with no institutional voice that could arbitrate the competition over his country. The Security Council does not convene. The international community issues a statement and moves on.

Here is the structure behind that silence.

The United Nations Security Council has five permanent members, all nuclear powers, all former or current empires. No African permanent member. No Latin American permanent member. No Southeast Asian permanent member. The body responsible for international peace and security reflects the power distribution of 1945, not 2026.

Africa, 54 countries, 1.4 billion people, 28 percent of the United Nations' total membership, has no veto and no permanent voice. It holds three rotating non-permanent seats out of ten. Over 50 percent of Security Council meetings and 70 percent of its resolutions concern Africa. The continent is the primary subject of decisions it has no structural power to shape. In 2025, 22 of 35 Council press statements concerned African issues.

The numbers at the financial institutions are equally stark. The International Monetary Fund gives the United States 16.5 percent of voting power, an effective veto. The entire African continent holds approximately 5.5 percent. The World Bank presidency has never been held by a non-American. The IMF managing directorship has never been held by a non-European. African nations borrow at average interest rates of 9.8 percent. Germany borrows at 0.8 percent. The same institutions set the lending conditions for both. The African Union's annual budget is less than the budget of the New York City Police Department. Its headquarters, a \$200 million building funded and constructed by China as a "gift", was revealed in 2018 to have been bugged. For five years, between midnight and 2 a.m. each night, confidential data from AU servers had been transferred to servers in Shanghai. Microphones were found in desks and walls. The AU kept the discovery secret for a year. It then signed additional technology partnership agreements with Huawei, the company implicated in the surveillance. The story gets worse the longer you sit with it. The \$200 million building was inaugurated in 2012 as a symbol of African-Chinese cooperation. The computer systems were fully equipped by Chinese contractors, who installed a backdoor, an intentional fault in the code, that gave Chinese administrators access to the AU's entire computing system. When AU technicians discovered the nightly data transfers in 2017, the organization chose silence. An AU official told *Le Monde*: "The Chinese have nothing to listen to. They have never colonized us. They have supported the struggles of independence on the continent and help us economically today." That sentence: "They have never colonized us", is the sentence this novel orbits. It contains a truth (China was not a colonial power in Africa) and a logic (therefore Chinese surveillance is more tolerable than Western surveillance) that reveals the depth of the trap. The AU's choices are not between surveillance and privacy. They are between

being surveilled by a partner who builds infrastructure and being surveilled by partners who colonized the continent and then lectured it about governance. Western intelligence agencies, the NSA, Britain's GCHQ, had conducted their own surveillance of the AU building. Another AU official acknowledged: "They are not alone."

The AU continued working with Huawei. In 2022, it signed a further Memorandum of Understanding to expand the technology partnership. In 2020, Japanese cybersecurity experts detected that surveillance camera footage from across the AU campus was being redirected to a Chinese hacking group. The cameras that were supposed to protect the building were being used to watch the people inside it.

That fact, that the African Union continued partnering with the company that allegedly spied on it, tells you everything about the options available when you have no chair at the table. You do not choose your partners. You accept the partners who show up.

In January 2026, Canadian Prime Minister Mark Carney delivered a speech at Davos that articulated what many African leaders had been arguing for decades. The rules-based international order, he said, was "partially false", the strongest exempted themselves when convenient. We were "in the midst of a rupture, not a transition." Great powers now used "trade, finance, supply chains, and tariffs as instruments of coercion rather than cooperation." The World Trade Organization, the United Nations, the climate accords: "the very architecture of collective problem-solving", were under threat.

The speech received a rare standing ovation. The Carnegie Endowment called it "uncharacteristically candid both for Davos and a Canadian." What made it remarkable was not the argument, African leaders, Latin American leaders, Southeast Asian leaders had been making the same argument for decades. What made it remarkable was who was making it. A white, Western, former central banker, standing at Davos, telling the assembled billionaires and heads of state that the system they had built was "partially false." When Diallo says it, it is dismissed as grievance politics. When Carney says it, it receives a standing ovation. The asymmetry is the point.

One line in particular could serve as the novel's epigraph: "When we only negotiate bilaterally with a hegemon, we negotiate from weakness. This is not sovereignty. It is the performance of sovereignty while accepting subordination."

Carney was speaking about Canada. The line applies to every country in this novel. But it applies with different force. Canada negotiates from weakness relative to the United States. Kessara negotiates from weakness relative to everyone. Canada has a seat at the G7. Kessara has no seat anywhere. The performance of sovereignty that

Carney described is, for countries like Kessara, not a diplomatic inconvenience. It is the permanent condition of national existence.

Diallo is a democratically elected president, governing a sovereign nation, holding a sovereign referendum, surrounded by powers whose interests will determine the practical meaning of whatever his people decide.

VI. What Lies Beneath

The Democratic Republic of the Congo produces over 70 percent of the world's cobalt. It captures approximately 3 percent of the total value chain from mine to battery to electric vehicle. Between 150,000 and 200,000 artisanal miners work in the DRC's cobalt and coltan mines. An estimated 40,000 children and teenagers are among them.

Nearly \$1 billion vanishes from the legal cobalt supply chain each year through middlemen who mix illegally sourced minerals with legally certified ones. The certification systems exist. The tracing programs exist. The audit frameworks exist. And nearly \$1 billion in conflict minerals passes through them annually because the systems were designed to create the appearance of accountability without the cost of actually achieving it. A Bloomberg study found that building a battery precursor plant would cost three times less in the DRC than in the United States or China. The processing capacity could be there. The value could be captured locally. The reason it is not is political: the current arrangement benefits every party in the chain except the one at the beginning, and there is no institution on Earth with the power to compel the others to accept less.

In February 2025, the DRC suspended cobalt exports for four months, an act of resource nationalism that demonstrated both the country's leverage and its vulnerability.

VII. The Leaving

Fatou Mensah grew up in Toronto. She carries a Canadian passport and a Kessaran name and the discomfort of a woman who translates Africa for international audiences and knows that the translation is also a form of extraction.

The diaspora journalist is a real figure in African media. The most globally visible African journalism is often produced by people like Fatou, reporters who carry African identity but work within Western institutional frameworks. They are valued by their employers precisely because they can go where Western correspondents

cannot, can read the room in ways that outsiders miss, can lend authenticity to coverage that might otherwise feel colonial. Whether this journalism illuminates Africa or further commodifies it, whether "an African voice" at a global outlet serves Africa or serves the outlet, is a question the novel leaves with Fatou and, through her, with the reader.

The tension Fatou embodies is part of a larger hemorrhage. Africa loses an estimated \$2 billion annually in human capital flight. Approximately 70,000 skilled professionals leave the continent each year. There are more Ethiopian-trained doctors in Chicago than in Ethiopia. More Ghanaian-trained nurses in the United Kingdom's National Health Service than in Ghana's public health system. The hospital where Youssouf dies in the novel, two doctors for 600 beds, no functioning X-ray machine, the orthopedic surgeon gone to Dubai, is drawn from real staffing ratios in West African public hospitals. The doctor who stays, Dr. Touré, stays because someone has to. The doctor who left is not a villain. He is a person who made a rational decision in a system that rewards leaving and punishes staying.

African diaspora remittances exceed \$100 billion annually, more than total foreign direct investment and official development assistance combined. This number is staggering. The largest single financial flow into Africa is not Chinese loans or American aid or European investment. It is money sent home by Africans who left. Ibrahim's money from the Granite Group is a dark mirror of this. Remittances earned not through migration but through mercenary service. The novel places the doctor in Chicago sending money home beside the soldier in a foreign war sending money home. Both are symptoms of the same failure: the failure to create domestic economies that allow people to build lives where they were born.

Diallo's son Ibrahima studies in Paris and speaks of Kessara with the mixture of guilt and distance that diaspora children know well, loving a country you chose to leave, defending a place you have not lived in, carrying an identity that is real and also, increasingly, inherited rather than inhabited. The novel does not judge any of these people. It asks you to see the system that made their choices necessary and to notice who benefits from the arrangement. The countries that receive Africa's skilled professionals, the United States, the United Kingdom, France, Canada, the Gulf states, did not train them. The countries that trained them cannot keep them. The investment flows one direction. The talent flows another. The remittances flow back, and the cycle continues, and the hospital in the novel has two doctors for 600 beds, and the orthopedic surgeon is in Dubai.

The hospital where Youssouf dies is not an exaggeration. It is a composite drawn from real staffing data across West African public health systems. In many countries, the doctor-to-patient ratio falls below the World Health Organization's minimum threshold. The reasons are systemic: salaries that cannot compete with Gulf or Western offers, equipment that does not function, drug supplies that run out mid-month, power cuts that interrupt surgery. Dr. Touré in the novel has been offered three jobs abroad this year. He stays because someone has to. His colleague, Dr. Diarra, young, furious, trained to save lives in a building that cannot keep its lights on, stays from a rage she cannot yet articulate. They are not fictional types. They are drawn from the real staffing crisis, the doctors who absorb, in their bodies and their careers, the cost of every colleague who left.

The thirty-eight minutes that kill Youssouf, the time it takes to walk forty meters through a gate and a protocol and a locked drawer to reach compatible blood in the MSF freezer next door, are not about incompetence. They are about system design. Two hospitals sharing a fence, operating under different protocols, funded by different donors, serving different mandates. The blood was forty meters away. The key was in a locked office. The doctor whose office it was had gone to lunch and had not come back because the streets were closed. Every element of that chain is ordinary. The death it produces is ordinary. That is the most devastating thing about it: nobody was negligent. Nobody failed. The system performed as designed. The design kills people. Youssouf Coulibaly wanted to build houses that ordinary people could afford to live in. He was a second-year architecture student. In a country with a functioning economy, he would have graduated, opened a practice, built the houses. In Kessara, in the countries Kessara is made from, his trajectory was intercepted by a bullet and a blood bank and a locked drawer. The deal he was protesting is supposed to address the conditions that killed him. It might. It might also reproduce them in a different form. The novel does not tell you which. The novel asks you to hold both possibilities at once and to notice which one is more comfortable.

VIII. The Debt That Never Ends

Sub-Saharan Africa's total external debt surpassed \$1 trillion in 2024, having doubled in four years. Debt servicing costs hit \$74 billion, a 335 percent increase from 2010. Thirty-two African nations spend more servicing external debt than funding healthcare.

The interest rate disparity makes the arithmetic brutal. African sovereign borrowing averages 9.8 percent. Germany borrows at 0.8 percent. A country that was colonized for a century, stripped of its resources, then subjected to structural adjustment programs that shrank its public sector, is assessed for credit risk by agencies headquartered in the countries that did the colonizing. The rate reflects the risk. The risk reflects the history. The history was not an accident.

Belgium's extraction from the Congo funded Belgian highways, universities, and public buildings for decades. The descendants of the people whose labor paid for that infrastructure are now borrowing from Belgian-headquartered institutions at 9.8 percent interest.

Zambia defaulted in 2020. Ghana defaulted in 2022. Ethiopia and Chad restructured. In each case, the process took years while the country continued paying interest it could not afford. Commercial debt like Eurobonds now accounts for 44 percent of the total, more expensive, harder to restructure, and held by private investors whose interests do not include the welfare of the debtor country.

Fourteen African countries still use the CFA franc, pegged to the euro, with 50 percent of their foreign reserves held by the French Treasury. This colonial-era arrangement has been maintained for seven decades. Several Sahel countries have signaled their intent to abandon it, partly in connection with their broader pivot away from France.

At the African Union's first Debt Conference in May 2025, African scholars offered a framing that could have been spoken by any character in this novel: "Africa is not defaulting on its debts. It is defaulting on its development."

IX. The Ghost at the Table

France does not appear as a character in the novel. It does not need to. France is the architecture.

Kessara's legal system is based on French civil law. Its official language is French. Its currency is pegged to the euro through a mechanism designed in Paris. Its educated elite were trained in French universities. The companies that controlled its mining sector before the Chinese arrived were French. The military that maintained order before the Russian mercenaries arrived was trained by the French.

This is not unique to Kessara. It is the condition of francophone West Africa.

France maintained military bases in its former African colonies for decades after independence. It intervened militarily in African countries over 50 times between

1960 and 2023. Operation Barkhane in the Sahel, a counterterrorism mission that deployed thousands of French troops across Mali, Burkina Faso, Niger, and Chad, ended in withdrawal between 2022 and 2024, replaced in each country by Russian mercenaries. The pattern was consistent: military juntas seized power, expelled French forces, and invited Wagner.

The French withdrawal from the Sahel is one of the most significant geopolitical shifts in 21st-century Africa, and it is almost entirely absent from Western media coverage. An imperial presence that lasted over a century, first colonial, then post-colonial, maintained through military agreements, monetary control, corporate dominance, and linguistic hegemony, was replaced in less than three years by a different external power with a different extractive model.

The novel's treatment of France as a ghost, present in the structures, absent from the room, is a deliberate choice. The Chinese are negotiating the deal. The Americans are funding the opposition. The Russians are providing the guns. But the legal framework they are all operating within, the language they are negotiating in, the monetary system that denominates the debt, all of it was built by France, and France benefits from its continuation whether or not a single French official appears in the story.

The CFA franc, the French-language education system, the civil law framework, the corporate relationships, these are not relics of the past. They are active mechanisms that shape the present. When Aminata argues her case in court, she argues in French, using precedents from French law, in a system designed to protect French economic interests. When Diallo negotiates with Beijing, he negotiates in a currency whose value is set in Frankfurt and whose reserves are held in Paris. The ghost is not haunting the room. The ghost built the room.

Consider what the CFA franc means in practice. Fourteen countries, home to approximately 200 million people, cannot set their own interest rates. They cannot devalue their currency to make their exports competitive. They cannot print money to respond to a domestic crisis. Half their foreign reserves sit in an account at the French Treasury, earning interest that accrues to France. The arrangement was established in 1945, the year the United Nations was founded, the year the current world order began, and it has survived every wave of decolonization, every African independence movement, every structural adjustment program, every change of government in Paris. Reforms were announced in 2019, the currency was renamed, the requirement to deposit reserves in France was theoretically relaxed, but the structural peg to the euro remains, and the practical consequences for monetary sovereignty remain largely

unchanged.

The countries that have most aggressively rejected French influence, Mali, Burkina Faso, Niger, are also the countries that have turned to Russian mercenaries. The pattern is not coincidence. It is sequence. The French withdrawal created a security vacuum. The Russian arrival filled it. But the legal system is still French. The language of government is still French. The corporate interests, in uranium, in gold, in agriculture, are still substantially French. Total, Bolloré, Orange, Société Générale, French companies operate across francophone Africa with a depth of market penetration that no Chinese or American competitor has matched. The competition between Beijing, Washington, and Moscow is a competition for new influence. France's influence is the furniture.

X. God's Architecture

Grand Marabout Thierno Bâ is fiction. The institution he represents is older than any government in the novel and will outlast all of them.

West Africa's Sufi brotherhoods, the Tijaniyya, the Mouridiyya, the Qadiriyya, are not churches in the Western sense. They are social systems. A grand marabout's authority is spiritual, but its practical reach extends into agriculture, commerce, migration, education, conflict resolution, and politics. When Thierno Bâ's silence on the referendum becomes a political event, it reflects a real dynamic: in Senegal, no presidential candidate campaigns without seeking the endorsement of the leading marabouts. In northern Nigeria, Sufi leaders mediate disputes that the state cannot reach. In Mali, the Sufi establishment maintained social cohesion during periods when the government effectively ceased to function. The novel's spiritual landscape is more complex than a single faith tradition. Ousmane wears a gris-gris under his shirt, a leather pouch containing a Quranic verse, plant seeds, and a pinch of soil. This is the material intersection of Islam and the indigenous practices that predated it by millennia. Dramane tends a sacred grove that is not Islamic and not anti-Islamic, it is something older, something that exists alongside the mosque the way the market exists alongside the mosque, each occupying its own ground. This coexistence is under pressure. Saudi-funded Salafi and Wahhabi movements have spent decades promoting a "purer" Islam that rejects Sufi practices, indigenous traditions, and the syncretic faith that most West Africans actually live. Gulf money funds mosques, schools, and media that advance this vision. American evangelical money funds churches, clinics, and media that advance a different one. Both compete for the same

ground, the spiritual life of communities that have been navigating multiple traditions for centuries without outside assistance.

The novel's Abdoulaye, Thierno Bâ's eldest son, seven years in Medina, carrying a Saudi-educated certainty that Islam is pure and singular, represents this pressure from inside the family. "The grove is not Islam, Father," he says. And Thierno Bâ answers: "The grove was here before Islam. It will be here after Islam. What I believe about it does not change what it is." That exchange is not a theological debate. It is a generational one, between an older faith that accommodates complexity and a newer one that demands purity. The same exchange happens in mosques and families across West Africa, and the outcome matters enormously, because the version of Islam that wins will shape the political and social fabric of societies for decades.

The Gulf funding is not trivial. Saudi Arabia and other Gulf states have invested billions in mosques, Islamic universities, and religious media across sub-Saharan Africa. The theology that arrives with this funding is not West African. It is Gulf Arab, shaped by different histories, different social norms, different relationships to gender, to authority, to the state. It is not inherently violent, and it is inaccurate and irresponsible to suggest otherwise. But it displaces local traditions that have maintained social cohesion for generations, and it creates new fault lines in communities that had managed their religious diversity without outside intervention. The novel positions the Sufi brotherhood as the one institution in Kessara that no foreign power can purchase or replicate. Thierno Bâ's authority is not legal, not political, not economic. It is accumulated trust, trust earned over decades of being present in people's lives in ways that no government, no NGO, and no foreign embassy can match. When he speaks on Day 6, his words reshape the referendum not because he commands people but because people believe he answers to something beyond the election cycle, beyond the debt payment schedule, beyond the strategic calculations of Beijing and Washington. His voice carries a weight that power cannot manufacture. That weight is the spiritual infrastructure of West Africa, and it is the most important thing in this novel that the global analysis consistently fails to see.

XI. The Continent That Will Decide the Century Everything in this afterword, the deals, the debts, the minerals, the mercenaries, the missionaries, the missing chairs at the global table, converges on a single demographic fact that most of the world has not yet absorbed.

Africa's population will reach 2.5 billion by 2050. One in four humans on Earth will be African. The median age on the continent is 19. Within five years, Africa will be home to 75 percent of the world's population under 35.

This is not a footnote in the 21st century's story. This is the story.

Think about what that median age of 19 means. It means that in the countries this novel is drawn from, half the population was born after 2007. They have no memory of a world before smartphones, before Chinese construction cranes on the skyline, before the referendum debates on WhatsApp. They are Awa's generation, university-educated or trying to be, digitally connected, politically aware, impatient with the compromises their parents made and not yet old enough to understand why those compromises were made. They are the generation that will inherit the deals being signed now, the debts being restructured now, the leases that will still be in effect when they are grandparents. The 99-year lease on Kessara's port will expire in the year 2125. The people who will live under its terms for most of that century have not been born yet. Awa's activism in the novel, the student movement, the social media campaign, the vigil, is drawn from real youth movements across the continent. In Senegal, young people led the protests that reshaped the 2024 presidential election. In Nigeria, the EndSARS movement demonstrated the organizing power of a generation that communicates in memes and mobilizes through group chats. In Kenya, students led tax protests that forced the government to withdraw a finance bill. These movements are not footnotes to the political story. They are the political story. The generation that will live with the consequences is demanding a voice in the decisions. Every global challenge, climate change, food security, energy transition, migration, public health, technological development, the future of democracy itself, will be shaped by what happens on this continent. The question the novel asks, through seven days in a fictional country, is the question the world has not yet seriously engaged: what does it mean for 54 nations and 2.5 billion people to have almost no structural power in the institutions that govern the global order?

The novel's deepest commitment is to African agency, not as aspiration but as fact. Diallo is not a victim. He is a president making decisions under constraints he did not create. Ousmane is not a symbol. He is a farmer who knows his soil and his tree and his children and who refuses to be reduced to a compensation figure. Aminata is not a Western-educated savior. She is a lawyer who built her career on grief and fights for a country that has not always fought for her. Liwei is not a villain. She is an engineer who followed her training until the training and her conscience diverged. Ibrahim is not a statistic. He is a son trying to come home.

The novel insists that these decisions matter, that African choices about African futures are not subordinate to the strategic calculations of Beijing, Washington, Moscow, Paris, or London. The referendum may be imperfect. The deal may be

compromised. The vote may be insufficient. But it happened. Twenty-two million people marked a ballot. That act, flawed, pressured, manipulated from every direction, and still sovereign, is the novel's moral center. Awa's choice on Day 7, to sit under the tree and not vote, to hold the complexity rather than collapse it into a Yes or a No, is not apathy. It is the most demanding form of political engagement: the refusal to pretend that a binary question can answer what the country is actually asking. The country is not asking Yes or No. The country is asking: on what terms do we enter the future? And who gets to decide?

That question belongs to 1.4 billion people today. It will belong to 2.5 billion tomorrow. The answer will shape the century.

XII. What I Owe This Story I have spent my career building systems, the kind that wire large institutions together, that connect processes most people never see. I learned to read the architecture behind the interface. I learned that the most important part of any system is the part that the user never touches: the scoping decisions, the configuration choices, the assumptions baked into the design before the first user logs in. Those invisible choices determine who the system serves and who it excludes.

This novel is about a system. The global economic order is a system. Its user interface, the summits, the handshakes, the aid pledges, the headlines, is designed to look like cooperation. The wiring underneath determines who benefits and who pays. The twelve pages that Liwei writes, the document that risks her career to tell the truth about what the project will destroy, are fiction. But the gap they describe is real: the gap between what a scoping document measures and what a community loses. I have read scoping documents in my professional life. Documents that define with precision what gets counted. The tree is never in the scope. The well is never in the scope. The names on the stones in the grove are never in the scope. The scope is defined by the client, and the client did not ask about any of these things. This novel is about what gets left outside the scope. And who decides.

I did not write this novel to tell you what to think about China, or America, or Russia, or Africa. I wrote it to make the thinking harder. The deal is deliberately ambiguous because the real deals are ambiguous. The people who negotiate them are not monsters. The people who suffer the consequences are not saints. The systems that connect them are not conspiracies. They are systems, built by humans, maintained by humans, alterable by humans, that produce outcomes nobody would design on purpose and nobody takes responsibility for.

If this afterword has done its work, you are uncomfortable. The discomfort is not something the novel created. It is something the novel revealed. It was always there, in

the cobalt in your phone, in the interest rate on a bond you will never see, in the doctor who is not in the hospital because she is in your hospital, in the child who is not in school because the debt payment was due.

The numbers in this afterword are real. They are also inadequate. A number cannot hold Mariame, a mother in house shoes who arrived at a hospital after her son was already gone, who knew before anyone told her because the faces in the corridor told her, who did not change her shoes because there was no time between the phone and the door. A percentage cannot describe the sound of corrugated iron shutters coming down at seven-forty-five in the morning. A statistic about brain drain cannot capture Dr. Touré staying in a hospital that cannot keep its lights on because someone has to be the last one who does not leave.

You have met these people. You spent seven days with them. They are fiction, and they are everywhere.

That is why I wrote a novel instead of a report. The story makes you care. The facts show you why the caring matters beyond the page. Together, they are the argument.

See the people inside the numbers. That is what I am asking. That is all I have ever been asking.

* * *

The Wiring

*“You never change things by fighting the existing reality. To change something, build a new model that makes the existing model obsolete.” —
Buckminster Fuller*

You have read the building. Now let me show you where the electrical panel is.

The novel gave you people. The Mirror showed you the systems those people live inside. This section is shorter than both, because the question it answers is simpler: what can you actually do? I am not an activist. I am a mathematician by training and a systems architect by profession. I build things that work. What follows is not a manifesto. It is a wiring diagram.

Read the Contract

The most dangerous part of the deal in this novel was not hidden. It was on page sixty-one. Article 7, Section 3. Anyone could read it. Almost no one did.

This is how extraction works in the real world. The terms are public. The complexity is the camouflage. A ninety-three-page agreement in bureaucratic French, with revenue splits buried in annexes and arbitration clauses tucked inside definitions sections, the document is technically available and practically invisible. Transparency without accessibility is not transparency. It is a locked door with a glass window.

The Awas of the world are already reading these contracts. Law students in Dakar and Lusaka and Nairobi are pulling apart concession agreements the way Awa pulled apart Article 12. They need tools, not inspiration.

They exist. The Natural Resource Governance Institute publishes contract analysis for extractive deals across Africa. ResourceContracts.org hosts the actual texts, mining licenses, production-sharing agreements, infrastructure concessions, searchable, downloadable, free. The Extractive Industries Transparency Initiative tracks revenue flows from resource deals in fifty-seven countries. These are not secrets. They are websites. The gap between a contract being public and a contract being understood is the distance the next generation of African lawyers and journalists and citizens need to close. Some of them are already closing it.

If you are a reader outside the continent: the next time your government signs a bilateral mineral access agreement, read it. Not the press release. The annex.

Follow the Value

Ousmane's coltan leaves Kessara as ore. It returns as a component inside a phone that costs more than his annual income. The novel calls this extraction. The economists call it a value chain. The difference between the two words is the difference between a diagnosis and a euphemism.

The problem is not that Africa has resources. The problem is that the resources leave before they become valuable. Cobalt is mined in the Congo and refined in China and assembled into batteries in Germany and sold to consumers in California. Each step adds value. Each step happens somewhere else.

Changing this requires three things that are not dramatic, not heroic, and not simple: capital, infrastructure, and trade policy. Local venture capital, not aid, not sovereign debt, not foreign direct investment with repatriation clauses, but African capital funding African processing. The African Continental Free Trade Area, the AfCFTA, is the largest free trade zone in the world by number of countries. It is designed to make it easier for a Zambian manufacturer to sell to a Kenyan buyer than to a Chinese one. It is young, imperfect, and the most important economic architecture

on the continent.

The professional middle class, the doctors who stay, the engineers who build, the entrepreneurs who process rather than export, are not in this novel because the novel covers one week. But they are the people who build the battery precursor plants. They are the people who turn ore into components. They are not waiting for permission. Many of them are waiting for financing, for regulatory clarity, for trade routes that do not pass through a former colonial capital on their way to the country next door.

If you are an investor, a policymaker, or a consumer: ask where the value is captured. If the answer is "not here," ask why.

Close the Distance

You are inside the system. This is not an accusation. It is a wiring diagram.

The phone in your hand contains cobalt that may have been mined by hand in conditions that would be illegal in the country where the phone was designed. The battery contains lithium from a salt flat where the water table is dropping. The rare earth elements were processed in a facility whose environmental standards would not survive scrutiny in the country where the phone is sold. None of this is hidden. All of it is tolerated because the gap between the mine and the screen is long enough that the connection feels abstract.

The novel tried to shorten that distance. Ousmane's field. Liwei's corridor. Ibrahim's desert. Youssouf's white shirt. If those images stayed with you, the distance is already shorter than it was four hundred pages ago.

What remains is not guilt. Guilt is passive. What remains is information, and information is a building material.

Demand supply chain transparency from the companies whose products you use. Support organizations that fund investigative journalism in resource-rich countries, the journalists who do what Fatou does, in places where doing it is dangerous. Vote for trade policies that reward processing over extraction. Read. This is not symbolic. It is structural. Every person who understands how a concession agreement works is one more person the agreement cannot hide from.

The system that connects your daily life to Ousmane's field was not built by accident. It was engineered. It can be re-engineered. But only by people who have read the wiring diagram.

You have read it now.

* * *

Author's Note

"If there is a book that you want to read, but it hasn't been written yet, you must be the one to write it." — Toni Morrison

I was born in Zambia. My family left for Canada when I was young, for reasons of safety. I grew up between two countries, and later moved to the United States for work. I have spent my career in technology, building enterprise systems, designing architectures, understanding how large institutions are wired together beneath the surface. I know how systems work. I also know who they work for.

This novel came from the collision between those two facts, the country I was born in and the systems I learned to see. I watched Zambia become a line item in reports about Chinese debt restructuring and IMF conditionality. I watched the copper that shaped my childhood become a commodity ticker. I read the coverage and recognized the country and did not recognize it at all, because the Zambia in the reports had numbers but no people. It had GDP figures and debt ratios but no fathers standing in fields, no mothers on buses in house shoes, no students who wanted to build houses ordinary people could afford.

Each book I have written has approached truth from a different angle. The Cost of the Machine trilogy is nonfiction, direct, analytical, built from the systems-thinking that my career taught me. Hungry By Design braids my own story with the lives of five fictional children born on the same day in five countries, exploring the six drives that run in every human being regardless of where they were born, the hunger to belong, to matter, to know, to be forgiven, to consume, and to feel alive. It is nonfiction supported by fictional characters. Someone To Look Up To is fiction drawn from the experience of arriving somewhere new and learning to see the world from the outside.

This novel reverses the lens entirely. It is fiction built on nonfiction, a story assembled from real deals, real debts, real consequences, designed to make you feel what the data alone cannot convey. And The Mirror, the afterword you have just read, drops the fiction and shows you the architecture underneath.

I keep changing the form because the truth keeps demanding it. Some things land harder as data. Some as story. Some as the collision between the two, the moment a reader who has spent seven days inside Ousmane's field encounters the real numbers, the real countries, the real children in real mines. That collision is the point. That is what I am building toward, book by book. Different doors into the same room.

My family still has roots in Zambia. I have extended family there. I visit, but I do not live there, and the difference between visiting and living is the difference between reading about a country and being read by it. I carry the guilt of distance, the discomfort of a person who left a place that needed people to stay. I am not unique in this. The diaspora data in this novel's afterword describes millions of people carrying the same weight. I am one of them. I did not write this novel to resolve that guilt. I wrote it because fiction can go where headlines cannot, into the room where the decision is made, into the field where the tree is cut, into the corridor where a mother arrives in house shoes. I wrote it because the facts are urgent and the facts alone are not enough. The facts need faces. The data needs to breathe.

This novel was written with the help of Claude, an artificial intelligence made by Anthropic. I want to be transparent about that. The story, the characters, the arguments, the moral architecture, those are mine. The process of keeping nine distinct voices consistent across 47 chapters, that was a collaboration. I used AI as a thinking partner, a structural editor, and a research synthesizer. The machine could hold the entire manuscript in its attention at once and tell me when a farmer was thinking like a professor or when the narrator was editorializing instead of trusting the scene. I am not embarrassed by this. I am a systems builder by profession. I used the best tools available to build the best book I could. I am also aware that the AI I used runs on infrastructure that may include the very minerals this novel is about. The irony is noted. It is not hypocrisy. It is the condition of living in a connected world where complicity is universal and the question is not whether you participate in the system but whether you see it while you do. One commitment I want to make here, to you, the reader who has already finished the book and is reading these final pages. This is not a sales pitch, you have already bought the book or borrowed it or been given it, and nothing I say here changes that transaction. Five percent of my profits from this novel will go to a foundation supporting education and development in Zambia. I have not yet identified the right organization, but I will, and I will follow through, because a novel that asks its readers to pay attention to a continent cannot be written by a person who looks away from his own country.

Thank you for reading. Thank you for staying to the end.

Pumulo Sikaneta, 2026